She-Ra and the Crystal Gems: Twin Destinies

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/25119613.

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General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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Gen

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), Steven Universe (Cartoon)

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Additional Tags:
and the rest - Freeform, semi-original characters, Fandom Fusion, Steven Universe: The Movie

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Part 5 of She-Ra and Steven Universe: Heroes United

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by TheInkredibleKaptainKaiju

Summary

Earth was at peace. Etheria was at peace. Homeworld had been stopped. The Horde had been stopped. Why, then, was the fighting not over? The Crystal Gems and the Princess Alliance both learn the hard way that their stories have not yet reached their happily ever after. There are still more threats to vanquish in order to save the universe, and the only way they stand any chance is if they do it side by side!

Notes

You read that right, no happy endings for these folks! Maybe someday, but not now. Now, the next chapter in this epic saga has begun! Enjoy!

Here We Are in the Future

She-Ra and the Crystal Gems: Twin Destinies

Chapter One: Here We Are in the Future

– – –

" *Steven…* "

It was the same voice. The same one he had heard every night for the past three days. The first time seemed like just a fluke. The second time could have been a coincidence, but Steven had been doing this for too long to believe in coincidences anymore. By the third time, he knew something was wrong, which tonight only confirmed.

"Steven...you must… "

The same collection of images that had flashed before him appeared again. An enormous castle in the distance, a grassy field between himself and the structure. A circular room, looking like it was inside the same castle, being enveloped in a blinding white light. A strange figure standing silhouetted against the setting sun, standing next to the ruins of said castle; only this time, the figure was not standing as he had been on the previous three days. This time, he was on his knees, his head bowed.

" *You must find…* "

This had been where the visions had ended before. But this time, more images flashed before him. First, he seemed to be walking through a corridor of some sort. It looked like something out of the middle ages, or it would have been were it not for what looked like Homeworld robonoids gathering dust next to the assorted swords and shields. Not to mention, the hallway was lit with glowing spheres attached to the wall rather than torches. Just where was this place?

" *The sword…* "

He then found himself inside an underground cavern, travelling deeper and deeper into the earth. The scene flashed and shifted numerous times, as though he was watching it in fast-motion.

"Steven, you must find the sword."

Now, finally, he was in a gigantic chamber, which he assumed to be at the end of the caverns. Waterfalls of lava (would that make them lavafalls?) oozed down from the ceiling, pooling into a molten lake that surrounded a raised platform in the room's center, to which a bridge connected the entrance. And on that platform, embedded into the stone, was a sword. Both the handle and blade seemed to be the same silvery-grey in color, and between the two was a cage-like formation of six strips of metal. Inside this 'cage' was a red jewel, hovering in the air.

" *Steven...You must…* "

" *Steven…* "

" *…* "

" *Steven!* "

– – –

Startled awake by the sudden shout of his name, Steven sat up with a gasp. He tried to slow his breathing. He looked around: his room was exactly how he had left it the night before, and the sunbeams of early morning had already begun to leak in through the windows.

"Well. The dream was definitely different *that* time!" Steven said aloud, pulling himself up out of bed. He started to ponder what it could mean...until he glanced at the clock. "Oh man, is it that late already!? I've gotta get going!" He hurried through the door and down the stairs.

Two years. It was hard to believe that so much time had passed. It seemed like only yesterday when White Diamond had torn out his gem in order to get his mother back, and now she was excited for his arrival. Not to mention, Little Homeworld was coming along quite nicely. So many of his former enemies were now learning to live under Era 3. He made a mental note to go and visit the town later.

Upon reaching the lower floor, he was surprised to see that he had a guest. "Connie! What are you doing here so early?"

The young woman in question was sitting on the couch in the living room, Lion resting beside her. "I wanted to see you off!" said Connie, looking up at Steven as she stroked the pink feline. "I figured you could use some encouragement before your coronation."

Steven laughed nervously. "Connie, you remember what I told everyone, right? I'm not going to stay on Homeworld. I can't, especially not after everything that happened between me and the Diamonds."

"I know, but I wanted to wish you luck anyway," Connie said, getting to her feet. "White and the others might not take the news so well. After all, they've probably been missing Pink for the past few thousand years. I know if my parents didn't see me for a long time, they'd never leave me alone again after that, especially if they thought I was dead!"

"I guess," Steven agreed, tugging on his pink jacket. "But at least your parents aren't giant evil space alien empresses. *Formerly* evil, I should say. They're trying to change that."

"And who better to help them with that than you!" said Connie. "Now come on, you don't want to be late!"

"Right, right, of course!" said Steven, hurrying into the kitchen to make himself a quick breakfast. "Sorry, I've been kind of... *off* lately."

“Is this about that dream?” asked Connie. “The one where you can see that medieval castle?”

“Yeah,” Steven answered. “I had it again last night. Only this time, it was different. I was going through this underground cave, and I ended up in this room filled with lava. And the same guy kept asking me about a sword or something. It’s weird.”

“Yeah, it sounds weird,” Connie replied. “Do you think...maybe it has something to do with Etheria? And She-Ra?”

“I honestly don’t know,” Steven answered, sealing a PB and J in a plastic baggie. “Maybe if I could ask Adora about it. Of course, it has been two years...” Neither Steven or Connie wanted to admit it, but the both of them figured that there was little chance of seeing their friends from Etheria again.

“You know, maybe it’s a subconscious thing. I could look into it a little if you want me to,” Connie offered. “I’m sure there are some books at the library about this sort of thing, or I could look it up online.”

“Thanks, but you don’t have to go to all that trouble just because of me,” Steven said. “We’ll talk about this later, but now I have to go!”

The two shared a quick hug before Steven hurried off to the warp pad. “Bye!” said Connie, waving to him as he hurried upstairs. “Good luck with your aunts! ...Or would they be his sisters?”

– – –

Adora stared out the window at the setting sun, letting out a heavy sigh. Even though she, as She-Ra, strived to bring peace to Etheria, something didn’t quite feel right now that she had accomplished just that. Of course, this was probably because it wasn’t true peace.

Two years. It was hard to believe that so much time had passed. It seemed like only yesterday when Horde Prime had been laying

waste to the planet, and now the Horde itself was hardly even present. And when there was no Horde…

"Adora?" A light knock on the door accompanied this voice. "Are you awake?"

"Yeah, I'm up," Adora called over her shoulder. "What's up?"

The door to Adora's room opened, and Glimmer walked in. "Some of our scouts just got back with a report on Horde activity," she said.

"Let me guess: Horde soldiers are bringing Horde Prime's tech back to the Fright Zone, and not engaging with civilians or soldiers. And nobody's seen Catra, either." It was clear from Adora's tone of voice that she was growing tired of every day bringing the exact same thing.

"Uh...yup, exactly that," Glimmer responded. "So, we are a bit of a rut here. But at least they aren't still attacking us, right?"

"That's what I'm worried about," said Adora. "I'm sure Hordak still wants to control Etheria, and with all these ships and bots lying around, he has more of an opportunity than ever. He's just been biding his time these past two years."

Glimmer could tell her friend was upset, and her instincts lead her to believe it wasn't about Hordak. "Hey, don't worry, I'm sure she'll turn up eventually," she said, trying to comfort her friend.

"But will she?" Adora asked. "Nobody's seen any sign of her for two years. And given how intent Catra was at winning this war, I can't imagine she'd be willingly staying behind. What if...what if Hordak did something? What if he punished her for her failure, or something like that?"

"Then we'll make him pay," said Glimmer, with such determination that Adora had no choice but to believe her. And while the sentiment was the same, Glimmer cared less about Catra herself, and more for the face that Adora cared about her. In truth, the

princess was neutral in regards to the cat girl. They had teamed up against Skeletor, but at the end of the day, she was still with the Horde.

"Right," said Adora. Renewed by some of that determination from Glimmer. "Hordak's bound to make a move before too long. And when he does, we'll be ready for him." She strolled over to the foot of her bed, picking up the Sword of Protection. She gazed into her reflection in the blade for a few moments before slinging the sword over her shoulder. "So, what's our next move?"

"Uh…" Glimmer didn't really have an answer. "I don't know, to be honest. I just figured you, me, and Bow could head out to investigate the area where our scouts saw the Horde troops."

"Works for me," Adora said. Once more, she strolled over to the window, gazing out into the night. "The Horde is out there, scheming. We have to beat them to the punch if we want to have any--wait...what's that?"

"Huh? What's what?" Glimmer asked, looking out the window as well. She couldn't see anything out of the ordinary. At least, not on the ground.

"That," Adora said, pointing out something hovering in the night sky. A tiny light shined over the treetops; it was dim, but unmistakable. "Is that…"

"A star," Glimmer finished. "But...that's impossible."

Adora's eyes narrowed. "I don't like this," she said, shaking her head. "Do you think the Horde has something to do with this?"

"I don't know, but I think we'd better go find out," responded Glimmer. The two of them hurried towards the meeting hall to tell everyone else about the star; chances are, most of them already knew. The only way a star could be seen on Etheria was if the planet was being transported back into the main universe.

Or if something else had been transported into Despondos with them.

Two Years in the Making

Chapter Summary

> After two long years of peace, two new threats to both Earth and Etheria appear, biding their time for the perfect opportunity to strike.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter Two: Two Years in the Making

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Even two years after making it her own, Catra still hated Hordak's sanctum. She could easily have changed it up to suit her tastes, but she never did. Instead, she kept it exactly the way it had always been. It was still the same dark, dismal dungeon it had been back when Hordak was in charge. And even though Catra had taken his place, she was still unnerved by the room.

But that was exactly the reason she kept the sanctum as it was. If *she* , Lord Catra, was afraid just to be in her own sanctum, then everyone else would be, as well. She knew that she was no Hordak, but she had something he didn't--she could read people. And if they were afraid of her, then she had secured her position as sovereign ruler of the Fright Zone, supreme commander of the Horde.

Catra stood up from the throne that was now hers, descending the stairs before her. Going along with her newfound 'promotion,' as she liked to call it, she wore a new outfit to make her authority known. She had gotten Entrapta to modify Hordak's old exoskeleton to make it fit her. Catra's version of the armor was far less bulky, and it no longer had any boots, so she was free to use her claws. Of course, there was also a hole in the back for her tail.

All of this allowed her to keep her agility while still having her strength and durability augmented by the suit.

Catra walked through the Fright Zone, as everyone she passed saluted her. She paid them no attention. Two years ago, Horde Prime had used this area as a factory for its cybertroops, and today was no different. Only this time, she controlled them.

Not long after Catra had assumed position as the Horde's leader, following the disappearance of Hordak and the destruction of Horde Prime, she had ordered Entrapta to rework the latter's old factories. The ships and machines it had left strewn across Etheria weren't worth anything just sitting around, and if they didn't do something with them, she knew the Rebellion would. And so, they had created this setup.

She examined the assembly line as she made her way to the controls, passing by Horde soldiers along the way. She was much more likely to mingle amongst the general infantry than Hordak was. Of course, that was only so she could see to matters personally. Although she delegated as much as she was willing to, she preferred to be hands-on in her projects.

Take this one, for example. Now, in addition to producing the spherical bots as normal, the Fright Zone now had an assembly line for the more humanoid cybertroops. And with time, they would soon be able to produce cybertanks as well. Cybercolossi seemed like a distant dream, but Catra could always hope.

Once Catra reached the control room, she was greeted by a cybertroop standing guard at the doorway. Unlike the others, its visor was purple rather than the standard Horde green, and it chirped happily as Catra approached, as though it was happy to see her. "Move it, Emily," Catra said. "I'm here to see Entrapta." The cybertroop obliged, stepping aside.

Inside, Entrapta was looking over some data, as Catra expected her to be. What Catra didn't expect, however, was for Scorpia to be in there with her, looking at whatever discovery Entrapta had

made this time. “Oh, Catra, wonderful timing!” said the purple-haired scientist, turning around once she heard Catra enter. “Something weird’s going on.”

“Yeah yeah yeah, weird, I know,” Catra said, brushing her off. “What I want to know is the progress on our new army.”

“Oh, the cybertroops are coming along just fine,” Entrapta said. “No loyalty issues, no residual traces of Horde Prime’s programming, so that’s good. But take a look at this!”

“It’s true, Lord Catra!” said Scorpia. “You might find this interesting.”

“I thought I was very clear when I told you that you two are exempt from calling me ‘Lord’ Catra,” said Catra, a look of annoyance on her face.

“As you command, Lor--I mean, Catra!” said Scorpia. She was clearly having fun with her best friend now being in charge of the Horde.

“Okay, what is this?” Catra asked, walking over to the table. “This had better not interfere with my invasion plans in any way.”

“No, I don’t think it should,” Entrapta said. “But it’s definitely worth further study. You see--”

“We found a star!” blurted Scorpia.

“You…’found a star’?” said Catra. “What exactly is that supposed to mean?”

“I’ll explain,” said Entrapta. “Just five minutes ago, the skies above the Fright Zone were completely normal: not a celestial body in sight, save the moons. However, security cameras over the west sector rooftops picked up *this* nifty little shot!”

Entrapta unveiled the picture in question. Indeed, there seemed to be a small pinprick of light in the sky. Catra, however, was

unimpressed. " *That's* what you're freaking out about? How do we know it isn't a firefly, or a rogue spark?"

"That's just it, though!" exclaimed Entrapta. "I thought it was something like that at first, but it didn't move, even when I called Scorpia in to look!" Now that it had been brought to her attention, Catra could see that it was not a still picture, but live video feed. The star still hovered in the sky, twinkling slightly on closer inspection. "Whatever it is, it has to be hundreds of miles away," Entrapta said.

"Okay, that definitely is weird, but it's nothing we have to worry about if it's that far away," Catra said. "Tell me, are we ready to begin the assault?"

"Almost, Lord Catra," said Scorpia. "But--"

"Good," said Catra. "Then get ready. You're with the other Force Captains. Once the ships are ready, we'll begin marching on the kingdoms. And as for the star…" She gestured towards the video feed. "...put it out of your mind for now. And make sure every single one of those bots is in fighting shape."

"You got it, Catra!" said Entrapta. Of course, she didn't take her eyes off the screen as she said this.

Catra just rolled her eyes as she and Scorpia left. "You know, if you keep calling me 'Lord Catra,' I'm going to start exclusively referring to you as 'Force Captain Scorpia.'"

"Fine by me!"

As the pair of them left, Entrapta continued staring at the curious celestial phenomenon. "Now, what's a star doing here?" she wondered aloud. "I wonder what could be happening up there?"

– – –

"Steven? Steven, wake up!"

Steven awoke, taking a moment to realize where he was. He was in his own bedroom, so at least he was where he remembered. Garnet stood by the side of his bed, looking concerned. "Huh? What's going on?"

"You were talking in your sleep," said the fusion. "Something about a sword. You were yelling for someone not to go. You...sounded really upset."

"I was?" Steven tried to remember his dream. All the dreams he had been having the previous nights--or rather, the same dream, over and over again--had been so vivid and memorable. But he couldn't recall this one, even though he had just been woken up. "What was I saying?"

"Something like 'Don't go, don't go, we need to find the sword,'" said Garnet. "Steven, are you sure you're okay?"

"Yeah, I...I'm fine," he said, getting up. "It's probably just stress. Today was a long day: the Diamonds wanted me to move in with them, we put the finishing touches on Little Homeworld--yeah, probably just stress, that's all."

"Do you need anything?" asked Garnet. "Glass of water? Bedtime story?"

"Thanks, Garnet, but I'm not a kid anymore," said Steven. Nevertheless, he smiled at the sentiment. "I think some fresh air should do the trick."

Steven glanced at the clock: it was just after midnight. He descended the stairway into the living room, before making his way out the door onto the porch. With the gentle washing of the waves and the calming sea breeze, he felt better already. He was about ready to head back inside when Garnet joined him.

"I've never really had much chance to sit back and enjoy it," she said, "but I'm really glad Rose chose this place. Something about Earth's ocean is just...magical."

“Yeah,” Steven agreed. “All things considered, this was a pretty good place to grow up. I’m glad I get to spend the rest of my life in a place like Beach City.”

“Your whole life?” asked Garnet. “All of it?”

“Why would I want to leave?” he replied. “Everyone I know is here, human and Gem. I’ve spent all my life in Beach City, so what reason would I have to leave?”

“I guess so,” said Garnet. “I just thought you might like some change.”

“Maybe in some futures,” said Steven, glancing up at the stars. “But for this one, I’m content right where I am.”

The stars were really pretty tonight: not a cloud in the sky to block them. Each one shined so brightly, too. Steven glanced around to look for constellations, but decided to just take in the sights when he couldn’t find any. A sky full of stars, each one the same shape and size. And equidistant from each other. Almost like a grid.

It was here that he realized that something was wrong.

“Garnet?” he asked. “What’s up with the stars?”

She looked up at the sky, immediately knowing that something was wrong once Steven pointed it out. The night sky looked so uniform, so artificial. What *was* going on? Then, Garnet stood bold upright in shock as the future vision hit. “Those aren’t stars.”

“They’re what?” said Steven. “Then what are they?”

As if in answer to his question, the lights began to move. Barely noticeable at first, but it soon became apparent that these mysterious objects were coming closer to the ground. Without a word, Steven made a run for his telescope.

Gazing through the lens, Steven tried to focus on one of the descending stars. After a few moments of fiddling with the dials, he eventually managed to get one in sight. The object, light blue in color and triangular in shape, was just dipping beneath the atmosphere.

"It's a ship," Steven said in quiet awe. "They're all ships. *Gem* ships." He focused the light on more of them. Each one was a different shape and size, but from far away, thor lights could easily have been mistaken for a star. And all of them were coming closer to the ground. "How many of them *are* there!?"

"Steven, wait here, I'll get Amethyst and Pearl," said Garnet, her voice almost reaching panic. She hurried inside, leaving Steven to continue gazing at the incoming armada.

"This had better not be the Diamonds' idea of a party," Steven grumbled, watching as the ships made landfall. There were so many of them, but even the ones directly above Beach City were landing somewhere beyond the horizon. With the sheer amount of vessels, it seemed like there were enough to surround the entire planet.

This made way for an even greater concern for Steven. If these ships weren't stars...then where did the real stars go?

"Steven!" He turned around to see Garnet, Amethyst, and Pearl running to join him on the hilltop. "Garnet filled us in," said Pearl. "What did we miss?"

"Um, the ships are starting to land," Steven said. "Look, I don't know what's going on, but it's probably my fault. Today, the Diamonds wanted me to stay on Homeworld with them, but I refused. This probably has something to do with that."

"Whatever it is, let's hope we can deal with it quickly," said Amethyst. "We've had two years of peace, let's not ruin it now!"

A light humming noise halted their conversation. Starting gradually, it soon grew into a loud drone. Steven looked up, and

immediately found its source: one of the ships was coming down right towards them. And he recognized it immediately.

“That...that’s the *Destiny Destroyer* ,” Steven said, realizing how bad this situation could actually be. “That’s Emerald’s ship.”

As the ship in question grew closer and closer to the ground, the Crystal Gems drew their weapons. All four of them stepped back as the green vessel landed in front of them atop the hill. Smoke rushed out as it came to a stop, obscuring everything from view.

The four stood in tense silence, waiting for Emerald to make the first move. Eventually, a hiss broke the silence: the sound of the ship’s door sliding open. A lone figure stood in the doorway. The smoke made it impossible to see them, but from the silhouette, it clearly wasn’t Emerald.

“Are you Steven Universe?”

Chapter End Notes

> Wow, this one came in a bit late, sorry folks! I can't guarantee I'll be adding new chapters to this one as often as I did for the last entries in this series, but I'm still working. Don't think I've forgotten about it! Anyways, I'll get there eventually. I hope you enjoy the ride!

Your New Best Friend

Chapter Summary

A new enemy arrives with a vendetta against Steven and his mother. And she's not alone...

Chapter Three: Your New Best Friend

– – –

"Um...yeah?" Steven wasn't sure why he was so unsure about that. He *was* Steven Universe. But in his past experiences, strange Gems asking him if he either was someone or knew where someone was rarely turned out well. Aquamarine and the Ruby Squad both came to mind. "And, uh, who are you?"

The mysterious Gem let out a high pitched cackle as she stepped into the light. Tall, lanky, and pink, she had a large heart-shaped gem on her chest. However, it was upside-down. She grinned from ear to ear as she stepped closer, though her eyes glared daggers at the young human. "Oh, I'm *SO* glad you asked!" she said, her voice dripping with venom beneath her cheery facade.

"It...it's you," said Pearl. "But that's impossible!"

"Wait...Pearl, you know her?" asked Steven. Amethyst and Garnet were similarly surprised.

"On the contrary, it's *very* possible!" said the pink Gem. "Your old pal Spinel was always one to do the impossible, wasn't she? Especially now that I've made some...new friends!"

Spinel, which seemed to be her name, gestured towards the entrance of the ship she had stepped out of. From within walked another Gem, one whom Steven was a bit more familiar with. "Emerald!" he exclaimed.

The green Gem stepped onto the grass, flanked by a pair of armed Citrines. "Disgusting planet…" she muttered to herself, before focusing on Steven and the other Crystal Gems. "But yes, it is I, Emerald! Commander of Homeworld's spaceborne legions...or at least, I was. Until you came along." Emerald, too, was glaring at the boy.

Just as Steven was about to say something in his defence, Spinel popped up in front of Emerald, pointing at him. "You ruined the both of us!" she shouted.

Emerald sighed. "Spinel, just...just let me handle this." She gently nudged Spinel aside. "Now, where was I? Oh, yes! Thanks to you, Steven Universe, I was stripped of my status as Homeworld's greatest admiral!" She stomped closer; the Gems raised their weapons, but she didn't seem to care. "You disassembled the empire. You tore down everything I had worked so hard to build. You took everything from me! ...Some of it literally."

"Emerald…" said Steven. "When I talked the Diamonds down, I was trying to save Homeworld. I'm sorry about your status and all that, but you're free now! You don't have to follow the Diamonds' orders anymore! You can do anything you want!"

Both Emerald and Spinel laughed at this. "Boy, he sure has that right!" the latter said.

"What do you mean?" asked Steven.

"What she means is, those last two statements were absolutely correct!" said Emerald. "I can do whatever I want...and what I want is to retake what you stole from me, even if I have to tear this planet apart to do it!"

Spinel once more popped up in front of her, causing the green Gem to lean to the side with a look of irritation. "Exactly! And what *I* want *is* to tear this planet apart!" She stepped away from Emerald, who shook her head in exasperation. "This planet that

she loved so much, that she chose over me...I'm going to destroy it all!" She glared at Steven. "Starting with you."

Amethyst rolled her eyes. "Yeah, and what makes you think we'll let you? Heck, what makes you think the Diamonds'll let you? Somehow I don't think they'll be too happy with you two hurting their precious Pink."

Emerald let out a small chuckle. "That's the beauty of it all, little off-color! The Diamonds have no say in this. Me and my...ugh... *new best friend* took care of that." Spinel beamed, while Emerald just groaned again. "And do you know why?"

"Why?" Steven asked hesitantly.

"Why, just look around you!" Emerald exclaimed. She threw out her arms, gesturing all around them. "How can the Diamonds send help to their *precious Pink* , if her horrible little planet...is nowhere to be found?"

Steven suddenly realized what she meant: there were no stars in the night sky. Somehow, Emerald had managed to do...something to make the Earth inaccessible to the rest of the universe. "H-how?"

"Oh, it was no big thang!" said Spinel, throwing an arm around Emerald's shoulders. Emerald slowly removed the arm, brushing off her shoulder. "Do you happen to know anything about...Project: Drawbridge?"

"Um...no, actually, I don't," said Steven.

Spinel deflated considerably at this, quite literally. "Oh. Well, that takes the winds out of my sails. Emmy, you wanna get 'em up to speed?"

"I would love to do nothing more," said Emerald in monotone. "All you need to know, Steven Universe, is that your fellow Diamonds can't help you now. It's just you versus us. And we hold the advantages in this fight. For example...Spinel? Weapon out."

“Right-o, friend-o!” she said excitedly. Her heart-shaped gemstone began to glow. Reaching into it, Spinel pulled out an object that looked quite like a pen. However, once she clicked the button on it, the object grew into the handle of a weapon. A pink blade of energy materialized on the edge, turning it into a scythe, which Spinel held above herself menacingly.

“What...I don’t...Garnet, do something!” shouted Pearl.

Garnet stepped forwards--she lowered her gauntlets, but still kept them on her fists. “Okay...I don’t know who you are,” she nodded towards Spinel, “but *you* need to get off this planet. Now. You and all your cronies.”

Spinel let out an exaggerated gasp at this remark. “Wh--B--J--*Cronies!?* Excuse me, kind madame, but Spinel is *nobody’s* crony! Not anymore!” She waved her scythe at the Gems. “I’ve got half a mind, I do!”

“Spinel, just wait a moment,” said Emerald, holding out her arm. “Steven Universe, I am going to give you one chance to save your world: give me the location of Lars of the Stars and his crew.”

So that was what she wanted. “Is that all?” said Steven. “You just want your ship back? I’m sure if we talk to Lars, we can work something out--”

“There will be no working of anything out,” Emerald said. “Tell me where that infernal Captain Lars and his degenerate crew are hiding, so that I can make them suffer for everything they’ve done to me! I will take back my beloved *Sun Incinerator* by force, or destroy everything on this planet trying. Only you can make that decision, Steven Universe.”

“Wh...no!” Steven exclaimed. “I can’t tell you where Lars is if you’re gonna hurt him!”

Emerald nodded. She grinned, seemingly serene, but it was clear that she was growing tired of this back-and-forth. “I can’t say I expected anything different,” she muttered. “Very well. I’ll simply

have to find him myself. *Without* your help." She looked at Spinel, before nodding towards the Crystal Gems. Spinel grinned.

Faster than Steven could blink, Spinel launched herself at the Gems. Only Garnet was quick enough, grabbing the scythe before it could slice through anyone, as the other three dove out of the way.

"So, you must be Garnet, then!" said Spinel. "Tell me...what was it like when Rose Quartz--er, excuse me, Pink Diamond, left you? To become that?" she said, gesturing to Steven. "What did that feel like?"

Pearl tried to help Garnet by lunging at Spinel, swinging her spear at her head. However, Spinel simply pulled her head into her body like it was made of rubber, dodging the blow. She stuck her tongue out at Pearl before looking back at Garnet, still wrestling with her for control of the scythe.

"No, really, go on, answer!" Spinel urged. "I want to get some info! Did it hurt? Were you devastated? Please, tell me!"

Garnet was trying to stay silent, but opened her mouth to answer. However, as soon as she did so, Spinel interrupted.

"WRONG!" Spinel leaned back, throwing Garnet behind her and regaining her grip on the scythe. "The correct answer was, it didn't. Not nearly enough. And do you know why?" Spinel loomed over Garnet. "Because you got to say goodbye."

Spinel raised the scythe to strike Garnet, but Amethyst caught her wrist with her whip. The pink Gem turned to face her. "Ah, and you must be Amethyst! So nice to meet you!"

"Is it?" asked Amethyst. "'Cause I get the feeling you don't really like any of us!"

Spinel laughed. "Ooh, perceptive, isn't she?" She then flung her arm at Amethyst, the limb extending into a whip much like

currently held. Her hand grabbed onto Amethyst's wrist in a mirror of Spinel's current predicament. "So...what's your next move?"

Amethyst yanked on her whip, pulling the scythe out of Spinel's grip. The surprise caused Spinel to release her grip on the Quartz, who took the time to curl up into a ball and launch herself at her attacker. Spinel, however, was quicker. Both of her legs extended, nearly doubling her height, with Amethyst passing harmlessly between them. Amethyst then collided with Garnet, sending both of them tumbling.

Smirking, Spinel then went to retrieve her weapon, only to find someone had beat her to it. "Well well well, if it isn't pretty little Pearl!" she said. "Good job, by the way. On being chosen by Pink. Over me. I just thought I'd congratulate you."

"Spinel, you don't have to do this!" said Pearl.

"Uh, *duh* !" Spinel said. "Emmy went over that earlier. I'm doing this because I *want* to!"

Pearl tried to gradually creep towards the scythe before Spinel caught on. "Can't you see that Emerald is just using you?" she said?

"The thought has crossed my mind," Spinel said. "But you know why I don't mind? Emerald may say she's my friend, but only be using me for her own ends...but at least she's honest about it. Unlike someone we know…"

Pearl glared at Spinel. Unfortunately, this momentary lapse in judgement also made her move closer to the scythe, causing Spinel to catch on. Pearl dove for the weapon, only for Spinel's boot to collide with her face, knocking her back. The stretchy Gem pulled the scythe back to herself, walking closer to Pearl's dazed form.

"She left you behind too, you know. Abandoned you. Threw you aside. Like *trash* ."

“You can’t speak for her!” Pearl summoned her spear again, lunging at Spinel...who was quicker. With one swing, the scythe cut through Pearl’s form, causing lines of pink energy to spread across her body. Her physical form then disappeared in a puff of smoke, her gemstone falling to the ground.

“Pearl!” yelled Steven. He had stayed on the sidelines for most of the fight, but the shock of seeing Pearl get destabilized caused him to instinctively summon his shield. “Get away from her!”

“Spinel!” shouted Emerald, who had likewise been passively watching. “Stop toying with them and wrap this up!”

“‘Wrap this up?’ Don’t mind if I do!” said Spinel. She sprang into the air, landing on the side of the nearby lighthouse. Her whole body contorted into a spring shape, which she used to hurl herself at Garnet and Amethyst.

Both Gems were able to dodge to the side, but Spinel expected this. Though her initial attack missed, she extended her legs out to her sides. Each one wrapped around a Gem, ensnaring Garnet and Amethyst like a pair of giant pink snakes.

Knowing they would be able to free themselves soon, Spinel pulled the two over to her. Although they saw it coming, there was nothing neither of them could do. All it took was one swing of Spinel’s weapon, and they shared Pearl’s fate.

Great work, great work!” said Emerald as the three gemstones landed in the grass. She sounded genuinely impressed. “Now *end him* !”

Spinel was just about to comply when something slammed into her, causing her to spin around in place. Once she stopped spinning, and shook off the resulting dizziness, she found that the something in question was Steven. He held his shield out in front of him, wearing an uncharacteristic glare. “I don’t know who you are, or why you’re helping Emerald, but I do know that you don’t attack my friends!”

“Oh, he fancies himself a little hero!” said Spinel. “Just like his mommy!”

“Don’t pretend like you know her!” Steven snarled.

Spinel giggled. “Oh, didn’t she tell you? Pink Diamond and me--we go way back! Why, I knew her before she even knew about this nowhere planet!”

“You...knew my mom?” said Steven, his anger subsiding, but only slightly.

“Yup, sure did!” Spinel exclaimed. “In fact, it’s because of her...that I’m going to make sure the only thing left of this planet are ashes and broken promises. Just like what she left me with…”

“What are you--?”

Before Steven could get confirmation, Spinel lunged. Steven held up his shield, expecting it to block the blow, only for the scythe to pass right through it. His shield vanished, replaced with an odd tingling sensation. When Steven looked at his arm, he saw that it was covered with the same pink markings that appeared on the Gems before they had poofed. They soon faded, but the sensation remained.

“Hmm, that’s weird,” Spinel said, scratching her head. “Usually, all it takes is one slice!”

“Hit him again! He’s part Diamond, he might take more!” yelled Emerald, growing impatient.

Spinel complied, striking Steven again and again. The energy blade of the scythe passed through Steven’s body, leaving only the glowing markings behind. “Would...you...stop... *hitting me* !?” Steven grabbed hold of the weapon, trying to wrest it away from its owner.

“You’re a resilient one, little Universe, I’ll give you that!” said Spinel. “But let’s see how well you fare without your mommy’s

help!”

“Enough!” In a fit of sudden Diamond strength, Steven yanked the scythe out of Spinel’s grip. So forcefully, in fact, that the blade cut through Spinel’s form. Like with the three Gems before her, the pink lines spread out over her body. Spinel said nothing, only laughing, as the energy consumed her. Her laughter grew deeper and deeper, until finally, she too was poofed.

Steven took several deep breaths, trying to assess the situation. The Gems had been poofed, yes, but it wasn’t anything he hadn’t dealt with before. He was sure they would be fine--what he was truly worried about was Emerald and her army.

“Looks like I underestimated you, Steven Universe,” she said. “So, have you changed your mind? Now that I’ve shown you what my forces are capable of, will you take me to Lars?”

“Why are you doing this!?” said Steven, sounding more frustrated than angry. “It’s just a ship, you have hundreds of them! What makes this one so special?” He got to his feet, walking towards the green Gem.

Emerald and her guards, however, shied away from him. Or rather, from the weapon he still held in his hands. “So, you’re playing like that?” she said. Emerald ushered the two Citrines back into the ship, with her close behind. “You’ll regret everything you’ve ever done to me! You and Captain Lars both!”

“Wait!” shouted Steven, as the *Destiny Destroyer* rose up into the air. “Where are we? What did you do!?”

Emerald chuckled. Just before the door closed, she offered a small bit of insight to Steven. “You’re in Despondos now, little Diamond.”

Despondos. The last time he had heard that name had been two years ago. Everything rushed back to him: Etheria. She-Ra. Adora. Catra. Skeletor. Horde Prime. Emerald had somehow sent the Earth to Despondos.

As the revelation washed over him, Emerald's ship sped off into the air. He could still see it, hovering just a few miles above Beach City.

However, as Steven collected the fallen gemstones of his family, along with Spinel's, he noticed another light in the sky. He knew there were no stars in Despondos, so there was only one thing it could have been.

Etheria.

– – –

2 years ago...

Although most inhabitants of Etheria believed otherwise, the seemingly-inhospitable desert known as the Crimson Waste was teeming with life. Not just plants and animals, but people as well. Mainly runaways and criminals, there was nevertheless a thriving community among the bright red sands, kept secret from the outside world.

Watering holes were common in this desert, including one frequented by the most notorious figure in the entire Crimson Waste: a desert raider known as Huntara. However, this very same bar had recently been visited by a new, and highly unwelcome, customer.

Broken furniture and shattered glasses littered the floor. As did the battered and bruised forms of numerous patrons. Groaning in pain, nursing their wounds, or simply unconscious, something had torn its way through every single one of them. Or rather, some *one* had.

The amazonian warrior stood stalwart, despite the strength her opponent had shown. "You've got a lot of nerve coming in here and picking fights, after everything you've done," she growled.

"I suppose so," said her foe. Hordak stood in the center of the room, Imp perched on his arm. There was barely a scratch on his

armor. “And with this ‘nerve’ I have displayed, I take it you will reconsider my offer... *Force Captain Huntara* ?”

Huntara scoffed. “Not a chance. I served you once, I’ll never do it again.”

“Is that so?” said Hordak. “And here I thought the philosophy of the Crimson Waste was to serve whoever was the strongest. And haven’t I proven myself stronger than anyone here?”

Huntara gripped tighter to her modified battle-staff. “Not yet you haven’t,” she said quietly. She charged, raising her weapon and bringing it down onto Hordak’s head. Hordak, however, proved himself far stronger than he looked, stopping the blow with a single hand. He threw the weapon behind him, where it embedded into the wall. Huntara tried to follow up with a punch, but Hordak simply caught this as well. He held out his other hand, a glowing light shining from his palm. A red blast of energy shot out, throwing Huntara back into the bar, crashing through it.

Hordak looked down at his armor. “Entrapta truly has outdone herself,” he said, mostly to himself. “Now then...what was that you were saying about me not proving myself?”

Huntara growled. Hordak had torn through the others in less than a minute, but she had lasted nearly twenty. Despite her impressive endurance, her body was beginning to give out. Hordak, being practically more machine than man, did not have this problem. She hated to admit it, but he had conquered the planet for a reason. Reluctantly, she stayed down.

“Good,” said Hordak with a grin. He stepped up onto the bar, addressing all of his latest victims. “Congratulations. You have all been selected to become the latest members of the Horde. Any previous loyalties you possessed are now null and void; you will answer only to me, and me alone. Our first order of business: taking back the Fright Zone from the traitorous Catra.”

The New Horde

Chapter Summary

The Princess Alliance goes to attack a new Horde outpost, where they discover why the Horde has been inactive for so long.

Chapter Four: The New Horde

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Whatever the star-like object in the skies over Etheria was, it was causing quite a stir across the planet. Many who had heard the stories of the times before Despondos thought it could be the first of many of its kind. Those who had never heard of the stars worried it may be some kind of Horde weapon.

Speaking of the Horde, although the Princess Alliance was also concerned about the newly-appeared celestial body, they also had to deal with problems much closer to home.

As the members of the Rebellion sat around the war table, Brightmoon's General outlined the information retrieved by their scouts. "The Horde seems to have set up some kind of base just due south of the town of Almura. The residents have been evacuated, but our scouts have reported that this outpost is much larger than the ones we've previously dealt with. Adding to that, the exact location is also of note: their base is positioned directly on top of a vein of rare metals--exactly the ones the Horde uses to make its armor and robots."

"Then it doesn't take a genius to figure out why they're there," Mermista said. "What should we do?"

"Duh! We should head down there and mess their whole thing up!" said Frosta, eager as always.

Queen Angella wasn't so sure. "I don't think that is the best course of--"

Glimmer, however, was completely on board. "Mom, Frosta's right," she said. "Whatever the Horde wants that metal for, it can't be good. And since they don't know we're coming, we'd be in the perfect position for an ambush. We go in, all of us, and stop whatever they're planning before it even begins!"

"Glimmer, please," said Angella. "We have no idea what they're doing there. For all we know, *they* could be the ones leading *us* into an ambush! We need to at least send in a small scout force first."

"But Mom, that's what we just did!" Glimmer said. "Besides, they can't be all that tough, right? The Horde's been inactive for two years now!"

"Most likely because they've been biding their time," Angella countered. "We have no way of knowing what exactly they've been doing in all that time, but, as you yourself said, it can't be good."

Seeing that tensions were beginning to rise, Adora raised her hand. "Angella--um, your majesty, might I suggest a compromise?"

Angella leaned back in her chair. "Go on…"

"You mentioned that we should send scouts in first. Me, Bow, and Glimmer could do that, and if we get into trouble, the other princesses could be waiting for our signal to bail us out! That way, we can try and do things subtly, but we have a backup plan if things go sideways!"

"Yeah, we'll have a way to ambush the ambushers!" said Bow. "What do you say, Queen?"

Judging by her facial expression, Angella didn't think too highly of the plan. But, given Glimmer's expression, *she* certainly did. "Very

well," she said, relenting.

"Yes! We won't let you down, promise!" Glimmer said.

"You will only let me down if you do not return safely," said the Queen. "Which I have the utmost faith you will. Yes?"

"Don't worry, Mom, we'll be fine!" said Glimmer. To demonstrate, she teleported several times around the room, ending up beside her mother. "I've been practicing!" With that, she warped out of the room.

"Almura, here we come!" said Perfuma, getting up out of her chair. The others followed suit. "I hope we have some time to spend there after we free them from the Horde. I hear they make wonderful cake there!"

"Hey, leave some for me!" said Adora. She was about to leave, when Angella spoke up.

"Adora."

"Hmm?" The girl turned around.

"I've noticed that Glimmer has been a bit restless lately," she said. "She's been wanting to get out into the field more and more. I worry that her impulsiveness may put her in danger." She looked down for a moment, before returning her gaze to Adora. "Just promise me you'll look out for her, won't you?"

Adora, filled with resolve by Angella's request, nodded. "You can count on me, Angella," she said, holding out the Sword of Protection for emphasis. She turned to leave after the others. Angella smiled, knowing that Adora would keep her promise.

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Upon arriving at their destination, the group soon found that the Horde was indeed after the metals present. Huge drills, constructed from the remains of Horde Prime's machinery, tore

through the earth to reveal the coveted material. Horde soldiers and modified cybertroops transported the metal into large trucks, where it would be taken back to the Fright Zone to be refined, and converted into more machines of war.

"I'll admit, this operation is a bit bigger than I expected," Glimmer whispered as she peered out from the trees. "Anyone have any ideas?"

"All we have to do is destroy those giant drills," said Bow.

"Oh, is *that* all?" Adora said. "Why do I get the feeling that'll be easier said than done?"

"Because it probably will be," replied Glimmer. "But we might as well get to it." She pointed towards the nearest drill, indicating its control panel. "If we can hijack that drill, we might be able to use it against the other ones. Let's go!"

Glimmer teleported towards cover, with Bow and Adora following her. They snuck past the guards, avoiding being spotted thanks to more of her teleports. Soon enough, they reached the drill's control room. Only two soldiers were present.

"Okay, here's what we'll do," said Bow. "Me and Glimmer will take out those two, and Adora, you stand guard."

"Got it!" Adora said, saluting. Bow and Glimmer nodded, heading off down the hallway.

While Adora waited for the pair to deal with the guards, she heard someone talking in the distance. Normally, she would have paid this no mind past a quick glance, but she recognized the voice. It was one she hadn't heard in so long.

"Catra?"

In spite of herself, Adora had to see where she was. Scanning her surroundings to make sure there were no troopers around, she

slunk towards where the voice was coming from. Her search led her to a nearby tent, with the flap open; she peered inside.

An incredibly tall figure stood inside, made entirely of stone. Adora recognized him as Callix, one of the Horde's Force Captains. He was holding a data pad of some sort, which is where Catra's voice seemed to be coming from.

"Your instincts were correct," said Callix, his voice deep and slow. "There is enough here to double our current cybertroop count."

"I'm not interested in cybertroops anymore," Catra's voice said. "If Entrapta's theories are correct--which they usually are, surprisingly--then someone else found a way to bring another planet into Despondos. And if they found a way in, that means we have a way out."

Another planet in Despondos? Could that be what the light in the sky was? Adora pondered this for a moment, as well as the fact that Catra was alive and well.

Meanwhile, Bow, having taken out the two guards alongside Glimmer, tried to figure out how to work the drill. "Just give me a minute," he said. "This reverse-engineered Horde Prime tech isn't exactly what I'm used to…"

Unfortunately for them, because Adora wasn't present to watch for guards, one was able to waltz right in and notice two members of the Princess Alliance fiddling with the controls, next to two unconscious Horde soldiers. "Hey!" he shouted, drawing his stun baton and aiming it at the pair. "Don't move!"

Of course, their first instinct was to move. Bow drew his bow and fired a net arrow, but not before the trooper fired a blast of energy from his baton. The shot whizzed past Bow and Glimmer, colliding with the control panel and short-circuiting it. "That's probably not good, is it?" Glimmer said.

The drill, currently rotating at full speed, suddenly and unexpectedly ground to a halt. Callix looked up from his call;

although Adora tried to duck out of sight, his piercing green eyes caught her vanishing. “Lord Catra...I think your old friend is here.”

“You know what to do,” Catra responded. The feed cut out.

“Intruders!” Callix shouted. “Arm yourselves!” Horde soldiers and cybertroops alike dropped what they were doing and began looking for the invaders.

“Guess it’s time for plan B!” said Adora. “For the Honor of Grayskull!”

With a blinding flash of light, Adora was transformed into the titanic warrior She-Ra. Still holding her sword aloft, she fired a blue beam of light from her blade, which traveled into the sky where it burst like a firework.

A short distance away, the other three princesses noticed this. “That’s our signal!” said Mermista. “Let’s go!”

As Adora fended off a group of soldiers, Glimmer and Bow teleported next to her. “Adora, where were you?” asked Glimmer, slightly annoyed. “You were supposed to be our lookout!”

“I know, I know, I’m sorry!” Adora quickly apologized. “I thought I heard Catra, and I went to go look for her, and--careful!”

The giant warrior woman yanked Glimmer out of harm’s way as a Horde bot fired a beam in her direction. The laser missed, colliding with some crates in the distance. “Thanks,” Glimmer said. “We’ll worry about that later, let’s focus on these guys for now!”

Adora’s sword morphed into a shield to block a barrage of lasers, fired at them from a group of cybertroops. Bow retaliated by firing an arrow of his own, which embedded in the ground at the bots’ feet. It then exploded, demolishing the lot of them.

“This is great teamwork and all, but what are we supposed to do about these drills?” Bow asked.

In reply, the sound of creaking metal caught the group's attention. The nearest drill was being pulled up out of the earth by an unseen force; soon revealing itself to be vines. Perfuma made her appearance, carried in by more vines as she tore the machine asunder. "Plan B has arrived!" she proclaimed.

With her came a blast of frigid air and a torrent of water, throwing around the remaining Horde soldiers. Frosta and Mermista entered the fray, freezing one drill and washing another away, respectively.

However, they weren't done yet. A nearby wall of ice began to crack, as though something large was attempting to burst through it. And burst it did, sending shards of ice towards the heroes. The form of Callix stood in the newly-created hole, wielding an underslung drill weapon on one arm.

"Adora the traitor!" he said, pointing the drill at her. "I've waited a long time to face you myself! And won't Catra be pleased when I drag you back to the Fright Zone, along with all your new friends!"

"The only thing you'll be dragging is your sorry but back to Hordak!" said Frosta, as she sent a wave of ice in his direction.

Callix simply thrust the drill forwards, shattering the icy wall to pieces. "Hordak, hmm? Catra was right, you princess types really are behind the times!"

"What's that supposed to mean?" asked Adora. "Did something happen to Hordak? And what's going on with Catra?"

Callix took on a defensive stance, holding the drill behind him. "Come closer and I'll tell you!"

Adora rushed forwards, knowing that Callix would attempt to strike her. And he did, thrusting the drill forwards once more. Knowing it was coming, Adora was able to duck under his attack, and retaliate with a strike from her own weapon.

The Sword of Protection collided with Callix's arm, shattering the appendage. Bits of rock fell to the ground at his feet, but he was unbothered by losing an arm. The rocks simply began to float back towards their original places, and his arm was as good as new.

"Not good enough, princess!" Callix raised his drill above his head, preparing to bring it down on Adora.

"Adora, look out!" Perfuma sent forward some vines to entangle Callix. While these were successful in preventing Callix from attacking Adora, they weren't enough to keep him down. He used his drill to tear through the plants binding him faster than Perfuma could replace them.

Adora continued to strike at the distracted Callix, as did Glimmer. However, even with both princesses striking him at once, they were unable to do any lasting damage. Any part of the rock giant's body that they were able to chip away, he simply pulled back into place.

As Adora and Glimmer battled Callix, Bow noticed something important: on the Force Captain's drill weapon, an exhaust port was located on the back. Steam periodically hissed from the port as the weapon spun. With his knowledge of technology, Bow knew that an exhaust port was absolutely essential to a machine like this.

Not wanting Callix to realize his plan, Bow silently lined up an arrow. He would only get one shot at this before Callix was on to him. He waited for just the right moment, when the rock giant had his back turned, and let the arrow fly. It wasn't a perfect shot, but it hit its mark nonetheless.

Lacking a nervous system, Callix didn't notice when his drill began to overheat. However, he did notice when it began to hiss and groan from the strain. "How did--" was all he managed to say before it exploded.

Of course, Callix himself was unbothered, even with most of his torso missing. He simply began to call the missing stones back into place. Adora was able to notice something before he did: Located in his chest was a glowing green tetrahedron of sorts. This crystal was Callix's true body.

"We have to get to his heart! That's his weakness!" Adora shouted to the others.

"Easier said than done!" Callix replied, pounding his stone fists together.

"It is, so we might as well get to it!" Glimmer replied. She rushed forwards, teleporting out of the way just as Callix slammed a fist into the ground, creating a sizable crater. Mermista followed up by sending a jet of water at the Force Captain.

"Let's see how you handle a little erosion!" she said.

Despite the sheer force of the water, Callix stood where he was, even taking a few steps forwards. "You don't have the thousands of years to spare! Your time is almost up!"

"Oh, is it?" said Adora. One of Perfuma's vines was wrapped around her waist, suspending her in midair. Perfuma thrust her arm forward, and the vine threw Adora straight at the Force Captain, unable to move because of Mermista's torrent.

Adora slammed into him, leading with the Sword of Protection in shield form. The impact was enough to completely break Callix apart; his body broke into pieces, while his core was thrown some distance away. But even this wasn't enough to put him down.

Callix's core levitated into the air, calling the rocks that made up his body back towards him. But before they could reach him, They were blocked by a wall of ice. Frosta, thinking quickly, encased Callix in a chunk of ice before he could regenerate. The rocks collided with the ice, but were unable to do more than stick to the surface as though they were magnetized.

“Behind the times, and yet a force to be reckoned with,” Callix said, his voice coming from the prism. “Catra was correct on both accounts.”

Adora reverted back to her original form, approaching the miniature glacier. The rocks that had been Callix’s body orbited his core, unable to return to it. “Enough games, Callix! Tell us what’s going on!”

“Oh? Nothing beyond the ordinary,” he said. “The Horde is attempting to conquer this planet, and I am honor-bound to aid its leader in that purpose.”

“You keep saying stuff like that,” said Mermista. “You make it sound like Hordak isn’t in charge anymore.”

Callix chuckled. “Proficient strategists you are, I had assumed you would have been able to piece it together by now! But, since it’s apparent you continue to overlook the clues, I will tell you: Hordak disappeared years ago, during Horde Prime’s occupation.”

“He...disappeared?” said Glimmer. “Like, into thin air?”

“Into thin air,” Callix continued. “None know where he is, or even if he is still alive. What is known is that another was more than happy to take his place!”

“You don’t mean…?” said Bow, dreading the answer.

“Is it not obvious? The Horde is now under the command of Lord Catra!” said Callix. “And a truly ruthless leader she is! If only you knew what she had prepared for you!”

“Oh yeah? And what *does* she have planned?” asked Frosta.

“Now, now, I can’t spoil *all* the surprises!” Callix said. “But how does this feel, Adora? Your old friend, now the commander of the Horde!”

“So *that’s* why I haven’t seen her in so long…” Adora said. “This isn’t good.”

“You’re telling me!” said Mermista. “I don’t really know Catra personally, but from what you three have said about her, this...yeah, this *really* isn’t good.”

“So what do we do now?” asked Perfuma, the nervousness in her voice clear.

“Right now, we go back to Brightmoon,” said Adora. “This place is trashed, so I think it’s safe to say the Horde won’t be coming back. We’ll report back to Angella for now, and come up with our next course of action.”

The others agreed. Whatever was going to happen next, chances are things were going to get much worse. Adora knew that Catra was much more ruthless than Hordak, and that combined with the Horde Prime tech at her disposal--she shuddered to think what ‘Lord Catra’ was capable of.

Rebooted

Chapter Summary

Emerald gives the Earth an ultimatum, and Steven deals with the aftermath of Spinel's attack.

Chapter Five: Rebooted

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Panic had more or less set in across the whole of planet Earth. Memories of Horde Prime's invasion were still fresh in the minds of people all across the globe; memories that these vessels, one hovering above just about every city on the planet, each one bristling with weapons, brought flooding right back.

Gems was nowhere near as common in other cities as they were in Beach City, though most people these days knew of their existence, even if they had never seen a Gem in person. Some were savvy enough to recognize the starships above them as Gem in origin. But with Homeworld and Earth at Peace, what these invaders wanted was beyond even the humans' top scientists. However, as the governments of the world scrambled for answers, the invaders would introduce themselves.

A signal suddenly appeared, being broadcast across the globe. Its origin would later be traced to one ship in particular, somewhere above Delmarva, but all the other ships in the fleet acted as transmitters, broadcasting the invaders' message to everyone and every place able to receive it. On every television, phone, anything with a screen, the face of a green Gem appeared. Radios could only transmit her voice, but the message came through clearly, no matter where it was being heard.

"Are you all hearing this?" Emerald asked. She silently inspected some things outside the humans' point of view, confirming that her audio was active. "Good, good. Now then, I'll cut right to the

chase. Hello, pitiful insects! This is Emerald, one of the greatest, if not *the* greatest, fleet commander in Homeworld's history, speaking. I'd ask you to listen for a while, but I don't have to, seeing as you're a captive audience!"

All around the world, people stood in terror, though perhaps not as much as before. Nevertheless, they still waited to hear Emerald's plans for them.

"As even primitive slugs such as yourself are no doubt aware, the former Diamond Authority has been disbanded, and Homeworld's once-great empire along with it, by none other than one of your own. Steven Quartz Universe, son of the traitorous Pink Diamond." The screen briefly flickered to one of Steven, before Emerald returned. "As you might imagine, some of us have taken issue with this little fact. To have Gemkind not only reduced to a shell of its former self, but now living side-by-side with you underdeveloped Earth monkeys, is simply unacceptable. However, primate or not, I am giving your species one last chance to avoid your rightful fate of annihilation at our hands."

The screen now turned to two images: one of the *Sun Incinerator* , and the other of Lars himself, post-resurrection.

"This lowly individual is Captain Lars, also known as Lars of the Stars, a notorious space pirate. Also pictured is the ship he stole from me, known as the *Sun Incinerator* . Captain Lars has taken refuge among you, hiding like a coward while you are in danger. He is also known to associate with a twinned Rutile, a defective Padparadscha Sapphire, two cross-Gem fusions known as Rhodonite and Fluorite, as well as the aforementioned Steven Universe."

The image shifted back to Emerald. Her expression was one of smug satisfaction, as though humanity's surrender was assured. However, due to her twitching eye, it was apparent that she was beginning to lose a bit of her already-frayed sanity.

"You all have a collective forty-eight hours to bring Lars of the Stars and his crew to justice, and return the vessel he stole to its rightful owner. After that, you will all be blown back to the stone age by my like-minded friends. It doesn't seem like too long ago to us, but I imagine it would be quite an inconvenience to you. Attempt to fight back, and you will be met with the same result. Attempt to negotiate, *and you will be met with the same result* . And yes, that includes all of you Gems down there as well. By associating with the humans, you are no better than they are. And Lars, if you're watching this…" She leaned in closer to the screen. "...I hope you realize the importance you now have. If you would simply turn yourself in, this all could be avoided. But it never is that easy with you, is it? I implore you, and the rest of your race, to make the right choice. Emerald out."

The video feed went nowhere, Emerald's face still appearing on every screen across the globe. She glanced around, confused.

"A-are we still live? How do we...No, no, that one's audio, I know, how do I turn it *off* ?" An inaudible offscreen voice directed her to the correct switch. "Ah, I see. Farewell, pitiful hu--"

The feed then cut off.

Up on the *Destiny Destroyer* , Emerald then got up from her chair. "There. I think they got the gist of that," she said. "Before long, the *Sun Incinerator* will be back in my hands, and Lars will be a thorn in my side no more!" She gave a disdainful look over her shoulder at the planet below. "And the Earth will be left in this empty dimension, where it belongs…"

Attention was now drawn to the ships hovering above the world. Heated debates raged on what should be done, but the message was clear: there was only one way to avoid extinction. Where were the Crystal Gems when they were needed?

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Greg shut off the TV. “So...tell me again what happened out there.”

Steven, after Emerald had left, had brought all of the poofed Gems inside, including the hostile newcomer. “She just...she got everyone,” he said. “Emerald and this one,” he pointed to the pink gemstone, “showed up out of nowhere. She used this.”

He produced the pen-like object from his pocket. Clicking it caused it to extend into the energy scythe he had seen Spinel use to cut down the others. Greg, of course, was startled by this.

“What the heck even *is* that thing!?” he asked.

“I don’t know,” Steven admitted. He still held onto the weapon as he explained. “It must be some sort of destabilizer or something, but I’ve never seen one like this before. And I can’t go to the Diamonds, or Hessonite, or anyone else for help. I asked Bismuth to come over as soon as she could, but--”

As if on cue, the screen door to Steven’s house opened, and Bismuth herself walked in. “So, what is it that you wanted to…” She paused when she saw not only all the gems sitting on the table, but also the weapon in Steven’s hand. “... *Wow* . I knew this was gonna be bad, but this is way worse than I thought.”

“Steven! What happened?” Lapis and Peridot entered as well. “Where is she? Where’s Emerald?” The former seemed ready to throw down.

Peridot, however, was immediately concerned over the weapon Steven held. “Steven, where did you get that!?”

“This?” Steven retracted the weapon into its compact form. Bismuth took it to examine it. “That pink Gem with the stretchy powers used it to...well, you can see what she did with it. Emerald said her name was Spinel.”

Peridot was confused. “Wait, why would Emerald have gotten help from a Spinel?” she asked, to nobody in particular. “I mean, I

know Homeworld cultural norms are being phased out, but it still doesn't make much sense."

"Why's that?" Greg asked.

"Spinels are...well, they're basically playmates," Lapis explained. "They're just supposed to be silly and make their owners happy. They aren't built to fight."

"Neither are Pearls," Steven said, glancing at Pearl's gemstone. "She did say she knew my mom, though."

"I don't ever remember Rose mentioning a 'Spinel,'" said Greg. "Of course, I don't remember her mentioning being Pink Diamond, either. But at least that's something she would have wanted to keep secret. Why wouldn't she ever mention her?"

"It probably had something to do with her time as Pink Diamond," Steven guessed. "Pearl seemed to know her, too; we'll ask her once she reforms."

"Yeah, I don't know about that, Steven," said Bismuth. She held up the device: "I don't know how our little friend here got her hands on this thingy, but she clearly didn't want us Crystal Gems getting in her way."

"I don't like the sound of that," Greg said. "What is that thing, exactly?"

"This...is a rejuvenator," Bismuth said. "Homeworld started building these during the War, once too many Gems started joining our side for their liking. One poofing blow from one of these, and everything, your memories, your loyalty, your character development-- *gone* . It'll be like you just crawled outta the ground."

Peridot gulped. "It's like one big reset button."

"Exactly," Bismuth continued. "Once they reform, they aren't gonna remember who we are. They aren't even gonna remember

who *they* are. They'll think they're just...nobody."

Steven looked at the Gems, laying inert on the coffee table. Was it really possible? These Gems had been with him for his entire life, and once they reformed, they'd just see him as one human among millions.

"Is...is there any way we can reverse it?" asked Lapis.

"Well...sort of," said Bismuth.

"'Sort of?' That doesn't exactly fill me with confidence," Peridot said.

"Just let me finish! A rejuvenator doesn't completely erase a Gem's memories, it just blocks them. They're still in there, deep down. Deep, *deep* down. All it would take is to remind them of who they are, but that's gonna be easier said than--"

A bright light coming from the table interrupted Bismuth. Steven, initially hopeful that one, if not more, of the Gems was returning, grew worried when he noticed that it was Spinel's gemstone doing the glowing. He was about to summon his shield, only to remind herself what Bismuth had said: Spinel wouldn't remember them, or even herself.

"Should we be concerned about that?" asked Lapis.

"I don't know, maybe!" said Bismuth. "We don't even know what she was like before!"

A white outline formed around the pink gem. However, unlike before, the gem itself was rightside-up, looking like just a regular heart. Her physical form returned...and she looked far different than she did before. Rather than looking like a demented jester, now she looked like, well, a regular jester. And she was much smaller than before, even more so than Steven. Who, as luck should have it, was the first being she set her eyes on.

Just as her feet hit the floor, Spinel bounded over to Steven, nearly bowling him over. “Well, hiya, friend!” she said, in a voice clean of any and all malice. “Nice to meetcha!”

“Um…” said Steven, unsure of how to react to this. “Do you...know who I am?”

“Sure I do, silly! You’re my new best friend!” Spinel threw her arms around Steven, each one stretching to wrap around him three times over. “We’re gonna have so much fun together, right?”

“Y-yep, sure are!” said Steven, awkwardly returning Spinel’s hug. “Why did I say that?” he added under his breath.

Greg, too, was unsure of how to take this. “So, she’s friendly now, then?”

“For now, at least,” said Peridot. “Hopefully she stays like this for a while. That would be one less thing to worry about.”

Steven walked closer, Spinel still clinging to him. “Okay, let’s look at the factors: the Gems got their memories wiped, Spinel’s apparently my new best friend, we’re stuck in Despondos, and Emerald gave us only a few days before she blows up the planet. We can handle this, right? Right, guys?”

“Nothing we haven’t dealt with before,” Lapis said. “...Wait, what the heck is a ‘Despondos?’”

“You remember, right?” said Steven. “Etheria? She-Ra? The Horde?”

“Of course I remember,” said Peridot. “You mean to tell me that Emerald somehow trapped us in an alternate dimension?”

“Yes, exactly,” said Steven bluntly. “That’s why there aren’t any stars. She used something called Project: Drawbridge.”

“Project: Drawbridge?” repeated Peridot. She had definitely heard of that before.

Meanwhile, Lapis had headed back outside to check on the lack of stars. She had been so focused on helping Steven that she hadn't thought about looking at the night sky on her way over. Bismuth, Peridot, Steven, and Greg followed. Spinel tagged along as well. Sure enough, there were no celestial bodies in the sky, save for one."

"So we really are trapped," Bismuth said breathlessly. "How exactly do you teleport an entire *planet* like this!?"

"It already happened once," Steven reasoned. "Etheria had to end up here somehow."

"And that star up there, that's…?" Despite asking, Greg was fairly certain he already knew the answer.

"I mean, what else could it be?" said Lapis.

Steven, meanwhile, had just been struck with an idea. Currently, Emerald had them outclassed: she had an army, while their best fighters were out of commission. They needed outside help. "I know what we can do," he said.

"Er, and what's that?" said Greg, already worrying for his son's safety.

"We can't fight Emerald on our own, she has too many allies," he explained. "And I don't think talking will work. The only way we'll be able to fight her is if we get some allies of our own. Like the Princess Alliance."

"Are you suggesting flying all the way to Etheria?" asked Lapis. "Steven, no offense but that's...ludicrous! We don't have a ship, and even if we did, we'd never be able to fly past Emerald's blockade. *I* certainly couldn't do it!"

"We may not have a ship, but I know someone who does." Steven ran down the stairs, hurrying down the sand towards the town.

"Hey, best friend! Wait for me!" Spinel hobbled after him.

“Steven, wait!” called Peridot. “Did you not hear the part about Emerald’s blockade!?”

“Don’t worry, I have a plan!” Steven called back, before continuing his run. “Emerald wants Lars so bad? Then she’ll get Lars!”

Rightful Heir

Chapter Summary

Hordak, with help from his new 'allies,' aims to retake his place as leader of the Horde.

Chapter Six: Rightful Heir

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During Lord Catra's time as ruler of the Horde, her forces had started sending more and more scouting parties into the Crimson Waste. According to Catra herself, her interests were in securing the vast desert simply to acquire more territory for the Horde. In reality, however, she was searching for something. Or rather, someone.

Although she had more or less secured loyalty from the rest of the Horde, she knew that Hordak would not approve of her usurping him. And as long as he was out there somewhere, she knew he would try and retake his old position by any means necessary. She had to find him before he found her.

The normally still desert sands were being kicked up by a convoy of Horde skiffs, racing to deliver supplies to the newest outpost. There were dozens of hazards present in the Crimson Waste, so failure to deliver these supplies would mean that the Horde would have to pull out from their new base. Which is exactly what a certain band of raiders wanted.

From up atop a nearby cliff, a small team of Crimson Wasters watched the convoy roll through their territory. The imposing figure that was their leader glared through a pair of binoculars at the invaders. "By my count, there're nine craft," said Huntara. "Four carrying supplies, five escorts. Five hundred meters from the trap, and closing."

“Only five escorts? Catra’s becoming complacent,” the voice of Hordak responded from the other side of a communicator. “Get ready to spring the trap.”

“On my mark.” Huntara looked to the horned woman to her right. The woman gripped tight to the detonator in her hand, her thumb hovering over the button.

Huntara turned her attention towards a cactus that lay just a few meters down the convoy’s path. A large gash had been cut into the plant’s side, a completely unassuming detail to onlookers, especially ones who would rush by it as fast as the skiffs would. But to Huntara, who had carved it herself, it was an indicator of where the trap had been planted. Not directly underneath the cactus itself, but several meters ahead of it, to give the skiffs some time to reach the explosives once they reached it.

The skiffs could faintly be heard speeding across the sands. “Come on, you Horde lackeys, come on…” She held her binoculars tightly, waiting to give the signal. Even slightly early, or slightly late, they would lose their chance. She threw her arm into the air the moment one of the vehicles passed by the cactus. “Now!”

Her ally pressed the button on the detonator. Directly underneath the convoy, barrels loaded with explosives were hurled upwards from their hiding spots underneath the sand. The barrels detonated in midair, showering the skiffs not only with fire, but fragments of magnetic rock found in the Crimson Waste. The skiffs that escaped damage from the initial explosions would still have their navigation systems scrambled by these rocks, making them easy prey.

However, it seemed either Huntara was a split second too late on her call, or her partner was too late on pressing the detonator. The barrels rose in the middle of the convoy, rather than ahead of it, like was planned. A few hit the underside of the skiffs, being knocked aside or back down before they could explode, and dealing minimal damage. A few failed to explode at all. Most of the skiffs were able to outrun the trap, but a few were caught in

the explosions. Minimal damage to most, while one was critically damaged, but still ran. Only two were destroyed, one cargo and one escort. The escort craft spun out of control before crashing on its side, while the cargo skiff fell directly down, skidding to a halt.

Huntara pounded the stone beneath her before radioing to Hordak. "No good. We managed to hit a few, but most of the skiffs avoided the trap. And now they know we're coming."

"Unfortunate, but not crippling," Hordak replied. "We can salvage this yet. Take what you can from the wrecked craft, and leave the rest to the assault squadron."

"Affirmative," Huntara responded. As much as she hated taking orders from Hordak, she had largely gotten used to it, learning how to hide the venom in her voice, if not the scowl on her face. "Let's get down there and take everything still usable," she said to her two companions. She, the horned woman, and a four-armed lizard woman descended the cliff towards the pair of crashed skiffs.

Hordak switched frequencies on his communicator, sending orders to another party. "Assault squadron, prepare to move in."

The convoy, now numbering seven skiffs, was on high alert. It didn't take a genius to figure out that this was a coordinated attack, an ambush. And because the initial trap hadn't taken them all out, a second wave was sure to follow.

And follow it did. As the convoy sped through a canyon, several modified skiffs, hidden on the other side of the mountain, gave chase. These appeared to be stolen and scavenged Horde vehicles, rebuilt with whatever parts the desert raiders could get their hands on. Many of them had a sigil painted onto the wing; a snake with its tongue in its mouth, forming a ring.

Despite their seemingly shoddy repairs, the raiders' skiffs were able to match speed with the convoy. The Horde skiffs closed up

their formation, aiming their weapons at the pirates. They opened fire on the raiders, who were forced to take evasive maneuvers.

Among the raiders, one figure stood above all the others. Literally: he clung to the side of a wing, caring not about the intense speed nor the incoming fire. A snake man with bright red scales, and a whip at his side. “Fire the harpoons!” he shouted.

Two skiffs near the front launched a pair of harpoons at one of the Horde skiffs. The harpoons speared through the metal, causing the cables to go slack as both skiffs slowed down. The one harpooned was pulled away from the convoy, as a third raider skif caught up with it. Raiders began boarding, led by the reptilian with a whip.

Horde troopers drew their stun batons. The raiders, most of whom were likewise reptilian, didn’t have weapons nearly as sophisticated, but made up for that in sheer numbers. Although a few were incapacitated, the raiders were ultimately able to overwhelm the troops. Only one remained, who charged at their leader. His hand went to his whip, snapping it so the tip wrapped around the Horde trooper’s wrist. With another flick, he slammed the troop into the skiff’s mast, knocking him out cold.

“Get this thing free,” the red snake man said. “This is my ship now.”

His lackeys returned to their own skiffs, but not before prying the harpoons free from the hull. All four spread apart, followed by the rest of their squadron, with the intent of surrounding the convoy.

The Horde skiffs continued firing. A raider skiff took a hit directly to the chassis, melting through the hull and straight into the engine. The already-bare-bones skiff fell apart as it flew, before grinding to a halt among the sands, disappearing into the distance as both parties continued to rush forwards.

Now aboard a skiff with proper weaponry, the raider’s leader fired back. The craft’s main cannons pounded against the back of the

proceeding escort skiff. Although its pilots tried to avoid his fire, their craft soon gave out, veering off to the side as the others kept on.

"Only two gunners left," the leader said. "You know what to do."

Several raider skiffs began to advance. The three cargo ships sped up as their escorts pulled back to deal with the hostiles. The raiders once again tried the harpoon strategy, but the troopers were wise to it. One craft's crew was able to cut it free before it could be stopped, while the other fired on its attackers. This, however, wasn't an ideal strategy. Although one of the raider skiffs was destroyed before it could attach to its target, the other had already fired its harpoon. The damaged craft fell to the ground, being dragged along by the Horde skiff. Try as it might, the vehicle was weighed down by the hanger-on, and it, too, fell behind.

"Stop the cargo skiffs, I'll deal with this one!" the leader said. His subordinate nodded as they sped ahead, and he himself pulled towards the last remaining escort ship. Too focused on protecting its cargo, the craft didn't notice his approach.

Taking aim, the red snakeman opened fire, handily disabling the skiff. The Horde vehicle spun out of control, trying futilely to get one last hit in on the raiders before it came to a rest atop a dune.

Smirking at his accomplishment, the head raider threw a fist upwards. "Yes! Let this be a lesson to all who would dare oppose the rightful ruler of the Crimson Waste, T--"

Something rocked his skiff before he could finish. He looked back to see that the last attack skiff had broken free of its dead weight, and had returned to finish its job. The wreckage of several raider skiffs dotted the sands behind it, and it was now set on making him its next victim.

Although he tried to swerve, the escort's marksmanship was superb. Knowing he was about to crash, the head raider waved

one of his lackeys over. Another skiff pulled up next to his own as the Horde craft prepared to finish the job.

He flung his whip towards the ship's mast, wrapping it around the top. Making sure his skiff was directly in front of the enemy one, he stopped it in its tracks. As his skiff pulled to a halt, he pulled himself aboard the raider skiff using his whip. His commandeered vehicle was slammed into by the Horde skiff, destroying the both of them. His self-satisfied grin returning, the head raider motioned to regroup with the others.

Without any escort craft to protect them, the cargo skiffs had been easily taken. Not only would these supplies be put to good use by Hordak's new team, but any supplies that didn't make it to the Horde base meant a victory by default. Satisfied with their haul, the lead raider radioed his new boss. "Tung Lashor here. We've hit the jackpot here!"

"Excellent work, Force Captain Lashor," replied Hordak. "Rendezvous with Force Captain Huntara and return to base."

Meanwhile, Huntara and crew had easily handled their own skiffs. They were surrounded by unconscious Horde troopers, some paralyzed by poison darts, some dealt with personally by Huntara. The three of them had unloaded the cargo skiff, and weren't waiting for long when they saw Lashor's convoy approaching in the distance.

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In the many months Hordak had resided in the Crimson Waste, he had personally managed to recruit just about every raider he had come across. Not only was he rather persuasive, but his exoskeleton made him possibly the most formidable fighter in the entire desert. And in the Crimson Waste, the strong took what they wanted.

His new base of operations was an ancient First Ones ship, which seemed to have crashed into the desert long ago. As his

knowledge of First Ones tech paled in comparison to Entrapta's, he was unable to restore any of the ship's systems, though it made for a passable base in his current situation.

He was interrupted from repairing his suit when Huntara and Tung Lashor entered his new sanctum. "Welcome, Force Captains," he said. "Today's excursion was a complete success. I must commend you both."

"No commendations needed!" said Tung. "I'm just glad to be a part of something greater."

Huntara huffed at this comment. "Right, we have some supplies. Now what?" she asked.

"Now we wait," Hordak said. "Catra will slip up again sooner or later, and when she does, we will be ready."

"So that's it, then?" Huntara said. "We lay low and wait until the Horde makes a mistake, and *then* we attack?"

"Precisely," answered Hordak. "Now, unless either of you have any questions, I would like to return to my work."

Tung Lashor headed out, with Huntara reluctantly following him. She sent a suspicious glance at Hordak as she left, only noticing that Imp was staring at her when he swooped down from his perch in the rafters. Once they were both gone, he landed next to Hordak. "Entrapta, Entrapta," he said in his master's voice.

"Quiet, you," growled Hordak. Nevertheless, he had to stifle a sigh. But there would be time for that later. Now, he had to focus on retaking what was rightfully his.

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A light knock at Catra's, formerly Hordak's, sanctum door. Without waiting for her to answer, Scorpia let herself in. "Heyyyy, Lord Catra," she said, in a slightly nervous tone that suggested that she had some unpleasant news.

Reluctantly, the Horde's current leader turned away from her conversation with Entrapta. "What is it, Scorpia?" she asked, expecting the worst.

"So, you know those convoys we send out into the Crimson Waste sometimes? Well, I just got word that the most recent one has been…"

"Has been *what* ?" asked Catra.

"...destroyed, it's been destroyed," Scorpia said. "Just like the last one. And we don't know by who. But, uh, the outpost never received their supplies."

Catra only groaned, massaging her forehead. "Good to know," she said. "Send out another one, more guards this time."

"You got it, I'll be right on that!" Scorpia said. "So, is there anything else you need from me? Any more orders, or…"

"Not right now," Catra replied. "I'm busy with Entrapta right now."

"Oh, okay," said Scorpia. "Well, if you need anything, you know where to find me!" She departed, leaving the two alone once more.

"Another convoy lost," said Entrapta. "Either those Crimson Wasters are more organized than we thought, or someone's making them attack us."

Catra had often thought the same thing Entrapta had. She, however, kept it to herself, knowing how Entrapta would react. "I doubt it," she said. "If Hordak had been sent to the Crimson Waste, he would have returned to the Fright Zone by now."

"Mmm...I suppose that's true," she said. "But if he's not in the Crimson Waste...where could he be?"

"I don't know," Catra replied. "But we'll find him sooner or later. All we have to do is keep looking." This wasn't a lie, as Catra really

intended to find Hordak. Her reasons for doing so, however, were far different than Entrapta's.

The two of them were reviewing footage Entrapta had taken of the mysterious celestial object that had recently appeared. Now with the benefit of high-powered magnification, it seemed to be a planet of some kind. Neither of them knew what this meant, but it seemed to be surrounded by numerous smaller objects. They were too small to make out at this distance, but they were too intelligently placed to be natural.

"Wait...we have movement!" Entrapta suddenly exclaimed.

"What? Where?" asked Catra.

Entrapta centered the footage as best she could on the object. A tiny shape was moving away from the planet.

"What is it?" asked Catra.

"I can't tell yet," Entrapta said. "But whatever it is, it's headed right towards Etheria…"

Planet-Hopping

Chapter Summary

Steven accompanies Lars and crew as they travel to Etheria, seeking help in stopping Emerald's plan.

Chapter Seven: Planet-Hopping

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"Yeesh. I know I say this a lot, but Emmy's really lost it this time!" said Lars. He shut off the T.V., having just seen Emerald's broadcast for the third time in a row. He still couldn't believe that she was still upset about this whole ship thing, even after all this time. "So, uh...what happened to you?"

"It's kind of a long story," said Steven. Behind him, Spinel was busy rummaging through Lars' things. Peridot and Rhodonite tried to rein her in, to no avail. Bismuth stood nearby, cradling the still-inert Crystal Gems. "That's Spinel. She's my new best friend."

"Uh-huh," Lars said, still not entirely sure what was going on. "Where'd she come from? And what happened to the Gems?"

" *This* happened," said Lapis, stepping forwards. She produced the rejuvenator, extending the weapon into its scythe form.

"Watch where you're pointin' that thing!" said Bismuth, shying away from the blade. Rhodonite, too, pulled away. Curious, Spinel reached out to poke the tip of the blade, only for Peridot to push her arm down.

"Long story short, she--" indicating Spinel, "--and they--" indicating the Gems, "--got mind-wiped. When they come back, they won't remember who they are, just like she can't remember she used to work for Emerald."

“Wait, she was with Emerald?” said Lars. “Then we can ask her what her plan is!” He stood up, making his way over to Spinel. He leaned down, talking to her like one would a young child. “Spinel? Do you know what Emerald wants to do to Earth?”

“Ummmmm...nope!” said Spinel. “I don’t know any Emeralds. I’m Steven’s best friend, and that’s good enough for me!” She hugged him to emphasize her point.

“Yep. Mind-wiped,” said Peridot. “But there’s still a chance! We might be able to restore not just Spinel’s memories, but those of the other Crystal Gems as well!”

“And it’s not like we don’t already know what Emerald wants,” said Steven, trying to squirm his way out of Spinel’s grip. “She’s here for you, Lars. You and your ship. And she’s gonna blow everything up if she doesn’t get it.”

“That seems a bit...excessive,” said Rhodonite. “What exactly are we supposed to do?”

“That’s why I came here,” said Steven. “I think I know what we can do.” He walked over to a nearby window, gesturing for Lars to join him. After a few moments of searching, he found the star-that-wasn’t-a-star in the sky. “Up there. That’s where we need to go.”

“To a star?” said Lars.

“That’s no star,” Steven said. “I don’t know how yet, but apparently, Emerald trapped the Earth in some kind of alternate dimension. But it’s one we’ve been to before. That ‘star’ up there? That’s Etheria.”

“Etheria…” said Lars, memories coming flooding back. “You mean, with She-Ra? The princesses? *Catra* ?”

“Yup, that one,” Bismuth said.

“And I think two of those three will be able to help us fight back against Emerald,” said Steven. “Maybe all three. We don’t know what’s happened there in two years.”

“Alright, I think I get what you’re saying,” said Lars, nodding. “Emerald’s got herself a shiny new army, so we need one of our own. But how do we get from here to there without Emmy noticing?”

“Actually…” Steven said, “I was kind of hoping she *would* notice. We could lead her away from Earth. Buy them some time, you know.”

“Hmm. Sounds risky,” said Lars. “I like it!”

“Y-you do?” asked Rhodonite.

“Sure do!” Lars replied. “Alright, team: warm up those nova thrusters, we’re goin’--”

Lars’ speech was suddenly halted when Bismuth’s arms started glowing. “Oh, she’s comin’ back!” she exclaimed. Everyone gathered around, though they kept their distance to give the returning Gem some room. Spinel clung to Steven.

Amethyst’s gemstone rose into the air. Light warped around the gem, forming the familiar shape of her short frame and wild hair. The form flickered, before settling one one wildly different. As color returned to the small Quartz, it became apparent that while this was definitely Amethyst, it also *wasn’t* Amethyst. Her once long hair was incredibly short, and her body was oddly segmented, almost like a mannequin.

It was Steven who approached her first, cautiously. “Uh, Amethyst? Are you okay?”

She cocked her head to the side. “Amethyst, are you okay?” she repeated.

“Yeah! Are you?”

“Yeah! Are you?”

“I am, thanks for asking!”

“I am, thanks for asking!”

“This is certainly...interesting,” Peridot said. “She seems to have reverted back to her mindset from when she first emerged.”

“So, this is what she was like before she met everyone?” said Steven.

“What you’re looking at here is pre-Crystal Gem Amethyst,” Peridot said. Spinel had walked over to examine the newly-formed Gem. Amethyst shapeshifted to resemble Spinel, who then looked like a kid playing around with a funhouse mirror.

“Should we...take her with us?” asked Rhodonite. “It seems like it’d be dangerous for a newly-formed Gem like her.”

“I wouldn’t worry about her,” said Steven. “Amethyst’s always been scrappy! Right now, she’s just a little…” Amethyst was still copying Spinel’s movements. “...loopy, that’s all!”

“If you say so,” Lars said. “Alright, let’s get ready for takeoff!”

– – –

Steven was pacing back and forth in front of Lars’ house, waiting for him and his team to get ready. Amethyst was pacing back and forth beside him. Spinel sat on the curb nearby, watching intently.

Finally, the one Steven had been waiting for arrived; a portal materialized down the street, and through it came the familiar form of Lion, ridden by Connie. The young woman and her mount came to a stop beside the three of them.

“Steven!” Connie called, hopping off of Lion’s back and up to her friend. “I came as soon as I could--where are they? Is everyone alright?”

“Um…’alright’ is relative,” answered Steven. “None of the Gems are hurt, but the rejuvenator...well, you can see what it did to Amethyst.”

Connie looked into Amethyst’s eyes; the Gem looked back. There was no trace of any kind of personality in them. She was a blank slate, taking in everything around her. “So, this is who she was before?” Connie said.

“So this is who she was before?”

“I should probably mention, she’s been doing that for the last ten minutes,” Steven said. “But yeah, this is what she was like before she met mom, and Pearl, and Garnet. Speaking of, the two of them haven't reformed yet. Three, actually, considering Ruby and Sapphire.”

“Hey, Steven! Who’s your friend?” Spinel, curious to know about what the two were talking about, had come over.

“Oh, I almost forgot,” said Steven. “Spinel, this is Connie. Connie, Spinel. She’s sorta the one who, y’know...made the Gems the way they are now. And then I sorta made her this way now, it’s a whole thing.”

Connie held out her hand, which Spinel took and shook enthusiastically. “She sure is a friendly one,” Connie said. “Why do you think she wanted to help Emerald?”

“Beats me,” Steven said. “But Emerald seems to be getting by just fine without her. Which is exactly why we need to go to Etheria for help.”

“About that…” Connie said. But before she could continue, a thought suddenly struck her. “Wait, about that rejuvenator...Steven, did you get hit by it, too?”

“Yeah, a few times, actually,” Steven said. “It doesn’t look like it affected me, though. Just like the destabilizers. Perks of being part human, I guess.”

“Alright, everything looks about ready to ship out!” Bismuth stepped out of the house, remaining unformed gems in hand. “They’re ready to take off when you are.”

“Great. The sooner we can get Emerald’s attention away from Earth, the better,” said Steven. He turned to Connie: “Did you want to come too?”

“That’s actually what I wanted to mention,” she said. “I think it would actually be safer if I stayed here. Not for me, of course, but what if Emerald starts attacking when she realizes you all are gone? I’d...I’d like to stay behind, so I can help protect Beach City. And my family. Y’know, just in case.”

“Oh, uh, that’s fine!” said Steven. “It’s always good to have a backup plan, right? Peridot and Lapis and Bismuth were staying behind, too, so you can watch each-other’s backs. You’re the New Crystal Gems!”

“New Crystal Gems, alright!” said Bismuth. “I imagine we’ll be looking after these two, too?”

Spinel and Amethyst were both sitting nearby, listening intently to the conversation despite understanding little of it. “I was actually gonna take Amethyst with me,” said Steven. “Maybe someone on Etheria can help get her memory back.”

“Hmm, good point,” said Bismuth. “In that case, you’d better take these ones with ya, too.” She handed Steven the gemstones of Pearl, Ruby, and Sapphire. “You take care o’ them, you hear?”

“Of course!” said Steven, preparing to head inside. Spinel, however, had other plans, following behind him. “Spinel...I’m gonna need you to stay here with Connie and the others, okay?”

“W-what?” said Spinel, looking betrayed. “But...I want to stay with you!” She reached out to grab Steven’s free hand, holding it between her own.

“I know, it’s just that...it could be dangerous, and we don’t want you to get hurt,” said Steven.

“Yeah, just hang out here for a bit!” said Bismuth. “We’ll show you around Little Homeworld! Maybe if you want, you can stay once this is all over?”

Spinel was undeterred. “You’re letting *Amethyst* come with you!” she said.

“That’s because Amethyst is used to danger,” Steven said. He tried to free himself from Spinel’s grasp, but she was surprisingly strong. “Spinel, it’s for your own good!”

“No it isn’t!” Her grip on his hand was becoming painful now. “You just want to leave me here so you don’t have to see me ever again! But I won’t let you!”

Steven actually cried out in pain from Spinel squeezing his hand; this was enough to get her to let go. After the brief silence that followed, Spinel hurried inside the house towards the *Sun Incinerator* . Steven examined his hand for a moment; it didn’t look like it was hurt too badly.

“Well...guess she’s comin’ along with ya,” Bismuth said.

“Yeah, I guess so,” said Steven, sounding slightly annoyed. “We’ll send someone back through Lion once we get there.”

Steven stepped inside the house, passing by Peridot as she stepped out. “What was that about?” she asked. “ I’ve never seen Steven look so...un-Steven-like.”

“It’s nothing to worry about,” said Connie. “So where is this ship, anyway?”

“In there,” Peridot said, gesturing to the garage.

“...You mean Lars somehow managed to fit an entire spaceship in his garage?” asked Connie.

"I was wondering the same thing," Peridot said. "Beats me how he did it. I just hope he can get it out of there without breaking it."

– – –

Fortunately, Lars was indeed able to maneuver the *Sun Incinerator* out of his garage, dealing only minimal damage to both the ship and his house. While Bismuth, Peridot, Lapis, and Connie stayed on Earth, Lars and Steven, Rhodonite, the Rutiles, Padparadscha, Fluorite, Spinel, and Amethyst, not to mention the currently unformed Gems, tucked away in Steven's jacket pockets, rose into the sky towards the absent stars.

They knew long before they could see it that Emerald's flagship hovered just above Beach City. Likewise, it was obvious that she knew they were coming. The occasional blip on the radar indicated they were being trailed, probably by her other ships.

As the air thinned, the *Destiny Destroyer* came into view. "Iiincooommiiing traaansmiiisiooon," said Fluorite.

"Patch it through," Lars said. Emerald's grinning visage appeared on the ship's monitor.

"Captain Lars!" said Emerald, her voice oozing with smugness. "It's so nice to see you after all this time. And you brought me a gift, how thoughtful!"

"Not in the mood for witty banter right now, Emmy," said Lars, doing his best to sound defeated. "We are on a deadline, after all. Just accept this token of our surrender, and leave Earth alone."

"Of course, of course! Once the *Sun Incinerator* is in my hands once again, I will leave good enough alone, you have my word. *Pleasure* doing business with you, old friend."

As the transmission ended, bay doors opened on the *Destiny Destroyer* 's underside. A pair of other Gem warships hung just to their port and starboard, as though daring them to try any funny business.

“Such a shame Emerald managed to get the best of us,” Lars said, his tone exaggerated. “If only there had been something we could have--”

“Uh, Captain? She can’t hear us anymore,” said the Rutile twins. Lars slumped down in his seat. The vessel slowly crept forwards, heading towards the docking bay.

“I would express caution,” said Padparadscha. “Emerald has all of her guns trained on us. She does not want us to escape.”

“Luckily for us, she wouldn’t dare fire on her prized ship!” Lars said. “Get ready to punch it, on my mark!”

The *Sun Incinerator* was only three of its own length from the *Destiny Destroyer* . The crews of both starships were silent in anticipation. Emerald, while silent as well, was beside herself with excitement. Surely nothing could keep her beloved vessel from her now?

“Now!”

The ship’s nova thrusters roared to life. Slipping just under the larger vessel, Lars and company shot off into the distance right out from under Emerald’s proverbial grip. None of the three warships had time to react.

“NO!” cried Emerald. “Follow that ship! Don’t let them get away again!”

The *Destiny Destroyer* turned around and sped off after the *Sun Incinerator* , which had quite the head start. Despite this, the larger ship thundered after it, while the other two returned to their posts.

“It’s working!” said left-Rutile. “She’s following us--and alone, at that!” added right-Rutile.

“Just as planned!” said Lars. “Now all we need to do it--”

The ship was suddenly rocked by a violent impact. It seemed that Emerald was firing on them. "Yooouuu weeere saaaaayiiing?" said Fluorite.

"Evasive maneuvers!" yelled Lars. The *Sun Incinerator* swerved and twirled to evade the incoming blasts. "I don't understand, I thought she wanted to keep this ship in one piece!"

"She seems to be aiming for our engines," said Padparadscha. "I predict she will try to disable us."

"Just what we needed!" exclaimed Rhodonite.

Meanwhile, Spinel was clinging to the back of Rhodonite's chair, treating their evasive maneuvers like an amusement park ride. Amethyst simply watched from the side, unbothered by the sudden movements.

"What are we supposed to do now?" asked Steven.

"I have an idea," Lars said. "Keep this up, I'll take care of this!" With that, he got up from his seat, and made his way out of the bridge.

"Lars? Captain, where are you going?" asked Rutile.

"Heeeee's goooing tooo heeelp!" said Fluorite.

Sure enough, a small object darted out of the *Sun Incinerator* moments later. Lars' voice appeared on the radio; "Time to take matters into my own hands!"

Piloting the Star Skipper, Lars rushed back towards Emerald's warship. Dodging the blasts aimed at the pirated vessel, he opened fire on the *Destiny Destroyer* 's cannons as soon as they came into range. The beams simply ricocheted off the cannons, doing no damage.

"No effect! That worked last time!" he said.

A third party joined the radio conversation, snickering madly. “Unluckily for you, this isn’t *like* last time!” said Emerald. “I’ve upgraded my warship to be leagues above your pitiful craft! You and your band of pirates don’t stand a chance!”

“If the ship is so pitiful, then why do you want it back to bad?” asked Lars.

“Sentimental value!” Emerald unleashed a salvo of missiles, locked on to the Star Skipper. The fighter flew all around the two ships, trying to shake them off.

The tiny dot of light in the distance was growing brighter, and smaller dots were now visible around it. Etheria was growing closer.

“Lars! Just hold on a little bit longer, we’re almost--” Steven was interrupted by a glowing light coming from inside his jacket. “No, not now!” He quickly removed both Ruby and Sapphire from his pockets, and the pair took form.

They looked almost identical to how they looked before. Sapphire still had her serene grace, and Ruby still had her gruff edge. “What the!? Where are we?” snapped Ruby.

“We seem to have found ourselves aboard a stolen vessel,” said Sapphire calmly. “A traitor to Homeworld is also attempting to shoot us down.”

“Not on my watch!” said Ruby. “Hey! This thing have any escape pods?”

“Not last I checked,” Rhodonite said.

“Ruby, Sapphire, glad to see you’re alright,” said Steven. “Now this is gonna sound a bit weird, but--”

“Who’re you?” asked Ruby. “You don’t look like any Gem I’ve ever seen. You a new type or something?”

"Er, I'll explain later," said Steven. "So, you don't remember anything? Rose Quartz, the Earth, Garnet, anything?"

"The only thing I know is that I've gotta keep My Sapphire safe," Ruby said. "And this ship isn't safe at all!"

"Veer left," said Sapphire.

They did so, narrowly avoiding being blasted by Emerald's ship.

"Veer--nevermind," said Padparadscha.

Etheria was quickly approaching. By this point, the surface could be seen, as well as the clouds in the atmosphere. But if Emerald got to them first, it wouldn't matter how close they were.

"Guys, this isn't working!" said Lars. "Nothing I do can scratch her ship, it's too heavily armored!"

Ruby approached the control console. "This thing have any weapons?" she asked.

"I-I think so," Rhodonite said. "We haven't really used them before, but--"

"Well, now's a great time to start! Open fire!"

"B-but Captain Lars said--"

"Your captain's about to be blown to space dust!" said Ruby. "You gotta do what you can to complete the mission, understand?"

"Y-yes ma'am!" said Rhodonite. She and Rutile immediately turned the ship around.

Emerald glared at the screen before her. Lars was in her sights. There was no escaping this time. "Farewell, dear friend," she said. "I would say it has been an honor--but it hasn't…"

Moments before Emerald could press the button to fire, the *Sun Incinerator* launched a barrage of its own. A flurry of laser beams

was hurled from previously-unseen guns, tearing through the *Destiny Destroyer* 's shields. Alarms began to go off within the warship. "My Emerald, our hull's been breached!" exclaimed a Peridot. "Fuel cells eight through fourteen have ruptured--we can't control our course!"

"We don't need to! Stay on them!" yelled Emerald, either ignoring the sorry state her vessel was in, or too gung-ho to care. "Don't let them escape, under any circumstances!"

"It might be too late for that, My Emerald!" a Nephrite said.

Both ships were now entering Etheria's atmosphere. The *Sun Incinerator* , with the Star Skipper by its side, cruised down towards the surface, while the *Destiny Destroyer* tried futilely to follow them. The warship's engines gave out. Its hull burned from the friction, and the guns were torn clear of their places.

Sirens continued to blare. "My Emerald, we're losing all control!" said a Peridot. "Our engines have completely failed! It--it's over."

The *Destiny Destroyer* , damaged beyond all repair, streaked towards the ground below like a meteor. From the last intact corner of the viewscreen, Emerald glared at the retreating form of the *Sun Incinerator* . "Crash positions," she muttered, retreating to the armored safe room of her ship. Several Gems followed her, while others still tried their best to salvage what they could of the failing vessel.

Steven watched as Emerald's ship fell to the earth behind them, fading into the distance as they pressed forward to the horizon. "Why do I get the feeling this won't be the last we see of her?" he asked.

"Emmy's tough like that," said Lars. "She'll bounce back from this, just you wait. But that just makes it more important than ever that we get the princesses' help. You all remember the way to Brightmoon?"

"Leeeead the waaay, Caaaaptaaain!" said Fluorite.

The Star Skipper sped off into the distance, the *Sun Incinerator* following close behind.

Planetfall

Chapter Summary

> After meeting up again, our heroes form an alliance. So do our villains.

Chapter Eight: Planetfall

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The dead of night on Etheria: everyone in Brightmoon was fast asleep. It would not stay that way, however, as a tremendous boom echoed across the landscape, waking all who heard it. Adora's warrior training shifted into high gear, as she leapt out of bed clutching a dagger. She looked around for the source of the noise, but saw nothing out the window. For a moment, she wondered if she had imagined the sound, but upon hearing the commotion from the halls, she knew she hadn't. She followed the source of the murmurs to see what was going on.

"Bow?" asked Adora, running into him upon stepping out of her room. "You all heard that too, right? It wasn't just me?"

"We heard it alright," said Bow. Many of the castle's residents had filed out into the halls, and were converging on the main hall to see what was happening. He looked ahead, wondering. "What *was* that?"

"At this point, I think it's safe to assume it had something to do with the Horde," Adora answered. "They *have* been really interested in that Prime tech lately. You don't think they got their hands on one of those giant robots, do you?"

Bow looked concerned. "I hope not. But, like you said, it's safe to assume…"

Through the shuffling crowd, Adora managed to catch a sudden glimpse of Glimmer standing on a balcony overlooking the

landscape. Wondering what she was doing out there, she went over to her, Bow following after.

Outside, Glimmer was scanning the horizon with a pair of binoculars. “Glimmer?” said Adora. “What’s up? You see anything?”

“Nothing yet,” answered Glimmer, still staring out into the distance. “But whatever made that noise came from this direction, and it can’t be far away!”

“Are...are those my binoculars?” asked Bow. “Where did you get those?”

“Borrowed ‘em.”

“That...doesn’t answer my--”

“You think it could be the Horde?” said Adora. It was mostly a rhetorical question, but nobody knew for sure yet.

“That was my first thought,” said Glimmer. “We know they’re back in business again, so we can’t count anything out. Especially now that Catra’s calling the shots.”

“I still can’t believe Catra managed to take over the whole Horde,” said Bow.

“Me neither,” said Adora. “Well, kind of. It was surprising, but having known her my whole life, it makes a lotta sense.”

“Hold on, I see something!” Glimmer shouted. Adora and Bow looked where she was, but saw nothing. “I can’t tell what it is, but it’s getting closer!”

“What is it? What is it!?” said Bow, growing frantic.

“Here, look!” Glimmer held up the binoculars; Adora and Bow both went to look at the same time, each ending up looking through only one eye. After a moment of searching, they finally found

what Glimmer had seen. Some sort of ship, green in color, was flying towards Brightmoon.

“What the…?” Adora said. “Is that Horde tech?”

“I can’t tell from this distance,” Bow said. “It sort of looks like it, though.”

Glimmer took back the binoculars to look again. “We need to warn everyone,” she said. “Horde or not, that thing’s headed this way, and with that boom, it can’t be good!” She teleported back inside, leaving the binoculars behind. With a worried yelp, Bow caught them before they hit the ground.

“Hang on a minute…” Bow took another look at the approaching ship. “I remember that. I know what it is!”

“What? Not Horde?” said Adora.

“It’s… Remember two years ago, with Steven and the Gems, and--”

“Oh!” Adora took hold of the binoculars, looking at the ship as well. “That’s, um, that’s what’s-his-name’s ship, right? The pink guy?”

“I have no idea how they got here from Earth, but that’s definitely the same ship,” Bow said. “I think we can rule out them being the Horde.”

“Well, maybe not yet,” Adora said. “I mean, it could be a trick. Probably not, though.” The two stared awkwardly at one another for a moment. “I’m gonna go grab my sword, just in case.” She left to do just that, while Bow headed for the main hall.

“Mom, I’m telling you, we can’t take any chances!” Glimmer was already in a heated argument with her mother over what to do about the mysterious event. “We can’t just sit here and wait for the Horde to--”

“If we ‘sit here,’ we’ll be better prepared if the Horde does attack,” said Queen Angella. “And since we don’t know for certain it *is* the Horde, there’s no reason to get up in arms at all!”

“Bit if it *could* be the Horde, don’t you think we should at least send someone to investigate?” Glimmer shot back. “What happened to ‘better safe than sorry?’”

“I already have. And once they return, we can--”

“Glimmer! Your majesty, everyone!” said Bow, waving his arms to get their attention. “Uh, sorry for interrupting. But it’s not the Horde!”

Glimmer teleported nearer. “Then who is it?”

“We don’t know exactly, but it’s the same ship from two years ago, the one that belongs to Steven’s friend.”

“That pink guy? How did they get here from Earth?” asked Glimmer. Bow shrugged.

Queen Angella stood up, stepping closer to the both of them. “If that is the case, I see no reason to prepare for battle.” Unnoticed by her, Glimmer groaned. “However, if the last time they were here is any indication, I can’t imagine this is merely a conjugal visit. We shall go and greet them, and hope they come here on better terms…”

When Glimmer and Bow made their way to the field where the ship would likely land, they found that Adora was already there, Sword of Protection hung on her back. A small battalion of guards followed after them as Angella watched from the castle.

“So...Steven’s back?” said Glimmer.

“We think so, but we aren’t sure,” said Adora. “And we still don’t know how they got here…”

"I think I'd be more interested in why they're here in the first place," Bow said.

"We'll get to ask them in a moment," said Adora, as the ship drew closer.

The *Sun Incinerator* slowed down as it drew closer and closer to the landing point. The Best Friend Squad took a few cautious steps back as it lowered down, coming to a rest atop the grassy field. The doors hissed open to reveal a familiar face: hidden behind age, but there was no doubt that this was the same Steven who had been here all those years ago.

"Hey, it *is* Steven!" Adora said.

"Guys!" Steven's face lit up upon seeing his old friends. He rushed outside, followed by a face that was less-than-familiar to the Etherians. Ruby headed out as well to secure the perimeter, Amethyst copying her every move.

"It's been a while, what happened with--Oh, okay, we're...yeah, we're hugging now." Steven had pulled Adora in for a hug, surprising her with both his strength and the suddenness of the gesture. Spinel hugged her as well, wrapping her arms around both of them. Several times. "Yup, okay, this is--yeah."

"Good to see you again!" said Bow. "Who's your new friend?" He looked around, seeing Ruby, Sapphire, and the newly-rejuvenated Amethyst. "Come to think of it, who are all of your new friends?"

Spinel finally let go, allowing Steven to let go as well. "It's kinda hard to explain," he said. "But basically, this is Spinel, my--"

"--New best friend!" she interjected. "Are you Steven's friends, too? Because that makes you my friends! But not *best* friends, because that spot's taken!"

"Aww, she's adorable!" said Glimmer.

“She didn’t used to be,” said Steven. “Especially since she used to be working with Emerald.”

“Emerald...why do I get the feeling that she’s a bad guy?” said Adora.

“‘Cause she is.” Lars walked over, the other off-colors examining their surroundings. “She’s the reason we’re here in the first place. And not just on Etheria--in Despondos, too.” He pointed up at the lone pinprick of light in the sky.

“So that’s...Earth?” said Bow. “How did she manage to bring it here?”

“To be honest, we aren’t entirely sure yet,” said Steven. “She crashed her ship back there, but she’ll probably be back.”

“That explains the bang,” said Adora. “But what happened to your purple friend? And where’s the skinny one, and the tall one with big hair, and--”

“Like I said, it’s hard to explain,” said Steven. “Do you think we could maybe go back to the castle? It’s been kind of a tough day...”

“Sure!” said Glimmer. “I’m sure Mom would be happy to see you.”

“A lot’s happened here in two years, and I’m sure a lot’s happened back on Earth,” said Bow. “We’d be happy to--”

For a third time, Steven’s pockets began to glow. A smooth oval gemstone rose out of his jacket, coming to a rest in midair. Ruby jumped in front of Sapphire, who didn’t react at all. “Oh boy,” Steven said. “Remember how you were asking where Pearl was?”

Unlike the other gems, Pearl’s appeared to have some sort of holographic shell around it, shaped like a clam. “Administrator identified. Please input your preferred designation.” It sounded like Pearl’s voice, but it was clear that it wasn’t her talking.

"...I'm Adora," Adora said. The gemstone did seem to be facing towards her, after all. "Is this normal for her? Because I--"

"Identity confirmed: Imadora. Please input customisation options."

Adora looked back and forth between the others. "Um...Pearl? Is that you? Because this feels a bit...weird."

"Default appearance set. Congratulations on your new Pearl!"

"Uh, thanks." Pearl's physical form finally began to appear. Once her color had been restored, she resembled her appearance before she had become a Crystal Gem, complete with pink skirt. "W-what was that about, exactly?"

Pearl opened her eyes, smiling widely. "Greetings, My Imadora!" She bowed to Adora, who was still confused. "I am your humble Pearl, and I will do whatever is needed of me to serve you!"

"What!?" shouted Bow and Glimmer.

"Oh, no," said Steven, his face in his hands.

"Uhhhh…" said Adora.

"Well, this just got even weirder," said Lars.

– – –

Several miles away, a long trench had been dug into the ground. Not by hand, but by the impact of a large object: specifically, the *Destiny Destroyer* , which had come to a rest by a mountainside. The ship had been completely totaled, and was unlikely to be repaired any time soon.

But while the ship was totaled, its occupants were very much still alive. Pieces of broken metal were pushed aside, and Emerald pulled herself from the wreckage. "LARS! You've evaded me for the last time! Next time I get my hands on you, I'll wipe that smirk off your stupid organic face!" She dusted herself off, taking

in her surroundings. “MY SHIP! That’s twice--no, *three times* Lars has taken my ship from me!” She took a moment to compose herself, leaning up against the *Destiny Destroyer* ’s wreckage. “Peridot, status report.”

A Peridot pushed her way from the rubble. “Yes, My Emerald. By my readings, most of the personnel are unharmed, and some of the equipment survived, but due to damage sustained from the crash, the ship has been rendered...er...inoperable.”

Emerald glared at nothing in particular. “Fantastic,” she muttered. “Can we at least communicate with the rest of the fleet?”

“We can most likely put something together, but it may take some time,” the Peridot said.

“Then there’s no reason not to get started,” said Emerald. She banged on the side of the ship. “You hear me in there? Get to work!” She looked out at the horizon, content at having solved all of their problems. “Soon, Lars. Soon…”

“Uh, My Emerald?” said the Peridot, worried. “I’m detecting several energy signatures headed towards us. No telling if they’re hostile or not.”

“Energy signatures?” said Emerald. “What is there on this backwater planet that could possibly produce enough energy to register on--” She trailed off as she saw what was approaching: several Horde skiffs, moving to surround the wreckage. Numerous troopers disembarked, all of them armed. “Oh. *Locals* ,” Emerald said.

The soldiers aimed their stun batons at the Gems. “By order of Lord Catra, don’t move!” one of them shouted.

“Stand back, Peridot, I know how to deal with their type,” Emerald said. She stepped forward, trying to sound as menacing as she could manage. “Hear me, feeble organics! For I am Emerald, the greatest--OW!” Her thought process was interrupted as a stun blast collided with her head.

“I said don’t move!” the same trooper yelled.

“How dare you fire upon me!?” yelled Emerald. “Once my legions pull themselves from the wreckage, I will rain--Ow! Again!?”

“Final warning!” said the trooper.

“You don’t give warnings! *I* give warnings! And I’m warning you--Stop it!”

One of the Horde soldiers turned to another. “You’d think she’d have taken the hint by this point.”

“Prepare to open fire, on my mark!” said the first trooper.

“Hold on.”

At this voice, all of the troopers lowered their weapons. Emerald watched as the sea of green parted to reveal a smaller figure in red and grey.

“And...who are you, exactly?” asked Emerald.

“Who am I? I’m the one in charge here,” said Catra. “And who are *you* ?”

“Me!? I am Emerald, the greatest admiral Homeworld has ever seen! Entire galaxies tremble in fear of my military prowess!”

“Uh…” Catra looked past Emerald at the wrecked ship. “...I’m sure they do. But right now, I’m gonna need you to come with us.”

Emerald was aghast. “What!? Never! The great Emerald is nobody’s prisoner!”

“Uh-huh,” said Catra, unimpressed. “And does ‘the great Emerald’ always crash her ship?”

Wh--j--No!” Emerald stammered. “I’m only here because that infernal Lars of the Stars managed to slip through my grasp once again!”

“Lars?” Memories of being shocked with her own stun baton came flooding back to Catra. “He wouldn’t happen to be pink, would he? Scar over one eye? Stupid cape?”

“Yes! That’s him!” said Emerald. “And he stole that cape, I should add! Just like he stole his ship--it’s *my* ship!” Emerald paused as she realized something. “...Why? Do you know him, too?”

“You could say that.” Catra made her way past Emerald and climbed onto the wrecked ship, perched as if it was a throne. “Well, ‘the great Emerald,’ it seems like we have a common enemy in this ‘Lars of the Stars’ character. How about if, instead of coming with us as a prisoner, you came with us as a guest?”

She considered this for a moment. “And what exactly would I have to gain from working with a lowly organic?”

Catra scoffed. “Like it or not, Emmy, this ‘lowly organic’ is much more equipped than you. She knows the terrain, unlike you. She knows her enemies better than you. But like you, she has a vendetta against Lars and his allies. Like it or not, sweetheart, but I’m your best chance at revenge.”

Emerald growled, furious at being shown up like this. However, as much as she hated to admit it, the snarky feline had several good points. “...Fine,” she said begrudgingly.

“I’m glad to hear it!” Catra said. She hopped down from her perch, throwing an arm around the (much taller) Emerald. “So, shall we head back to the Fright Zone?”

“Very well,” Emerald said. “Get everything you can salvage in working order!” she said to the Peridot, who saluted. “And send everything over to...where was it, again?”

“The Fright Zone,” said Catra, as she and Emerald stepped aboard a skiff. “I think you’ll like it there…”

Allies on Etheria

Chapter Summary

> While Steven worries about his recurring dreams, Catra introduces the others to her new friend.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter Nine: Allies on Etheria

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" *Steven…* "

" *You must find…* "

" *The sword…* "

"My *sword* …"

" *Steven* !"

Just as he had before, Steven woke up with a jolt. The same dream. That same dream, with that same castle, that same voice, and that same sword. It was obvious that someone, he had no idea who, was trying to tell him something. But what? What was this sword, and where was he supposed to find it? Seeing as it was already daytime, Steven figured there was no point in trying to fall back to sleep. After taking a brief moment to remember where he was (a guest room in Castle Brightmoon), Steven got to his feet and prepared to leave when someone else opened the door.

"Hey, Steven?" It was Spinel. "That's the matter? I heard you shout, so I figured something was wrong. Nothing's wrong, is it?"

He shook his head. “No, just another bad dream. Wait...were you waiting out there all night?”

“Of course,” said Spinel, as if it were obvious. “You’re my best friend! I don’t *ever* want to leave you alone!” She threw her stretchy arms around Steven again, pulling him closer to her.

“I...don’t think you have to worry about that,” said Steven. “We might be stuck here for a while because of Emerald. You don’t remember anything about her, do you?”

“Mmmmm...nope,” Spinel said. “All I know is that you’re my--”

“New best friend, I remember,” Steven interjected. “Come on, let’s go see what everyone else is doing.” He walked out the door, heading towards the main hall, with Spinel right on his heels.

Spinel could certainly be a bit overbearing, but that wasn’t why Steven was so apprehensive around her. Rather, it was because of what he had seen before she was rejuvenated. Whoever Spinel had been, she had known his mother, and something between them made her want revenge. Given that she was willing to side with Emerald, he shuddered to imagine what would happen once she got her memories back.

Steven could hear talking in the distance, which he headed towards. As he got closer, he could make out the voices as Pearl and Adora; they seemed to be arguing over something. Or rather, Adora was trying to get something from Pearl, who wasn’t listening.

“No, it was the big one!” said Adora. “The big shiny one with the blue jewel in the middle! The one you took from my room!”

“Ah, of course!” said Pearl. Steven rounded the corner just as she produced a sword from her gemstone, handing it to Adora. It looked nothing like the Sword of Protection. “Here you are, My Imadora!”

“That’s not--” Adora just groaned in defeat, taking the weapon. “Oh, Steven, you’re up early.”

“So are you,” said Steven. He nodded towards Pearl. “Is...is something going on?”

“She ate my sword and won’t give it back!” said Adora, pointing at Pearl.

“I am simply storing it inside my gem for safekeeping,” Pearl said.

“Can I...have it back now?” she asked quietly.

“Certainly. What is it you would like to retrieve?”

Adora shot Steven a pitiful glance, who only shrugged in response. “My sword,” said the former. “The Sword of Protection, the one with--”

“Sword of Protection, right away.” With a glowing light, Pearl produced another sword, the correct one this time. Adora quickly snatched it away, clinging to it like it was her child. “I am glad I could be of service, My Imadora!”

“Um...yeah, me too,” said Adora. She took a step away from Pearl, who just took one towards her, staring up at her with wide eyes. “This feels so weird!” she whispered aside to Steven. “She wouldn’t leave me alone all night!”

“How do you think *I* feel?” replied Steven. Spinel clung as tightly to him as Pearl did to Adora, though more literal in the pink Gem’s case. “It’s like she’s from opposite-world. All the Gems are. Pearl wants to be a servant, Amethyst’s acting all quiet and stuff, Ruby and Sapphire aren’t fusing--I don’t like it!”

“But hey, at least you still have me!” said Spinel.

“Yeah, I do,” Steven said quickly, almost dismissively. “Yesterday, I tried getting them to remember who they were--no, who they *are*

, but they weren't listening. They might as well be completely different people now."

The two of them and their respective hangers-on strolled through the corridors of the castle. "I'm sure you'll get through to them eventually," Adora said. "You were such a big part of their lives, they're bound to remember something sooner or later, right?"

Steven nodded. "I hope so." He stopped by a window, staring out into the garden below. A patrolling guard was being tailed by an exact double of herself, the only difference being that the copy was purple. Amethyst copied the guard's movements as closely as she could, which had evidently been going on for a while, given how annoyed the guard seemed. "Adora...you have a sword, right?"

"I do, no thanks to her," she said, shooting a glance back at Pearl. "Why?"

"Well...it's just…" Steven struggled to find the right words. "Adora, when you first found your sword, did you have any weird dreams? Telling you to find it, or something like that?"

Not immediately grasping the implications, Adora explained. "Yeah, actually. After me and Catra found it in the woods, I I got these really weird visions of Light Hope talking to me." She looked sorrowfully down at the blade. "I wish she was still around. There's so much about being She-Ra I still don't understand." It hit her. "Why do you ask?"

"Because...I've been having some dreams, too," said Steven. "Over the last few days. There's a castle, and this voice is telling me to find a sword. Just earlier today, he said it was his sword. And I...I have no idea what any of it means. I just figured that since you had a magic sword, you must have been through something similar."

Adora wasn't sure what to say. I...I don't know what this means, either," she said. "Light Hope never mentioned anything about any

other swords. Do you think this could have something to do with you being half-Diamond?"

Steven had explained everything yesterday, as had Adora.

"I don't know, but I know it has to have something to do with everything that's been happening lately," said Steven. "Emerald's faction and the Horde both attack after I've been having these dreams? It has to mean *something* …"

Before either of them could comment further, not that there was really anything to be said, a voice called out to the two. "Steven! Adora!" Bow came hurrying over from the direction of the main hall. "I'm glad you're awake already, we have to get the team together and head out, now!"

He ran further down the hall, the two of them following. "What's going on?" asked Adora. "Is it the Horde?"

"The Horde and then some!" Bow said. "We just got word that they're setting up some kind of huge base at the border of the Crimson Waste. And judging by the size, they're preparing for something big. There's no time to wait around!"

"Ooh, this should be fun!" said Spinel, running after them.

"Looks like you were right," Adora said to Steven. "Back in business!"

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"So...what do you think Catra's bringing back?" asked Scorpia. She and Entrapta waited by the entrance to Catra's sanctum for her to return. She and her entourage were on their way back, bringing an unknown package with her.

"I don't know," Entrapta replied. "She was really cryptic about it. She would have just told us if it was more First Ones tech, right?"

Scorpia looked around, taking note of all the cybertroops and the like nearby. "We've kinda got a surplus of that stuff right now. Even if she is bringing some more, I don't know why she'd be so excited."

"Looks like we're about to find out," Entrapta said. A platoon of Horde skiffs sped back to the Fright Zone, Catra's among them.

As the skiffs came to a halt, Catra hopped out of hers, landing in front of Entrapta and Scorpia. "I take it you got my message?" she said.

"Well, we...certainly did," said Scorpia. "What exactly was it about? You said you were bringing something back, and we should be waiting for you?"

Catra grinned, looking as sinister as she did pleased. "Not something, someone. And I have the feeling that someone will be exactly what we need to take down the Rebellion. Emerald! Come on out!"

Emerald, previously unnoticed by the pair, disembarked from the same skiff as Catra. She was occupied with examining her surroundings intently, taking in everything the Fright Zone had to offer. "So, this is the place," she said. "I have to admit, it is impressive. But only a little bit. In a way, it almost reminds me of Homeworld. Again, only a little bit."

"Ooh, a Gem!" Entrapta got right up in her face, causing Emerald to lean way back with an indignant expression. "Ever since the Crystal Gems left, I've been dying to meet another one! I've got so many experiments I'd like to--"

"Bah! Get away from me!" huffed Emerald, taking a step back. "Cursed organics," she added under her breath.

"Huh. What's a Gem doing here?" asked Scorpia. "And why does she want to help us?"

Catra was about to explain, only for Emerald herself to speak up. "I'll tell you why! I don't *want* to help you, but I'm doing it anyway to get revenge on Lars of the Stars and get my ship back! And unfortunately, working with you is the best way to accomplish that…"

"Well, we're glad to have ya!" Scorpia tried to give Emerald a hug, but the green Gem held out an arm and blocked her. After a few seconds of trying, she gave up; "Alright, we'll, ah, we'll put a pin in that."

"Hmmph. Are these really the subordinates you want to surround yourself with?" Emerald asked Catra.

"Hey, they get the job done," Catra said with a shug.

"It doesn't seem right to me," said Emerald. She strolled inside like she owned the place, completely ignoring any of the guards. Catra followed, amused. "Take mine, for example. The Gems under my command are disciplined, efficient, and unfailingly loyal. Why wouldn't they be? I trained them myself! By contrast, your generals seem a little...well, I can't speak for their loyalty, in any case. I could give you some pointers."

Catra considered. "You know, Emerald, I feel like the two of us are more alike than I thought."

Emerald scoffed. "I'm not sure if I should take that as a compliment or an insult." Their path had taken them to a factory, where Horde bots and cybertroops were being constructed. "You seem to have the right idea about weapons, at least. But what good are all of these robonoids if you aren't using them?"

"Excuse me?" said Catra. "You only just showed up an hour ago, why do you act like you know so much about this war? And of course we're using these!"

"Obviously not enough," Emerald muttered. "You see, Catra, the keyword here is 'war,' not 'massacre.' Given what I remember of this pitiful planet from the last time I was here, your Horde is

much more technologically advanced than this rebellion you fight. If this technology was properly used, you should have flattened them in mere days."

"And why do you suddenly know much more about this than I do?" said Catra, beginning to grow frustrated.

"Because I *do* ," Emerald said. "I am the greatest admiral Homeworld ever had. While your ancestors were still starting fires with sticks, I was conquering entire planets before noon. This may be your turf, Catra, but you can't deny that I have the experience."

This prompted a raised eyebrow from Catra. "Really? And if you're so experienced, why does one simple pink boy in a spaceship give you so much trouble?"

Emerald's temper flared, wheeling around to face Catra. "He is nothing! If he didn't have my ship, I'd have blown him into space dust the moment I had the opportunity! This is not a matter of competence, it is merely--"

"I never said it was," Catra said, smirking. "Looks like this Lars is a touchy subject for you, though."

All Emerald did to reply at first was growl. She turned away, and continued talking after a pause. "Like it or not, we need each other's help to win."

"Do we, now? And what does Homeworld's greatest admiral suggest we do?"

Emerald didn't pick up on Catra's sarcasm. "Easy. As I said, this is a war, not a massacre. If we want to change that, we'll need to hit them fast and hard, with everything we've got. As soon as my Gems can contact the rest of my fleet, we'll blow those princesses back to the stone age!"

"Hmm...promising," Catra said. "In the meantime, we'll--"

“ *What we’ll do* in the meantime,” Emerald interrupted, “is test their capabilities. You have experience with the Crystal Gems, the Rebellion, and Lars alike, while I don’t. I’ll need to see what they’re capable of so I can form a plan of attack. We’ll set up a false base for them to attack, making them think they’ve won. From there...well, we’ll see where it goes.”

“That’s a terrible idea,” said Catra.

“Hey, who among us two has conquered the most planets?” snapped Emerald. “Exactly, that’s what I thought. Unless you have a better idea, we’ll proceed with my plan.” Emerald walked off into the facility with an air of pompous pride about her. Catra growled as she left.

Entrapta and Scorpia had entered in time to see the tail end of their conversation. “What happened?” asked the former. “It sounded like you two were fighting.”

“We kind of were,” Catra said, her tail twitching. “Emerald seems to think she’s in charge just because I suggested we team up.”

“I knew I didn’t trust her,” Scorpia said. “The moment I saw her, I thought to myself, ‘this lady’s bad news!’ And I was right! We should--”

“Hold it,” Catra interjected. “I don’t trust her either, but like it or not, Emerald’s our best hope at beating the princesses. We’ll just have to put up with her for now.”

Catra followed after Emerald, hoping her new ‘friend’ wouldn’t completely wreck the place. Once she left, Scorpia and Entrapta shared a glance, unsure of where this new alliance would lead.

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By this point, the fleet of rogue Gem starships that hovered above the Earth was unknown to nobody. Attempts had been made to contact these ships, but none had been answered. As far as everyone knew, destruction was imminent. And so widespread

was the threat, one would have to live under a rock not to know of it.

And in at least one case, even someone living under a rock knew. Poking her head out of her (supposedly) temporary shelter, Jasper stared upward at the numerous warships orbiting the planet.

"Huh," she said gruffly. "Interesting." She went back inside without a second thought.

Chapter End Notes

> Sorry if it feels like things are going a bit slow. I promise this is building up to something, just you wait!

Down and Out

Chapter Summary

The Princess Alliance attacks the Horde outpost, unaware they're being watched. Steven finds himself unable to access his powers.

Chapter Ten: Down and Out

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It was just as the scouts had said: the Horde was setting up a truly massive fortress at the edge of the Waste. Soldiers, weapons, bots--it was as though they were preparing for an invasion of some kind. Unknown to them, so was the Princess Alliance.

"Just as I suspected: heavily-fortified," said Bow, viewing the base from afar through his binoculars. "But why here? And what are they preparing for?"

"Whatever it is, they sure aren't prepared for us!" said Frosta.

"Not so fast," said Adora. "Maybe they *are* preparing for us. For all we know, they could be waiting to ambush us."

A shape rustled through the bushes next to her, sticking out his equine head. "Well, then why don't we turn that back around on them?" said Swift Wind. "Ambush the ambushers!"

"I like that plan!" said Frosta.

"As long as we can stop what they're doing, I'm all ears," said Glimmer.

"But we don't even know *what* they're doing!" Adora said.

“Then why don’t we find out?” Now it was Steven’s turn to speak. “I know we aren’t really in the position to ask them, but there has to be someone or something in there that knows.”

“Great! Let’s go get the others!” Frosta excitedly ran back to their temporary camp. Glimmer teleported after her.

Adora shook her head. “I don’t like this, Bow. The Horde is up to something. I don’t know what, but I can’t shake the feeling that something’s up here.”

“I’m sure they are, Adora. I trust your gut,” said Bow. “But everyone’s here. We could take everything Horde Prime had to throw at us, so what can these guys do?”

“With Catra in charge? I hate to imagine…” Adora said. Nevertheless, she too regrouped with the rest. “But that’s just all the more reason to put a stop to it!”

Hidden within the forest was the *Sun Incinerator* , next to which the rest of the team waited for their next move. Despite Steven’s insistence, Spinel had tagged along, as did Amethyst, Ruby, and Sapphire. And Pearl absolutely refused to leave Adora’s side.

“So, we have a plan yet?” asked Mermista. Spinel hurried over to Steven, and Pearl to Adora. “Or are we just winging it?”

“I’m thinking something like what we did at Almura,” said Bow. “We split into two teams, and attack at different angles.”

“And, er...what should we do about...or friends, here?” asked Perfuma. She indicated the Gems, none of whom were exactly in fighting shape. Save for maybe Ruby, but she was practically glued to Sapphire.

“Don’t worry about them,” said Lars. “I’ll watch them while you guys take care of the Horde over there.”

“Theeeeey’ll beeee saaaaafe heeere,” said Fluorite.

Steven turned to his newfound best friend, hoping she wouldn't resist too much. "Did you hear that, Spinel? It might get dangerous in there, so you need to wait here with Lars, okay?"

"But...but I'm your best friend!" protested Spinel. "We have to stick togeth--"

"I know, but I don't want you to get hurt," Steven said. "It'll only be for a little while. Lars and the off-colors will take care of you, okay?"

Spinel looked very much like she wanted to argue further, but didn't for one reason or another. Luckily, Adora had had more luck getting Pearl to stay; she had taken it as a command, standing patiently beside the ship. The Gems occupied, Steven and the Princesses set off to begin their assault.

The team split off into two smaller groups. Bow, Glimmer, Perfuma, and Frosta went to attack from the west, while Steven, Adora, Swift Wind, and Mermista headed to the east side. Everyone hid behind nearby trees, waiting for the signal. "Everyone ready?" said Adora.

"Ready when you are!" said Steven.

"For the Honor of Grayskull!" In a flash, Adora was transformed into She-Ra, sprinting towards the fortified wall of the base. A single swing was all that was needed to cleave through it. A path now open, the others charged as well. Over on the other side, Bow detonated his explosive arrow, blowing a similar hole in the wall. His team entered as well, catching the Horde troops unawares.

Steven held out his arm, preparing to summon his shield. But, much to his confusion, the pink disc would not appear. No matter how hard he tried, how much he concentrated, his weapon could not be summoned. "What the? What's happening?" he asked, to nobody in particular.

“Hmm? What’s wrong?” asked Swift Wind, noticing his plight. He flew over to Steven just in case any stray shots should come the latter’s way.

“It’s my shield,” he said, still trying to bring it out, to no avail. “It won’t...I can’t make it appear! I don’t know why!”

“Come on, over here!” As the battle heated up, Swift Wind pulled Steven into cover behind a nearby building. “So, uh, has this happened before?”

“Not really,” answered Steven. “I had a little trouble with my powers back when I was younger, but that was different!”

“Well, maybe it’s a confidence issue,” Swift Wind suggested. “Do you *believe* you can bring your shield out?”

“Of course! I’ve done it more times than I can count!” Steven dug down, searching for any last bit of power within himself. Despite all of this, all that he could muster was a small flicker of pink light on his forearm. The exertion caused him to fall to his knees. “What’s going on?” he said quietly.

Swift Wind looked around uncomfortably. “Look, buddy, this isn’t really my area of expertise. I do know that sometimes Adora’s powers don’t work so good, but--”

Steven’s eyes suddenly went wide, as he realized what was happening to him. “The rejuvenator…”

“The who now?”

“The rejuvenator, Spinel’s weapon!” said Steven. “That’s the thing that made all the other Gems forget who they were! I thought it didn’t work on me, but...I guess it did.”

“Do any of your other powers work?” asked Swift Wind. “What about that one where you turn into that bigger person?”

“I need Connie to become Stevonnie,” said Steven. “But let’s see…” If he couldn’t summon his shield, there was still a chance he could create a bubble. Once again, he tried to bring out his latent powers, but no bubble appeared. “No…” Desperate for even the tiniest fraction to remain, Steven bent down to pluck a blade of grass, before licking his finger and placing it on the end. It did not grow back. “No! My powers are gone! Now what am I supposed to do!?”

“Uh, just lay low for now,” said Swift Wind, preparing to take to the air. “Leave this one to us, and we’ll talk about this once it’s safe.” He flew off, leaving Steven behind with no powers to call his own anymore.

Deeper within the fortress, the Princess Alliance fought the Horde’s forces. Adora took on droves of soldiers at once, cleaving through bots and cybertroops. “Heads up!” Shifting the Sword of Protection into a whip, she caught a Horde troop by the leg and tripped him up before he could stun Bow.

“Nice catch!” shouted Bow. “Perfuma! Give me a boost!” He notched a trio of arrows, bracing himself as a group of cybertroops approached.

“Coming up!” A large vine summoned by Perfuma appeared beneath Bow, throwing him into the air. He let the arrows fly, each one hitting their mark. As he was coming closer to the ground, a wave of water caught him, slowing his descent.

“Gotta watch yourself!” said Mermista. She threw a torrent at a battalion of soldiers, washing them aside.

Unbenounced to the princesses, their battle was being watched from miles away. Catra and Emerald saw everything through the eyes of the Horde’s robots, the latter watching especially intently. “I still don’t get what the purpose of this is,” said the former. “If we wanted to attack them, why not go all out?”

“We can’t afford to, at least not yet,” said Emerald, not taking her eyes off of the monitor. “We need to learn everything we can about your enemies before we can truly fight them.”

“And we need to waste good resources to do that?” said Catra.

“Trust me, this is more than worth the cost,” Emerald replied. “Now, prepare the cybertank.”

Back at the battle, Swift Wind landed near Adora, knocking a pair of Horde soldiers away. “Where’s Steven?” she asked.

“His powers aren’t working, so he’s hanging back,” said Swift Wind, blocking incoming stun blasts with his wings.

“What? What do you mean, his powers aren’t working?” Adora asked.

“It’s exactly what it sounds like!” Swift Wind said. “Something about a rejuvenator, or something.”

“Hang on--Glimmer!” Adora hurried over to her friend. “Glimmer! I think something’s wrong with Steven, could you make sure he’s okay?”

“Sure thing.” Glimmer, surrounded by unconscious soldiers, teleported away.

The battle was going in the princess’ favor, but that was about to change. Before anyone knew what was happening, the largest building at the center of the base began to shift. Gears turned and panels shifted as the Horde revealed their ace in the hole: the scavenged upper torso of a Horde Prime cybertank locked in place, turret charged and cannons spinning. The massive machine locked on to its targets, unleashing fire down on the princesses.

Frosta created an ice barrier to block the incoming fire, but it could only last so long. “Everyone get down!” shouted Bow. As the ice barrier splintered and cracked, the princesses ran for cover as the cybertank continued its barrage.

“Great, *great* , just what we need!” said Perfuma, ducking behind a nearby building. “Is just a simple raid too much to ask!?”

“Hey, we’ve beaten these things before, we can do it again!” Adora said. “I’ll draw it’s fire, someone else take it down!”

“Adora, wait!” But despite Bow’s warnings, Adora had already run out into the open, waving her arms and making herself as visible as possible. Her sword had taken the form of a shield as she blocked some shots and dodged others.

Meanwhile, some ways away from the fighting, Steven still tried to form his own shield, to no success. “Come on, shield, come on! Why won’t you work?” In a flash of light, Glimmer appeared, interrupting his attempts--not that they were getting anywhere.

“There you are!” she said. “Adora said something’s wrong, are you okay?”

Steven looked down at his shield-less hand. “My powers aren’t working!” he said. “I want to be able to help you guys, but without powers, there isn’t much I can do!”

“Then come here!” Glimmer teleported away, taking Steven with her. They rematerialized some distance away from the Horde base, muffled sounds of conflict coming from within. “You wait here, we’ll meet up when we’re done.”

“But I--” Glimmer warped away, leaving him alone as the fighting carried on.

As much as Steven wanted to do something to help, he realized, albeit begrudgingly, that there was nothing he could do. With no shield, no bubble, presumably no healing, he would be more of a hindrance than a help. Reluctantly, he began walking back to the ship to wait with the Gems.

“Can I be mad at Spinel?” he wondered aloud. “This is technically her fault, but she isn’t the same Gem right now… Then again, maybe this is Emerald’s fault. I wonder where she went?”

“Steven! Hey, new best friend!”

“That almost sounds like Spinel now,” Steven mumbled. He looked up, seeing the pink Gem running towards him. “Wait, that *is* her! I thought I told you to stay back with Lars and the others!”

“But I got bored…” Spinel said sheepishly. “And besides, why do I have to stay if Ruby and Pearl get to leave?”

“Ruby and Pearl…?” Sensing trouble, Steven looked up to see the Gems in question hurrying towards the battle. “What!? No, where are they going!?”

Steven ran after them, Spinel in tow. Likewise, as he ran, he soon came across Lars running after them as well, Amethyst similarly following him. “No, get back here!” he called, to no avail.

“No can do!” Ruby called back. “That fight over there could put Sapphire in danger! I can’t let that happen!”

“Yes, and I have to find Imadora!” cried Pearl.

Steven caught up with Lars. “Lars, what happened?” he said. “I thought you were watching them!”

“I *was* !” he said. “But they heard the fighting over here, and Pads mentioned a fight, and then Ruby ran off, and Pearl followed her, and Spinel ran too--We couldn’t catch all of ‘em!”

The two Gems were surprisingly fast. Before either Lars or Steven could catch them, Ruby and Pearl had made their way into the base via the hole created by Adora. They followed, Amethyst and Spinel close behind.

Inside, the princesses were still fighting against the cybertank. Even though there was only half of it, it was still just as formidable as the whole thing. Adora continued trying to distract it, now aided by Glimmer.

“Hey, big robot! Shoot at me!” Adora shouted, waving her shield.

“No, over here! Shoot at *me* !” Glimmer teleported all over, trying to confuse it.

While it was trying to decide on a target, Perfuma approached from behind, wrapping several vines around the cybertank. “I think I’ve got it!” she called. “Someone do something!”

But the cybertank was not as helpless as she believed. It turned around on its axis, tearing through the vines that held it. A shot from its turret-head was fired at Perfuma; luckily, she erected a barrier of plants to block it, but the shockwave still knocked her down. The cybertank prepared to follow up with its rotary cannons.

“Perfuma!” Adora fired a beam of her own from her sword--it wasn’t enough to damage the cybertank, at least not much, but it did get its attention. The massive machine turned back around, giving Mermista enough time to get Perfuma to safety.

Steven hid behind a building. “Pearl! Ruby! Get back here!” Neither Gem paid him any mind, running through fire to save their respective charge (neither of whom was in any immediate danger).

“Huh? What are they doing here?” asked Frosta. “Hey, Lars, didn’t you say you were gonna watch ‘em?”

“It was harder than it looked!” he called back.

“Imadora? My Imadora, where are you!?” cried Pearl, desperately looking all around to find the girl in question. Her eyes passed by She-Ra several times, apparently not noticing the two were one and the same. As she searched for someone who didn’t currently exist at the moment, she also didn’t notice the small group of cybertroops approaching, weapons out.

“Pearl, look out!” Despite his lack of powers, Steven sprinted over to her with no regard for his own safety. “Get away from her!”

He threw a punch at the nearest cybertroop. Unsurprisingly, the only one hurt by this was Steven himself. He fell to the ground as his fist collided with the metal, groaning in pain and holding his hand. If anything, at least it turned the cybertroops' focus away from Pearl. And towards him.

With no way to fight back or defend himself, all Steven could do was try to get away. It didn't look good, though, as the robots all had their blasters trained on him. Just as it looked like they were ready to open fire, someone shouted. Loudly.

"YAAAH!" A pink shockwave cut through the bots, sending most of them flying. Lars had launched a sonic shout to stop them. "You okay, Steven?"

"Yeah, I think--" But not all of the robots were dealt with. A small handful picked themselves up off the ground, readying their blasters once again. Before either Steven or Lars could react, a giant fist collided with one of them, smashing it to pieces.

"Don't hurt my friend!" Who should come to Steven's aid but Spinel, throwing herself at the machines. Two more were smashed, one by a giant fist, the other by a giant foot, and one more was thrown far into the distance. The threat dealt with, the pink Gem turned back to Steven, beaming.

"Thanks, Spinel!" said Steven. He was glad everyone was safe, but something still troubled him. Aside from his hand, that is. It didn't seem to be broken, but it still hurt something fierce. He tapped it with the tip of his tongue, and...nothing. No shield, no bubble, no healing.

Of course, not everyone was safe, not yet. There was still the matter of dealing with the cybertank. Everyone was throwing everything they had at the machine, but despite its damage, it would not fall. "Just keep at it! It has to go down eventually!" said Mermista.

“We...we can’t keep this up forever!” said Swift Wind, out of breath. “Robots don’t get tired, after all!”

“Mermista’s right, we need to--hang on…” said Bow.

Glimmer teleported over to him. “What’s that?”

“I’m getting some weird readings,” he said, looking at his tracker pad. “Something’s heading this way. It’s coming from the Crimson Waste.”

“What? That can’t be right!” Adora said. “The Waste’s nothing but harsh sun, hot sand, and deadly wildlife. Unless...is the Horde sending reinforcements?”

While everyone took cover to ponder and/or prepare for this new development, the cybertank continued to scan for targets. One would soon reveal itself, announcing its presence with a fireball to the tank’s face. It focused on the source: a tiny Gem, staring up at it with fury. “You want a fight!? Get down here and let’s do this the right way!”

The cybertank charged up its main cannon, targeting the Ruby. Between the power of said cannon, its relative accuracy, and the Ruby’s refusal to back down or move, things would not have gone well for the red Gem. It would not have gone well, that is, save for two facts.

One, Ruby was not alone. When she ran off to join the fight, she had done so to protect Sapphire. Sapphire, however, was perfectly safe; though with the help of her future vision, she could tell that Ruby was not. As soon as the possibility of Ruby being in danger showed itself, she ran off as fast as she could--which was quite fast. She wasn’t entirely sure why, even.

“Ruby!” Moments before the cannon shot could hit its target, Sapphire appeared to tackle Ruby out of the way. The shot impacted several feet away, creating an explosion almost as great as the two of them felt in that moment. Their eyes met and their gems touched, and a white light enveloped them both.

And two, something else had distracted the cybertank. A sudden impact to its back, causing it to turn ever so slightly. Something grabbed its arm, moving it slightly more. Before it was able to register what was happening, it was beset by a wave of unseen attackers.

Looking out at the explosion, Adora noticed two things. First, was that Ruby and Sapphire had fused once more into Garnet. She looked quite different, however. “Wait, is that...Garnet?” Second, was that someone else was fighting the cybertank. A whole team of someones. “Who are…?”

Numerous beings dressed in rags, using weapons that seemed to be scavenged from scrap, attacked the cybertank at once. They, seeming to be led by a red lizard man, bound its rotary cannons with rope, preventing it from using them. Once they were disabled, another figure dealt the finishing blow. A truly enormous pink woman leapt to the top of the machine, driving a spear of some kind into its head. Sparks erupted from the wound, as the cybertank shook and shuddered, before finally going lifeless.

“Um, who exactly are these people?” asked Perfuma. “Are they what you picked up coming from your tracker pad, Bow?”

“I’m not sure,” Bow replied. “They *do* look like they came from a place like the Crimson Waste, though.”

The red lizard man, now back on the ground, eyed the princesses from afar. “Looks like we’re not done yet,” he said, readying his whip. He sounded excited at the process of more fighting.

However, the pink woman held out her arm. “No. We don’t have any reasons to go after the princesses. Not now, anyway.”

They, the lizard man reluctantly, returned back the way they came. They boarded several Horde skiffs, scavenged by the look of them, and raced off back into the Waste.

“Y-you all saw that too, right?” said Frosta. “That wasn’t just me?”

“No, I’m pretty sure that was real,” said Glimmer. “So there are people living in the Crimson Waste--who knew?”

Once the fighting had ended, Steven made his way over to the newly-formed fusion. “Garnet?” he said. “Are you...Can you remember anything?”

“Garnet?” she said. “Is that my name?” She seemed more interested in looking at everything her surroundings had to offer than remembering her past, if she even could.

“Uh...Well, it’s a start, at least,” Steven said.

The base was all but abandoned, the Princess Alliance having won the day yet again. “Looks like we’re all done here,” Adora said, returning back to her normal form. “Let’s head back to Brightmoon and--”

“My Imadora!” Having located her master, Pearl sprinted to her side. “Thank the stars you’re alright! I couldn’t find you, and I feared the worst! I can’t tell you how glad I am to have found you!”

“Uh...yeah, me too,” Adora said, shying away. “So, what’s up with Garnet?”

“I...think she’s back,” Steven said. “Sort of.”

As the team regrouped and headed home, none of them noticed a Horde soldier watching from the shadows, disappearing out of sight.

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Catra remained in her seat, grudgingly watching as Emerald made a mess of her computers. A cracked monitor with the imprint of a fist sat in front of her. “Are you *done* yet?” she asked.

Emerald, breathing heavily, slowed and eventually stopped her rampage. “Yes...yes, I think I am,” she said. “Apologies, it’s

just...that didn’t go nearly as well as I had imagined!”

“Hey, you’re the one who said this was only a test,” Catra reminded her. “They were supposed to win, remember?”

“This was an exercise to gather combat data!” said Emerald. “I can’t tell how these princesses fight when those Gems and *whoever those desert raiders were* get in the way! They contaminated the whole experiment!”

“Whatever you say,” said Catra, unimpressed. “Look, this little science experiment of yours didn’t exactly pan out. We tried things your way--now we do things *my* way.”

“And what exactly does ‘your way’ entail?” Emerald asked.

Catra made her way over to one of the lone intact computers in the sanctum, pulling up several files left over from Hordak’s time as the Horde’s leader. “You were able to bring a whole planet into this dimension, right?”

Emerald looked over the files--schematics for a portal of some sort. “Yes…”

“So, could you manage to do it in reverse?”

Change of Plans

Chapter Summary

The heroes' and villains' paths begin to converge.

Chapter Eleven: Change of Plans

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The lone Horde soldier made his way through the forest, until coming across the familiar sight of a camp located in a clearing. Despite the camp not being a Horde base, he simply walked in without any concern, either from himself or those within.

And speaking of those within, not only were they completely unconcerned that a Horde soldier was in their midst, but they didn't seem to be aligned with the Rebellion, either, or any sort of Etherian party. Many of them bore one or more oddities that could only be described as mutations. More (or less) limbs or eyes that their species should have, or other bizarre qualities giving some a monstrous appearance. In some, they were not recognizable as any species native to Etheria, or even beyond. Despite this, the Horde soldier just walked on through, paying them just as much mind as they paid him--that is to say, none aside from a glance.

The faceless trooper walked a familiar path that took him down into an underground hideout that the others present at the camp seemed to avoid. As he stepped down the stairs, a change overcame his form: the green of his armor was replaced with featureless black, before his shape morphed to a taller, more slender one. The black gave way to a darker green of scaly skin. Double Trouble arrived at the bottom, into his master's air.

"Double Trouble. I'm surprised you came here as yourself. Usually, you come disguised as something or other." Their master's metallic voice came from the darker recesses of this lair, though it was too dark for him to be seen.

“I was *going* to, but then I asked myself what the point was,” Double Trouble said, leaning up against a nearby piece of machinery. “I can almost never fool you anymore. Besides, Mantenna would have known it was me anyway…” A pair of creatures stood further into the room, one massive and muscular, one sharp and spindly. The latter stared at Double Trouble with bulging eyes. “Killjoy…” the shapeshifter muttered.

“Just as well.” At a table at the room’s end sat Double Trouble’s master, Modulok. A rack filled with vials sat before the scientist, each filled with a few drops of reddish liquid. “What knowledge have you brought back of the Horde’s latest excursion?”

“Oh, nothing new,” they said. “Once again, the great Rebellion swoops in to save the day! It was actually really boring. Although...there were a few unexpected guests…”

Modulok produced a small, unassuming pouch from a nearby drawer. “And what sort of guests were these?” He added a small pinch of black powder from the pouch to one of the vials. The red liquid began to violently churn, almost like it was trying to climb out of the glass tube.

“Crimson Wasters,” Double Trouble said, with all the enthusiasm of revealing a great secret. “They showed up completely uninvited, destroyed this big Horde machine, and then bailed!”

“So,” Modulok mused, “it looks like Hordak had made an army for himself after all. He’s done it once, I suppose it makes sense he could do it again.”

“And what about those Gems?” A third voice, belonging to a previously unseen listener. The darkness of the unlit room swirled around, conglomerating into the form of Shadow Weaver. “Surely even you didn’t expect their arrival? What effect will they have on our plans?”

“I assume you are referring to the planet Earth suddenly appearing?” Modulok said. “While I will admit, such a

development was certainly unexpected, the presence of neither Emerald nor the Crystal Gems changes anything. We will proceed as normal."

"And what *is* normal?" Shadow Weaver approached the Surgeon, looming over him. "It has been two years since we first spoke, and what has been accomplished in that time? What purpose can this possibly serve?" She gestured to the vials in front of him, which he continued adding the black dust.

"We will do nothing, because we need not do anything," he said. "And why should we?" He stood up, slithering over to a large tank containing a mutated creature. "When you have lived as long as I have, you will learn to be patient." He turned back to face his partner. "In their war, the Horde and the Princess Alliance will accomplish everything we need for us."

Although she wore a mask, it was clear Shadow Weaver was glaring at Modulok. "Let us hope so. Otherwise, I may regret allying with you…" Once again, she disappeared into the shadows.

Modulok grinned. "Dear old Shadow Weaver. Always a woman of action. We will be free of this prison soon enough, of that you can be sure…"

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"What do you think it all means?"

Back at Castle Brightmoon, the Best Friend Squad discussed the recent battle. Even after raiding the base, nobody was entirely sure what its purpose was. For such a heavily-fortified installation, its placement was odd as well. Why the Crimson Waste, of all places?

"To be honest, I have no idea," said Bow. He stared down at his tracker pad, looking over the data he had gathered from the fight. "This doesn't seem like anything the Horde would do…"

“But does it seem like something *Catra* would do?” asked Adora. “Like something to mess with our heads. Maybe she just did this to distract us from something bigger.”

“Maybe,” Glimmer said. “Our scouts haven’t seen anything so far, though. Maybe they’re just trying to tire us out?”

“Or maybe they just did this so we’d go crazy trying to figure out why they did this,” suggested Bow. “If that’s the case, their plan’s working!”

“Alright, everyone just take a minute to calm down!” said Adora. “We can’t let Catra get in our heads like this! That’s what she wants!”

“Easier said than done,” Bow said.

“The best thing we can do right now is wait for her next move,” Adora said. “Since we have *no* idea what that could be, there isn’t really any way to prepare.”

“Of course there is!” Glimmer said, jumping up. “We know that someone else out there is fighting the Horde, right?”

“And...who would that be?” asked Adora.

“Those guys from the Crimson Waste!” Glimmer replied. “They just showed up outta nowhere, destroyed that cybertank like it was nothing, and vanished! If we can get those guys on our side, Catra won’t stand a chance!”

“You know, that’s not a bad idea,” said Bow. “But there’s just one problem: we have no idea where they are. Or even if they’d *want* to help us. ...Huh, I guess that’s actually two problems…”

“Well, we know they’re from the Crimson Waste, so that’s a start!” Glimmer said. “And we’ll bring Steven with us--getting people to join him is practically his specialty! Come on, let’s go!” Glimmer took off, teleporting out of the room before the other two could even get up.

“Glimmer, hang on!” said Adora, running after her. Bow followed. “Let’s think about this a little! I’m all for running into a situation blindly, but don’t you think we might be a little *too* blind here? We should at least talk this over with Angella first!”

“If I had to guess, I’d say that’s exactly what she’s doing,” Bow said.

Once the two made it downstairs, they found that Bow was exactly right. Glimmer had already found her mother, and was giving her the pitch for their journey into the Crimson Waste.

“Think about it: we’d be unstoppable!” she said. “Since the Gems are in kind of an...iffy position right now, we need all the allies we can get. So, what do you think?”

Queen Angella thought about it for a moment. “This plan shows potential…” Glimmer perked up. “...but it’s ultimately too risky.”

Glimmer deflated. “Mom, come on! What about this plan is any riskier than anything we’ve done before!?”

“For one, the Crimson Waste is hostile, dangerous, and unexplored,” said the queen. “We have no idea what kind of dangers it could hold. And even then, these raiders you speak of could very well be just as hostile. This plan poses too much risk for what could very well amount to a wild goose chase!”

Lars, who was nearby, looked up. “You guys have geese on this planet, too?”

Glimmer tried to protest. “But--But--”

“No but’s, Glimmer,” Angella said. “I will consider sending out a scouting party, but that is as far as we will go for now. Until then, we must simply wait for the Horde’s next move.”

“Uuugh!” Groaning loudly, Glimmer teleported away. Figuring she would be back in her room, Adora and Bow walked back that way. Unknown to Angella, Lars opted to follow them.

“So,” Lars said, “You want to follow those weird guys from the desert?”

“Something like that,” said Bow. “But if Angella won’t let us go, there’s nothing we can do.”

Yeah, that’s true,” Lars said. “Can’t do anything. ...Except sneak out, that is.”

Bow and Adora shared a glance. “I mean, we definitely *could* ,” said the latter. “But wouldn’t Angella be mad?”

“Not if she doesn’t find out!” said Lars. “And even if she does, wouldn’t she be glad to have a couple of new Horde-fighting allies?”

“...I guess…” Bow said.

“Great!” Lars hurried back down the stairs. “You go get Glimmer, I’ll warm up the ship!”

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Within the dark of the long-inoperable command bridge of the First Ones ship, only two figures stood: Huntara and Hordak. Three, if you counted Imp. “I take it your excursion was a success?” said Hordak.

“Kind of,” said Huntara.

Hordak turned around, looking up from his work. “‘Kind of?’ Force Captain Huntara, explain to me how a simple mission can be ‘kind of’ a success?”

“We destroyed the Horde base,” Huntara explained. “The princesses were there. So were some Gems. No sign of your friend, though.”

Sighing, Hordak turned to continue working on his suit. One hand absentmindedly reached up to touch the purple crystal near his

chest. “Catra must be keeping her at the Fright Zone. I suppose it was foolish of me to hope otherwise. Then we must--”

Hordak was about to stand up, but something happened. Something in him gave way, resulting in him falling to one knee. Imp flew over to him as he groaned in pain, looking at his master with concern.

Huntara, meanwhile, did nothing but take this in. “You saw nothing,” said Hordak. “Leave.”

“You’re getting weaker,” Huntara said. “This isn’t the first time something like this happened. You’re getting weaker, and sooner or later, you won’t be able to control us.”

“I said *leave* !” Hordak bellowed. “Or do I need to remind you of my superiority?”

Huntara turned to go. “That armor of yours may make you stronger, but it’s failing, isn’t it? How long before it gives out completely?”

Once she had left, Hordak hauled himself back into his chair. “She...is right,” he said to Imp. “Years of disrepair in this arid wasteland have wreaked havoc on Entrapta’s creation. I can’t say how long it has left.” Once again, he touched the crystal powering his suit. “All the more reason to find her…”

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Completely unaware she was being searched for (even though she did some searching herself), Entrapta was busy at work on another project. “Okay, I’ve worked some of the data for Project: Drawbridge into some First Ones tech. It’s only a prototype, so I can’t say what the results will look like, though.”

Catra and Emerald stood nearby, overlooking the portal before them. “Doesn’t matter,” Emerald said. “Is it ready for activation?”

“Just about,” Entrapta said. “Portal is increasing as we speak. Currently at thirty percent power...forty...fifty…”

“Hey, Catra?” whispered Scorpia. “I don’t really know about this. Are you sure this is a good idea?”

“Of *course* it is,” said Catra. “Stop worrying for five minutes!”

“...one hundred percent, and...gaining?” said Entrapta. “Emerald, are you sure this is safe?”

“It will be, if you throw the switch!” Emerald said. “Quickly, before it overloads!”

Entrapta threw the switch. Cracking with energy, the portal began to activate, its three pieces levitating into place. Emerald and Catra looked at it expectedly, though Entrapta seemed uncharacteristically worried. Soon it became clear why, as the energy grew unstable. The pieces of metal swirled around like debris in a tornado as the portal itself sparked and surged. Eventually, there was too much power to be contained.

“Catra!” cried Scorpia. As the portal exploded, she dove in front of her friend, pulling her to the ground. Entrapta hid behind the controls. Only Emerald was unconcerned, standing in place as only her hair was blown back by the force of the explosion.

Once the danger was over, Catra shoved Scorpia off herself. “Get off me!” she growled. She took her place back beside Emerald. “What happened?” she asked Entrapta.

Entrapta looked at the data present on the screen. “Well...the experiment was unsuccessful.”

“Obviously,” groaned Emerald. “Why?”

“The portal itself worked fine, but the quantum tunneling was unable to breach through Despondos into the main universe,” Entrapta explained. “It’s as if...oh, that’s strange. It’s like

Despondos is some sort of sealed door, and we need a key to get through."

"What *kind* of key?" asked Catra.

"Most likely a powerful First Ones artifact of some kind," said Entrapta. "But not just any artifact. Only something really, really powerful, like…"

"...Like Adora's sword," Catra said.

"Yes, that could work!" said Entrapta. "Do you think we could convince her to let us borrow it?"

"I'm sure we can work something out," said Catra. "How about I go pay her a visit?"

"Great!" said Scorpia. "It's been a while since we were out in the field. Catra and Scorpia, dynamic duo--"

"No," Catra said. "You stay here. I need someone to make sure Entrapta doesn't blow up the whole Fright Zone. And you…" She looked at Emerald. "...can you talk with your fleet again?"

"Almost," said Emerald. "My subordinates are working on repairing the communicators as we speak. They should be ready in about…" She silently counted on her fingers. "...soon."

"Good," said Catra. "You all keep up the good work, I'm taking a team to Brightmoon to--"

"Wait a minute," Entrapta said. "Catra, something's on our radar. It looks like...a ship. It's heading from Brightmoon to the Crimson Waste."

Emerald looked at the radar, her face immediately contorting into a grimace. "Lars…" she growled.

"Well then," said Catra. "I guess I'm going to the Crimson Waste."

She stepped out, leaving the three of them behind. Scorpia looked back and forth between the door and Entrapta a few times, before deciding to quietly follow Catra.

Into the Waste

Chapter Summary

The princesses and Horde both head into the Crimson Waste, unaware that their paths are close to converging.

Chapter Twelve: Into the Waste

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"Remind me again…" said Catra. "I told you specifically to stay in the Fright Zone. Why did you decide to follow me? ...Actually, don't answer that. Why did you decide to come along at all?"

Another fleet of Horde skiffs had departed for the Crimson Waste. Catra stood on one, aiming to track down Adora. Much to her annoyance, Scorpia had tagged along as well. Catra had sniffed out the stowaway rather quickly, but had decided that they were too far along at this point to turn around. She reluctantly allowed the Force Captain to tag along, Scorpia now standing by her side.

"Because, the Crimson Waste is dangerous even without all those raiders!" said Scorpia. "You need someone to watch your back, and I'm just the gal for the job!"

Catra groaned, stepping away from Scorpia. She raised her arms to the side, giving her a better look at the exoskeleton Entrapta had made for her. "Do I *look* like I need someone to watch my back?"

"Well, no, but...hey, the more the merrier, right? Besides, Entrapta'll be fine! Emerald's there to watch her, isn't she?"

It seemed like Catra didn't really believe that, but she at least pretended to. And even if Scorpia was a handful, she was right about one thing: Catra would need all the help she could get. No, not help--backup. She never needed help.

Reaching the vast desert was the easy part. As the fleet of skiffs raced across the sands, lookouts scanned the horizon for any sign of civilization. Catra still wasn't entirely sure why Lars' ship had headed to the Waste in the first place, but she had a few ideas. Once they found him, he could lead them to Adora. And from there, she'd have everything she needed.

"So, what exactly are we looking for?" asked Scorpia. Once again, Catra found her to be entirely too close for comfort.

"You remember Lars, don't you?" said Catra. After thinking for a moment, Scorpia nodded. "We're after that ship of his."

"Why do we need his ship? We already have--"

"We don't want his ship!" Catra snapped. "We just want to find out where he is! That way we can follow him back to Adora and her sword. Or…" She ran her claws down the guardrail she was holding on to. "...we 'convince' him to take us himself."

After a long time of travelling the Crimson Waste looking for anything that could be a lead (during which Scorpia insisted on making small talk), one of the lookouts finally spotted something. Through their binoculars, they spotted something glinting in the distance; something too metallic to be a rock, and too large and isolated to be a vein of ore. Catra ordered the fleet to turn towards it.

As they grew closer, the object became clearer. It seemed to be a vehicle--a Horde skiff, to be exact. It lay on its side, seemingly driven to crash by some unseen force. No troopers were around, so either they had left, been eaten by some giant desert monster...or were never there to begin with.

Catra ordered the skiffs to stop, and the troops to stay alert. Whatever wrecked this thing could still be nearby. She hopped down to the sand and made her way over, Scorpia following close behind.

“Hmm...yeah, that thing’s definitely seen better days,” Scorpia observed. “What do you think it means?”

“It means someone wanted us to find this,” said Catra.

Scorpia apparently didn’t understand. “They...wanted us to find a wrecked skiff out in the middle of the desert?”

“Exactly,” Catra continued. “Notice how it isn’t covered in sand? If it had been out here for a while, it should at least have a thin layer of sand on it. That means it was put here recently.”

“You’re sure?” asked Scorpia.

“No. Of course, it could have just crashed. Which makes it really weird that somehow, by sheer coincidence, it crashed just between the Fright Zone, and a Horde outpost on the other side of the Waste. One of our patrols would have had to run into it at some point.”

“Huh, that’s a pretty good point,” said Scorpia. “But that just begs the question of *why* is it here?”

Scorpia was about to walk closer to investigate, only for Catra to hold out an arm to stop her. “Wait. Look closer.”

Although nearly invisible to most eyes, including Scorpia’s, Catra’s sharp vision had picked up one small, but no less important detail. A few wires stuck out from the skiff’s interior here and there, some of them looping back inside, some attached to even more well-hidden sensors. These blended into the metal almost seamlessly. “...I give up, what am I looking for?” said Scorpia.

“Just hold on.” Catra walked back over to where her skiff was parked. She took a stun baton from one of the troopers, aiming it at the crashed skiff. “You may want to back up a bit.”

Though she wasn’t sure what Catra was doing, Scorpia followed her advice, hurrying to a safe distance. Catra carefully took aim, letting a blast fly. The shot hit the side of the skiff, the sparks

triggering the explosives that had been laid within. The wrecked skiff went up in an enormous fireball, sending shrapnel, sand, and tepid air in all directions. “What just happened!?” exclaimed Scorpia.

“I thought so,” said Catra, tossing the stun baton over her shoulder. “Someone laid a trap for us. And something tells me...that they’re still here.” She scanned the horizon, but was greeted with nothing but silence. Despite this, she knew her enemies were close by, just waiting to strike.

As if on cue, a battalion of raiders burst out of the sand--they had been hidden underground, covered by tarps while waiting for the Horde to arrive. Instantly they surrounded the unsuspecting soldiers, overwhelming them with speed and numbers. Nearly half of the whole party was taken out before the rest could offer any resistance.

“It’s an ambush!” shouted Scorpia. “Quick, do...something!” She blocked a strike from one of the raiders with her claw, before retaliating with a punch and taking cover behind a nearby skiff. “What’s the plan, Catra!?”

“There is no plan!” she yelled back, as raiders surrounded her. “Fight back, that’s the whole plan!”

About five of the raiders descended on her, each one bearing weapons and armor that seemed to be at least partially scavenged from Horde tech. “Well, if it isn’t ‘Lord’ Catra herself!” one of them said. “I knew we’d get lucky with this little booby trap, but I didn’t think we’d catch the lady in charge!”

Catra scoffed. “If you think an exploding skiff and a couple goons are enough to stop me, you’ve got another thing coming.” Catra unsheathed her claws, simultaneously activating a feature in her exoskeleton: metal blades connected to her fingertips were charged with energy, heating them to extreme temperatures. Catra’s already-impressive claws had been augmented by Entrapta’s designs. “Let’s go!”

All five raiders charged at once, which Catra used to her advantage. She attacked one, her claws easily slicing through his armor before she threw him to the ground. Another swung a polearm at her, which she cut in two: she grabbed the top half, using it to trip him up before throwing it at a third raider, momentarily stunning her.

A fourth raised his energy rifle, firing a shot at Catra. She held up her arm, blocking the shot with her gauntlet. Before he could fire another, Catra took control of his blaster, firing several shots at the fifth raider, dispatching him before he could even get close. She then finished off the fourth with a kick to the stomach, and a knee to the forehead.

The third of them was not finished just yet, and charged at Catra with a sword above her head. She didn't get far, however, collapsing before she could reach her target. Catra turned around to see that Scorpia had stung her attacker. "I did say I'd watch your back, didn't I?"

In spite of everything, Catra couldn't hold back a grin. "Come on, let's show these two-bit desert scumbags why you don't mess with the Horde!" Side by side, Catra and Scorpia charged.

The few Horde troopers that were still conscious fought back as well as they could, but they were still outnumbered. Without the superior numbers and firepower they were used to, it was only a matter of time before the raiders took all of them out. However, that all changed when Catra and Scorpia joined the fray. The former charged in like a bulldozer, tossing raiders aside, while the former finished off the ones she missed.

"What are you all waiting for!?" shouted Catra. "Are you going to let these scavengers get the better of you!? You're Horde soldiers, now start acting like it!"

With their presence added to the fight, the soldiers felt reinvigorated. One by one, they picked themselves and their comrades up, dusted themselves off, and leapt back into combat.

Stun batons and energy whips collided with rusty swords and scavenged blasters as the former underdogs fought harder than ever.

Scorpia grabbed a raider and threw them into the air. Catra hit them with a leaping kick as they came down, sending them into another raider. The raiders, recognizing the pair for the threat they were, began converging on them. Despite the massive amount of enemies piling up, neither was deterred. Claws and stingers flew as every last raider fell before them.

Before long, the fighting stopped. Catra and Scorpia stood, panting, in the middle of a pile of defeated raiders. Victorious, a few of the Horde troopers couldn't help but cheer as the others began tending to their wounded brethren.

Catra looked around at the carnage surrounding her, and she couldn't help but feel slightly impressed. "You see?" she said, looking up at Scorpia. "I knew we could handle them."

"Of course we could!" exclaimed Scorpia. "You and me, Catra and Scorpia, the original Super Pal Duo? We're unstoppable!"

Catra grinned once again. "Alright, I'll say it: we make a pretty good team." Scorpia positively beamed. "Okay...change of plans." Catra walked over to a raider that had been stunned by Scorpia's venom. She lifted him up by his shirt, her face inches from his. "Alright, big guy...since your little ambush failed-- *again* --I'd say you owe us a little favor. It's not like you're in any place to refuse."

"What do you want?" snarled the raider.

"You and your little buddies are gonna tell us where your base is," said Catra. "And then, you're gonna take us there."

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As he sat down on the sand, Steven couldn't help but stare at his gemstone. By now, he had more or less accepted that his powers were gone...but that didn't mean he had to be happy about it. In

spite of its lack of power, the gem shone as brightly as ever, maybe even more so under the hot desert sun.

"Why so glum, chum?" asked Spinel, sitting down beside him. "Is your gem still on the fritz?"

"Hmm? Yeah, it is," Steven said. He was now flanked by two Gems: Spinel on his left, Amethyst on his right. The latter had sat down beside him earlier, copying his movements. "You, uh, wouldn't happen to have any insight into that, would you? Any ideas?"

"Mmmmmmmmm...nuh-uh," said Spinel. "Got no insight, outsight, oversight, *or* undersight! But what I *do* have is some words of wisdom!"

"And what are they?" Steven asked, him and Amethyst looking at her expectantly.

"I may not know much," Spinel said, "but I know that you don't have to have all sorts of fancy powers to get by! Know what you do need?" She pointed into the distance, where Adora, Pearl, Glimmer, Bow, Lars, the Rutiles, and Garnet were. "Friends! The bestest, loyalest, friendliest friends you can get!"

Steven looked down at his gem again, then back up at his friends, and then back to Spinel. "You know what, Spinel? You're right. "I didn't have any of my powers when I started out, but I still made it! And Connie never had any powers, but she's one of the most powerful people I know! And my dad doesn't have powers, and neither does Sadie, or Bow--Lars has powers, but he didn't used to, and neither did Peridot!" He stood up, Amethyst and Spinel following suit. "Hey, Spinel?"

"Yeh?"

Steven reached out a hand. "We may have only known each other for a few days...but you really are a good friend."

“Awww, thanks, Stevie!” said Spinel, throwing her arms around Steven. Amethyst joined in the group hug as well. “You’re a good friend, too!” Eventually, they broke off. “Y’know, I can’t remember who told me that. But I’m sure they were a good friend, too!”

Once again, Steven glanced down at his gemstone. “Spinel...you said you knew my mom, right?”

Spinel looked thoughtful. “Maaaaaaybe. Which one’s your mom? The swirly one with three eyes? Or the pink one with the wings?”

“No, not them,” Steven said, smiling slightly. “Her name was Rose Quartz.” Spinel shrugged. “Wait, you might have known her as Pink Diamond. Ring a bell?”

“I...no, I can’t say it does,” said Spinel. Despite this, however, her eyes gained a dark shadow to them for a split second, identical to how they looked when Steven first met her. It lasted only a moment, but Steven noticed. “Sorry, I don’t know any Diamonds! Not personally, anyway!”

“That’s alright, don’t worry about it,” Steven said. “Come on, let’s go see if Bow found anything!”

“See anything yet?” asked Lars.

“Not yet,” said Bow, scanning their surroundings with his tracker pad.

“Me neither,” said Garnet, looking into the distance with Bow’s binoculars. “But I’ll keep looking!”

“Remind me again. What are we looking for?” asked the Rutiles.

“First Ones stuff,” said Adora. “Instead of scanning the whole desert for places where those Crimson Waste guys *could* be, we thought it’d be easier to look for some places they’ll *probably* be!”

“And...you think they’ll be at a First Ones site?” asked Rutile. “Just like that?”

“Hey, it beats combing the whole desert!” said Glimmer with a shrug.

“Wait, hold on!” said Bow, springing to his feet. “I’m getting a reading! It’s faint, but whatever it is, it’s pretty powerful!” With everyone except Garnet bunching up behind him to see the screen, he held out the tracker pad to catch the signal. “It looks like it’s coming from...that way! Garnet, could you check it out?”

“Okay!” Garnet looked up from the binoculars for a moment, before turning to look where everyone else was facing. “I can’t really see anything...just a lot of rocks. Really, really big rocks.”

“Yeah, I can see them from here,” said Glimmer. “Adora, you still have the map?”

“Yup! Pearl? Map me!” said Adora.

“Right away, My Imadora!” said Pearl, producing a map from her gemstone and handing it to her.

Adora unfolded the map, scanning over its surface. “Let’s see...if we’re here...and north is this direction...that looks like it’s right here! Right in the center of the Crimson Waste!”

The Rutiles looked at the map. “The center, huh? What could be there?”

“Whatever it is, it’s probably important,” Bow said. “Even if it isn’t the people we’re looking for, we should probably check it out.”

“Sounds like a plan!” said Adora. “Pearl? Sword me!” Pearl handed her the Sword of Protection. “Let’s do this!”

The group set off back for the *Sun Incinerator* , meeting up with Steven, Spinel, and Amethyst on the way. “You’re done already?” said Steven. “What did you find?”

“Big rocks!” said Garnet, looking proud.

“And a powerful First Ones signal,” said Bow. “We’re going to go check it out, just in case.”

“Hey,” Glimmer said to Steven. “Is your gem still not working?”

“Yeah, but I won’t worry about it right now,” Steven said. “We’ve got more important things to deal with, like the Horde, and Emerald, and the Gems’ memories. Besides, Spinel reminded me you don’t need powers to make a difference!”

“That I did!” she said.

“How true!” said Lars. Bow nodded in agreement.

They arrived back at Lars’ ship. “Wherever we’re going, let’s just hope it doesn’t try and kill us,” said Adora. “...Aw, who am I kidding, we all know it will.”

Crash Site

Chapter Summary

The team arrives at the raiders' base, hoping to ally with them against Catra's Horde.

Chapter Thirteen: Crash Site

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"Yup," said Adora, resignedly. "Whatever's in there is definitely gonna try to kill us."

After a brief flight closer to the signal, the *Sun Incinerator* had touched down on a hill overlooking the source: a crashed First Ones vessel, embedded into the desert. Some sort of encampment had been built around it, with metal scaffoldings forming walkways between hastily-constructed towers. There were numerous Crimson Wasters standing guard, enough that this wasn't just some wayward outpost.

"No need to be so negative," Steven said, trying to lighten the mood. "They could be friendly. Why don't we try talking to them? Just watch: we'll head down there, and after a few minutes, they'll be on our side!"

Glimmer leaned over to Lars. "Is he always like this?" she asked quietly.

"Eh, yes and no," Lars replied.

"You know what? I'm with Steven on this one," said Bow. "Sure, they look scary and ready to fight, but you know who else is? The Horde. I'm willing to bet that they're just local people trying to defend themselves from a Horde attack. If we head down there and explain who we are, I'm sure they'll be willing to listen!"

"I'm in!" said Spinel, giving a thumbs-up. "Better to solve problems with talking 'stead of fighting, that's what I always say! …'Course, it isn't like I can't fight if I *need* to."

"And we probably *will* need to," Glimmer said. "We should have a plan B, just in case."

"Alright, here's the plan," said Adora. "Bow, you and Steven are the least threatening of us, so you'll go down there and--"

"Wait, are you saying I'm threatening?" asked Glimmer, half-jokingly.

"Well...I'm not *not* saying that…" said Adora.

"And you're saying I'm *not* threatening?" said Bow, not-jokingly.

"Can we focus, please!?" Adora hissed. "Bow and Steven will go and try to talk to them, and if they turn out to be hostile and attack--"

"You mean, when they inevitably do attack," added Glimmer.

" *When they inevitably attack* ," Adora said, growing more annoyed, "the rest of us will rush in and help out before things get too intense."

"Excellent strategizing, My Imadora!" Pearl said cheerfully. "I've written it all down right here!" She held up a holo-screen displaying something written in Gem script.

"Okay, sounds good to me!" said Steven. "I imagine Spinel will be coming along, too."

"You bet!" Spinel said, leaning closer to Steven. Amethyst repeated after her, mimicking her movements.

"Can I come, too?" Garnet asked quietly, raising her hand.

“Hmm…” Adora examined the multicolored fusion. “Can you fight?”

“I can if I need to!” she said cheerfully, holding up her fists. She tried to scowl, but her expression looked more like a pout.

“...Yeah, you’d better go down there with them,” said Adora. Garnet grinned and happily skipped over to Steven’s group. Two Gems and Bow behind him, Steven started off down the hill towards the ship.

“Are you sure this is a good idea?” Bow asked him. “Without your powers, it...could get pretty dangerous down there.”

“Nah, I’ll be fine!” Steven said. “I’ve got you, Garnet, and Spinel, don’t I? And besides, I still have the greatest power of all: my ability to persuade!”

“That’s one way to look at it,” said Bow.

With the four of them walking in plain sight towards the base, it wasn’t long before someone spotted them. They could tell by the commotion within that the guards were debating what to do with them. Nobody shot at them, or ran at them with swords, which was a good sign. Hopefully, these desert nomads were just as opposed to the Horde as they were.

“Okay, let’s get our story straight,” Bow said as they got closer. “We’re explorers, and we got separated from the rest of our party. We’ve been wandering the desert for a few hours, and we’re relieved to have found civilization. Everyone got that?”

Spinel grinned and gave another thumbs-up, Garnet nodded, and Steven said “Yup!” By the time the four of them reached the base, a gang of raiders was present at the entrance to meet them.

“Uh...Hello there!” said Bow, awkward waving.

One of the raiders, a gruff-looking snakekin, stepped ahead of the others. “What’s this about, eh? What’re a couple characters like

you doin' out here in the Waste?" His hand hovered close to a knife at his hip.

"Oh, I can't tell you how good it is to finally meet someone out here!" said Steven, mocking relief. "We've been wandering out here for days! Do you have any water? Because we *really* need some water!" The four of them all feigned exhaustion, including Garnet.

The raiders looked to one another, as though confused. "A'right...but why're you out here in the desert in the first place?" asked the biggest one.

"We're, um, archaeologists," said Bow. "Our research party was attacked by the Horde, and we got separated. We don't want to trouble you, just a few moments and we'll be gone!"

The larger raider thought for a moment, then pulled his companions into a huddle. After whispering to each other for a few moments, he turned back to face the group of 'explorers.' "So, Horde's givin' you trouble, too, huh? Alright, you can come in for a bit."

"Yay, thank you so much!" Spinel sprang forward, wrapping him up in a hug. "You're such a kind and generous host!"

The snakekin man pried the Gem off of him. "Don't push it, pinky." He waved for the guards to stand down, and escorted Steven and the others inside. Steven looked around nervously at the multitude of aggressive-looking raiders that surrounded them. "'Ey, Huntara!" he called out. "We got visitors!"

The raiders parted as an imposing figure made her appearance. A very tall, very muscular woman with pink skin strolled towards the group: the same one from the Horde base. With her build and hair color, Steven likened her to a Quartz. Two other figures walked beside her, a goatkin woman and a lizardkin with four arms.

"So," she said, "What's a couple of characters like you doin' out here in the Waste?"

“Apparently, they’re archaeologists,” the snakekin man said, his tone of voice skeptical.

“We had a bad run-in with the Horde,” said Garnet. “We were wondering...could you help us?”

“With what? Fighting the Horde?” asked Huntara. “What do you think we’ve been out here doing for the past two years?”

“So, you’re against the Horde, too?” Steven said hopefully.

“Yeah, basically,” Huntara said. “Why wouldn’t we be?”

“In that case, we both want the same thing!” said Steven. “The Horde’s attacking all our homes, too. We should team up! It’ll be a lot easier to fight them together!”

“Yeah, that’s not happening.” Another voice came from behind them. The four turned around to be faced by another snakekin man, this one with red skin and a whip tightly gripped in one hand. “Not with your kinda company, anyway.”

“Uh, what do you mean?” asked Bow, trying to hide his nervousness.

“What’s this about, Lashor?” said Huntara.

“What it’s about,” he continued, “is the ship we picked up on our scanners landing not far from here.” He glanced up at Huntara. “If they’ve really been lost in the desert for as long as they say, wouldn’t they have seen it?”

“I...have no idea what you mean!” said Spinel. “What ship?”

“The one you came here on!” said Tung Lashor. Bow twitched, which he noticed. “Am I right? I’m right, aren’t I? And if you’re not lost, what are you doing here? Who are you really with?”

“N-nobody!” said Steven. It was clear that the raiders were beginning to grow suspicious, Huntara included. “Back me up

here, Bow…”

“You know what I think?” Tung Lashor said. “I think they’re with the Princess Alliance!”

“What?” said Bow, his voice having gone up an octave. “No, that’s ridiculous! We don’t...don’t associate with those princess types! Right, Spinel!”

“Nope, of course not!” Spinel said. “I don’t even know any princesses! I didn’t know what a princess was up until recently!”

“Is that so?” Tung Lashor stepped forwards, letting his whip loose. “So, none of you are magic?”

“Not one!” Garnet said.

“Huh. In that case…” For a moment, it looked like Tung was going to walk away, turning his back on the group. Before they could breathe a sigh of relief, however, he spun around, swinging his whip directly at them. Steven closed his eyes, preparing for the impact.

In a pink flash, the whip stopped in its tracks. Glimmer stood before the group, holding the tip in her hand. “I don’t think so!” She yanked the whip, pulling Tung Lashor to the ground.

“See?” he said, sounding smug despite spitting out sand. “Princesses.”

“Well, wouldja look at that?” Huntara cracked her knuckles, she and the other raiders tightening their circle around the group. “The boss doesn’t really care for princesses, not anymore than he does the Horde.”

Bow produced his, well, bow, notching an arrow. Glimmer’s fists erupted in sparkles. Garnet and Spinel held up their fists as well, as did Steven, for all the good he knew he could do. “Wanna tell us who your boss is?” asked Glimmer.

Huntara picked up a small rod, which, at the press of a button, extended into a large staff. “You’re gonna have to earn that!” she said.

The raiders charged. Bow and Glimmer met their assault before running out of the huddle. Garnet, despite her lost memory, could apparently still throw a mean punch, even without her gauntlets. Spinel, meanwhile, pulled Steven out of harm’s way with her stretchy limbs. “Let’s get you somewhere safe,” she said.

“Thanks, Spinel,” he said. He sounded disappointed. “So much for my plan.”

Spinel shrugged. A raider ran at the two of them. Spinel punched him away. “Eh, you win some, you lose some.”

“Yeah, but it sure feels like I’ve lost a lot lately,” he said.

Spinel gave him a gentle punch on the shoulder. “Hey, who better to change that than you? Let’s go get ‘em!” She tooted a little fanfare into her hand shaped like a trumpet, before charging into the fray. Steven ran after her.

Huntara ran at Bow, her staff extended. She swung the weapon, but just before it could make contact, it collided against another weapon, sparks flying from the impact. “Not so fast!” said Adora, her sword blocking Huntara’s staff.

“You a princess, too, blondie?” said Huntara, as their respective weapons clashed.

“Oh, I’m *the* princess!” said Adora.

A short distance away, safe from all the fighting, Pearl watched Adora intently, cheering her on. “Go, My Imadora, go! Show them your might!” Nearby, Amethyst was busy copying Tung Lashor, of all people.

“Heh, big talk for such a little girl!” said Huntara. She pushed against the Sword of Protection with all her might, which was

quite a bit more might than Adora had at the moment.

"'Little,' huh?" Adora shot back. "Why don't you try this on for size?" Despite her current predicament, Adora refused to falter. "For the Honor of Grayskull!"

A bright light obscured her form, which grew to nearly match that of Huntara. "What the!?" she yelled, momentarily blinded. When the glow subsided, She-Ra stood where Adora had.

She smirked. "Not so little now, huh?"

Huntara laughed. "Still little enough!"

She swung her staff, which Adora blocked once again. While the two titanesses traded blows, Pearl stood nearby, looking around in confusion. Just as before, her master had disappeared without a trace. "My Imadora!" she called. "My Imadora, where have you gone?"

The only person not currently fighting someone, Steven turned towards her shouts. "Pearl?" He ran over. "Hey, Pearl!"

"Hmm? Oh, Steven Universe!" she said. "Please, if you could help me--I can't seem to find Imadora anywhere!"

"Uh…" Steven stared at She-Ra. "But she's right there."

"Impossible!" Pearl said. "That glowing golden woman looks nothing like Imadora! No master of mine would make such a radical change to her form!"

"That's basically what my mom did," Steven said. "You remember that?" A brief pause. "Oh, wait, of course you don't remember that."

"Your…'mom?'" said Pearl.

"Yeah. Rose Quartz? Pink Diamond? Either of those names ringing a bell?"

Pearl glanced around. “If they do, I certainly can’t hear one. Now if you’ll excuse me, I need to find my master.”

“Pearl, wait!” said Steven, running in front of her. “Don’t you get it? This isn’t you!” Pearl only stared blankly at him. “The Pearl I know didn’t have a master! She was devoted to Rose Quartz because she loved her, not because she had to be!”

“I-I don’t understand,” said Pearl. “Who is this ‘Rose Quartz’ you keep mentioning?”

“She…” Steven struggled to find a way to explain it to the amnesiac Pearl. “Rose Quartz is the woman you loved more than anything else in the whole universe,” he said.

“Was...she my owner before Imadora?”

“No! ...Well, yes, but...not exactly. She loved you Pearl. And you would have done anything for her. And when she had me, you...you did everything to protect me.” When Pearl still didn’t respond, Steven pulled up his shirt, revealing his gemstone. “Look, she passed on her gem to me. Tell me this doesn’t bring back any memories!”

Pearl looked closer at the gem. A spark of recognition appeared in her eyes. “I…” But after a moment, it dimmed again.

Steven had to strike while the iron was hot. “Yeah! You and her started the Crystal Gems! With Garnet, and Amethyst, and Bismuth, and everyone! And one time...one time you told me, she made you feel like you were everything.”

“Everything…”

Suddenly, Pearl’s entire body was enveloped in a glowing white light. Steven stepped back in surprise as she rose up into the air, her physical form shimmering. Slowly, her appearance began to change, cycling between every other form she had taken since Steven had known her. After a moment, the light show was over, and Pearl slowly descended to the ground. Her color returned,

revealing the same Pearl that had been with Steven before this whole mess had begun.

Steven approached her cautiously. “Pearl?” he asked softly. “Do...you remember me?”

Pearl met his gaze, returning it with a warm smile. “Of course I remember you, Steven.”

“Does this mean you aren’t Adora’s servant anymore?”

“Oh, I’m nobody’s servant!” Pearl declared proudly. “I’m my own Pearl, and nobody can keep me down!”

As it turned out, Pearl’s transformation had attracted some attention. A small gang of raiders were headed in their direction. “Uh, Pearl?” said Steven. “I think we’ve got some company!”

“Do we? In that case…” Pearl threw her arms over her head, spinning around once as she summoned her spear from her gemstone. “I’d be happy to entertain them!”

“Pearl’s back, alright!” Steven said.

Pearl met the group with her spear, tripping one up before he even knew what was happening. She fought off the attackers with the grace of a ballerina, her spear like her ribbon.

Meanwhile, Adora and Huntara continued to clash. Metal met metal again and again, neither of them backing down.

“Not much of a princess, princess!” Huntara said.

“Oh, I’m just getting started!” said Adora.

“ *Enough* .”

Just one word carried enough power to halt the entire fight. Everyone, princess, Gem, or raider, stopped in their tracks.

Everyone knew that voice. With a feeling of dread, they all turned towards its source. “Hordak…” Adora murmured. “He’s here?”

Hordak walked from the darkness of the ship and into the sunlight. Imp flew around him, before perching on his shoulder. The former leader of the Horde scanned the area, glaring at everyone he saw, enemy or ally.

With a swing of his arm, a crimson blade of pure energy erupted from his wrist. The air hummed from the heat as his gaze focused on Adora, singling her out as the greatest threat. One he knew all too well.

“ *This. Ends. Now.* ”

The Old Horde

Chapter Summary

After two years of isolation, Hordak finally reveals himself to do battle with Adora.

Chapter Fourteen: The Old Horde

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Admittedly, Adora had wondered where exactly Hordak had been all these years, especially once she knew that Catra had taken his place. Now that she was face to face with him, however, she figured she would have been content with not knowing.

Once the former Horde leader entered the scene, all of his raiders slowly made space for the imminent battle. Every single one of them had been coerced into joining his side by force, and as such, they knew all too well what he was capable of. Even Adora and the others were hesitant to approach him.

Hordak made the first move, lunging at Adora with his blade extended. He was surprisingly quick; Adora barely had time to raise the Sword of Protection to block. His energy blade hissed as it met metal, his crimson eyes glaring into Adora's. Imp had taken to the skies, circling the pair.

She said nothing. Unable to push him back, she ducked under his blade, swinging her own sword at him. He leaned back to dodge. When Adora raised her sword to strike again, he thrust out his palm, a blast of energy sending her flying.

Adora got to her feet, spitting out sand. "Adora! Are you okay?" Glimmer teleported over to help her friend to her feet, and Bow wasn't far behind. The two of them stood beside her, preparing to face Hordak.

“I’m fine,” Adora said. She glared at Hordak. “So, is this where you’ve been all this time? The former leader of the Horde, reduced to a desert nomad?”

“Hardly.” Hordak gestured around to the raiders surrounding them. “While you and Catra have been at each other’s throats, I’ve been amassing an army to reclaim my rightful throne. After I’m done with you, I will return to the Fright Zone and do the same to your friend.”

“That’s assuming you win!” Hordak turned towards the voice, seeing Steven, with Pearl next to him.

“You look familiar,” said Hordak, trying to remember where he knew the boy from. “Where have I seen you before?”

“I’m Steven, Steven Universe, from Earth!” he said. “Does that ring a bell?”

“Earth…” Hordak growled. “Steven…” Memories came flooding back to him. “Yes, I know all too well who you are.” Hordak threw both his arms to the side, an energy blade igniting from each wrist. “And you are a liability that cannot be allowed to stand!”

Just as before, Hordak charged, this time towards Steven. Pearl instinctively shoved him aside, meeting his twin blades with her spear as Spinel pulled Steven to safety. “I won’t let you hurt Steven!” cried Pearl. “Especially now that I just got him back!”

“How noble,” Hordak said. “Unfortunately for you, you don’t have a say in this matter.” He prepared to strike her again, only for something else to catch his eye. He whipped around, catching an arrow moments before it could hit its mark.

Bow prepared to fire another one. “We can’t let him separate us; we only have a chance if we take him all on at once!” He aimed at Hordak, while Glimmer and Adora charged.

While he was distracted, Pearl struck with her spear. The weapon collided against Hordak’s armor; it didn’t break through, but it did

cause some sparks to fly, causing Hordak pain. She backflipped out of the way when he swung at her.

The next arrow heading towards him fared no better than the first, as Hordak simply leaned to the side, causing it to sail harmlessly past him. Glimmer teleported near him, blasting him with energy before disappearing again. Despite being blinded by the blast, he was still able to block Adora's next attack. "This means nothing!" he shouted. "Without the princesses at your side, you cannot--Argh!"

Hordak suddenly cried out in pain, stumbling back from the fight. His armor sparked and seemed to be cracking apart. It was subtle, but it almost seemed like it was falling apart at the seams. Once it passed, however, his vigor was renewed, and he once again threw himself at his foes before any of them had time to dwell on this.

Adora met his blades with hers, but wasn't prepared when he followed up with a punch. She fell back, but just before he could strike again, Glimmer appeared, teleporting her out of harm's way. Pearl returned Hordak's strike with one of her own, to which he followed up with a swing of his blade.

From a safe distance, Steven watched the fighting go down. As his four friends united to take on the Horde's former leader, he noticed that none of the raiders were rushing in to assist him. "Hey...how come they're not fighting?"

"Hmm?" asked Spinel.

"Well, usually, the bad guy's henchmen will try to help him out," Steven said. "But they're just watching, even though they were fighting us earlier."

"That's simple." Both Steven and Spinel were startled to notice that Huntara was standing right beside them. "This is his fight. It's not our place to interfere. Also...we just don't want to." She

glanced down at the two. “It’s not like we follow him out of loyalty or anything.”

“So, you just do what he says because...he’s tougher than you?” Steven asked.

Huntara shrugged her shoulder. “That’s just how it works in the Crimson Waste.”

Hordak seemed to be growing more and more furious as the battle progressed. Not only that, but it was almost like his movements were becoming less coordinated and more strenuous. Despite this, he was almost always able to block or avoid an incoming attack, even ones coming from behind him. Adora and Pearl’s blades were almost always blocked, and aside from one that Hordak had reached for but missed, Bow had been unable to land an arrow on him. Glimmer had more luck, though that was most likely because of her powers being inherently unpredictable.

“How’s he doin’ that?” said Spinel. “It’s like he’s got future vision, or somethin’!”

Steven had noticed it too. “I don’t know *what* he has,” he said. “Maybe he has cameras built into his suit.” His eyes caught a glimpse of movement above them; he looked up to see Imp circling the fight below like a vulture, always facing behind his master. “Or maybe…”

Hordak rotated to block Pearl’s spear with one of his blades, having blocked Adora’s sword with the other. Glimmer teleported in to blast him, but he disabled his energy blades, shoulder charging the princess before she could get out a shot. She teleported away before he could follow up, but he did duck underneath a sneak attack from Adora.

“Even with the mighty She-Ra on your side, you stand no chance against the full might of the Horde!” he declared.

“Maybe not the Horde,” said Adora. “But you? I think I can manage!”

As Adora tried for an overhead swing, only for Hordak to catch the sword--in his hand, not bothering to use his blades. "You misunderstand me. I *am* the Horde."

He grabbed Adora, pulling her around to block an incoming arrow. It burst into a net, which tangled around her. Hordak then unceremoniously tossed her aside, now focused on the one who fired it. Nobody but him noticed that his palm was damaged from catching the sword.

"I'm really not having the best luck today…" said Bow.

"Guys! Up there!" Steven ran over, pointing skyward. "Hordak's pet flying goblin thingy! I don't know how, but I think that's how he's predicting your attacks!"

"What? His imp?" said Adora. Glimmer was trying to help her free from the net. "Are you sure?"

"We don't really have a lot of options right now, so it's worth a shot!" said Bow. He notched another arrow, preparing to fire it at Imp. He was forced to abort when Hordak fired a blast of energy in his direction, yelping as he dove to the side.

Pearl rushed forwards, clashing her spear against his blades. Adora, now free from the net, lunged at him from behind. He jumped aside just in time, both Pearl and Adora having to redirect their attacks to avoid hitting each other.

"It is as I said: you have no chance of overcoming Entrapta's creation!" Hordak said, his hand momentarily reaching for the crystal on his chest.

"Entrapta…" Bow said quietly, before regaining his composure. "We have before, and we can again!"

"Perhaps...but you have never faced me before!" Hordak fired a blast from each hand, everyone diving to avoid them. Glimmer, however, warped right beside him.

“Surprise!” She unleashed a sparkly blast into Hordak’s face; he roared when it hit, temporarily blinded. “Adora! Now!”

Adora ran forwards to attack while Hordak was incapacitated. However, Imp noticed her, and thanks to the camera on his collar, so did Hordak. He raised his blades to block her strike, just as he had done before.

This is exactly what Glimmer had anticipated, however. “Now’s your chance, Bow!” she said, teleporting near him. She pointed up towards Imp.

“Okay, here goes nothing!” Bow aimed up and let an arrow fly. With Hordak blinded and Imp focusing on Adora on his behalf, there was nobody to prevent the latter from being covered in green slime, which quickly hardened.

“No!” Hordak immediately disengaged when Imp started falling towards the ground. Glimmer teleported up high to reach him, warping him away closer to the First Ones ship. She placed him on the ground next to it after making sure he couldn’t move.

“I’ve always wanted to be the one to ground someone for a change!” said Glimmer, ignoring Imp’s indignant screeching. She warped back to join the others as he tried chewing his way out.

All Hordak could now see through Imp’s camera was a view of the ship half-covered in slime. He growled, and in his momentarily distracted state, didn’t notice that Adora was prepared to strike until after the fact. His armor sparked once again as the sword collided with his back. He tried to regain his balance despite the discomfort, barely missing her as he swung his blade behind himself.

“Now we have a chance!” Pearl said. She pulled a second spear from her gem, wielding one in each hand. “Don’t let up! Attack!”

Bow was first to act, firing an arrow at Hordak’s feet. It released a cloud of smoke, preventing him from noticing when Adora, Pearl, and Glimmer all charged him at once. While he was able to block

Adora's attack, Pearl and Glimmer got beside him and struck at the same time. Stunned from the impacts, Adora was able to throw Hordak to the ground.

Hordak quickly recovered, getting back to his feet before anyone could follow up. "I will not allow myself to fall so easily!" He tried to summon his energy blade once more, only for it to flicker a few times before disappearing entirely. He tried once again, but aside from a few flashes, it refused to appear. "No...it can't...not now!" He fired a pair of energy blasts at Adora.

Just before she was hit, Adora transformed the Sword of Protection into a shield, blocking the shots. When Hordak tried to fire more, he was met with only sparks. Letting out an enraged roar, he sprinted towards her.

Hordak threw a punch at Adora, unable to do anything else. His fist collided against her shield, to which she fired a blast of her own from the Runestone in the center. He reeled back, and Pearl struck with both of her spears, causing his armor to spark once again. As the battle went on, it was becoming more and more damaged.

Bow fired an arrow at Hordak's back, which exploded upon impact. Almost driven to his knees by the blow, he still refused to go down. In response, he charged angrily at Bow, who hastily tried to notch another arrow. He fired, only for Hordak to lean out of the way. He was almost upon him, leaving no time to notch another.

Hordak felt someone grab onto him moments before he reached Bow. "Going somewhere?" Glimmer, with Hordak in tow, teleported the two of them dozens of feet into the air. Pushing herself away from him, she teleported back to the ground, letting gravity do most of the work.

A column of sand shot into the air as Hordak returned to the ground. Everyone was certain that the fight was over. "So...is that it?" asked Steven hesitantly. "Did we win?"

Before anyone could answer, Hordak's mere appearance told him otherwise. Still standing, he rose out of the small crater, glaring at the princesses.

"You think this means anything?" he growled. "I refuse to--" More sparks. He fell to his knees, coughing.

"It's over, Hordak." Adora walked up to him, not letting her guard down. "Give up, while you still can."

Despite being seemingly in pain, Hordak chuckled. "I will never," he said. "Not until I am in control of the Horde once again. And nothing you do can stop me!"

"Look at yourself!" Adora said, her voice sounding less firm than before. "You're falling apart!" Indeed, piece by piece, his armor was beginning to shed itself from his body, revealing his true sickly appearance.

"You know nothing," he said weakly. "I was once Horde Prime's greatest general! It will take far more than--" Once again, he was overcome by a coughing fit. Purple liquid dripped to the ground, both from his mouth and his back.

Imp, having freed himself, was quick to fly to his master's side. He clung to his arm, gently pulling as though trying to get Hordak to stand. He tried to, but fell back down almost immediately. The crystal on the front of his armor fell out of place, landing among the sand and blood.

Steven, Glimmer, and Bow had approached him as well. "What's going on?" he asked. "Did...did you hurt him too badly?"

"I don't know," Adora said. She sounded surprisingly concerned. "I-I've never seen him like this…"

The raiders that surrounded them were unsure of what to do. Some of them contemplated leaving then and there, while others debated on whether they should attack him while he was weakened. None of them moved, however.

Adora, like them, didn't know how to react. She glanced down at her sword, then back over to Hordak. She turned around, pulling the other three into a huddle.

"Okay, I know you aren't gonna like this," she said quietly, "and I know it's gonna sound crazy, but...I think I should heal him."

" *Heal* him? Why?" replied Glimmer. "He was just trying to kill us, remember?"

"I know, but...look at him, Glimmer, he's dying." Glimmer looked over at Hordak. She had to admit, even though he had been trying to conquer the planet, seeing someone slowly waste away like this was hard to stomach. "He may be against us, but..."

"...But if we heal him, maybe he'll help us," Steven said. "It's worked for me before. Sometimes. But either way, we can't just let him die, right?"

"They're making some good points," said Bow. "Besides, both of us want to stop Catra, right? This could be good for us!"

Glimmer was quiet for a moment. "Adora...I want you to know that I *don't* like this, and I *do* think you're crazy...but I also think you should do what you think is right." Both Steven and Bow nodded in agreement.

"Okay." Adora took a deep breath, focusing on her sword. "Hordak," she said after turning around, "We've decided that we...want to help you."

Growing ever weaker, Hordak struggled to look up at her, even for only a second. "Try whatever you like," he said. "I have tried to fix my decaying body for years, to no avail. Nothing you can do will have any effect."

Adora held her sword in front of her face. "That's where you're wrong," she said. "At least...I hope so…"

She slowed her breathing. Thoughts of everything Hordak had done swirled around in her mind, which she tried to push away. Instead, she thought of everything that was going on at this time, and all the good having Hordak as an ally instead of an enemy could bring, even after all the bad he had done. Surely nobody, not even Hordak, could be all bad, right? And she truly didn't want him to die...

A faint blue glow surrounded the sword. The glow surrounded Adora and Hordak as everyone surrounding them looked on in awe, aside from those familiar with the powers of She-Ra. And before their very eyes, Hordak began to change.

His armor fell to the ground in pieces, pulled apart as his sickly body filled out within it. As his emaciated form grew, the scars on his back faded. He got to his feet as he was rejuvenated, made just as healthy as when he was first born--no. Better.

As the last of the armor fell from his back, something else came with it. Where there had once been nothing but scars and metal, a pair of batlike wings extended from Hordak's shoulder blades. They were a brilliant white color in the bright desert sun.

Soon, the blue glow dissipated. Adora opened her eyes to examine the results. "Oh, wow…" she said. "You, uh, you have wings." She glanced down at Imp. "I mean, I guess that makes sense."

Of all the people surprised at Hordak's new appearance--which was just about everyone--none seemed to be more so than Hordak himself. He stared down at his arms, his body, and especially his wings. He reached down, picking up the crystal from the sand. Imp, overjoyed at his master's survival, flew up to his shoulders while chattering up a storm.

"I…" Hordak seemed to be at a loss for words. He glanced out at all of the people surrounding them, before his eyes settled on Adora. "...Thank you." He sounded like he truly was grateful.

A Less-Likely Alliance

Chapter Summary

With a team-up with Hordak on the horizon, the Horde shows up at the worst possible time.

Chapter Fifteen: A Less-Likely Alliance

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"So, uh...anyone know what to make of this?" asked Huntara. It seemed that nobody did. Indeed, Hordak had just sprouted wings right in front of them--that was enough to make anyone ponder what was happening!

Adora took a step back to examine the results of her handiwork. "You're...you're welcome," she said. Of all the people she thought she would be healing anytime soon, Hordak was not high on that list. And yet here they were. "How do you feel?"

Hordak clenched and unclenched his fist. He spread his new wings. "Better than I ever have," he said. "I...truth be told, I had no idea I even had wings."

"I don't think anybody did…" said Tung Lashor.

"So…" Bow cautiously approached the ex-Horde leader. "Does this mean you're willing to help us fight back against Catra?"

"No. It means I'm willing to let *you* help *me* retake my place as rightful commander of the Horde," said Hordak. His thumb absent-mindedly traced across the crystal in his other hand. "But yes, regardless, I will accept your offer of an alliance."

Glimmer teleported in next to Bow and Adora. "Can I talk to you two for a moment?" She warped all three of them a short distance away. "Okay, so you fixed Hordak. Now what?"

“What do you mean, ‘now what?’” said Adora. “Now we head back to Brightmoon, put a plan together, and stop Catra from doing whatever it is she’s doing!”

“Alright. But once we stop Catra, and Hordak’s back in charge again, what’s to stop him from doing the exact same thing as Catra!?”

“Well, I, um…” Adora stammered. “Okay, admittedly, I haven’t thought this out that far. But between a Horde led by Catra, and one led by Hordak, I think I know which one I’d prefer. You’ve met Catra, Glimmer, you know what she’s capable of!”

Glimmer looked over at Hordak, who seemed to have struck up a conversation with Steven. Or rather, Steven was talking to him, and he was pretending to listen. “Fine,” she sighed. “We’ll take him back to Brightmoon. But I doubt my mom will be happy about this.”

“Nor should she be,” Bow pointed out. “Just because we’re working with Hordak now doesn’t make him one of the good guys.”

“Right, or course not,” said Adora. “But after we’ve been working together for a while, who knows where this could go?” She and the other two returned. “Okay, that settles it: everyone back to Brightmoon!”

“Great!” said Steven. “I was just telling Hordak about how I was able to make peace with the Diamonds. I said if there’s hope for them, there’s hope for him!” Hordak groaned in annoyance, unknown to Steven.

“Where’s Lars, anyway?” said Adora. “Let’s find him so we can start the...ship…?” Adora trailed off as something in the distance caught her eye. Something was kicking up dust, but it was far too small to be a sandstorm. It also seemed to be coming this way. “Does anybody else see that?”

“See what?” asked Steven, turning to look. Spinel did so as well.

“I’m on it.” Bow took out his binoculars, focusing them on the approaching object. “It looks like…”

“Horde skiffs approaching!” Before Bow could give his report, Huntara gave it for him, looking through a pair of binoculars of her own. “I count seven of them, maybe more!”

“Should we get ready for them?” asked Tung Lashor.

“No,” said Hordak. “This is the perfect opportunity to reveal to them that Lord Hordak lives! Let them come.”

The skiffs grew closer, spreading out as they approached. “Everyone, get ready for round two!” said Adora, gripping the hands of her sword.

Glimmer prepared her magic, and Bow notched an arrow. “Steven, come with me,” said Pearl, grabbing his shoulder.

“Huh? Why?” he asked.

“Without your powers, you’re in danger,” she said. “Now come along, we need to get you somewhere safe!” She pulled him away from the crowd just as the skiffs arrived.

Evidently, the Horde was opting for a quick offense, as their first action was to bombard the area with blasts from their stun batons. Some of the skiffs circled around the perimeter while others rushed right in, all of them carpeting the area with projectiles. Any sense of unity the group had before this fell apart, as it was every raider for themself. Formation broke, and chaos ensued.

The Horde troops began disembarking, doing battle with Hordak’s raiders. Nowhere near as disciplined or regimented, the raiders were at a serious disadvantage. Although it seemed to be a losing battle, many of them fought hard nonetheless, most of all Huntara and Tung Lashor.

Several of the Horde troops converged on Adora, hoping to catch her before she could transform. “Adora, look out!” Glimmer teleported behind her, blasting a soldier before they could strike.

A trio of soldiers ran at her from another direction. Before they could get close, Bow fired his arrow; a net burst out, trapping all of them. Bow notched another arrow, ready for any other troopers that came his way.

Hordak looked around at the battle around him. “Enough of this!” Spreading his wings, he took off into the air. This attracted the attention of several nearby fighters, though he wasn’t done yet. He landed atop the ship he and his raiders were using as a makeshift base, spreading his wings as Imp landed on his shoulder. “Warriors of the Horde, hear this! Your rightful master lives!”

Many of the Horde soldiers looked up at him. “It’s Hordak! He’s alive!” one of them said.

“Catra has taken my title, but she has done so behind my back!” he continued. “She has unrightly claimed my place as leader of the Horde! I ask you now: to whom does your loyalty belong? Catra...or me!”

As many of the Horde soldiers seemed to debate this, two members of the new Horde watched from atop a skiff. “Catra, you’re seeing this, right?” said Scorpia. “I mean, Hordak’s alive! What should--”

“I *know* he’s alive!” Catra snapped. “I have eyes!”

“...and he has wings,” said Scorpia. “Huh.”

“It doesn’t matter that he’s alive,” said Catra. She climbed atop the skiff’s mast so that her voice could be better heard. “Yes, Hordak’s alive!” she said. “But where was he all this time? Out here in the desert. He left all of us behind! I stepped up in his place while he abandoned you all! So answer me this: who *really* deserves to run the Horde?”

The divide between the Horde troopers grew even greater. All of a sudden, the silence was broken when a voice rang out. “All hail Lord Hordak!”

It was met in turn with another voice. “All hail Lord Catra!” And then the fighting resumed. The Horde troopers now split into two factions, those loyal to their old master, and those loyal to their new one. Although not happy with this development, Catra was content. Even more so when she heard a familiar voice from behind.

“Catra!”

Oh, this was too easy. Catra turned around, grinning. “Hey, Adora,” she purred. “Just the girl I was looking for!”

“I don’t know what you’re doing in the Crimson Waste,” Adora said, pointing her sword at her old friend, “but I will stop you!”

“Sheesh, all business!” said Catra. “We haven’t seen each other in, what, two years? I thought you’d be a bit happier to see me!”

“Two years, and you really haven’t changed that much,” said Adora. “For the Honor of--Waugh!”

Before she could transform, Catra shot her in the wrist with a stun baton. The Sword of Protection flew out of her hand, and landed several feet behind her. Before she could retrieve it, Catra followed up with a punch to Adora’s stomach.

“Either you got a lot sloppier in that time, or I’ve gotten way better,” Catra said. She kicked Adora in the back, knocking her to the ground. “Probably both, though.”

Adora rolled back onto her feet. “What is it you’re after, Catra?” she said.

“In the long run? I want to prove that I’m the greatest conqueror this planet’s ever known,” said Catra. She stepped back, picking up Adora’s sword. “Short term, though? I’ll settle for this.”

Adora was about to rush Catra, but something caught her ankle. She fell to the ground again, under the effect of Scorpia's paralyzing venom. Catra walked over, sword in hand, grinning down at her unconscious form.

"I lost the loyalty of a few soldiers, but I got what I came here for," she said. "Scorpia, get her into the skiff. We're done here."

Scorpia lifted Adora off the ground, as she and Catra stepped back into the skiff, heading off back towards the Fright Zone. In the commotion, only one person noticed them leaving, and that Adora was with them.

"Adora!" Glimmer gave chase, warping closer to the skiff. She landed near it, but not quite on it. Landing in the sand, she tried again, this time making it onto the vehicle. "Give her back!"

Scorpia was busy steering, so Catra stepped forward to deal with Glimmer. "Sorry, sparkles, no can do," she said. "But if you want her so badly, you're welcome to try and take her!"

Glimmer did just that, letting out a war cry as she thrust her palms forwards. However, rather than a blast of magical energy, she only produced a few sparks. Her magic was drained.

Catra acted before Glimmer could react, whipping out a stun baton. Glimmer was shocked by the green energy, falling to her knees, but not falling off of the skiff as Catra hoped. She approached her to remedy that.

"Aww, sorry princess!" she said. "Looks like Adora's *my* best friend now. Why don't you run home to Mommy now?" Catra lifted up her foot and pushed Glimmer off the skiff. She fell to the sand, tumbling to a stop as the skiff, accompanied by several others, raced off into the distance.

Shakily, she got to her feet. Between the shock, the falling off of a moving vehicle, and being out of magic, Glimmer was quite dazed. She tried to concentrate on the retreating skiffs, drawing from every last drop of magic in her. But she was too drained to even

teleport a short distance. Exhausted, Glimmer fell back down to the ground.

“Glimmer!” She perked up slightly at Bow’s voice. She looked up to see him and Steven running towards her. Bow knelt down beside her; “Are you okay? What did they do to you!?”

“I’m fine, Bow,” she said. “Just tired. But...they took her.”

“Took...Adora?” said Steven.

“We have to go after her,” said Glimmer. Bow helped her to her feet. “Where is everyone? Did you find Lars? Is his ship ready?”

“Yeah, he’s back at the *Sun Incinerator* ,” said Steven. “Come on, we’ll think of something.” The three of them started walking back towards the others.

“Don’t worry,” said Bow. “We’ll get her back. I know we will.”

“I hope so,” said Glimmer. “She’s the only one who could convince Mom to work with Hordak.” She realized the gravity of the situation. “Oh. We’re gonna have to bring Hordak back with us to Brightmoon, aren’t we? Mom isn’t gonna like this…”

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“Absolutely not!”

“But Mom--” Glimmer stammered.

“But nothing!” said Angella. “I don’t know where to begin with you! Not only do you run off into the Crimson Waste against my wishes, putting yourself and others in danger, but you bring back this...this...monster!” She thrust her arm out towards Hordak, who was surrounded by armed guards, their spears pointed at him. The other members of the Princess Alliance stood nearby as well. Hordak didn’t seem to care.

“Mom, think of it like this: we finally captured the leader of the Horde!” said Glimmer. “Well, ex-leader, but that’s beside the point. And now he can help us get Adora back!”

“Adora wouldn’t--” Angella stopped herself. “How can you trust the most dangerous threat Etheria’s ever faced?”

Glimmer looked at Bow for support. “Um...I wouldn’t say he’s the *most* dangerous threat Etheria’s ever faced. There was Skeletor, and Horde Prime, and now Catra’s kind of a thing…” Unbeknownst to him, Hordak was glaring at him.

“Trust me, Mom,” said Glimmer. “I know you don’t like this--I don’t either--but only good can come from this! As long as we keep him on a short leash, we can work together to stop Catra, defeat the Horde, and then Etheria can live in peace!”

“On the contrary--” Hordak began, before being interrupted by an ice spear inches from his face.

“Quiet, prisoner!” shouted Frosta. “I don’t care that you did grow wings, I’ll still stab ya if I have to!”

Hordak raised an eyebrow. “Oh? I wasn’t aware that your Princess Alliance allowed ten-year-olds to join,” he said.

“I’m thirteen!” Frosta said indignantly. “Going on fourteen…” she added under her breath.

Queen Angella brought a hand up to her head. “Glimmer…” she began.

Glimmer cut in. “Adora would have been on my side,” she said.

“I know,” said Angella. “But her absence does not factor into my decision. Hordak will stay here.”

“He will?” Glimmer said.

“Yes. He and all of these...raiders...will stay in Brightmoon, provided they are kept under close watch. Once Adora is rescued and the Horde is gone for good, we will decide what to do with them. Escort our guest to the dungeon.”

“Wait...we have a dungeon?” said Netossa.

“... *guest room* ,” said Angella. The guards escorted Hordak to said chamber, making sure neither he nor Imp tried anything funny. Angella stood up from her throne, walking down the stairs to her daughter’s side. “I hope I am not mistaken in trusting your judgement,” she said.

“Don’t worry, Mom, this’ll be fine!” she said. “Have I ever been wrong before?”

The Queen didn’t answer, only glancing down at her daughter. “I’m going to see that the guard is increased,” she announced, walking out the door. “We will discuss strategy when I return.”

“Uh, okay,” Glimmer said, as her mother left. “I’m glad you...saw things my way…” She looked down.

“Glimmer…” Bow placed a comforting hand on her shoulder. Glimmer reached up to return the gesture, only to brush his hand aside.

“I’m fine,” she said. “I just need to recharge, is all.” She left the room behind, heading outside towards the Moonstone chamber. Both were technically true: she certainly did need to recharge, and she was fine. No, scratch that--she *would* be fine, she just needed some alone time.

Hearing a voice, Glimmer realized she wasn’t alone in the garden. “Didn’t go so well?” She turned to see Hordak’s huge pink lieutenant sitting on a nearby fountain.

“It’s none of your business how it went,” she said. “Who are you, anyway?”

“Name’s Huntara,” she said, getting up. She seemed to notice Glimmer’s frosty reception, so she didn’t come any closer. “I know you probably don’t trust me, given how I was following Hordak, but trust me...I don’t like him any more than you do.”

“Then why were you following him?” asked Glimmer.

“That’s just how things work in the Crimson Waste,” Huntara said with a shrug. “He beat us, so he got to lead us. Doesn’t mean we wanted to. But hey, we aren’t in the Crimson Waste anymore, are we?”

“So then, why are you helping *us* ?”

“‘Cause I want to. Look, the Horde’s been attacking the Waste for months now, and I’m sick of it! Aside from him being stronger than we were, the only other reason I was working with Hordak was so we could keep the Horde from attacking my home. And with you guys...well, you don’t threaten people to do your dirty work is all I’m saying.”

“Good to know,” Glimmer said, though she didn’t sound particularly glad. “You’ll probably have to take it up with my mom, though.” She turned to leave.

“Oh, yeah, the queen,” said Huntara. “I heard a little bit of that argument back there. Hey, nothing wrong with a few mommy issues.”

Glimmer wheeled around, glaring. “What’s that supposed to mean!?” she snapped. “I do not have mommy issues!”

“Alright, alright, whatever you say,” said Huntara. “I’ve just been in the same boat, so if you...Princess?” Glimmer had already turned to head up the tower to the chamber.

Muttering to herself, Glimmer lay down on the table beneath the Moonstone. She tried to relax as its light washed over her, but there was too much on her mind to do so. She screwed up her face in concentration, until a voice broke it: “Glimmer?”

She sat up. “Mom?”

“Glimmer! I don’t know where to begin with you!” she said. Glimmer looked around, but couldn’t find her mother.

“Mom, what’s going on?” she said. While she didn’t find Angella, she did notice a very interesting sight on the windowsill.

“Glimmer!” Angella’s voice came out of Imp’s mouth. “Glimmer!”

“Augh! Get out of here!” Glimmer shooed the tiny creature away, who cackled as he flew off. Growling, she lay back on the table, hoping a brief rest would fix everything. Everything except Adora, that is...

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“Incredible…” said Emerald, looking up at the massive crystal before her. “And you’re certain that these…’rune stones’ are related to Gemkind?”

“Not just related!” said Entrapta. “If my data is correct, which it certainly is, both Gemkind and the Runestones were both created by the First Ones!”

Emerald looked at Entrapta like she had just suggested that Gemkind was created by magical shapeshifting snake people. “‘Created?’ ‘First Ones?’ Do you even know what you’re saying?”

“Sort of, but it varies from moment to moment,” Entrapta said. “Why?”

“Because that’s insane,” Emerald said. “Gemkind was created by the Diamonds. Plain and simple.”

“And who created the Diamonds?”

“I--wh--nobody!” Emerald exclaimed. “They were formed from the virgin energies of the newborn universe! Spawned from the font of creation! As ageless and eternal as existence itself!”

It was Entrapta's turn to give Emerald a weird look. "...Um...sure. Anyway, why did you want to see this thing again?"

"Isn't it obvious? My ship was destroyed, my army has no idea what to do, and *Lars of the Stars still has the* Sun Incinerator!" Emerald shouted. Entrapta was leaning far in the opposite direction. "We need all the help we can get if we want to defeat the Princess Alliance. And *I'll* need all the help *I* can get to help *you* ."

"Okay, so what does--"

"Entrapta!" The door to the Black Garnet chamber slid open, revealing Catra and Scorpia. The former held the Sword of Protection. "What are you doing in here!?"

"Oh, Hi, Catra!" said Entrapta, giving a friendly wave. "Emerald wanted me to show her the Black Garnet. She thinks we can use its power to--hey, isn't that Adora's sword?"

"It is, now get to work," said Catra, handing over the sword. "This should work as that key you needed. "And you," she pointed at Emerald. "...do whatever it is you need to do. The princesses have more allies now, so we'll need all the help we can get."

"I know," Emerald said.

"New allies, eh?" Entrapta said, examining the sword. "Who?"

For a moment, Catra froze. Then, slowly, an idea came to her. "I'm sorry, Entrapta."

"Sorry?" She looked up at Catra. "What for?"

Catra placed a hand on Entrapta's shoulder. "When we were in the Crimson Waste...we saw Hordak."

"You did!?" said Entrapta, immediately jumping up out of her seat. "Where was he? Is he okay? Where has he been all this time?"

When she noticed Catra's somber expression, her excitement faltered. "Catra...where is he now?"

"He...he left us," said Catra. "He was in the Waste all this time, with a new army. By the time we got there, he...joined up with the princesses."

To say Entrapta looked crestfallen would have been an understatement. "Hordak…" she said. "No, he...he wouldn't just leave us! The princesses must have captured him or something! We have to save him!"

"All the more reason to finish working on that portal," Catra said, leading Entrapta out of the room with a comforting arm around her shoulder. "We'll get him back, don't worry." As the two left, Catra glanced back at Emerald. The two met eyes as the door closed.

Emerald looked back up at the crystal when Scorpia nudged her, much to her annoyance. "So, the Black Garnet, huh? Y'know, it used to belong to my family before the Horde showed up. In theory, I should still have some sort of connection to it, isn't that cool? Just in theory, though."

Emerald gave Scorpia a quizzical glance. "Is that so?"

Meanwhile, Back on Earth

Chapter Summary

While waiting for Emerald to make her move, Connie and the B-Team receive an unexpected visitor.

Chapter Sixteen: Meanwhile, Back on Earth

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Since Gems didn't need to sleep, Jasper wasn't asleep that evening. Instead, she was deep in thought, her mind racing over nothing in particular. So, instead of being awoken by the loud noise above her, she was simply distracted. Her eyes snapped open, and she irritably trudged out of her cave to see what the deal was.

A ship of Gem build descended from above the trees, landing in a nearby clearing. Jasper wondered what exactly Homeworld was doing here, of all places: was it her they were interested in? If that was the case, why had they only just come here now? She decided to go and investigate. It wasn't like sitting in a cave all day was doing her any favors.

By the time she had arrived at the landing site, the ship had already landed, and two Gems had disembarked: an Amethyst and a Citrine. They looked off into the distance, seeming to be searching for something. As they talked, Jasper walked closer.

"It's about time someone showed up for me!" said Jasper, much to the surprise of the other two Quartzes. "What, were the Diamonds too busy fawning over Steven to send someone earlier?"

The Quartzes' reaction to the ultimate Quartz was not one Jasper predicted. "Beat it, Crystal Gem!" snapped the Citrine. "We're busy looking for Steven Universe!"

Crystal...Gem? "What did you just call me?" said Jasper, taken aback.

"You heard us," said the Amethyst. "Go on, run back to your 'little Homeworld,' or whatever you call it."

"Do you...have any idea who I am?" said Jasper, stepping closer. The other two looked more irritated than curious. She decided to inform them. "I am Jasper! Champion of Pink Diamond, scourge of the Crystal Gems! During the war for Earth, I tore this planet apart as I--"

"Yeah-yeah-yeah, we don't really care about your old war stories, 'Champion,'" said the Citrine. "If you're not gonna tell us where your pal Steven is, just get lost!"

"And I don't know if you've heard, but the Diamonds aren't in charge no more," said the Amethyst. "We don't have to do anything they say. So we don't. We don't even respect them anymore! Not White, not Yellow, not Blue, and *especially* not Pink!"

Jasper's pupils dilated. "What was that?" she said calmly.

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"Lapis! Come quick!" Peridot called out to the blue Gem, who quickly flew over to her location. The smaller of the two was standing out on the deck of Steven's house, looking through a cobbled-together telescope up into the sky filled with Gem ships.

"What? What's the matter?" said Lapis, sounding worried. "Is it Steven? Is he in trouble?"

"No, worse!" said Peridot. "Emerald's forces are beginning their attack! Look!" She gestured for Lapis to look through the telescope, which she quickly did.

After a few moments of looking into the night sky, Lapis spoke up. "Uh, Peridot?" she said. "...That's a meteor shower."

“What? No it’s not!” Peridot pushed her way back over to the eyepiece to get another look. “I’m certain those are her battleships entering the atmosphere! Look at the way they curve as they fly downwards!”

“...Like a meteor,” Lapis said.

The door behind them opened, and Connie stepped out. “What’s happening out here?” she asked.

“Nothing. Peridot’s just being Peri-noid,” said Lapis, grinning at her own wordplay.

“Am not!” said Peridot. “Connie, you’re a genius--surely you can tell the difference between a meteor shower and invading enemy forces!”

“Well, I dunno about a ‘genius,’ but I can take a look,” Connie said. She looked through the eyepiece as Lapis had. “...Yyyyup, meteor shower,” she said after a few moments.

Lapis shot a glance down at Peridot, who pouted. “I guess we thwarted that invasion,” Lapis said, as Peridot muttered under her breath.

Their party was increased to four, as Bismuth poked her head out the door. “What’s this about a meteor shower?” she asked.

“Nothing,” said Lapis. “Just Peridot being Peri-noid, as usual.”

“I am not being Peri-n--I mean paranoid!” she shouted. “Our enemies are hovering right over our heads, I think a little caution is warranted! When the next ‘meteor shower’ turns out to be a barrage of proton missiles, you’ll thank me for being so--”

Peridot’s train of thought was interrupted when a shadow fell over the house. Seeing that Connie, Lapis, and Bismuth were all looking up at the sky with worried expressions, Peridot turned around to do the same. It was apparent that their worry was

warranted: a Gem ship hovered above them. It was black in color, and shaped like a flying saucer.

"...So, is that one a meteor shower, too?" asked Peridot.

"It *could* be," said Bismuth. "It's still too early to say…"

A door on the front of the ship slid open, the inside glowing with a dim blue light. A figure illuminated by the light leapt down onto the sand below, followed by another, and another. Connie recognized some of the Gems--there were Quartzes, Rubies, Peridots, even a Zircon--but there were several she didn't. The last one down she knew all too well, however: her landing causing an eruption of sand, she recognized the familiar shape of a Topaz fusion. The same one that had almost kidnapped her years before.

"So…" said Bismuth. "What do you think the odds are they're here to help us with our Emerald situation?"

"Not high," said Lapis, cracking her knuckles.

From the collection of Gems down below came a single voice. "Well well well, you must all be Steven's new friends! A pleasure to meet you, it is!" The Gem in question appeared from behind Topaz, flying up to the others' level with her four wings. She was small, smaller even than Peridot, and was both red and blue in color. "The name's Azurite, Bluebird Azurite!"

"Connie," said Connie. "But I take it you knew that already. Why are you here?"

"Oh, no reason, really," said Bluebird Azurite. "Just here to see an old friend of mine. You wouldn't happen to know where he is, would you?" She grinned maliciously.

"And why would we tell you?" said Peridot.

Bluebird tittered. "Because we outnumber you five to one, of course!" She turned back to the other Gems beneath her.

“Emerald put this team together for a reason, isn’t that right, girls?” The other Gems all cheered--except for Topaz. “You see, Steven getting the Diamonds to step down was the worst thing that ever happened to Homeworld! All of us were perfectly fine until he came along--he ruined our lives! We’re just here to *return the favor…* ”

“Alright, I’ve heard enough,” said Lapis. She raised her hand, and a pillar of water rose up from the nearby ocean. Forming it into a fist as the enemy Gems stared up at it, Lapis slammed it down on the ship, causing it to crash into the sand. The Gems were scattered by the impact, but most of them were still in fighting shape.

Bluebird glared at the four of them, falling back to join the rest of her troops. “Get them!” she shouted. The others began climbing up the stairs towards them.

“Grab your sword, we’re goin’ in!” Bismuth shouted to Connie, bulldozing her way through several of the incoming Gems. Connie was about to do so, but Bluebird suddenly rushed in, tackling her through the door. She quickly got to her feet, facing the fusion.

“You know, we were just here for Steven, but now that I think about it, we’re not very fond of you, either!” said Bluebird. She reached up to the Gem by her eye, pulling out a saber. “And if we can’t kill *him* , you’ll just have to do!”

“Good luck with that!” said Connie. She brought her hand to her mouth, whistling. Bluebird suddenly found herself blown back by a powerful wave of sound coming from a nearby roar. Lion ran down the staircase, coming to a stop by Connie’s side. She reached into his mane, pulling out her own sword.

Bluebird stood up. “Okay, alright, I guess that seems fair.” She spread her wings, taking to the air again, holding her saber imposingly. “But we won’t make the same mistake twice!”

The fusion lunged at Connie, who blocked their sword with hers. When the blades met, ice crystals began to spread across Connie's sword. Lion lunged, only for Bluebird to roll to the side underneath him. With another swing of her saber, she launched several shards of ice towards him, which froze him to the wall.

Connie ran over to free Lion, but Bluebird flew in front of her. The pair clashed blades again, as Lion tried to gnaw through the ice. Bluebird was fast, but so was Connie, despite the size of her sword. After a few moments of clashing, she flew back, perching on Lion's immobile back.

"You're pretty good at this, for a human!" she said.

"And you're pretty good for a pipsqueak," said Connie.

"So why don't we try something new?" Bluebird flew up into the air, diving down with saber extended. She drove the blade into the floor, causing ice to spread all over the house. Connie jumped out of the way as frozen pillars erupted from the floor, coating the floor and walls with ice. Bluebird pulled another saber from her gem. "Now we're getting somewhere!" She flew at Connie again.

Connie blocked her strike, following up with a downward slash, which Bluebird sidestepped. She thrust her saber at Connie, who dodged, kicking Bluebird in the chest. The fusion stumbled backwards, but took to the air again, following up with an overhead strike. Connie leapt back away from the slash.

"I get that you're mad, but is coming after me and Steven really the most constructive method of dealing with your problems?" Connie asked.

"Eh, probably not," Bluebird admitted. "It is the most fun way, though!"

"Should've guessed," Connie said. "Well, if you're having fun, I might as well have some, too." She then flipped her sword so that she was holding it backwards, before spinning around, and using

the momentum to hurl it towards her opponent. “Boomerang blade!”

Bluebird simply flew over the thrown weapon, but it flew to the other side of the room, hitting the ice holding Lion. It hit just hard enough to crack the ice, allowing the lion to free himself, and make his way beside Connie, growling at Bluebird.

“Hmm,” said the Azurite. “Y’know, now that I think about it, I probably should have--”

Lion let loose a sonic roar, blasting Bluebird through the same door she had tackled Connie through, back out onto the beach. Lion, with Connie on his back, bounded out the door after her. Unfazed, Bluebird flew towards them to continue their fight.

Meanwhile, the beach was already the site of quite a sizable battle. The rest of Bluebird’s acquaintances were not ones to go quietly, even when faced with a Lapis Lazuli. She was able to quickly wash away some of the weaker ones, but the heavier hitters kept coming. She fought mainly to protect Peridot, who hurled metal at their enemies when she could, but mostly just hung back.

Bismuth was all over the front lines, making short work of the enemy Gems. “ *Ha* ! I haven’t had a good fight like this in ages! You think you can take me!? Come on, show me what you got!” Bismuth had no weapons or unique powers, but her arms were all she needed, sending Gems flying with her punches.

All of that changed, however, when a large yellow Gem made her appearance. Even bigger than Bismuth, who had been the biggest Gem around just moments ago, the Topaz fusion stomped forward, no emotion on her face.

“You’re pretty big, huh?” said Bismuth, preparing to throw another punch. “But the bigger they are, the harder they--” Bismuth’s fist collided with Topaz...who didn’t budge an inch. “...Huh. That, uh, usually works.”

Topaz summoned a pair of clubs, one from each of her gems. With a single swing, Bismuth was launched into the air, landing hard in the sand several meters away. Topaz moved in to finish the job.

Spitting out sand, Bismuth pulled herself out of her crater. “The bigger they are, the harder they hit, I guess! No biggie, we’ll just try this again.” She shapeshifted both of her hands into giant hammers. “Come get some!”

Topaz and Bismuth met once more, each swinging both of their respective weapons. The impact created a burst of wind, blowing sand in all directions. Each of them swung at the other relentlessly; Bismuth, despite her size, was nimble enough to dodge most of Topaz’s strikes, while Topaz merely stood against Bismuth’s. Eventually, Bismuth switched tactics, swapping out her hammers for a pair of blades. Topaz blocked her first strike, locking the pair of them in a struggle.

“You don’t really talk much, do you?” said Bismuth. Topaz didn’t respond. “Hey, that’s fine, I can do all the--” Topaz broke out of the struggle, responding with a double uppercut with her clubs. Bismuth staggered backwards, holding her chin; “Argh, ffffffresh heck, that was a bad one!”

“I’m sorry,” Topaz said quietly.

Bismuth looked up at her, confused. “Say what? Y-you said...you’re sorry?”

Topaz nodded. “I’m only here because Aquamarine is making me.” She then combined both of her clubs into a single double-edged one. “I’m sorry about this.”

“Hey, it’s no big--Woah!” Bismuth ducked under Topaz’s strike, falling back to a safe distance. “But you don’t have to listen to her anymore, you know. That’s what Era-3’s all about!”

After a brief glance over at Bluebird Azurite, who was still fighting Connie, Topaz looked back at Bismuth with pleading eyes. “I

can’t,” she said. “I’m...scared. Of what she’ll do. She’ll separate my component Gems!”

“Heh, she can try!” said Bismuth. Her body language changed completely, from defensive to inviting. “You can always stay here if you want--nobody in Little Homeworld would try to separate you!”

“I don’t really--” Before Topaz could answer, she and Bismuth were interrupted when a Citrine was hurled by them, crashing against the cliffside hard enough to poof. Both of them looked around in confusion, wondering where she had come from.

“Hey, good throw, Lapis!” Bismuth called.

Lapis turned around. “Huh? That wasn’t me,” she said.

“If she didn’t...” Bismuth looked into the distance. “Then who…” Her eyes settled on the culprit, who was making her way over to the beach. “...oh. That’s probably not good.”

Jasper stomped through the sand, angrily glaring at every Gem before her. “WHO’S NEXT!?” she roared.

Instantly, the fighting stopped. Everyone present turned to face her. A silence of both fear and awe washed over Bluebird’s Gems, as well as Bluebird herself. Many of them took several cautious steps back.

“Listen up, you traitorous, classless, off-colored, sorry excuses for Homeworld forces!” Jasper bellowed. As she stepped forwards, the Gems in her way stepped aside. “Which one of you is in charge?”

Bluebird began to glow. Where she stood moments prior, now stood a pair of Gems, an Aquamarine and a Ruby. “Jasper!” shouted the latter, excitedly running towards her, as the former tried to stop her.

“Wait…” said Peridot. “Bluebird Azurite was Aquamarine and Eyeball this whole time!?” Lapis rolled her eyes.

The Ruby known as Eyeball ran up to Jasper, as the Quartz stared down at her with a mixture of disdain and curiosity. “Jasper, Jasper, it’s me! I’m your biggest fan! D-do you remember me!?”

“Vaguely,” Jasper said. “Weren’t you that Ruby from back during the war?”

“Yes, that was me!” Eyeball shouted. She saluted Jasper. “Ruby Facet 1F4 Cut 4ND, at your service!”

“Ruby!” Aquamarine chided. “We’re not here to socialize with Homeworld’s corrupted rejects!”

“But--” Eyeball tried to protest. Jasper cut her off when she stepped past her.

“So,” Jasper said, walking towards Aquamarine, “I take it you’re the boss?”

“You take right!” Aquamarine said. “Wait...that doesn’t--nevermind!” She looked around at her troops. “What are you all waiting for!? Get her!”

But none of them moved. All of them, even the newer ones, knew all too well who Jasper was and what she was capable of. They refused to budge.

Jasper let out a small chuckle. “No takers, huh?” She pounded her fist into her open palm. “Guess it’s just the two of us, then!”

“Uh…” Aquamarine looked around fearfully. “Okay, new plan: everyone back to the ship!” She and the other Gems quickly hurried to the vessel, which began to lift up out of the sand.

Aquamarine picked Eyeball up, carrying her up to the door. “Wait, we--” she tried to protest.

“No time!” Aquamarine said, depositing her inside. She looked around, scanning for anyone she had missed: she found only one. “Topaz! Get up here!”

Topaz, still down on the ground, only mumbled something, her eyes staring downwards.

“What was that?” said Aquamarine. “Get up here now, or we’re leaving you behind!”

“I...I don’t want to…” Topaz said quietly.

“What!?” said Aquamarine.

“I said I don’t want to!” Topaz shouted. “I-I only went along with you because you *made* me! But now I...I want to stay here, on Earth!”

Aquamarine glared down at her. “Fine, then.” The door to the ship slid closed. It lifted up into the sky, blasting off into the distance. The beach was silent once more.

Lapis relaxed, letting go of some water hands she still had up. “Well then,” she said. “That went pretty well, all things considered. Everyone okay?”

“Yeah, I’m good,” said Connie, placing her sword back in Lion’s mane. “Just another Gem trying to kill me. Same old, same old.”

“Doin’ pretty good over here!” said Bismuth. “Looks like Little Homeworld just got another resident!” She walked up to Topaz, placing a hand on her shoulder. “Hey. I don’t know if you’re ready, but if you ever wanted to join the Crystal Gems, there’s always a place here for ya!”

Topaz smiled. “T-thanks,” she said. “I...I’ll think about it.”

Peridot, meanwhile, made her way up to Jasper. “Hey, Jasper! Thanks for helping us fight off those rogue Gems!”

Jasper scoffed. “I wasn’t helping *you* . Those Gems came to me, badmouthed Pink Diamond, and insulted me to my face--I was just getting even.”

“Oh. Well...thanks anyway!” said Peridot, running back to the house, accompanied by Connie and Lapis. Topaz joined them as well. Jasper turned to leave, but felt a hand on her shoulder.

“Hey,” said Bismuth. “I don’t know if you’re ready, but--”

“Don’t bother,” Jasper growled, pushing off her hand and walking away. Bismuth shrugged, turning to join the others.

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“So, uh…” said Scorpia. She currently found herself tangled up in countless wires that connected her to the Black Garnet, and many more that connected her to some other unseen piece of machinery. “What’s the plan here, Em?”

Nearby, Emerald leaned over a nearby computer terminal, pouring over data gathered by Entrapta when she had last interfaced with the Runestone. She had even managed to dig up some of Shadow Weaver’s notes from when she managed to siphon it’s power. “Don’t call me ‘Em,’” she said. “And I’m using you to power my latest weapon.”

“Oh,” said Scorpia. “So...what’s the Black Garnet for?”

Emerald groaned. “Why me?” she said quietly, before regaining her composure. “The Black Garnet is an extremely potent energy source. Because you have an untapped connection to it, I am using you as a conduit to funnel its power into my aforementioned weapon.”

“You mean…” Scorpia looked at her reflection in the giant red crystal. “...I have a connection with the Black Garnet?” She reached out a claw, almost touching it’s surface.

“Dah-ah-ah, don’t touch it!” snapped Emerald. “There is painstaking research and development going on here, you’re going to throw off all of my data!”

Scorpia went back to sitting in her chair, her claws in her lap. “Sorry,” she mumbled. “Um, if I can ask, what sort of weapon are you building?”

“Simple, really,” said Emerald. “Lars of the Stars stole my favorite ship, and crashed my other ship, so I’m building one he can’t do either to!” She turned to the adjacent room, where the power taken from the Black Garnet was going. “Using the destroyed husk of my *Destiny Destroyer* , I have created the ultimate in airborne and spaceborne warfare! I call it...the *Destiny Destroyer mk. II* ! But for brevity’s sake, I’ll just call it the plain old *Destiny Destroyer* .

“...Huh. Neat,” said Scorpia.

Before the Breach

Chapter Summary

Both the Rebellion and the Horde prepare for battle.

Chapter Seventeen: Before the Breach

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"Hey Adora."

Adora lifted her head as the door slid open, bringing a little bit of light into the otherwise darkened room. She was on her knees, her arms bound above her head. As she looked, she could see a silhouetted figure enter the room. "What do you want, Catra?" she said.

"Wouldn't you like to know?" All that Adora could see of Catra was her glowing eyes, but she could tell from her tone of voice that she was grinning.

"Uh, yeah, I would. That's why I asked."

As Catra stepped closer, Adora could see her smug smile. "Well, since you asked nicely," she said. "Do you remember, back before all of this started? Before you found that sword? We told each other that we were going to rule this planet. Just the two of us, together." She looked at Adora with disappointment. "What happened to that, Adora?"

Adora sighed. "People change, Catra," she said. She looked up into her old friend's eyes. "You can change, too."

"Maybe I don't *want* to change," Catra said coldly. "Actually, scratch that. I do, just not in the way you're thinking." She turned away from her captive. "I'm going bigger. I'm *Lord* Catra now. This planet isn't big enough for me anymore. Do you get it?"

“I don’t think I do,” Adora said. “If you don’t want to rule Etheria, then what do--”

“The universe, dummy!” shouted Catra. “I’m talking about ruling the universe, just like the Gems! Just like Horde Prime!”

“Catra...what are you talking about? Where is this coming from?” asked Adora, almost in disbelief. “What do--”

“Where do you think *this* is coming from!?” Catra snapped. “You were always the one at the top, Shadow Weaver’s star student! Did you ever stop and think that maybe I wanted to be at the top for once? For once in my life, I want to be the one in control!”

“By invading other worlds?” said Adora.

“...Yes!” Catra yelled, as though it was the most obvious thing in the world. “What did you think the Horde’s been doing for the past few decades!? But now that I’m the one calling the shots...me and my new friends aren’t limiting ourselves to just one planet.”

“Catra…” Adora tried to think of something, anything, she could say to make her friend see reason. But ever since she had found the sword, seeing reason was something Catra had struggled with. “I’m going to stop you. *We’re* going to stop you. You know that, right?”

Although her expression barely changed, Adora could feel the disappointment radiating off of Catra. “I knew you wouldn’t understand,” she said, averting her eyes. “You never understood. I don’t know why I hoped you would this time.” She turned away, heading for the door.

“Wait, Catra!” Adora called after her. “It isn’t too late to stop this!”

Catra scoffed. She turned around, her eyes meeting Adora’s. “Stop? I’m doing this for us, Adora. You’re the one who decided to run away from this, not me. It’s not too late for *you* to join *me* . Let me know if you come to your senses.”

The door closed behind Catra as she left the room, once again surrounding Adora in darkness. She groaned as her head dropped, once again unable to get through to her old friend. She may not have known exactly what Catra was planning, but it had to involve her sword. And without it, there wasn't much she could do to get herself out of here.

Except that wasn't exactly true. Gritting her teeth and getting to her feet, Adora pulled on her restraints, searching for weaknesses in the bindings. Even if her friends were coming for her--which she knew they were--she could still get herself out of this. It just might take a little while…

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Glimmer, Steven, and Lars stood beside each other right outside Castle Brightmoon's guest room, where Hordak was currently being held. They stood there for a little while; though they all knew what the plan was, each of them was a little reluctant to go through with it.

Everyone knew what the situation was: the Horde was holding Adora prisoner, and were no doubt planning their attack at that very moment. But while Queen Angella wanted to exercise caution, Glimmer wanted to attack the problem at the source, and get her friend back as soon as possible. She couldn't afford to wait. And neither could Adora.

It was Lars who spoke first. "So...are we sure we can trust this guy?" he said. "I mean, he was a bad guy up until pretty recently."

"So was Peridot back when we teamed up," said Steven. "This isn't really that different: we both have the same goal, and working together is the best way to accomplish that. I'm sure Hordak feels the same way."

"We can hope," said Glimmer. "Just let me do most of the talking, okay?" She stepped forward to open the door, leading the three inside.

Within the guest room, Hordak had been sealed behind a magical barrier, courtesy of Castaspella. Other than that, the room itself didn't seem to be much of a prison, as it was just as luxurious as any other room in the castle. The prisoner himself didn't mind much either, sitting in a chair and reading as the trio entered. "I was wondering how long it would take you to arrive," he said, not looking up from his book.

"Right," Glimmer said quietly. She walked up to the barrier, so that the two of them were mere inches apart. "Hordak. I assume you know why we're here?"

"I know why *you're* here," he said. He gestured to Steven and Lars. "Them, not so much."

"We're Adora's friends, too," said Lars. "And we're not just gonna sit around while Catra has her!"

"That's right," added Steven. "We have to rescue her. But we need your help to do it."

Hordak glanced up, looking behind the three of them. "I don't suppose the queen knows about this?" he asked.

"Not...not exactly," Glimmer admitted. "She said that rushing in before we know what the Horde is planning could put Adora in even more danger. But she's already been kidnapped, she's in as much danger right now as she could be! So no, she doesn't exactly know about this. But we aren't exactly *asking* for your help."

"I didn't think so," Hordak said. "Do you have a plan?"

"Yes," said Lars. "Go in guns-blazing, knock Catra down a few pegs, and bring Adora back before Angella even knows we're gone!"

Hordak looked at him in exasperation. "That isn't a plan, that's a general outline. If you really want to rescue your friend, and

return me to my throne in the process, you'll need something better."

"Well, do *you* have something better?" asked Steven.

Hordak turned to face him, leaning closer to the barrier. "I assume you're the one called Steven? I don't believe we've formally met. How goes your search for that mysterious sword?"

Steven, taken aback, took a step backwards. "H-how did you…?"

"Wait...wait, what sword? No, come back…" Steven's voice descended down from the darkened ceiling. It was followed not long after by the one copying it, as Imp flew down from above, landing on a nearby windowsill, cackling at Steven's reaction.

"Nightmares," Hordak said.

"I...Okay, I've been having some weird dreams, but I have no idea what they mean. I don't even know what sword he's talking about!"

"Maybe he means Adora's sword," suggested Lars. "Catra probably has that too. Maybe this guy in your dreams is telling you to go save her?"

"Could be," Steven said with a shrug.

"Dreams or not, it doesn't change the fact that Adora's in danger," Glimmer said, turning back to Hordak. "Like it or not, we'll need to work together to get what we want. You help us save Adora, and we'll...consider putting you back in charge. But only if you prove yourself to be less of a threat than Catra!"

Hordak growled, but seemed to accept this. "Very well. You there, Lars. You have a ship, correct?"

"That I do," said Lars.

“Good. We’ll need to attack from the air if we want any chance; it is the only thing the Fright Zone isn’t fortified against. Now, set me free, and gather the other members of your little rebellion.” He turned away from them, facing in the direction of the Fright Zone. “It’s time I took back what is rightfully mine…”

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“These energy readings are...they’re unlike anything I’ve ever seen before!” said Entrapta, as the screen before her lit up with massive numbers. “You were right, Catra, this sword was just what we needed to get this portal working!”

Catra, Entrapta, Scorpia, and Emerald all stood before the completed portal. A Peridot, one of Emerald’s lackeys, worked on an unrelated device at the other end of the room. “I knew it would,” Catra said, grinning. “How long until we can get it up and running?”

Entrapta double-checked the data. “Should be only a few hours now,” she said. “Aah, this is so exciting! Aren’t you all excited? We’ll finally be able to explore the world outside of Despondos!”

“Um...not to rain on your parade, Entrapta, but didn’t we already do that?” said Scorpia. “On two separate occasions?”

“Oh. True…” Entrapta said. “But this time, it’ll be on our own terms! We won’t have to be bound by the limits of inferior technology anymore: with this First Ones/Gem tech combination, the whole universe will be ours to discover!”

“And to conquer,” added Catra. Emerald grinned.

“Speaking of which, I’d like to think that this party is almost ready to begin,” Emerald said. She turned to face the other gem. “Peridot! Is that communicator almost ready!?”

“Just about, My Emerald!” replied the Peridot. “I just need to...Ah! There it is! Ready to broadcast, My Emerald!”

“Excellent! Contact the fleet--soon enough, this planet will fall, and Lars of the Stars will be nothing more than dust beneath my heel!” She walked over just as Entrapta noticed a fluctuation in power in the portal.

“Hmm. That’s odd,” she said.

Scorpia leaned in over her shoulder. “Odd how?”

“The First Ones tech and the Gem tech...they should be meshing perfectly, but it’s almost like they’re rejecting each other. Like two magnets with the same polarity.”

“Is that going to be a problem?” Catra asked.

“Not in its current state,” Entrapta said. “As it is, it’s just a subtle push, like--”
“Good, said Catra. “Keep it that way. I don’t want anything delaying this. I’d prefer to be out of here before the rest of Adora’s ‘friends’ arrive.

Emerald returned. “Oh, I don’t think we’ll have to worry about them!” she said, sneering.

“And why not?” Catra asked.

“Because I’ve just called for every reinforcement I have,” Emerald said. “The Rebellion doesn’t stand a chance--in fact, I think it’s time we took the fight to them!”

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The silence was shattered as Peridot burst in through Steven’s front door. “Everyone, quick, get out here! You need to see this!”

Of the three inside, only Lapis looked up. “Is it another meteor shower?” she asked.

“Oh, *ha-ha* !” said Peridot. “Seriously, get out here right now! This is bad, really bad!”

“Woah, easy there, little buddy!” said Bismuth. “What exactly is going on out there?”

“The ships, they’re leaving!” Peridot exclaimed.

“Isn’t that...a good thing?” said Connie. “They’re leaving Earth alone, right?”

“Yes. And they’re *heading for Etheria* !” exclaimed Peridot.

“Wait, what!?” Bismuth stood up, hurrying over. “Show me!”

“ *Thank* you! Finally, someone gets it!” Peridot said. She led Bismuth outside to the telescope, with Connie, Lapis, and Topaz following. She brought them over to the telescope, but they didn’t need it to see the collection of Gem warships conveigning towards the lone light in the sky. “See?”

Bismuth was the first to look through the telescope. “Woah…” she murmured. “Yup, they’re heading there, alright.”

“So, um...what does this mean?” asked Topaz.

“Nothing good, that’s for sure,” said Lapis.

“I’ll tell you what it means,” said Connie. “It means Emerald’s up to something big.”

“There has to be something we can do,” said Peridot. “Some way we can warn them…”

Connie looked at Peridot, then at Lion, and then back to Peridot. The others joined her in staring at the small Gem.

“...What?”

Skies over the Fright Zone

Chapter Summary

Lars runs into an old friend as the heroes' attack on the Fright Zone begins.

Chapter Eighteen: Skies over the Fright Zone

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"Glimmer?" Queen Angella made her way up to her daughter's room, having not heard from the girl in several hours. "We're about to discuss strategy. If we are to invade the Fright Zone and rescue Adora, we will need your--" Curiously, the door to Glimmer's bedroom was left ajar. Angella peered inside, already concerned.

Sure enough, the room was completely empty. Angella entered, scanning the corners to make sure she hadn't missed Glimmer somewhere. She hadn't seen her leave--had she gone out the window?

Angella peered outside through the glass. There was no sign of Glimmer or any of her friends. There was, however, the sound of a ship's thrusters off in the distance. "No…" The shape of the *Sun Incinerator* rounded the corner of Brightmoon, headed off towards the Fright Zone. "Glimmer, no!"

Angella opened the window, flying after the ship, but it was too fast. The ship, no doubt carrying Glimmer and the others, sped off into the distance, towards a mission that was much too dangerous. Especially now that Hordak was among them.

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"Alright, we should arrive at the Fright Zone in a few minutes," Lars announced. "What then?"

“Wait,” Hordak said. “Land just before we arrive. For this plan to work, we will need to split into two groups.”

“Speaking of ‘this plan,’ would you mind telling us what ‘this plan’ even is?” said Mermista. “Because all we have so far is ‘rescue Adora.’ That’s not much of a plan, that’s more of a general outline.”

“That’s what Hordak said,” said Steven. Because his powers were still gone, he had equipped himself with a shield from the Brightmoon armory. “Don’t worry, I’m sure he has something!” In addition to Lars and his crew, Steven, Glimmer, Bow, Pearl, Hordak, Perfuma, Mermista, Frosta, and Hordak’s two lieutenants were present.

“Indeed,” added Hordak. “Rescuing your friend and regaining control of my base will require a diversion. And that is where this ship comes in.”

“We’re all ears,” said Lars.

“In the years since my...disappearance, Catra has heavily bolstered the Horde’s armies by repairing Horde Prime’s troops. I have no doubt that the Fright Zone will be heavily guarded by cybertanks and cybercolossi. Lars, you will need to distract these defenses while I lead my team inside.”

“Okay, I think we can manage that,” Lars said. “What do you guys think?”

“We’ve got this, Captain!” said the Rutile twins.

“Nooo proooblem!” said Fluorite.

“I’m sure it’ll be fine!” said Rhodonite.

“Let’s take off!” said Padparadscha.

“Good,” said Hordak. “My strike team will consist of the princesses, as well as Bow, Steven, and Pearl. We will--”

“Hang on,” said Bow. He took out his tracker pad. “I think I should stay on the ship. I can get better scans of the Fright Zone from the sky. That way, I can warn you if I detect anything out of the ordinary. Here…” He produced an earpiece from his pocket, handing it to Glimmer.

Glimmer, however, refused the device. “Bow, if you’re staying here, then so am I.”

“What?” said Bow. “But Glimmer, what about Adora? If we’re going to rescue her, don’t you want to be there?”

“I trust everyone to bring her back,” Glimmer said. “ *And* to make sure Hordak doesn’t try anything funny.”

“You can count on us!” said Frost. “...on both counts!”

Bow handed the earpiece to Steven instead. “I guess you’ll be our communications officer, then.”

Steven took the earpiece, fitting it into place. “Huh, fits pretty good,” he said. “Okay, I think we’re almost there. Now we should--”

Steven was interrupted by a clattering noise from behind. Everyone turned in the direction of the sound, many of them on their guard, fearing they had been boarded. “What was that?” asked Rhodonite.

“Probably nothing good,” said Pearl, summoning her spear just in case. She slowly approached a stack of crates in the corner, prepared to strike. She reached down, moved one of the crates out of the way...and was greeted by the sight of three stowaways.

“Spinel!?” exclaimed Steven. “What are you doing here? I told you to wait back at Brightmoon!”

“I know, I know!” Spinel, accompanied by Garnet and Amethyst, stood up. “But I couldn’t just sit around while you went off to save the day!”

“Spinel, this is going to be dangerous!” Steven continued. “I don’t want you getting hurt!”

“And I don’t want to be left behind again!” Anger flashed across Spinel’s face, but it lasted only briefly. A short silence followed, which was eventually broken by Lars.

“I mean, we can still turn around if you--” he said, but was cut off.

“No, it’s too late now,” said Steven, sounding slightly annoyed. “We’ll just have to bring them along.”

“Yay!” Spinel ran over, wrapping her arms around Steven. “Thanks, best friend!” Steven only grimaced.

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Steven, Pearl, Hordak, Perfuma, Mermista, Frosta, Huntara, and Tung Lashor disembarked, accompanied by Spinel, Garnet, and Amethyst. “Okay, do you all know what to do?”

“Relax. I am leading this team,” said Hordak. “As long as Lars performs his task as planned, this will be a successful mission.”

“I’ll take that as a yes,” said Bow, returning back onto the ship.

“Good luck up there, you guys!” called Steven.

“Right back at ya!” Lars called back, before the door closed, and the *Sun Incinerator* took off towards their destination.

Glimmer glanced back at them as the ship sped off. “I hope Hordak knows what he’s doing,” she said.

“I’m sure he does,” said Lars. “I mean, he probably wouldn’t have conquered your planet if he didn’t!...Okay, that came out way less reassuring than I meant it to.”

After a short flight, the Fright Zone came into view. It definitely looked better-defended than the last time they had seen it.

“What’s the plan, Lars?” asked one of the Rutiles.

“The plan? Be as loud and as visible as possible!” Lars said. “If we wanna get their attention, then we’ll have to grab it and never let go! Full speed ahead!”

The *Sun Incinerator* sped towards their destination. Already, the Fright Zone was beginning to activate its defenses. Just as Hordak predicted, cybertanks and cybercolossi were being deployed to counter the intruder.

Beams of energy streaked past the ship, some colliding against its hull. “They’re firing on us, Captain!” said Rhodonite.

“Then let’s fire back!” he said. “Target those robots!”

Avoiding the shots, the *Sun Incinerator* fired some beams of its own at its attackers. Cybertanks were torn apart by the barrage as it looped around for another run. A pair of cybercolossi returned fire, narrowly avoiding the vessel.

“Careful! Those cybercolossi should be our first priority!” said Padparadscha.

“Good thinking, Pads,” said Lars. “Team! Focus fire on the big ones!”

As the firefight continued, Bow’s eyes were fixed on his tracker pad. “Anything yet?” asked Glimmer.

“I think so,” he replied. “I’m getting a huge energy reading from this area here. I think that’s where Hordak’s sanctum is.”

The ship swerved to the side, almost making the two lose their balance. “First Ones?” Glimmer asked.

“Definitely,” said Bow. “I know what you’re thinking; yes, it’s probably Adora’s sword.”

“Better tell Steven,” said Glimmer. “If Adora’s sword is here, Adora probably is, too.”

Bow pressed a few buttons on his pad. “Steven, this is Bow, do you read?”

“I hear you, Bow,” Steven said. “How is everything up there?”

“Um…” Bow looked up as the *Sun Incinerator* tilted to its side to dart in-between two cybercolossi. “...doing okay,” he said. “Are you almost there?”

“We’re right on the edge of the Fright Zone,” Steven answered. “Lars looks like he’s giving them a hard time!”

“You know it!” Lars called from the captain’s chair.

“Steven, I think we know where they’re holding Adora,” Bow said. “Make your way to Hordak’s sanctum, there’s a huge energy reading coming from there.”

“Sanctum, got it,” said Steven. “We’ll head right there as soon as--”

“Wait a minute, something's wrong!” exclaimed Rhodonite.

“Wrong? Wrong how?” asked Lars.

“They...they’re lowering their weapons,” said Padparadscha.

“What? Why are they doing that?” asked a Rutile.

“...Steven?” said Bow. “I’ll need to call you back…”

The cybertanks and cybercolossi, which had previously been firing at the *Sun Incinerator* , had suddenly ceased fire, retreating back into their previous positions. This was in spite of the ship still circling the Fright Zone, and still having plenty of units left.

Glimmer was as confused as everyone else. “Did they give up or something?” she asked.

“Uh-oh. Guys?” Bow indicated his tracker pad. Another energy surge. This one’s...kind of a mish-mash. It’s got some First Ones, some Gem, some Horde...the works.”

“We see it on the radar,” said Rutile. “...uh-oh…”

“Y’know, I don’t really like that you guys keep saying ‘uh-oh,’” said Lars. What’s going on here?”

The source of the surge made itself visible. Bolts of crimson energy sparked from a pair of bay doors sliding open on a rooftop. A vast shape, equal parts green, red, and black emerged. “Is that…?” said Rutile.

“The *Destiny Destroyer* …” said Lars. “And it looks like it got some upgrades.”

The newly-completed *Destiny Destroyer mk. II* looked like a haphazard collection of parts, a veritable Frankenstein’s Monster of a ship. Pieces from the original had been slapped together, held in place by Horde tech that jutted out at unnatural angles. And the whole thing continuously emanated a red haze as it hovered up to meet its adversary.

A voice came through the comms. “We meet again, Lars of the Stars!”

“Emerald!” said Lars. “What’s the deal with your new ship? It looks like you made it yourself!”

“For your information, I did!” Emerald retorted. “But this is no ordinary ship! This is the *Destiny Destroyer mk. II* ! And thanks to the power the Black Garnet has provided me, it will be your end! I will finally have my beloved *Sun Incinerator* back, and you will be nothing more than dust!”

With a deafening creaking sound, a pair of cannons emerged at the front of Emerald’s ship. “Evaaasiiive maneeeuvers!” cried Fluorite.

Bolts of crimson energy shot out of the cannons, barely missing the *Sun Incinerator* . The ship swerved to the right, narrowly avoiding the shots. More and more of the bolts were fired, though thankfully none hit their mark.

“Those are pulse cannons!” exclaimed Rhodonite. “They’ll fry our systems if they hit us!”

“All the more reason not to get hit!” said Lars. “Now, let’s give Emerald a taste of her own medicine!”

The *Sun Incinerator* rounded the far corner of the Fright Zone, turning back towards Emerald’s new vessel. The cruiser let loose a barrage at the larger ship, only for the shots to pass through it, as though it was a shadow. “Captain! No effect!” Rutile exclaimed.

A peal of laughter came over the comms. “You didn’t really think it would be that easy, did you, old friend?” said Emerald. “As I said, I have the power of the Black Garnet on my side! With this power infused into this vessel’s very core, you have no chance at escaping me again! I will give you one last chance: surrender the *Sun Incinerator* to me, and I will allow you--”

“Fat chance!” Lars exclaimed. “Punch it!”

The *Sun Incinerator* sped towards the *Destiny Destroyer* , spinning to avoid the shots fired its way. The smaller ship flew under it, speeding off into the distance as Emerald gave chase.

“Wait, where are you going?” shouted Glimmer. “What about Adora and the others?”

“Don’t worry, as long as Emerald’s after us, she’s not after them,” said Lars. “And I don’t think she’ll ever give up this chase!”

It certainly looked like she wouldn’t. The *Destiny Destroyer* raced after its target, continuing to fire its barrage. One of the blasts hit its mark, right in the *Sun Incinerator* ’s thrusters. The engines cut out for just a moment, a split second, just long enough to worry those onboard.

“I would not recommend taking another hit like that, Captain!” said Padparadscha.

Emerald continued to hound the crew. “Alright, new plan,” Lars said. “If we’ve learned anything in our time on the run, it’s that Emerald’s ship is no good at cornering. Find somewhere with a lot of turns!”

“There’s a canyon not far from here,” said Rhodonite, “but are you sure that--”

“Excellent! Head there!” said Lars. The *Sun Incinerator* diverted its course as Emerald continued firing. A few of the pulses managed to hit, each one shorting out the systems for a brief moment. The ship held together, but the repeated attacks were beginning to have a larger effect.

“Are you sure about this, Lars?” asked Bow, concerned. “This seems a little bit risky…”

“Hey, better taking a risk than letting Emerald catch us!” said Lars.

As the *Destiny Destroyer* bore down on the smaller vessel, it made a quick barrel roll before diving down into the entryway to the canyon. Emerald’s ship was too large to enter, so surely they were safe down here. All that mattered now was not hitting any of the cliff walls…

“Nngh...Go around! Cut them off!” yelled Emerald. Her ship continued on above the canyon.

The *Sun Incinerator* raced through the narrow cavern, just small enough to slip through. “Fluorite, how’re we doing?” asked Lars.

“Nooot baaad, but nooot goooooood eeeitheeer,” Fluorite said. “Thooose puuulse caaanons aaaren’t doooing uuus aaany faaavors…”

“Okay, just hold her together a bit longer,” said Lars. “Any sign of Emerald?”

“She’s not on the radar anymore, we must have gotten too far,” said Rutile. “There is...something else, though.”

“Something else? Like what?”

“I can’t tell just yet,” said Rutile. “Some sort of disturbance in the planet’s upper atmosphere. We’d have to get back above-ground to get any more info.”

“Then we’ll leave this cave as soon as we can,” said Glimmer. “We have to get back to the Fright Zone before--”

As the ship approached a larger room in the cavern, a large shape suddenly jumped out at them, appearing out of nowhere, as if it had phased through the wall. The *Destiny Destroyer* blocked their path.

“Hard left!” Lars shouted. The *Sun Incinerator* swerved to the side, just as it was hit by a collection of blasts. Navigation and shields were scrambled.

Rather than ram headlong into the *Destiny Destroyer* , however, the *Sun Incinerator* instead passed right through it. One moment they were heading right for it, the next everything was dark, and the next, they appeared on the other side. Everyone was so taken-aback by this development that they didn’t react in time as the ship headed for the cliff face.

The ship’s crew pulled up just before they hit the wall head-on, but not before the bottom of the vessel scraped against the rocks. The cabin shook as the ship reeled from the impact--with no shields to protect it, the hull was shredded.

“Criiitiiicaaal huuull daaamaaage!” announced Fluorite.

“Captain, our core’s been breached!” said Rhodonite. “We’re losing power by the second, and our weapons systems are shot!”

Lars groaned, pounding the armrest of his seat. “We’ve only got one shot at this--take us back to the surface!”

“Right away, Captain.” Once they passed the next hole, the *Sun Incinerator* exited the cavern. The ship rattled and shook, its shields still not having come back online.

“Okay, okay…” Lars said, trying not to panic. “Let’s get started on repairs, and--”

“No use--the ship is falling apart faster than Fluorite can fix it!” said Padparadscha.

“Then we’ll have to set down somewhere,” he said. “Keep watch for Emerald, and...woah…

“...I take it that’s your atmospheric disturbance?” said Bow.

Gem warships of all shapes and sizes filled the sky. Coming from the direction of Earth, they began to spread out, covering the area above the Fright Zone and beyond. “Captain! We’re being targeted!” said Rutile.

“What!? By them, or by Emerald!?” said Lars.

“Both!”

A vibrating hum coming from behind them informed them that the *Destiny Destroyer* was back on their tail. More and more pulse shots collided with their ship’s rear. The already-failing systems got even worse.

Lars had nothing to say. Even if he had, he would have been interrupted as a familiar glow appeared on his head. “Not now--” Who should emerge from his hair but Peridot, looking worried.

“Sorry if this is a bad time,” she said, “but we’ve detected a large portion of Emerald’s ships headed towards your location!”

“WE KNOW!” yelled everyone.

“Oh. Okay, already on top of everything,” Peridot said. She looked around at the sorry state the ship’s bridge was in. “...Eesh. What

happened here?”

“Emerald happened!” yelled Lars.

An explosion rocked the ground some distance away. Another, closer this time. Unable to see any source on the ground, the crew looked skyward. “Captain? They’re shooting at us,” said Rhodonite.

Onboard the *Destiny Destroyer* , Emerald wasn’t happy about this development either. “What are those idiots *doing* !?” she yelled. “They’re going to destroy my beloved *Sun Incinerator* !”

One of the stray blasts collided with the cliff face, mere feet from said ship. Although it technically missed, the vessel was bombarded with shrapnel and energy, sending it reeling. The *Sun Incinerator* spun out of control, the bridge bathed in crimson light as a warning siren shrieked.

“Captain! We’re going down!” yelled Rutile.

“I’m outta here!” Peridot yelped, retreating back into Lars’ hair. She peeked back out for just a moment to say “Quick! Through here!”

“Peridot is right, we must evacuate!” said Padparadscha.

“Whaaat abooout Laaars?” said Fluorite.

“Don’t worry,” said Glimmer, “I can get him out of here!”

“...Go. Get to safety,” said Lars. “I’ll be fine, I promise!”

The ship stayed aloft, but only barely. The *Destiny Destroyer* had mostly retreated, watching its descent from afar. “NO! Lars, what are you doing!?” Emerald bellowed.

As Bow worked to keep the ship in the air, Peridot, Padparadscha, Rutile, Fluorite, and Rhodonite all disappeared through Lars’ hair. “Stay safe, Captain,” said Rhodonite, as she too vanished.

“I can’t hold it much longer, it’s now or never!” said Bow.

“Quick, over here!” said Glimmer. Both Lars and Bow ran to her, as she grabbed tight to both of them. They vanished just as the *Sun Incinerator* reached the ground.

Emerald could only watch in horror as her beloved ship went up in a fireball. She slowly got to her feet, staring out the window at the crash site. A Peridot next to her looked at her with concern. “M-my Emerald?” She did not reply.

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Lars slowly opened his eyes. “Are we dead?” He scanned his surroundings to see dusty plains all around.

“No, but that might change soon,” said Glimmer. She let go of Lars and Bow, pointing towards the distant shape of the *Destiny Destroyer* . “We should probably get going before she realizes where we are.”

“Good idea,” said Bow. “She probably won’t be happy that her ship blew up…”

“ *That’s* an understatement,” said Lars. The three of them headed towards the Fright Zone, hoping it wasn’t too late.

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Emerald stepped out of the *Destiny Destroyer* , a look of disbelief frozen on her face. The wreck of her beloved *Sun Incinerator* lay before her. Too damaged to be repaired, the whole ship had been consumed by the flames, leaving only scattered pieces of hot metal and melted chassis.

The Peridot looked at her, concerned, as Emerald picked up a small piece of the ruined hull. Her fist closed around it, crushing it into powder. “Are you alright, My Emer--”

“Glass the planet,” Emerald said quietly.

“I-I’m sorry?” said the Peridot, stepping closer.

“Glass. The. Planet,” said Emerald, turning to face her. “Get back in there, and contact the fleet. Tell them to open fire.”

“My Emerald, open fire on what?”

“EVERYTHING!” Emerald lifted the Peridot up by her neck. “Tell them to fire on everything that moves! Everything that isn’t *me* ! I want Lars of the Stars, and everyone he calls an ally, *reduced to nothing more than SPACE DUST!* ” She threw the Peridot back towards the ship, where she scrambled back towards. Emerald looked to the sky at the incoming fleet. The ships were growing closer. “I’m finished playing nice,” she said quietly. “You have nothing more to offer me, Lars of the Stars. You will die along with the Princess Alliance, the Crystal Gems, and anyone else who stands by you. Mark my words, *you will know my fury* .”

The Breach

Chapter Summary

> Steven and the others infiltrate the Fright Zone to rescue Adora. Adora, meanwhile, escapes, intent on stopping Catra's plans before it's too late.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter Nineteen: The Breach

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Adora wasn't entirely sure what was going on outside the Fright Zone, but it sounded like help had arrived. Cannons and all sorts of other weapons were going off at whatever or whoever had come, and given the sheer amount of weapons being used, they had brought backup. Either that, or Catra really wanted them dead. Likely both.

Either way, she wasn't about to stay here. She continued gnawing at the ropes that bound her arms, the battle outside encouraging her to work just a little bit faster. Thankfully, Catra, in her hurry to get the portal working, hadn't considered that Adora would be able to cut through a length of rope without her sword. It took her a minute, but her teeth of steel came through in the end.

Letting out a sigh of relief as she fell to the floor, Adora stood up, massaging her sore wrists. As much as she would have liked to take a moment to rest, Catra was about to use her sword to activate that portal of hers, and there was no telling where that could lead. "Right. Sword." She headed for the door. After putting her ear to the wall to check for nearby guards, she opened it and snuck out into the hallway. She may not have had her sword, but she was still an elite Horde commando--formerly, of course. Still, she hoped that backup would be here soon.

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"I hope Lars knows what he's doing," said Frosta, as the group approached the Fright Zone.

"I'm sure he does," said Huntara. "He wouldn't have stolen that ship of his if he didn't, right?"

"Don't worry, guys," said Steven. "Lars can handle this, I know he can. We should focus on our job."

"Exactly," replied Hordak. "Stick to the plan, and everything will go smoothly."

The team of princesses and Gems, plus Hordak and his two lieutenants, made their way past the ongoing light show and into the Fright Zone depths. Being the one most familiar with their surroundings, having built the place, Hordak led them all down a path where they were least likely to be spotted. Of course, most of the Horde troops were occupied by the battle currently raging above their heads, so they were unlikely to be spotted anyways. Though unlikely still meant possible.

Perfuma walked up to the front of the group. "Do we have any sort of attack plan?" she asked. "I know there's a lot of us here, but even with Lars keeping them occupied, I don't think we should just be wandering in here…"

"Hey, it worked the last couple times," said Mermista.

Hordak shot her a look. "And what exactly does that mean?" he growled.

Mermista shrugged. "This place doesn't exactly have the best security. I guess it worked out nicely for you, though, since now you have to sneak into your own base."

"I will have you know, the Fright Zone is the most secure location of the entire Etherian Horde!" shouted Hordak, apparently

unaware of the irony. “I assure you, all of your attempts to infiltrate in the past were only successful due to sheer luck!”

Before Hordak could continue, or Mermista could retort, Steven stepped in between them. “Guys, guys, can we just agree that both sides have room for improvement, and keep our eyes on the mission?”

“Works for me,” said Mermista.

Hordak turned away. “Fine,” he grumbled. “But just know that if it wasn’t for your friend causing a distraction, my soldiers would have overwhelmed us the moment we stepped within the Fright Zone’s borders!”

At that moment, Hordak opened a door into the hallway, only for the party to be treated to the sight of both Lonnie and Rogelio. The pair were moving boxes within the cargo hold, both frozen at the sight of three princesses, four and a half Gems, two Crimson Waste thugs, and their former boss staring at them. The feeling was mutual, as everyone just sat in silence, unmoving, for several seconds.

“Well, guess you were right,” Frosta said quietly to Hordak.

After a few more seconds, Lonnie’s eyes gradually shifted over to the wall: the comms. Just one button press, and the entire Fright Zone would go into high alert. And with the sounds from the dogfight outside beginning to dwindle, they would soon be surrounded. “Don’t,” Hordak said.

Rogelio was mainly just surprised to see Hordak, but Lonnie was still considering sounding the alarm, her eyes shifting back and forth from the panel to the group. She looked ready to drop the crate at any moment.

“Cadet, don’t even think about it,” Hordak continued. “ *I* am your true leader, Catra is nothing more than a usurper. Do you truly seek to betray Lord Hordak?”

“He’s right....in a way,” Pearl said. “Catra is more of a threat than Hordak ever was.” Hordak glared at her, but she continued. “Do you really want to be a part of that?”

Lonnie considered Pearl’s words. It seemed like working under Catra really had been worse than working under Hordak. It seemed, for just a moment, that she was considering letting the group by. Perhaps she might have, if the alarm didn’t sound at that very moment.

As warning sirens echoed throughout the halls, Kyle sheepishly removed his hand from the panel. “I’m sorry! I thought you were trying to signal me or something!” he said to Lonnie.

With diplomacy out the window, Lonnie and Rogelio dropped the box, charging at the team with stun batons drawn. Hordak spread his wings and charged, effortlessly battering the large lizardkin aside. Before Lonnie could follow up, Tung Lashor’s whip wrapped around her wrist, causing her to drop the weapon. A shoulder check from Huntara knocked her to the ground.

Kyle had already made himself scarce by the time the fighting started. Pearl drew her spear and pierced through the panel. The alarms ceased, but by then it was too late, as the entire Fright Zone knew they were here. “Hurry! We have to leave before more troops show up!” she said.

Hordak ran ahead, and the team hurried after their temporary leader. As they all ran, Steven pulled Spinel aside. “Spinel, listen to me, I need you to keep an eye on Garnet and Amethyst,” he said urgently. “They can’t fight like this, and your stretchy powers mean you’re the best one to keep them out of harm’s way.” The two amnesiac Gems in question followed along, neither knowing exactly what was going on.

Spinel’s arm curled around a few times before saluting. “You got it, new best friend!” she said, chipper as ever. “Nothin’ll happen to ‘em, you can count on me!”

Suddenly, upon entering a large room, the team ground to a halt. "Good," Steven said as he saw what was up ahead, "because these guys aren't happy to see us…"

The room was filled with Horde bots, soldiers, and cybertroops, all of them focused on the intruders. The sounds of weapons charging up filled the room, leaving them precious little time to react. Luckily, the first of them to react was Frosta, throwing up a wall of ice between them and their foes. Dozens of lasers collided with the frozen barrier, which chipped and cracked, but ultimately held. "Looks like we're doing this the hard way!" she said.

Huntara extended her staff, smirking. "Heh, I love the hard way!" She darted out from behind the ice wall, rushing towards a cluster of Horde bots. "Bet I can take more out than you!"

"Dream on!" Tung Lashor ran out the other side, whip at the ready. The Princesses, Pearl, and Hordak followed suit, charging the Horde forces, while Spinel quietly ushered Garnet and Amethyst away from the fighting.

Steven, despite his lack of powers, charged in as well. Although his current shield was only made of metal rather than being a Gem weapon, it still allowed him to block a shot heading his way, and bash the trooper who had fired it aside. A bot behind him charged a shot too quick for him to block, but before it could fire, it was impaled from the side by a trident. A wave of water flowed over the bot as it exploded, and Mermista picked up her trident and headed towards more targets. Steven did the same.

Meanwhile, Spinel struggled to find a way out of the warzone, her charges close at her heels. "O-okay, this is fine, we can do this!" she muttered, mostly to herself. "Just gotta keep moving. Keep moving, keep moving, *keeeeep* moving…" She turned back, and let out a yelp as she saw a cybertroop hurtling through the air towards Garnet. She quickly stretched out her arms to pull her out of harm's way.

The machine smashed against the wall, but it still wasn't out of commission. Its eye focused on the trio as it raised its arm to fire. Spinel threw a giant fist forward, crushing it into scrap before it could. Letting out a sigh of relief, she turned back to Garnet.

"You okay?" she asked. Garnet, however, was more interested in the wrecked cybertroop, particularly the red and blue wires sticking out from the metal. Touching them earned her an electric shock, not that she seemed to care. "Eh, she's fine. Now, where'd Amethyst run off to?"

Amethyst had apparently decided that watching the battle was more interesting than running from it, and had wandered over to Perfuma, mimicking the princess' movements as she fought off the Horde's forces with various plants. Spinel ran over to retrieve her, only for the Gem to become more interested in what Steven was doing.

"Wait, get back here!" shouted Spinel, squishing her body to duck under blaster fire. "Amethyst!" She was now mimicking Steven, holding her arm up as he did, holding an invisible shield. She continued this even when Spinel began to drag her to safety. "Come on, we have to go! We need to...huh?" Spinel looked down curiously, her arms now empty.

Her charge had further gone on to imitate Tung Lashor, who was fighting several Horde soldiers at once. "Come on, is that all ya got?" he cried. "I ain't the King of the Wastes for nothin'!" Spinel hurried over once again, but this time, she noticed something.

Rather than simply miming using a whip, Amethyst had instead drawn one of her own from out of her gem. She flung it around with expert precision as though remembering her pre-rejuvenated self. Spinel got an idea. "Well...Steven did say to keep them safe," she said. Rather than pulling Amethyst to safety, she instead pushed her closer to the brawl, where she could put her whip to good use.

Although it started as her simply copying Tung's movements, slowly but surely, she began to form her own as well. Recognition dawned on her face as she fought off the soldiers, to Spinel's delight. Soon enough, she had properly joined the battle, knocking enemies aside left and right. A bright light shone from her body as she rolled into a ball, tearing towards Tung Lashor.

The ex-bandit fought hard, but was slowly becoming overwhelmed. He panted as the soldiers surrounded him, moving too fast for his whip to catch. Before they could finish him off, a glowing ball of hair suddenly came tearing by, knocking all of them aside. Puzzled, Tung Lashor watched as the ball came to a halt, unrolling to reveal Amethyst, back to her old self. "I gotcha, lizard dude!" she said, flashing a thumbs-up.

"Uh...thanks...purple gal," he said, still a little confused. Amethyst hopped over to give him a quick fist bump, before heading off to aid Pearl. Tung looked down at his fist, and grinned, before rejoining the battle himself.

"YES! I did it! I fixed Amethyst!" Spinel shouted, jumping for joy. "Steven! Steven, did you see that? I did something cool!" She ran off to find her best friend as the battle wound to a close.

Steven leaned against a wall, sweating bullets. His shield was dented and he was covered with bruises. He let the shield fall to the ground as he wiped his brow--it would seem being without powers took a larger toll than he had first thought. He looked around to see that everyone had stopped fighting as well. The battle was won. He looked up as Spinel ran over to him.

"Steven! Didja see that!?" she asked excitedly.

"See what?" he asked, still panting.

"Look! Amethyst's all better now!" she shouted, pointing over to the purple Gem. Indeed, she was back to her normal self, chatting away enthusiastically with Pearl. "I did that! I helped her get

better!" She looked at Steven enthusiastically with giant eyes. "Isn't that great?"

"Spinel...that's…" Steven was indeed glad to see Amethyst back to normal, but something else was bothering him. "How did you do that, exactly?"

"She was copying that tongue guy, and she brought out her whip!" Spinel reported. "So I helped her over a bit, and--"

"Hang on...you let her go into the fight?" Steven said, suddenly becoming much less happy.

"No, of course not! I nudged her towards the fight!"

"That's even *worse* !" Steven was fully angry now. "I told you to keep the two of them safe, Spinel! I said to keep them out of harm's way! How is putting them *in* harm's way doing that!?" By now, everyone had made their way over to the ruckus.

"Well, I...I thought I was helping," said Spinel.

"I...I know, I just...ugh," sighed Steven. "But do you always have to help so much?"

"We don't have time for this," said Hordak. "Catra is no doubt sending reinforcements to our location. If we stay here, we will very likely be caught again."

"Hey, Steven, it's not that big a deal, dude," said Amethyst, putting an arm around his shoulder. "She did help me come back, after all."

"I know she did, and I *am* glad to see you, but I...I don't know," Steven said.

As the group talked, none of them were aware that a Horde soldier had gotten to his feet, aiming a stun baton at Steven's back. Only the charging of the weapon alerted everyone to his presence, but by then, it was too late to react. Mere moments

before he could fire, a fist collided with his mask, knocking him back to the ground. “Phew. Everyone okay?” asked their rescuer.

“Adora!” shouted Frosta.

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Catra stared at the screen, upon which several security feeds from around the Fright Zone played. Lars of the Stars had long since led Emerald away, and now the princesses had returned to ruin her plans. Adora had made it out, and was on track to rendezvous with them. She silently ran her claws down the side of the terminal, leaving deep claw marks in the metal. She let out an almost silent snarl before she was interrupted by someone opening the door and stomping into the room.

“Emerald?” said Scorpia, as the green Gem made her way into the portal chamber. “What happened? Did Lars get away?”

Emerald ignored her, making her way up to Catra. “How long will it take to get this portal working?” she growled.

“How should I know? I’m not the scientist here,” she replied, her eyes still on the security feed. “And what *are* you doing back here, anyway? Didn’t you have an archenemy to deal with?”

Emerald growled again, but didn’t respond. Instead, she turned back to Entrapta. “Well?” Her tone of voice implied the same question.

“...Oh! It shouldn’t be long now,” Entrapta said, turning to the monitor in front of her. “It just needs a few moments to calibrate. Once it’s ready, we can fire it up!”

“Good,” snarled Emerald, grinning maliciously. “I can’t wait to leave this cesspool behind.”

With an air of apprehension, Scorpia approached the two from behind. “Um...Emerald?” she asked. “Are you sure you know what

you're doing with this portal thing? Because it looks kinda...dangerous."

"Of course it's dangerous," said Emerald, rolling her eyes. "That's why we're doing it. But yes, I do happen to know what I'm doing. I managed to pull an entire planet into this dimension with nothing more than a pile of outdated tech and an old sword, a few warships would be like nothing!" Behind her, Entrapta looked concerned as she double-checked the data. "Thanks to me, the Horde will soon be able to eclipse even Homeworld, and Lars of the Stars and everyone he loves will be obliterated!"

"W-what do you mean?" asked Scorpia.

"What do you *think* I mean!?" snapped Emerald. "Captain Lars, and all those infernal Crystal Gems he associates with, were being protected by the Diamonds! Once we take our place as the *true* masters of the universe, I will finally be able to get the revenge that has been denied to me for so long! I will finally be able to--"

"Hey, you guys?" said Entrapta. "I hate to interrupt your evil monologuing session, but I'm seeing something here that's a bit concerning…"

Catra took interest, walking over. "How so?"

"Here, take a look at this," Entrapta said. She pulled up a graph on the screen, showing some dangerously high readings going up into the red. Scorpia looked confused, and Emerald and Catra looked unamused. "Oh, right," Entrapta said softly. "What this means is that having more than one planet in Despondos isn't exactly agreeing with the portal's automatic targeting system. It's locking onto both, which might cause some problems when we activate it…"

"And...what sort of problems?" asked Scorpia.

"Well, what could basically happen is that both Etheria and Earth would be simultaneously phased into the same point in space and time, which, in quantum physics, is a definite no-no. Two atoms

can’t occupy the same space at a time, and if they try to, well…” Entrapta pressed a key, which caused a graphic of a planet exploding to play on the screen. “It’s a worst-case scenario, but--”

“And what’s a best-case scenario?” asked Catra.

“...That it works just as planned, with no ill effects,” said Entrapta. “The planets colliding is only a possibility, but--”

“Then keep going as planned,” said Catra. “We’ve made it this far, I don’t want to stop everything just because it *might* go wrong. Once it’s ready, activate it.”

“W-wait, hang on!” Scorpia ran over to Catra. “Wildcat, do you really want to take that risk? We could all die!”

Catra groaned. “Scorpia, don’t tell me you’re having second thoughts *now* . After everything we’ve worked for, you really want to give up?”

“If everyone I care about is in danger, then yes, I do!” said Scorpia. “Think about this, Catra: is all of this really worth it? Taking over the whole universe just to prove a point? Is that really worth maybe dying for?”

When Catra paused, as if considering this, Emerald spoke up. “Don’t tell me you’re actually listening to her! Think of everything we could gain!”

“...She’s right,” Catra said. “I’m sorry, Scorpia, but I need to take this risk.”

Scorpia was quiet for a moment. “Then I’m sorry too, Wildcat.” She hurried over to the computer terminal near the portal. She began tearing out wires and smashing through metal, trying to do as much damage as possible.

“What are you doing, you idiot!?” Catra yelled. “Stop! Scorpia, stop that, now!” Her hand went to something on her hip.

“I can’t!” she yelled back, her voice strained. “Not until you see reason!” Entrapta leaned back in her chair, just watching.

“Unbelievable!” Emerald said. She turned to Catra. “Do something, now! Stop her!” Catra’s eyes softened for a moment, before they were filled with ice once more.

Electricity coursed through Scorpia’s form, and not from the wires. Entrapta covered her mouth in horror as Scorpia fell to the ground, Catra standing behind her holding a stun baton.

“C-Catra… What did you--”

Catra held the stun baton out towards her. “You wanna be next?”

Entrapta, unable to form any words, simply shook her head.

“Good.” Catra holstered the stun baton. “You, fix this mess,” she said to Entrapta. “And you, deal with her,” she said to Emerald.

“‘Deal with her?’ And how exactly am I supposed to--”

“I don’t know!” Catra shouted. “Just...get rid of her! Send her to Beast Island!”

“What?” Entrapta said, her voice barely a whisper.

Emerald grinned. She snapped her fingers, and two Citrines appeared, seemingly out of the aether. They lifted Scorpia up, carrying her away. Catra gave her one last glance, before turning back towards the portal. Entrapta wordlessly began to repair the damages.

“You made the right choice.” Emerald seemed to hover over Catra’s shoulder. “We don’t need someone like that jeopardizing the mission.”

Catra said nothing.

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The three princesses hurried over to Adora. “Are you alright? You’re not hurt, are you?” asked Perfuma.

“How’d you break out without your sword?” asked Mermista.

Adora smiled. “Don’t worry, everyone, I’m fine!” she said. “And I know my way around the Fright Zone--I did use to live here after all!” In spite of this reunion, her tone turned serious. “But there’s no time for any of that. Catra has my sword, and I think she’s planning something big.”

“How big are we talkin’ here?” asked Huntara.

“ *Very* big,” Adora replied. “Big like...woah, big…” Flustered at seeing Huntara up close and personal, Adora shook her head. “I, uh, think she’s planning to open another portal. She wants to use Emerald’s fleet to conquer the universe!”

“Oh, is *that* all?” said Mermista.

“Then there truly is no time to waste,” said Hordak. “We must move quickly if we are to stop her!”

Adora stood in silence for a few moments, before pointing to Hordak with a confused expression. “We’ll explain later,” said Pearl.

Steven steeled himself once more, picking up his shield. “Alright everyone, let’s move...except you, Spinel. Take Garnet and get her to safety, preferably far away from the Fright Zone. And please, actually *listen* this time.”

“Wh--but...I *did* listen…” she said, sounding almost hurt.

“No, you didn’t,” Steven said, massaging his forehead. “You put Amethyst and Garnet in danger just to impress me. So don’t get any more ideas--”

“Well *excuse me* for trying to make you happy!” Spinel suddenly snapped, to the surprise of everyone. “That’s all I do! That’s all

I've *ever* done! That's all I'm *supposed* to do! Make you happy! But apparently that's not good enough for you!"

Steven was taken aback, not only by her outburst, but by her face--for a brief moment, it had suddenly changed back to how it had looked before she had been rejuvenated. "Spinel, what are...it's not about that!" he said.

"Yes it is! For as long as I can remember, that's what it's been like! After everything I've done, you just abandon me on an asteroid out in the middle of nowhere! I…" With a sigh, Spinel sagged. "Nevermind. Good luck." She sadly walked away, taking Garnet by the hand and leading her away.

"Spinel, wait--"

Steven tried to follow her, but was stopped by Frosta. "Apologize later, right now we gotta stop Catra!" She hurried after Hordak and the others, who had already gone ahead. With one last look in Spinel's direction, Steven followed.

Even without running into any more soldiers, there was still an air of urgency as the group hurried towards Hordak's former sanctum. The lights flickered ominously as they ran. "The portal must almost be ready," noted Hordak. "We must hurry!"

"Yeah, whaddya *think* we're doing?" asked Huntara, running just behind him.

"Catra's not gonna be alone in there," said Adora. "The moment we get to those doors, expect to be swarmed by soldiers and Gems."

Amethyst summoned her whip. "Then we'll just have to go in swingin'!"

Sure enough, when they had reached the sanctum, everyone prepared for battle. "Ice princess, break it down!" Hordak commanded.

“You got it!” said Frosta, sending an ice wall through the door. “But because I was gonna anyway, not because you said so!”

The steel was torn apart easily under the ice. As soon as the door gave way, the team found that Adora was right--Catra’s forces were ready for them. A squad of Horde soldiers and Citrines poured from within the sanctum, weapons out. Hordak led the charge as usual, throwing the troopers aside as he ran into his throne room. “Go! We’ll hold them off!” said Perfuma, as she and Huntara fought through the ambushers.

Steven and Adora ran in after the others. Inside, in addition to even more guards, Emerald and Catra stood before the portal, which, thanks to the Sword of Protection, was beginning to come to life. “Catra!”

Hearing Adora’s voice, the Horde Lord turned back to her old friend. A smirk crossed her face. “Hey, Adora. Made it out, did you? Eh, can’t say I’m surprised.”

“Catra, please, this needs to stop!” Adora pleaded. “This isn’t you!”

She rolled her eyes. “Ugh, how many times can you make this speech? All it does is make you sound desperate, you know.”

“Enough banter!” Hordak made his presence known, stepping to the front of the group. “Force Captain, this is your last chance to stand down peacefully!”

The moment Hordak appeared, Entrapta turned around in her chair. However, before she could speak up, Emerald stopped her. “No, you need to finish here first. I’ll handle this.”

“But I--”

“Destroy them!” yelled Emerald, pointing her arm forward. Her Citrines followed her orders, charging at the heroes. The Horde soldiers did so as well, catching most of them unawares. Steven blocked an incoming shot with his shield, before doing the same

to a Citrine's sword. He almost buckled under the force, but Mermista washed her away before he could.

"Thanks!" he called.

"Don't mention it. Now take that thing outta commission before--Argh!"

Tung Lashor had suddenly and unexpectedly flown through the air, colliding with Mermista and sending the both of them hurtling against the wall. Steven turned to see Emerald approaching him, glaring daggers all the while.

A wave of ice washed over the green Gem, seemingly freezing her solid. "Not so tough not, are ya!?" said Frosta. However, Emerald easily broke free of the ice, turning her attention to the princess. "Uh-oh…"

"You get Catra, we'll take care of Emerald!" Steven shouted to Adora, running over to help. Adora ran off as well, picking a stun baton up off a fallen soldier as she sprinted towards the portal. She took aim at the mechanism and fired a shot..

The blast was heading straight for its mark, only to be stopped at the last moment by Catra. Her new armor let her block the shot with her claws. She lunged at Adora, who blocked this strike in turn with the baton.

"Catra, I get that you want to prove yourself, but is *this* really the best way!?" Adora pleaded. "You've lived your whole life here on Etheria...what's out there for you!?"

" *Everything* !" Catra replied. She raised her other arm above her head, where metal casings around her claws glowed with heat. She slashed downwards, Adora rolling out of the way just as her red-hot claws pierced the floor. "A fresh start! Out there, with Emerald's help, I can finally be what I was meant to be!"

"And what's that? A conqueror? A tyrant?" Adora raised her baton, preparing to strike again. "I'm sorry, Catra, but I can't let that

happen.”

Catra smirked as she flexed her claws. “Oh, Adora...that isn’t for you to decide.”

Over by the others, Emerald was proving to be a surprisingly adept opponent. Frosta was unable to keep her frozen for long, and she hit like a freight train, as anyone who came close found out. With a single swing of her arm, she had battered Hordak against the wall.

Despite the princess’ best efforts, Emerald was gaining on Frosta. “Hey!” shouted Steven, throwing his shield for good measure. The disc collided with Emerald’s head--it only seemed to annoy her, but it definitely got her attention. She turned her focus to Steven, who ran towards her.

Emerald raised her arm to throw a punch, and Steven raised his shield to block. Emerald’s fist collided with the shield, but the force was enough to almost tear it in half. Steven was sent to the ground as his shield skidded away. The Gem grabbed him by the neck, lifting him to eye level. “You may not be Lars,” she snarled, “but I’ve been wanting to kill you almost as bad!”

Before she could make good on her promise, Emerald suddenly cried out, dropping Steven. Pearl stood just behind her, her spear driven into Emerald’s back. She whirled around, batting Pearl aside as Steven crawled over to his shield. Emerald pried the weapon from her back, snapping it in half.

Meanwhile, Entrapta was working diligently at her desk, alternating between getting the portal ready, ducking under and around combat, and trying to find an opportunity to approach Hordak. Then, before long, the words she had waited for appeared on the screen: *Portal Charge 100%* . “Okay, it’s ready now!” she shouted over the din of the fighting.

Catra and Emerald’s eyes were both turned to a simple lever near the portal, the pulling of which would connect Despondos with the

universes once more. The latter attempted to make her way over, only to be stopped as a whip snagged around her arm. “Uh-uh, you ain’t goin’ nowhere!” said Amethyst. Emerald struggled, which was only made more difficult as Frosta froze her once more. All she could do was roar in anger and glare at Catra and Adora.

Catra had been momentarily distracted by Entrapta’s shout. Adora took this moment to thrust her stun baton forward, almost colliding with her torso, but she deflected it at the last moment. Catra swung her claws, slicing the baton clean in half. Then, as Adora stumbled back, she sprinted towards the portal.

Mere moments before Catra could pull the lever, Adora had tackled her from behind. She held on as tightly as she could, holding her back. Although she reached for the lever, Catra was mere inches from her target. She threw an elbow back, successfully connecting with Adora’s face, and loosening her grip. Catra struggled forward only for Adora to pin her down yet again.

The two were now face to face. “I did tell you I’d stop you, didn’t I?” said Adora.

“And I said that wasn’t your call,” Catra replied. “That’s your problem, isn’t it? You always have to be the hero. Always pulling yourself closer and closer to...danger.”

Catra thrust her claws upwards. Adora gasped as five sharp talons pierced into her side.

For a moment, both of them were still. Then, looking like she was in just as much pain, Catra shoved Adora off of her, and stood up to face the portal. Her hand moved forward, inches away from victory.

“Catra...don’t…”

With a sigh, Catra glanced back at her former friend. “Sorry, Adora. But you don’t get to tell me when I can win anymore.”

Catra pulled the lever. Almost instantly, a blinding light shone forth from the portal, as the Sword of Protection rose to its center. Everyone save for Emerald and Catra looked on in horror as the light seemed to consume the entire room, a horrible static buzzing coming from within. As the light filled the room, the buzzing seemed to vibrate within their very bodies, consuming everything.

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"Do...Do you guys feel that?" said Lars. As he, Bow, and Glimmer hiked back to the Fright Zone, he felt something deep in his chest, like a pit that was growing larger and larger.

"I definitely feel something," Bow replied. "What's going on?"

All three of them looked on in awe and terror as a beam of light shot up from the center of the Fright Zone. As it grew brighter, it seemed to spread, covering everything in its path as it raced towards them.

"What…" Glimmer could only stare as the pillar grew ever larger, and the pits in their chests grew deeper. "...is that?"

"Are we… Are we too late?" Lars said quietly.

The light and the buzzing soon spread across them, and all Etheria.

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"Hang on...something's wrong," said Connie. She stood up, looking around. "You can feel that too, right?"

"I don't feel anything," said Peridot. "Are you gonna be sick?" Lion definitely felt something, though, as he was staring up at the ceiling, growling.

"Do you think it might have something to do with that?" asked Rhodonite, looking out the window. Everyone crowded around to get a look.

“Woah…” said Bismuth, summing up everyone’s feelings quite nicely. Etheria, already shining like a star before now, was lighting up the entire sky like a sun, almost returning the blue color. “Looks like Steven’s at it again, huh?”

“I...don’t think that’s Steven this time,” said Lapis.

“So if it isn’t Steven, what is it?” asked Topaz.

Connie had picked up her sword, but upon seeing the light, she let it fall to the floor. The light grew brighter and brighter, eventually reaching Earth. The buzzing got louder and louder.

And then, silence.

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“Steven…”

“Find the sword…”

– – –

“Steven? Oh, *Ste* -ven? Wake up, Steven!”

“Mmph…” Steven pulled his blanket up over his head as the gentle voice coaxed him awake. “Jus’ five more minutes…”

“But you’ll be late in five minutes!” the voice said. “Remember? Adora, Glimmer and Bow are taking you to Mystacor today!”

“That was *today* !?” Instantly, Steven leapt out of bed, running over to the drawer to grab his clothes. “I completely lost track of time! Thanks, Mom!”

“Of course, sweetie,” said Rose Quartz, smiling. “Have fun!”

“I will,” Steven said, leaning over so Rose could give him a quick peck on his forehead. “Bye, love you!”

“Love you too!” she called as he ran down the stairs. He darted past Garnet, Amethyst, and Pearls on his way to the door. “Oh, Steven, you’re up early!” said the fusion, surprised to see him. “What’s the occasion?”

“Today’s our trip to Mystacor!” Steven called, heading outside.

“Oh, that was today? Must have slipped my mind…”

Amethyst chuckled. “Classic Garnet.” Garnet herself giggled at this as well.

To his relief, his friends hadn’t arrived yet. He strolled outside onto the deck, breathing in the salty sea air. Seagulls cried as he stared off into the distance; off to the left, he could just make out the form of Castle Brightmoon.

A sudden voice to his side pulled him back into reality. “Hey, Steven!” He turned to see Spinel standing down on the sand. “Get this: Rogelio ‘n his gang just ‘found’ some day passes for Funland! Wanna come?”

“Aw, sorry, Spinel, but I already have plans to go to Mystacor today,” Steven said. “Have fun without me, though.”

“Shucks, that’s right!” Spinel said, bopping herself on the forehead. “Welp, no sense in wasting those passes. Y’all have fun, though!”

“Thanks, we will!” Steven said with a wave.

After a few more minutes of waiting, the distant figures of the Best Friend Squad appeared. Steven hurried down the steps, running down the beach to greet them. After exchanging greetings, Glimmer began gushing about all the things that Mystacor had to offer.

“...and the hot springs--Oh, the hot springs are my favorite!” she said. “I could honestly fall asleep in there!”

“You have, on several occasions!” said Bow.

Everyone chuckled at this. “So, should we get going?” asked Steven.

“Sure thing,” said Adora. “To the warp pad!”

The four of them headed off back towards Steven’s house. He smiled ear to ear, looking forward to all the fun they would have together. Just another perfect day on Eartheria.

Chapter End Notes

> Woo! That's right everyone, first chapter in a while, and it's a blammer! I'm proud to report that I'm back to working on this series! With any luck, we'll be able to get to the end of this part in a month or two, so stay tuned!

Same Old World

Chapter Summary

> After waking up in a seemingly perfect world, Steven and Adora start getting visions of their previous life as reality begins to collapse.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter Twenty: Same Old World

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"Ahhh… You know, you guys were right. I really needed this…" Steven felt a wave of relaxation quite literally wash over him as he sank deeper into the pool. "You never realize how stressed you are until you take some time to relax."

"Ain't that the truth!" said Adora, soaking in the mineral water as well. Bow and Glimmer were doing the same nearby, the latter nearly falling asleep. The steam-filled room was making Adora feel sleepy as well, which she would gladly have done, were it not for a flicker of light down in the water below her.

Looking down at her reflection, Adora was perplexed to see what looked like a larger, brighter version of herself. Her hair was much longer, flowing well below her shoulders, and she seemed to be wearing some kind of golden armor. She rubbed her eyes, thinking that she was just sleepy, but the image persisted.

"Is something wrong, Adora?" Bow asked, noticing his friend's concerned expression.

Adora looked up at him--or more specifically, his reflection in the water. It was unchanged. "Yeah, do you see--" Upon looking down

at hers, it seemed to have returned to normal, showing her how she currently was. “Um…”

“What’s up?” asked Steven.

“Nothing,” Adora said, brushing it off as a trick of the light. “So, uh, I hear Connie’s off to college already!”

Steven chuckled. “Well, not exactly. She still has to graduate high school, but it’s always good to get a head start, right?”

“Either that, or her mom’s pushing her into it,” Adora mumbled.

“Mmm. I know what that’s like,” said Glimmer, revealing herself to be awake.

“Aww, come on, you guys, don’t you think you’re being too harsh?” asked Bow. Mrs. Maheswaran wants Connie to be successful, but she wouldn't force her into anything.” He turned to Glimmer. “And you’re always giving Queen Angella a hard time!”

“Easy for you to say,” Glimmer said, glancing up at him. “She’s always talking about what a ‘sweet boy’ you are.”

“ *Am* I a sweet boy?” asked Bow.

“Well, yes, but that’s besides the point! Sometimes, I get the feeling she loves you more than she loves me!”

“Glimmer, that’s not true!” Adora assured her. “Angella loves you! Parents just like saying nice things about their kids’ friends--I mean, just look at Bow’s dads!”

“Hey, speaking of dads, is Micah back from mis trip yet?” asked Steven. “Peridot asked me to return that book she borrowed from him.”

“He should be back later today,” Glimmer said. “But why can’t she bring it back herself?”

“Oh, she’s spending the day in Dryl with Entrapta and Hord--Ack!” Steven suddenly clutched his head, overcome with a sudden headache and ringing in his ears. He stood up and clutched the rim of the pool as strange yet familiar visions danced in his head.

A castle surrounded by life, soon replaced by devastation. Gem ships descending on world after world. An army led by Hordak, Catra at his side. Adora, eight feet tall and wielding a sword. He stood beside her, holding his mother’s shield, her gemstone on his stomach, facing off against a sceptre-wielding corpse. Shadow Weaver standing beside an orange-skinned creature he had never seen before.

“ *Find the sword…* ”

“Steven!? Steven, are you alright?” He slowly opened his eyes, finding all three of his friends surrounding him. He lay on the ground, seemingly having passed out from his visions. “Do you remember what day it is? Steven, what day is it!?”

“Bow, easy, give him some space!” said Glimmer. “He probably just got a headache from the hot water...right?”

Steven rubbed his head, the soreness vanishing. “ *Something* must’ve happened,” he said. “I saw these...visions, or something.” He looked up at Adora. “You were in ‘em.”

“I was?” she asked. She thought for a moment. “Um...this might sound a bit...random, but was I wearing armor? Like, some kind of golden armor? I don’t know, I just…”

Steven looked at her quizzically. “Yeah, you were. It was you, but bigger, and with a huge sword. How’d you know?”

“I...I saw something in there, too,” she replied. “It was me, but...well, like you said. Bigger. And with a lot more hair.”

“Ooookay, I think that’s enough of the mineral pools for one day,” said Bow. “This looks like a bad allergic reaction to me. This one time when I was younger, I touched some moss out in the

Whispering Woods, and I saw a talking horse! It was weird at the time, less so once Swift Wind became a thing…"

"I'll talk to Aunt Casta about this," Glimmer said. "Why don't we do something else instead? I'm sure there's still time to catch the moonset!"

"That sounds nice!" said Adora. She helped Steven to his feet, and the four of them set off, leaving the incident behind them. However, as they left, Steven glanced back at the pools, listening to the sounds of dripping water.

"Glimmer?" he asked. "You don't think someone put something weird in the water here, do you?"

"What? Like what, some sort of cursing potion?" she asked. "I doubt it, but like I said, it'd be safe to ask Castaspella, just in case."

Steven tried to put the memories of his visions out of his mind, but something about them persisted. They had just seemed so *real* almost as though they weren't visions, but memories. "Hey, don't worry about it," Adora said, noticing her friend's unease. "I remember a little while back, when the three of us came here, it was sorta the same thing. I kept trying to relax, but I kept worrying about Shadow Weaver…"

"Why would you be worried about Shadow Weaver?" asked Steven. He had only met the woman a few times, but she seemed nice enough, if stern.

The question took Adora by surprise, as she looked just as confused as Steven. "I-I don't know," she said. "Why *would* I be worried?" Just like with Steven and his visions, it was as though she was mentioning memories she didn't know she had.

Glimmer suddenly appeared between the two. "Guys, guys, enough worrying! Mystacor is no place to get all worked up over nothing! Come on, we're here today to enjoy ourselves!"

“You’re right,” Adora said. Today’s just for us--no worries!” However, at the back of her mind, she couldn’t shake the feeling that something strange was going on.

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Emerald groaned as the early-warning alarm broke the silence, throwing her magazine aside. It never failed--just when she was getting comfortable, something went wrong planetside. With any luck, this wouldn’t be anything too serious. Then again, when had she ever been that lucky? She exited her quarters, heading for the bridge.

Fortunately, her crewmates weren’t panicking, which was a good sign. “Alright, what is it this time?” she asked. She walked past her two lieutenants, Topaz and Bluebird Azurite, and sat in her captain’s chair.

“Well…” Topaz said, in a tone that Emerald hated to hear. “That’s the thing. We aren’t...entirely sure yet.”

“‘Not entirely sure?’” Emerald said, casting her a confused glance. “Then what triggered the alarm!?”

“We’re still trying to figure that out,” a Peridot said, “but some time ago, we started getting all sorts of strange readings. Seismic, atmospheric, quantum, you name it. On its own, this wouldn’t be as much of a concern, but here’s the strange thing: the readings have no obvious source.”

“Impossible,” Emerald said. “They have to be coming from *some* where.”

“They are, it’s just that, well…” said Azurite. “The ‘somewhere’ they’re coming from seems to be...the whole planet.”

Their commander took this in, gazing down at Eartheria. “The whole planet…”

“Indeed, My Emerald,” said the Peridot. “It’s as though the entire planet has somehow become unstable. We’ve yet to nail down a cause, but the strongest readings are quantum in nature.” She looked back at Emerald. “I suspect someone tampering with the fabric of reality is behind this.”

“Wait, like, other dimensions and stuff?” said Topaz. “Is that even possible?”

“It’s theoretical, but that theory suggests that it is,” Emerald replied. “After the defeat of Horde Prime, the Diamonds commissioned research into First Ones technology. Project: Drawbridge, as it was called, would have allowed the transportation of matter between dimensional barriers.”

“Um...hold on a moment,” Azurite said, thoroughly confused. “How would you know any of that? You’ve never even met the Diamonds.”

“Of course I…” Emerald suddenly stopped, realizing that she was right. She had lived on Eartheria all her life, never having had any contact with Homeworld. And yet, somehow, something inside of her felt so sure that she had. Memories of the Diamonds that felt so real, and yet she had never had before now. “We need to put a stop to this,” she said softly, trying to put the thoughts out of her mind. “Head for where the readings are strongest.”

“Yes, My Emerald,” replied the Peridot. “It seems that the energy is spiking at several locations across the planet, including the Fright Zone, Castle Brightmoon, The Citadel, and Beach City.”

“Did you say Beach City?” asked Emerald. “Mm...I should have known Steven Universe was involved in this. Set a course immediately.”

With that, the ship’s thrusters activated, taking them down towards the planet’s surface. “Er...what exactly do you think is going on?” asked Topaz. “And why do you think Steven’s involved?”

"Because he's *always* involved," Emerald grumbled. "Whenever something like this happens, it seems like he and his friends are right at the center. And whatever happened this time, I have no doubt they're at least partially to blame."

"A bit harsh, though, don't you think?" said Topaz.

"Only as harsh as she needs to be," Bluebird replied. "Should I prepare the troops for combat?"

Emerald nodded, much to the fusion's delight. As Bluebird flew off to gather the Quartzes, Topaz looked at her commander with uncertainty. She raised her hand, as though meaning to speak, but said nothing.

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"And you're...certain that the water was to blame?" asked Castaspella quizzically. The Best Friend Squad surrounded her, the concern for their members evident. "After all, there are warnings against staying in the hot springs for more than an hour at a time for a reason! It certainly wouldn't be the first time someone's gotten a little woozy from the heat…"

"We were only in there for a few minutes, though," said Bow. "And whatever Steven and Adora saw in there, they saw some of the same things."

"It's true!" said Adora. "I was a huge warrior lady with a big ol' sword! I would've thought I was delirious, too, but Steven saw the same thing!"

"Well...sort of," Steven clarified. "A lot of things popped into my head suddenly, Adora's...new look was just one of them."

Glimmer looked up at her aunt. "All I'm saying is, don't you think you should know if someone tampered with the water?"

Castaspella glanced out the window at the cloudy skies outside. In her mind, she knew that such a thing was impossible, but

something had clearly spooked Glimmer's friends. And that didn't change the fact that she could be wrong. "I still don't see why anyone would want to do such a thing, even if they could, but… I'll send someone to check the water, just to be safe."

"Thank you, Castaspella," Bow said. "And we're sorry to trouble you."

"Oh, no trouble at all!" she said, smiling. "The last thing I want is for something to spoil you four's trip! And if someone really has brought some sort of hallucinatory magic into Mystacor, well, I would think I should know about it. Now then, I don't suppose the four of you are hungry after this ordeal? While we wait, I could have the chefs whip up something special for my niece and her friends!"

Adora immediately perked up. "Actually, a feast sounds like just what we need! What do you think, Steven? ...Steven?" Just a moment ago, he had been standing beside her, but had now vanished. A quick scan of the room found him standing further down a hallway, looking up at something. Concerned, the others approached.

"Steven? Is something wrong?" asked Bow.

Once they got closer, they saw that Steven had made his way over to the statues of Mystacor's legendary sorcerers. He was standing between the statues of Light Spinner and King Micah, looking up at the latter. "Has...has this always been here?" he asked. His voice and gaze were soft, as if he wasn't entirely lucid.

"O-of course it has," said Castaspella, growing just as concerned. "Well, not forever, obviously. But my brother's statue has been here since you were all babies. You don't remember it?"

Steven looked down, his eyes unfocused. "I do, but…" He wracked his brain, trying to find the words. "I don't think...I don't think it's supposed to be here."

Adora and Glimmer shared a worried glance. “What do you mean?” asked the former. “Why shouldn’t it be here? Micah’s one of Mystacor’s most gifted sorcerers.”

“...Is he?” Steven looked over at Glimmer. “You dad...didn’t you say he was…?” He trailed off, looking back at the floor.

Glimmer stepped closer, placing a hand on his shoulder. “Steven, whatever’s going on, we’re here to--Gah!” As if an electric shock had run through Steven and into her, Glimmer drew her hand away in alarm and jumped back, startling the other three.

“Glimmer, what is it, what’s wrong!?” asked Bow, hurrying to her side. “Are you hurt? You’re not hurt, are you!?”

“N-no, I’m fine,” Glimmer groaned, rubbing her head. “It’s just that… All of a sudden, I saw...something. It was some kind of vision, but I’m not entirely sure what.” She looked down at her hand. “It was like I was trying to remember something, and I finally did, but...I didn’t like what I saw.”

“And what *did* you see?” Adora asked.

“Hard to tell, it was like one big flash of pictures at once,” replied Glimmer. “This huge jumble of colors and sounds and...feelings. But the weirdest part was that it all felt so familiar. Like it had all really happened.”

Adora looked over at Steven, to Glimmer, to Bow and Castaspella, both of whom were unsure of how to approach the situation. “Familiar, huh?” she repeated. The image of herself as a humongous warrior woman replayed in her head. She and Steven had both seen that, surely that had to mean something? “This might sound a bit weird, but what if it all feels like it really happened because...because it really *did* happen?”

Both Glimmer and Bow gave her odd looks. “You’re right, that does sound a bit weird,” said Bow. “Are you positive that water didn’t do anything to them?” he asked in a hushed voice to Castaspella.

“Okay, wait, hear me out!” Adora said, anticipating her friends’ skepticism. “I know us seeing weird visions of stuff sounds crazy, and it is, but it’s happened before, right? I mean, remember when I found the sword? I had no idea what was happening to me, but all that First Ones stuff I saw was Light Hope telling me to find her!”

“Wait, Adora, hold on, hold on,” Glimmer interrupted. “You’re not making any sense. W-what sword?”

“Wh- The Sword of Protection,” Adora said incredulously. “You know, the massive First Ones artifact that I carry around with me everywhere I…” Adora trailed off as her eyes widened in shock. Not only had she reached over her shoulder to find nothing there, but she realized she had no prior memories of ever finding any sort of First Ones sword. She had been holding it in her vision, but as far as she knew, she had never seen it before in her life.

“Find the sword…” Steven said, so quiet that he went unheard.

“Well, sword or no sword, this could have something to do with the First Ones,” said Bow. “Maybe if we go see Entrapta, she might know something about--”

But he was interrupted as a massive tremor suddenly ran through the whole island, throwing everyone off balance. Castaspella gasped, falling to her knees, as Glimmer hurried to hold Adora up, who herself held up Bow. The violent quake seemed to pull Steven out of whatever trance he was in, as he braced against the wall. Though only lasting a few seconds, the tremor seemed to go on for much longer, leaving everyone on edge.

“Alright, *what* on Eartheria was that!?” cried Bow, making sure nobody was hurt. “That was insane, right? Can we all agree that was insane!?”

Steven looked around cautiously. “Some sort of earthquake?”

“That doesn’t make sense--Mystacor’s in the sky!” said Glimmer. “Unless skyquakes are a thing now, which honestly wouldn’t

surprise me at this point."

"No." Castaspella quietly, almost somberly, got to her feet. "This was something else. Something much worse." She turned to face the teens. "You all have to go. Now. It isn't safe here anymore."

"Uh...Aunt Casta?" Glimmer said nervously. "You seem...intense. Do you know something we don't?"

She shook her head. "I can't tell exactly what's happening, but whatever it is, it's affecting all of Eartheria. Just before that shockwave hit, I felt something, a sort of...disturbance. There are magical imbalances appearing all over the world."

"We have to do something, then!" said Steven. "Let's get everyone together, the Princess Alliance and the Crystal Gems!" He turned to Glimmer. "I bet our moms will know what to do."

By now, a mild panic had begun to spread across Mystacor. Sorcerers hurred to and fro, attempting to discern the source of the disturbance. "He's right, we should get home," said Bow. "Are you sure you'll be okay here, Castaspella?"

She nodded. "I'll be fine! Did you forget that I'm the most accomplished sorcerer here? Now, you don't want to keep everyone waiting, do you?" She wrapped Glimmer up in a quick hug. "Now go save the world!"

"Aunt Casta, I doubt it's anything *that* serious," said Glimmer.

"Better safe than sorry," Adora said. The four of them waved goodbye to Castaspella before heading to the warp pad. As she watched them leave, her hopeful demeanor once again turned somber. Casting a discernment spell, she headed to where the energy from the tremor was the strongest.

"Do any of you think it's a bit cruel that something like this happens on our day off?" asked Steven, as they hurried through the halls. "I mean, I'm happy to help, but I was so prepared to relax today!"

“Tell me about it,” Glimmer added. “I just hope it isn’t Catra up to her old tricks.”

“Her old...what? What tricks?” said Adora.

As though realizing what she said, Glimmer threw her head back in irritation. “Ugh! Now I’m doing it too! Whatever’s happening to you, I’ll bet that quake’s related.”

“Yeah, probably,” said Bow. “Normally I’d say that sounds crazy, but today hasn’t exactly been normal…”

The four of them soon reached the warp pad. “Hang on,” said Steven. “You guys go on ahead to the castle. I’ll head back to my place and rally the Gems.”

“You sure?” asked Adora. “I feel like it’d be safer if we stayed together.”

“Don’t worry, it’ll be fine!” Steven assured her. “You heard Castaspella, it’s up to us!”

Bow was still unconvinced. “Didn’t she also say that the world was in danger?”

“ *And* that we all had to leave,” Steven said. “But I’m sure that once we get everyone together, we can all figure out what’s going on. Right? I mean, when have we failed before? Hordak, Skeletor, Horde Prime--we beat them because we had each other!”

“He’s right,” said Adora. “Whatever’s happening, it’ll be easier to deal with it if we had backup. So let’s go get some.” She, Glimmer, and Bow stepped up onto the pad.

“I’ll meet up with you all once I have the Gems,” said Steven. “Good luck!” After the rest of the Best Friend Squad had vanished, he stepped into place, teleporting back to the temple.

Once she saw the telltale pillar of light from the warp pad, Castaspella stepped away from the window and headed outside,

where several other sorcerers were waiting. “So,” she said, “any luck?”

“None,” one of them answered. “We’ve never seen anything like this before.” She and the others looked on at what had been described: seemingly as a result of the tremor, a giant fissure, growing larger by the second, had appeared in the side of the island. But rather than earth within, a hissing white static seeped out from the crack, leaving no trace of what it covered. “All we know is that if it keeps growing at this rate, Mystacor itself will disappear.”

“Then it’s worse than I thought,” Castaspella muttered. “Have you tried slowing it down?”

“No luck,” replied another. He looked at the encroaching static. “Forgive me for sounding morbid, but...what happens if we can’t stop this thing?”

Castaspella hung her head. “Then we hope Glimmer and the others have more luck than we did.”

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In a flash of light, Steven was back at his house. The moment he reappeared, all four Gems, plus his father, turned to face him. “Steven!” cried Greg. Before he had time to say anything, all of them had hurried up to him.

“Are you alright? We were just about to go to Mystacor ourselves,” said Rose. “What happened? You aren’t hurt, are you? Oh, where are the others?”

“Thank you, and I’m fine,” Steven assured them. “We all are. Adora and the others went back to Brightmoon.” From the looks on their faces, they had just as much idea as to what was going on as he did. “Garnet? What does your future vision say?”

The bi-colored Gem’s eyes darted wildly. “I-I don’t know,” she admitted. “I couldn’t see that earthquake coming, and ever since

then, the future's been all over the place! I can't make heads or tails of what's going to happen next!"

"Whatever it is, I think I'm involved somehow," said Steven. "See, when me and Adora were at the hot springs, both of us started seeing...stuff. Like, having visions of things that never happened, but they feel like they have. It felt like I was remembering a whole different life." Rose Quartz looked down at her son. It looked like she very much wanted to say something, but couldn't find the words to do so.

"Another life?" asked Pearl. "And what was this life like? Can you remember any details?"

"Sort of," Steven continued. "I...I still lived in Beach City, but I didn't know Adora or any of her friends. Glimmer, Bow, Catra, Entrapta, all the other princesses, they didn't exist. And all of us were fighting against Homeworld because the Diamonds wanted to colonize Eartheria. I think we convinced them not to, though, but then...something else happened. Someone else wanted to hurt us, but I can't remember who."

The others took it all in. "Woah," Amethyst said quietly. "Your other life sounds...rough."

Steven nodded. "It was. But I think the roughest part about it was that…" He looked up somberly at his mother. "...that you weren't there."

"Steven…" Rose stepped forwards and knelt down to hug her son. Greg did so as well, soon joined by the other Gems.

"What does this all mean?" asked Steven, suddenly feeling very emotional. "Why is this happening? And why now?"

"Because this isn't real," said Rose.

"What do you--"

Before Steven could ask his question, the group was interrupted by the drone of a loud engine coming from just outside the house. The hug broke off, and everyone looked at the source of the noise. "It's Emerald," Garnet announced.

"Oh, good!" Greg said, relieved. "If anyone knows what's going on, it'll be her. Come on, let's go ask!"

Greg headed for the door, followed by Garnet and Amethyst. "We shouldn't get our hopes up, though," said Pearl. "Oh! If she doesn't, maybe we could ask Peridot." She followed after them, leaving Steven and Rose alone.

"Um...Mom?" said Steven. "What did you mean when you said this wasn't real?"

Rose averted her eyes. "It's...nothing," she said. "We should go see Emerald. You know how she hates to be kept waiting."

As much as Steven would have liked to press her further, whatever was happening was more important right now. He headed outside to join the others, seeing Emerald's command ship hovering above the beach. A shuttle flew out of the main vessel, landing on the sand a short distance away. Emerald, joined by a small posse of her fellow peacekeepers, ventured out towards them.

"Now then, how about we get this over with quickly so we can all get back to our respective businesses?" Emerald said, holding both an air of professionalism and irritation. "Which one of you is responsible for destabilizing the fabric of reality?"

Nobody had expected this. Everyone looked at each other in confusion, unsure of how to answer a question like that. "Um...I don't *think* it was me," said Garnet.

Emerald brought a hand up to her brow. "I don't have time for this…" she muttered. "You there--Steven Universe! Our readings indicate that the quantum anomaly is stronger in this area. So, I ask you, are you responsible for this?"

“What, me?” said Steven, barely off the porch. “Look, I don’t know anything about reality falling apart or whatever! All I know is that I was having a day with my friends, then I started to remember stuff that never happened, and then there was a big earthquake in the sky--a skyquake, I guess--and that’s when I came back here.”

Pearl, deep in thought, spoke up. “Emerald, do you think it’s possible that Steven is somehow unwittingly acting as a nexus for this cosmic event? If what he’s experiencing are actually memories, it’s possible that this anomaly is the result of dimensional overlap.”

“Hmm...you make a good point,” Emerald said. “However, only someone who was already split between two worlds would be experiencing such symptoms.” Both Greg and Amethyst pretended to know what they were talking about, while Garnet watched with interest. “Unless Steven Universe was already split between two worlds, then--”

“Steven? What’s up?” Everyone turned at the voice as the pink Gem rounded the corner. “I didn’t know you were havin’ friends over!” Spinel made her way up to the house, barely acknowledging the enormous starship hovering overhead.

“Spinel…” Standing behind Steven, Rose whispered her old friend’s name. It almost seemed like she wanted to retreat back into the temple and close the door behind her, but stayed for Steven’s sake.

“Can this wait?” Emerald asked irritably. “We’re right in the middle of a very important discussion on interdimensional particle physics!”

Spinel waved her off. “Yeah, yeah, science stuff and whatnot. Hey, Steven, didja feel that quake? Hoo boy, that sucker *rattled* Funland! Kyle almost fell offa the ferris wheel!”

Steven tugged at the hem of his jacket uncomfortably. "I...Spinel, can this wait? Emerald's right, this is kinda important."

"Well, maybe I can help!" suggested Spinel. "Is it gonna be like an investigation? Ooh, I'll get the magnifying glass!"

"Not right now!" Emerald said. "Reality as we know it could be falling to pieces, so for once, could you just do what you're told and sit still!?"

"I've *been* sitting still!" cried Spinel, suddenly angry. Rose flinched at her response. "I've been sitting still for the past six thousand years! And how is this *my* fault? If you hadn't been *sooo* obsessed with that Lars of the Stars twerp, we wouldn't be in this mess!"

As Emerald and Spinel argued, Steven's head began to throb. Flashes of this other life raced through his head as he fell to his knees; he could feel Rose's hands on his shoulders, and hear her voice, but couldn't make out what she was saying. Make out what anyone was saying. All he could focus on was the memories that now filled his mind. *Fusing with Connie. Escaping Homeworld with Lars. His first time on Etheria. Talking down the Diamonds. Spinel and Emerald arriving on Earth.* All of it came flooding back at once.

"I...remember…"

Matching the splitting pain Steven felt in his head, the ground began to shake once again. This was no ordinary earthquake, but as though the planet itself was being shaken apart. A harsh white glow replaced the usual sun as Steven got to his feet, groggily examining his surroundings. "Steven? Steven, are you alright!?" Rose asked frantically.

"That's what you meant," said Steven, turning to face her. "None of this is real. This world is just some kind of illusion." Rose opened her mouth, but her words froze on her tongue. "How long have you known?"

"I…"

“No. It’s okay.” Steven’s words weren’t angry. They were simply heavy, holding the weight of disappointment. “It’s like your room, right? I have everything I want, but...I can’t stay here. It isn’t real. And...and neither are you.” Steven turned away from Rose, heading down to the beach. Rose held out her hand to stop him, but pulled it to her chest as he left.

Everyone was getting up from the shock, looking just as confused as before. “It’s all his fault,” Emerald said quietly, staring down at her hands. “It’s all his fault. It’s all his fault! IT’S ALL HIS FAULT!” She whipped around to face her lackeys. “Spread out! Find Lars of the Stars, and destroy him at all costs!” The frightened-looking Quartzes headed back onto the shuttle, while Bluebird Azurite and Topaz stayed with her. “And as for you,” she added, pointing to Spinel, “make yourself useful and dispose of Steven Universe!”

Spinel looked over at Steven, her expression turning from one of confused fear to one of gleeful malice. As a smirk spread across her face, black lines spread down her face. “With pleasure!”

But the four of them were the least of Steven’s worries. Steven realized that the white light wasn’t residual from his memories, but actual light, spilling up from a massive crevice. A malevolent static rose from the fissure, spreading across the beach, and towards the temple.

“Oh my stars…” Steven said quietly.

Chapter End Notes

> While we're here, did you all know that skyquakes are apparently a real thing? Because I sure didn't.

Brand New World

Chapter Summary

> Both Steven and Adora race against the clock to find a way to prevent both of their worlds from being erased.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter Twenty-One: Brand New World

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Everyone stared up at the wall of static that was consuming the world just meters away. The blue sky had faded to a harsh white, and the sand and water were disappearing into the fissure. What Emerald had said of the world growing unstable, this was the cause–or was it the result?

Emerald was the first of the bunch to break free of the terror this breach in reality caused. "It doesn't matter!" she growled, whipping around to face Steven and the Gems. "I swore that I would destroy Lars and all his allies, and this doesn't change any of that! Destroy them!"

Though Spinel gleefully obeyed, Topaz and Azurite were hesitant. "I-Isn't the entire world falling apart around us?" asked the latter. "Maybe we should focus on surviving first, before we–"

"I thought you *wanted* revenge on Steven," Emerald said. "End of the world or not, now you have your chance! GO GET IT!" Motivated by Emerald's words, both fusions ran forward to do battle.

Spinel was first into the fray, Amethyst catching her with her whip moments before she could grab Steven. Topaz summoned both her clubs and combined them into one, charging at Garnet with

her blue and red gauntlets. Pearl intercepted Azurite, where sword met spear, and Rose positioned herself protectively in front of Greg. “Steven!” she called out. The boy hurried over to join his parents.

“Mom! Dad!” shouted Steven as he reached their side. “I-I remembered what’s going on! Catra and Emerald, they…they fused Earth and Etheria together somehow!”

“Well, it looks like it’s trying to break back apart!” said Greg.

“And it’s not just that,” Steven continued. “Something about this place gives everyone the life they wanted, and…” His gaze went up to Rose, as his hand grasped absent-mindedly at his stomach. “It’s not real. We have to get everyone out of here.”

Rose thought for a moment. “Peridot,” she said. “If anyone knows how to reverse this, it’s her. Her and Entrapta.” She placed her arm next to her gem, summoning her shield. “Greg, take the van and get Steven to Dryl. I’ll buy you as much time as I can.”

“Wait!” Rose had turned to leave, but Greg had called her back. “You can’t just stay here! W-what if that static stuff eats this whole place!? What’ll happen to you all!?”

“Don’t worry,” Rose assured him. She leaned down, drawing the two of them into a hug. “It’s like Steven said: this isn’t real. I’m only a memory.” A single tear slid down her cheek. She stood up, looking proudly at the both of them. “Now go. Save these worlds.”

She turned to face the fighting, and like that, she was gone, rushed off to join in. Steven watched her go. “Mom…” she said quietly, pulled back to lucidity as Greg pulled him away from the beach.

“Hurry, we have to get to the van!” he said. “Rose’s right, Peridot should know what to do!” Giving one last look at the Gems, Steven followed his father into town.

Back on the beach, Spinel saw them leave. She was the only one who noticed, the others all too busy with their battles. Before she could follow them, she was attacked from behind by Amethyst, turning to face her once again. But her mind stayed on Steven, waiting for a moment to disengage from the fight.

Rose strolled towards them with purpose, glaring at their leader. "So, come to join the fight at last?" Emerald said. "The great rebel leader, Rose Quartz herself! And where's your family in this time of crisis?"

"If you want to get to them," Rose said, "you have to go through me." She summoned a second shield on her other arm, assuming a battle stance.

Emerald sneered, clenching her fist. " *Gladly* ."

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With nothing to do but stare out the window at the scenery rushing past, Steven did so. After making their escape from Beach City, he and Greg hadn't said a word to one another, even though there was a lot to be said. Steven let out a sigh, his breath fogging up the window. He began absent-mindedly doodling in the fog as the van rolled down the road.

"Everything alright there, Schtu-ball?" asked Greg. Steven didn't answer, and after a brief silence, he tried again. "I get it. This is all a lot to take in. I'm having some trouble with it myself. Here I was, thinking I was living a happy life with my wife and son, but… I guess it was only a memory." He looked somberly over at Steven for a moment, before turning his eyes ahead.

Another brief silence. "Hey, Dad?" asked Steven. "How come you're taking this so well? Like you said, you were living your perfect life, and to find out it was all fake…how are you not more upset?"

"Believe me, I'm plenty bummed," he said. He did a good job hiding his disappointment, but the cracks in this facade were

obvious. "If I could live in a world where everything turned out happily ever after, I would. But if that world wasn't real, or it took me away from you guys…well, that wouldn't be very happy at all, would it? Son, me and Rose lived our life together. Even though I miss her every day, I know that there's still more of life to come. And even if I don't have her, at least I have–"

"Dad, look out!"

Greg swerved to the side the moment Spinel appeared in front of the van, but it did them little good. She grabbed onto the front hood, using the momentum to throw the vehicle off of the road, where it collided with a tree, landing on its side. For a moment, Steven's world turned white.

His head pounding, the ringing in Steven's ears gradually gave way to Greg's voice. "Steven! Steven, are you okay!? Please, say something!"

"I…I'm alright," he said, holding his head. "Spinel…"

There was little time for either of them to get their bearings as the sound of footsteps came from what was currently the top of the van. Steven tried to unbuckle himself as a gloved hand latched onto the driver side door, ripped it clean off its hinges, and tossed it aside. "Well, who do we have here?" said Spinel, grinning. She reached for Greg.

"No!" Steven shouted. "Spinel, this is between us! I'm the one you want!"

"I know, I know! I was just getting him outta the way!" Spinel proceeded to yank a protesting Greg out from his seat, throwing him the way of the door. "You, Steven Universe, are the real prize!"

Steven was unable to undo his belt. Spinel reached for him, but moments before she could grab him, a bicolored shape tackled her to the ground. Through the crack-ridden windshield, Steven saw with equal parts relief and fear that Garnet had come to his

rescue, coming to a landing entangled with his attacker. While Garnet kept her busy, Greg reappeared atop the van.

"Quick, grab on!" he said, holding his hand down. Steven grabbed hold, and the two of them were able to pull him free of the wreckage. Not a moment too soon, as Garnet was just then thrown through the windshield, landing right where Steven had been moments before. Spinel slammed her fists, both grown gigantic, into the van, though Garnet got out of the way in time.

"Are you two okay?" Garnet asked them. Before Greg or Steven could answer, Spinel flung the wreckage of the van towards the three of them. Garnet caught it, using it to block a follow-up attack from the rogue Gem.

"Dad, let's go!" shouted Steven over the noise. He pulled his father away from the chaos and towards Dryl, which was still a ways away. Spinel saw them leaving and lunged towards them, only for Garnet to grab her by her ankles. The two continued grappling, until Spinel caught Garnet unawares. Garnet was hurled towards the pair, blocking their escape.

Greg helped Garnet to her feet. "Are you okay?" he asked.

"I-I think so," the fusion replied. "My future vision's all over the place! I can't tell what's going to happen!"

Spinel was bearing down on them. "Garnet, listen to me–you have to focus on the now!" said Steven. "Don't let all the possible futures distract you! Just look at what's happening right now!"

Spinel threw both fists forward. At that moment, a black visor appeared over Garnet's eyes. She pushed Steven and Greg out of the way, catching her fists in her own. Her whole body began to glow white, and when it subsided, she looked entirely new. Her red and blue skin was now a deep maroon, which her gauntlets matched, and her hair was now solid black. A brief look of surprise crossed Spinel's face before being replaced with the usual fury.

As Garnet, now with renewed vigor, continued trying to subdue Spinel, Greg and Steven were now confronted with a new problem: the static that was consuming the world was gradually getting closer. A fissure split through the ground, racing ahead of them. If it cut through the road, they would be stranded on an island in the static, cut off from the world until it was consumed.

"Go! Run!" Greg shouted. Although Steven did so, his father close behind, he glanced back at Garnet as he ran. What would happen to her if she was erased as well? Could any of this be reversed? If this really was like Rose's room, it could, but he had no way of knowing if that was the case.

"Dad!" Steven yelled. The fissure was getting closer, and it looked too big to jump over. For a normal human, anyway.

"Keep going! I'm right behind you!" called Greg. Steven was running on adrenaline now, and didn't look back as he sprinted down the road. "You can do it, Steven! You can do it!"

It wasn't until after he had made it over the cracked street that Steven realized what his father's words meant. He leapt as the fissure ran underneath him, coming to a rolling stop on the road on the other side. He laid there for a moment, catching his breath. "Dad, we…we made it," he panted. No reply. "Dad?" He sat up and looked around, seeing no sign of his father. Looking back, he only saw a chasm of white between him and the island within the static sea.

'You can do it.' He hadn't been encouraging Steven to make it over the gap. He had been telling him to make it to Dryl. To go on without him. To find a way to fix this.

"Dad…" Steven fell to his knees, gazing into the void. On the other side of the gap, the two Gems continued fighting. When Spinel looked over, she didn't see the expanse of static; all she could see was Steven, vulnerable. She took this moment to lunge, to excise all that remained of the architect of her hatred.

Just at the edge of the fissure, Garnet caught up with Spinel, grabbing onto her before she could reach Steven. The boy was broken out of his trance, watching as Spinel furiously tried to break free of Garnet's grip. "Steven! You have to go!" Garnet yelled.

"I can't leave you!" he cried. "Dad fell, the others probably did too, I…"

"Steven, listen to me! You can still save them!" The ground around them began to give way as the island crumbled. "I've seen futures where you fix all of this, but you can't do it alone! Get to Dryl! Get to Brightmoon! Get together everyone you can! You can stop this, together!"

The island was finally consumed by the static. Chunks of earth fell into the whiteness and disappeared into nothing. And Garnet fell as well, dragging Spinel down with her. Before long, Nothing remained of the beach, or the temple, or anyone who had called it home. Nothing save for Steven himself, who gazed out into the emptiness. What was he supposed to do now? How could he continue on if everyone he cared about was about to disappear?

"It's hard, seeing it happen with your own eyes, isn't it, dearie?" a voice came from behind him. "But you have to remember, they aren't really gone."

Steven turned around to see a little old lady standing behind him. She supported herself with a huge stick, and had glasses almost as large. She didn't seem to be a Gem, and yet had light red skin. "Who…?"

She looked at him, confused. "You don't remember old Madame Razz?" she asked. "Unless…maybe we haven't met this time. Hmm, I could have sworn we had. Perhaps we will later. But nevermind that!" She approached Steven, helping him to his feet. "The important thing right now is, you have somewhere else to be."

"And where…where exactly is that?" Steven was not following any of this. Had he really met this woman before? If he had, he didn't remember any of it. Was she somehow connected to all of this?

She chuckled at his question. "How do you expect *me* to know, dearie? You're the one who needs to be there, not me!" She reached up to pat him on the cheek. "To start with, why not go and see some friends? I find that when I don't know where to go, somewhere familiar is always a good bet."

"I… You're right," Steven said. For now, all he could do was stick to the old plan. "Thank you, Mis–er, Madame Razz."

"Oh, think nothing of it!" she replied. "Just say hello to Mara for me when this is all over!" She waved goodbye to Steven as he headed off to Dryl. "Oh, and I hope you find that sword you're looking for!"

"How did you…?" Steven turned back around, but saw nothing but static behind him. Had she wandered into it? No, surely she wouldn't have… There was no time to dwell on it now. Steven started walking again. It was a long walk to Dryl, and he didn't have any time to waste.

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"Adora? Adora, what's going on!?" Bow and Glimmer rushed to their friend's side, who had just cried out, grasped her head and fell to the floor. The two helped her shakily stand up, as she scanned the room curiously. "What happened?"

"I think…I think I remember now," she said quietly, still rubbing her head. Around her, the other members of the Princess Alliance sat at the table, looking concerned for her state. Flashes of another life had come rushing through her head. *Growing up with Catra. Finding the Sword of Protection, and leaving the Horde. Joining the Princess Alliance, and fighting to save Etheria as She-Ra* . Adora looked at the princesses surrounding her, her eyes stopping on one of them. "W-why are you here?" She stood up,

examining the one person in the room who was not supposed to be present.

"Huh? What do you mean?" said Scorpia. "I came here as soon as I heard something was up, same as everybody. Why?"

Adora continued to stare at Scorpia as though she had never seen a half-scorpion woman before. "So then…where's Catra?" she asked. "If you're here in this world, then why isn't she here too? It doesn't make sense, why are you here when she isn't!?"

"Hey, easy, easy!" said Bow, holding onto Adora's shoulders. "Just take a deep breath…there, good. Just because the world's about to end is no reason to panic." Calming down a touch, Adora sat back down. "So, you were saying something about Catra?"

"I…yeah. Okay. I'm good. I'm calm," Adora said. "It's just that…I remembered more about the old world. Before all *this* ." She gestured towards the wall, in the general direction of the static. Though nobody could see it, everyone knew what she meant.

"Like what?" asked Mermista. "I get that you and Catra are close, but what exactly does Scorpia have to do with it?"

"Well…" Adora tried to think of the best way to put it. "It's just that, uh, Catra's kinda the reason Earth and Etheria are doomed. Her and Emerald. And Entrapta and Scorpia, they helped. You're kinda like her minions."

"I-I am?"said Scorpia, her voice tinged with disbelief. "Why would I help end the world? For that matter, why would *she* ?"

"I'm not really sure of that myself," Adora said. "All I can say for sure is that this all started at the Fright Zone. So that's where I think we should go."

"Are you sure?" asked Perfuma. "This whole thing seems a bit *bigger* than anything the Fright Zone can pull off…er, no offense to your other friends."

“They have my sword,” Adora said grimly. “Or, had my sword, I still don’t know how this works exactly. But I think that getting my sword back should set all of this back to normal–”

“Hold on. ‘Think?’ Should!?’ Are you saying we should risk everything based on a hunch you have?” asked Netossa, getting to her feet. “We should all be flocking to Emerald’s ships! Get as far away from Eartheria as possible!”

“And do what?” Glimmer replied. “Even if we don’t get erased up there, we’d still be stranded with nowhere to go! Adora’s idea may not be at least there’s better odds of surviving!”

Netossa was growing more and more heated. “You wanna talk about surviving? Mizar is *gone* ! I watched the entire place get swallowed up by that whiteness! I tried to save everyone I could, but…” She faltered for a moment, before her anger returned. “And you want to talk about going back out there!?”

“Nettie, please!” said Spinnerella, standing beside her wife. “This isn’t Glimmer’s fault!” Netossa took a few breaths before sitting back down.

“It’s settled, then.” Everyone looked up to see the king and queen enter the room. “Right now, Adora is the only lead we have as to what exactly is happening,” Angella continued. “And besides–the longer we wait, the more of Eartheria is erased by that storm out there.”

“Mystacor has already fallen,” Micah said grimly. “If that sword really is the key to all of this, we need to move quickly, unless we want any more of our kingdoms to fall.”

The moment King Micah had entered the room, Adora shifted in her chair uncomfortably. Glimmer noticed, but refrained from saying anything. The princesses all stirred as well, uncertain that this plan was the best move. “And, what if she’s wrong?” asked Mermista. “I’m not saying I think she is, but…what would we do then?”

“I’m sure there’s something we can do,” said Micah. “We just haven’t thought of it yet. If we need a better plan, one will come to us in time.”

Scorpia leaned over to Frosta. “I thought this guy was supposed to be some kinda master tactician,” she whispered, to which Frosta replied with a shrug.

“I, for one, fully support this plan!” said Perfuma. “In times of crisis such as this, it is important to remain hopeful, no matter how dire the circumstances!”

And speaking of dire, a small tremor took that moment to run through the castle. Although nothing was damaged, it didn’t take much to figure out what this meant. Once it had subsided, Bow made his way over to a window to look outside.

“It’s getting closer,” he reported. “I don’t think Brightmoon’s going to last much longer.”

Angella stood up. “Then we leave immediately. Micah, tell the guards to evacuate the castle.” The king nodded and hurried out. “Everyone else, we head for the Fright Zone. Stick together, and don’t go anywhere near the static.”

With that, the princesses banded together and headed outside. “Hey, for what it’s worth,” Frosta said to Scorpia, “I don’t think you’d want to destroy the world, even if you did work for the Horde.”

Scorpia smiled. “Thanks, little buddy. And, eh, I don’t think you would, either.”

“Adora?” asked Glimmer. “Back there, when my parents came into the room, you looked kinda awkward. Is something up?”

Upon being asked, Adora shied away. “No, it’s nothing,” she said unconvincingly. “Now c’mon, the world ain’t gonna save itself!”

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A solitary hand reached out from the void, grabbing hold of what little earth there still was. Red and gloved, it was soon joined by another like it, this one dark gray. The arms that they belonged to stretched down far into the abyss, slowly pulling up their owner. Spinel soon pulled herself up to solid ground.

But she was different. Half of her body, including her face, and her gem, was pitch black, the colors gradually flaking off. “Steeee-veeeen…come and plaaaa-aaaay…” she murmured, her voice distorted. Her stride unsteady, she set off down the road in the direction Steven had been heading, intent on stalking her target and finishing what she had set out to do.

Chapter End Notes

> Hey, happy holidays everyone! I wanted to finish this one up before new years', but it doesn't look like it's gonna go that way. But regardless, we should be getting to the end soon, so I hope you enjoy, and have a very festive time with your families and loved ones--just remember to stay safe!

Drift Away

Chapter Summary

Steven confronts a friend, and Adora rallies hers.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter Twenty-Two: Drift Away

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And so, Steven walked. As the world collapsed around him, he walked on, unable to do anything as the landscapes he passed by disappeared into the emptiness. Sometimes he saw people running away from the static. Sometimes they didn't run fast enough. Although every part of him screamed to run and help when he saw that they weren't going to make it, he knew he could do nothing, and would only be putting himself at risk if he did. The only way he could stop this was to get to Dryl.

After what felt like hours, he finally made it to the top of the mountain where the city lay. He almost fell to the dirt in relief when he saw the city walls come into view. But knowing that the fate of the Earth and of Etheria hung in the balance, he staggered forward.

An intercom had been installed onto the front gates–not exactly a doorbell, but it was better than a booby trap. "He-hello? Is anyone still in there?" Steven said. "It's me, Steven. I need…I need to talk to someone."

"Hmm? Oh, Steven, welcome! I was wondering when somebody was gonna show up!" a peppy voice answered. "Yeah, hang on, I'll let you in." After a few moments, the gates slid open, letting Steven into the city.

As usual, Dryl had a sort of eerie feeling to it. Steven had only been a few times–at least, he had in this new reality–but it always seemed to be practically abandoned. However, as he approached the castle, a familiar and all-too-welcome face approached him. Or rather, ran straight at him.

"Steven! Where have you been!?" the green Gem practically screeched, almost running straight into him. "It's the end of the world!"

"Yeah, I, uh, kinda figured that part out," Steven said, almost humorless. "That's why I came here. If anyone can help me, it's a couple of scientists."

"Then you've come to the right place!" said Peridot. "C'mon, me and the lovebirds were just running some tests." She led Steven into the castle. "Why are you all alone, though? I thought you'd at least want to bring Connie, or Adora, or Pearl, or–"

"Peridot…" Steven said. It wasn't said forcefully, but the grave tone was enough to quiet her instantly. "Adora and her friends went back to Castle Brightmoon, but I headed back to the temple, and… It's all gone." His voice started to break, but he remained somewhat stoic. "My dad. Garnet. Amethyst, Pearl, my mom…they all fell into that static stuff."

The two stopped walking for a moment. "Did…did you see anyone else fall in?" asked Peridot, noticeably less energetic.

Steven shook his head. "I haven't seen Lapis of Bismuth, if that's what you mean. I don't know where they could have gone."

Peridot took a moment to process this. "O-okay then. Entrapta's right through here." She led Steven, silently, through a few more hallways before finally reaching the princess's chambers. Within, a handful of robots were working to process the data that had been collected so far. In the very center of the room, Entrapta and Hordak stood before a computer screen, a diagram of the planet on display.

Hordak was the first to notice the two. “It would seem we have visitors,” he said. Entrapta turned around to notice them as well.

“Ah, Steven, you’re here! Good!” The princess scooped him up in her hair, and pulled him over to the computer. “Well, not exactly ‘good,’ considering the state things are in, but it’s better to have you here than not!”

“Uh, yeah,” Steven said, brushing loose hairs off of his shoulder. “So, you’ve already been studying this thing for a while, huh? Have you figured out how to stop it yet?”

“If we had, we probably wouldn’t be sitting here in the dark,” Peridot said glumly. “We have made some progress, just…not enough.”

“What our friend means is that we know what this phenomenon is, just not what’s causing it,” explained Hordak. “The planet seems to be tearing itself apart at the subatomic level, as though it were made of two incompatible elements that were forcibly merged.

“That’s exactly what’s happening,” said Steven. All three of them turned to him, confused. “Something Catra and Emerald did with Adora’s sword fused Earth and Etheria together.”

“...Are you sure you weren’t somehow affected by this stuff?” said Peridot. “We aren’t entirely sure if being near it is harmful, but if it is…”

“Catra…” Entrapta said quietly, staring off into the distance. “I did this…This is all my fault…”

“Entrapta? What are you saying?” said Hordak. “How would this be your fault?”

She looked at Steven. “You…remembered, didn’t you? About the world before this one? What happened?”

Peridot and Hordak turned their confused gazes towards her now. "Where is this coming from?" asked the former. "Do you know something we don't?"

"It's…hard to explain," Entrapta said, looking like she was having trouble understanding it herself. "As soon as Steven mentioned Adora's sword, it's like I…like I remembered things. Things that haven't happened, but they *have* , just not here. Make sense?"

While neither of her labmates understood, Steven did. "This world, the one we're living in now, it isn't real," he explained. "Whatever Catra and Emerald and…and you did, it created this fake life for everyone. And it's falling apart. That's why I'm here–I need your help to stop it."

"This is…a lot to make sense of," said Hordak. "But if this has truly gone the way you described, then this sword you speak of must be the key to all of this."

"Ah, of course!" said Entrapta, immediately perking up. She hopped into a rolling chair and slid herself over to the main computer, bringing up a few images on the screen. "Catra's machine needed a catalyst to function, and only a powerful First Ones artifact could have possibly generated enough energy, which the Sword of Protection had more than enough of! But, since the machine was only designed to transport *one* planet, the end result was the two of them being merged together–Eartheria! Now, as for reversing this, one would only need to remove the sword from its current location."

"Alright, seems easy enough," said Peridot. "When can we start?"

"That's where things get difficult," Entrapta continued. "The sword is also the source of this anomalous dimensional phenomenon, or 'static,' as it's being called. Removing it would bring back everything deleted by the static, but would trap the person in question between dimensions. A space between spaces, even more empty and desolate than Despondos." She looked back to Steven. "Possibly forever."

The four of them considered this possibility in silence. “First, we must find the sword,” said Hordak.

“Well, if Catra’s the one who built the machine, then wouldn’t it be in the Fright Zone?”

“That would make sense.” Entrapta brought up a diagram of Eartheria, with the erased portions highlighted in red. Almost half of the planet was gone at this point. “So far, the static hasn’t gone anywhere near the Fright Zone, but there’s no telling how long that’ll last. Once everything else is gone, and the Fright Zone is the only place left, that’s where it’ll go. Almost everywhere else is gone. Salineas, the Highlands, and…and here.”

“W-what?” said Peridot.

The room shook as a tremor ran through the mountain. Steven braced himself against the walls as the many robots present went haywire, throwing themselves this way and that. In all the chaos, he could hear the telltale sound of static in the distance.

“How is this possible!?” said Hordak. “What happened to our early-warning system?”

“Seems like it got absorbed as well…” Entrapta reported.

“Come on, we have to get out of here!” said Steven, pulling Peridot towards the door. Entrapta and Hordak were set to follow, but the moment the door opened, the static had already made its way inside the castle. Panels of wall and flooring were sucked into the gaping mass of nothing, and as it drew closer, it seemed that they would follow. But Steven was already running, and stopped too late to avoid it.

“Steven!” Peridot, who was right beside him, took that moment to throw the metal panel he stood on back in the direction of Entrapta’s room. Steven landed with a thud, looking up at where he had stood just a moment before. In saving him, she had given up her chance of escape. “Go.”

The rest of the hallway was swallowed up by the white expanse, taking Peridot with it. “No!” yelled Steven, reaching futilely towards her. He got up to run over to her, but was pulled back inside by Entrapta.

“No, don’t!” she said. “It’s too dangerous!” Steven struggled for a moment, only to give up when he knew it was pointless. “We have to get outta here…Everyone, to the secret exit!”

Entrapta then hurried over to a hidden panel on the wall, removing it to reveal a small passageway. She ushered Steven in first, before moving to enter herself. However, the tremors were reinvigorated, causing the room to collapse.

The static entered the room through cracks in the wall. The floor started to give way, causing many of the robots to fall into the void. Hordak fell as well, only his claws digging into the metal preventing him from falling fully.

With a gasp, Entrapta hurried over to him. “Hordak!” she yelled. She tried to lift him up, but the harder she pulled, the more the room fell apart.

“Go! Leave me!” he said. “You have to get to the Fright Zone!”

“I’m not leaving you here! Not again!” she replied. The entire castle shuddered, ready to fall.

Steven crawled out of the vent to help. “Guys!” he shouted.

“Wait!” said Entrapta. “Hordak’s right–you have to get to the Fright Zone! Find the sword, and save everyone!”

“But–”

“Go!” Entrapta’s hair shot forward, sending Steven into the vent and tumbling down into the lower levels of the castle. All he could see were flashes of light as the castle was consumed. Finally, he exited out of a trapdoor, and after a short slide down a dirt hill, he landed on the ground, shaken up but unharmed.

Steven gave one last look up the mountain. The entire top half was nowhere to be seen, completely replaced by the static. The castle was gone. Entrapta, Peridot, and Hordak were gone. Garnet, his dad…

With a shout of frustration, Steven punched the ground as hard as his arm allowed. He panted heavily, looking down at his scuffed knuckles. With a sigh, he got to his feet and brushed himself off.

"Find the sword…" she said to himself softly, and set off in the direction of the Fright Zone.

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"Alright, everybody ready?" said Adora. In the absence of the Sword of Protection, she had been given another, less magical sword from the Brightmoon armory. "We only get one shot at this."

Bow, Glimmer, and Mermista readied their weapons. Perfuma, Scorpia, Frosta, Spinnerella, and Netossa prepared their magic. Micah and Angella oversaw the preparations of Brightmoon's army. Everyone was ready.

"Why exactly do we need all of this again?" asked Bow. "I figured Catra would want to stop this as much as we do. What do we need an army for?"

"Catra… It's complicated," said Adora. "I think she *wants* this to happen. I can't say if this Catra does, but the one I'm familiar with will definitely put up a fight."

"Hold on, Catra's not like that!" said Scorpia. "She may be a bit… vindictive, but there's no way she'd willingly destroy the entire world!"

Adora looked away gloomily. "Then you and me know very different Catras. Now, has anyone seen my–"

Before the party could set off, another wrench was thrown into the mix. At that very moment, who should arrive through the castle doors but Lars, no longer pink, joined by his off-color friends. He and Rutile ran in frantically, looking over their shoulders, followed closely by Rhodonite carrying Padparadscha. "Pads, is she still after us?"

"She's lost sight of us, but she hasn't given up!" reported the Sapphire. "It's only a matter of time before she narrows it down to here!"

The princesses and company stared at their unexpected visitors. "This is quite unexpected," said Perfuma. "Are you running from that awful static as well?"

"No, but that's definitely not helping!" said Rhodonite. "It's Emerald! She's gone completely ballistic! We were just minding our own business when all of a sudden, she comes in with a bunch of ships trying to kill us all!"

"We don't know *what* she wants!" Lars added. "She keeps calling me 'Lars of the Stars' and talking about something called the 'Sun Incinerator'...We ran all the way here! I'm surprised we're still alive!"

Glimmer turned to Adora. "Something from the other world?"

"Definitely," Adora said with a nod. She approached Lars and the others. "Listen, I know this is confusing and scary, but we think we have a way to fix all this. Come with us to the Fright Zone, we'll make sure Emerald doesn't–"

The castle was suddenly rocked by an explosion. A metallic hum was coming from outside, indicating that a ship, most likely one of Emerald's, was responsible. The soldiers and princesses went on alert as more explosions came.

"Oh, come on!" cried Adora. "Can I just finish a thought!?"

The ship outside continued to circle the place, occasionally opening fire. Missiles exploded against the castle walls, but it held strong for the time being. The front doors were thrown open, and everyone got ready to attack, only to see that it was Fluorite following the off-colors. "Sheeee fooooound uuuus!" the fusion said.

"Quickly, protect the civilians!" ordered Angella. Several of the Brightmoon soldiers ran over to the off-colors, ushering them to relative safety. "Everyone else, we must leave now!" The queen spread her wings and took to the sky, leading the princesses out and into the fray.

A single Gem assault skiff hovered in the sky above the castle, raining down fire. The moment princesses stepped outside, it turned away from its target to approach them. A loud, angry voice sounded out over the ship's speakers: "You! You are the ones harboring Lars of the Stars! Surrender him and his traitorous crew to me now, before I reduce this castle to rubble!"

"She does realize what's happening, right?" asked Scorpia. "Hey lady! The entire world's falling apart! Can't your vendetta wait until we sort this all out?"

All that Emerald gave as an answer was a barrage of missiles towards them. Frosta quickly called up an ice wall, barely blocking most of them, save for a few that collided with the ground. Angella flew up towards the ship, firing a beam of light into the glass. "Come on, we have to go!" yelled Adora.

As Adora ran away from the battle, Glimmer called after her. "Wait! What about everyone else? We can't just leave them!"

"We have to!" Adora called back. "If we don't stop this, they're gone anyway!" She ran on, leaving the battle behind.

Glimmer ran after her. "Adora! Adora!" Bow pulled her back, just as a missile landed between her and Adora.

As more missiles rushed towards them, Netossa caught them in her nets. The orbs fell to the ground as a flash of light came from within, and opened up to reveal nothing but smoke. Spinnerella launched blades of wind that buffeted the ship, while Micah tried to grab hold of it with magic. And during it all, the static crept closer.

"Stay here, I'll go after her!" said Scorpia, running off after Adora. Emerald paid her little mind.

"Scorpia, hang on!" Perfuma ran after her as well.

"What is this, are we just supposed to take this thing down on our own!?" said Mermista.

Glimmer took a moment to examine the situation. The few princesses that were left there were holding their own against Emerald's ship. "Bow…" she said. "I think we have to go with Adora."

"What?" he said. "What happened to staying here with everyone?"

"She's right," Glimmer said. "If we fix all of this, I think the world should go back to normal. It won't matter what happens here. Everything that the static destroys will come back."

"Hold on, you 'think?'" Bow asked. "And what about if Emerald–"

Glimmer grabbed hold of his arm, warping the two of them away.

– – –

Where Steven had previously been walking, he now ran. He ran as the world continued to fall apart around him, the static seeming to grow more and more insatiable. At this rate, he wasn't sure he could make it to the Fright Zone before this world was devoured. Despite the stitch in his side, Steven ran on.

If he had been half-Gem, he could have easily made it there in record time. But he wasn't half-Gem here: he was an ordinary

human, with an ordinary stomach. He could get tired, just like everyone else. Not that it would have done him any good at the moment anyway, thanks to Spinel's rejuvenator. Despite how much he desperately wanted to keep running, he forced himself to stop and catch his breath.

Looking around, Steven noticed that he was on top of a hill. All around him, the static descended–or did it ascend?--and consumed everything. Only a narrow bridge remained, and it likely wouldn't last long. He once again set off.

Before he could get far, however, the sound of racing footsteps from behind caught his attention. He turned around, only to be tackled by his unseen assailant before he could see them. The two tumbled down the hillside before coming to a rest at the base, where Steven got to his feet. "Spinel!?"

Indeed, he was faced with the very Gem he had seen disappear into the static, no worse for wear. No worse for wear, that is, aside from the fact that her entire left side had turned pitch black. She stared back at him with malice, amplified by the corruption her form had undergone. She laughed, her voice distorted by an unseen force.

"Greetings and bienvenue world, Spinel is back for one final performance!" she said, gesturing to an invisible audience. "At long last, I will finally get the *payback* I so rightfully deserve, for all the years I spent waiting for a friend who would never return!"

Involuntarily, Steven clenched his fist. "Why?" he said quietly. "...Why!? I didn't do anything to you! I was living my life, perfectly happy, until you and your new friend showed up! I was happy! *We* were happy! I didn't deserve this!"

A fist suddenly collided with his chest, sending him against a nearby tree. He struggled to stand up, wiping blood from his mouth.

"You wanna talk about deserve?" she spat back. "You were never abandoned by your best friend! You were never told to wait for six thousand years, only for her to forget all about you! *You* never had to realize that she found new friends, and that she never needed you at all!" She threw another punch. Steven was prepared for this one, but he still was sent flying a few meters. "Oh, and Emerald was never really a friend–just someone in the same boat as me!"

"Really?" said Steven, his voice more venomous than he thought capable. "You and her are more alike than I thought. Both clinging onto pointless grudges."

Spinel chuckled at this. "Maybe so. At least I have a better excuse. She's just mad about a crummy old ship! But me…my life was ruined. And now I'll return the favor."

This time, Steven ducked under the punch she threw, before throwing one of his own. She easily dodged, grabbing onto his arm and throwing him to the dirt.

"Aww, what's the matter?" she said. "All out of sorts without your powers?" Another chuckle.

"We don't have time for this!" he cried, standing back up. "If I don't get to that sword, this entire world is going to end!"

"You think that matters to me?" Spinel said darkly. "My world ended a long time ago."

With her fist grown to half the size of Steven's body, Spinel lunged forward. Steven held up his arms, but he knew there was little he could do against this attack. Before her fist could hit, however, something flew out of the nearby woods and collided with it, causing her punch to miss. This mystery object flew back into the hand of its thrower–Steven and Spinel looked over to see Rose Quartz catch her shield.

She emerged from the trees with a look of stalwart determination. She was quite disheveled, but very much alive. "Spinel!" she

called, sounding not angry, but firm nonetheless. “Leave Steven alone! He hasn’t done anything to you–if you should be mad at anyone, it’s me!”

“ *You* !” Spinel did indeed look angry. Steven completely forgotten, she approached the Gem she still recognized even in her new form. “Where do you get off, showing your face around here!? You left me on that rock for *years* , and now you choose *this* over me!? You…you…” With a scream of rage, Spinel threw herself at Rose. Her fists pounded against the latter’s shield, not that she tried very hard to protect herself. Steven almost got the sense that she was okay with being attacked.

As the ‘battle’ continued, Steven was unsure of whether or not he should help. Spinel continued to beat away on Rose, and although she seemed unfazed by the strikes, he found it strange that she didn’t do anything to resist.

“I gave you everything you wanted!” Spinel shouted. “I was your friend! Your playmate! The only one who really listened to you! And you just…you just…” Her attack slowed. Gradually, she stopped punching Rose, and slumped to the ground. Steven approached and saw that tears were falling from her eyes. “You just…left me.”

Rose sat down as well. Her face held a look of pain, as though years of holding it back had finally caught up to her. But Steven could tell, this pain wasn’t her own. She held her arms close to her side, unsure of whether she should wrap them around Spinel, or if she should just let her lie.

“Mom…?” said Steven. Rose looked up at him. Spinel blinked, but continued looking down. He didn’t know what to say. Was this even his place to interrupt? This felt more like a moment between her and Spinel.

“Steven,” Rose said in a matronly tone. She simply held out her arms, and he slowly walked over, allowing her to embrace him.

For a few moments, he sits like this, allowing the warmth to wash over him. He reached out his arms as well, returning the hug.

To the surprise of them both, another set of arms wrapped around them. Spinel had got to her feet, stretching her arms to hug the both of them as she buried her tear-streaked face in Rose's shoulder. "I thought I'd never see you again…" she said.

After a moment, Rose shifted to include Spinel in her embrace. "I'm so sorry…" she said, sounding close to tears herself. "I'm so sorry." Indeed, tears fell from her eyes, landing on the one in her arms. The corruption that had begun to consume Spinel retreated with a glow. Her pink and red coloration returned as she held herself close to Rose.

"Why?" Spinel asked. She no longer sounded angry. Instead, she seemed to be pleading for an answer. "Why didn't you come back? Was it…was it my fault?"

"No. No, none of this was because of you," Rose said. "I left you there because I was selfish, and childish, and I took what I had for granted. In many ways, I-I still am. Selfish and childish, I mean. But I never, *never* , took anything I had for granted again once I became Rose Quartz. If I could change it, and go back for you…If I could have never left you there, I would. I would take you with me, and never let you leave my side."

Spinel nodded, a small smile shining through her tears. "Hearing that…it almost makes it better, you know? Almost…" Rose's pained look returned for a moment, but she didn't stop hugging her.

Steven continued watching the two of them, but he also kept an eye on his surroundings. The static had not stopped through all of this. It had continued to spread, and had consumed almost all of their surroundings. All around them, there was nothing–no way to escape. No way to stop this. Rather than fear, a slow disappointment washed over him, as he returned to the pair. He sat down next to them, waiting for them to reconcile.

“Did you ever think about coming back for me?” Spinel asked. “In all that time, surely it crossed your mind to come back, at least once?”

“I did,” Rose replied softly. “At first, I was just so enamored by my colony that I…I forgot you. But after I became Rose Quartz, I started to think of you more. I wanted to go and bring you back, I truly did, but between the war, and my new friends, I…” She closed her eyes for a moment to regain her composure. “That’s no excuse, I know it isn’t. In truth, I had convinced myself that you would be fine without me. That you would find a new friend, and move on from me. If I had known you would be stuck there in that garden, waiting for all those years…”

“You know, it wasn’t the waiting that was the hard part,” Spinel said somberly. “If you had come back, I would have waited for twice as long. It’s that you never came back.”

With one last hug, the pair broke off their embrace, looking back at each other. It was now that they finally noticed their surroundings, seeing the static growing closer. “Oh, dear,” Rose said. “What’s going on?”

“I think it caught up with us,” Steven said. “I looked around, but I didn’t see any way out. I failed…”

“Hey, don’t talk like that, new best friend!” said Spinel, almost effortlessly shifting back to her cheerful self. “Nothing’s over ‘til you say it’s over! There’s gotta be something you can still do!”

“Not unless we can somehow get out of here,” Steven said glumly.

“Surely you aren’t the only one trying to save this place,” said Rose. “What about Adora?”

“Yeah!” said Spinel. “Adora’s gotta be doing something too, right? She’s not gonna let her home fall apart!”

“I guess,” Steven said. “But I–hang on a minute…home. Home!” He leapt to his feet. “Spinel, you’re a genius!”

“Aww, thanks!”

“Mom, the Earth is both of our home, right? But Spinel, she’s been in the garden for years! Er, not to make light of that.”

“Ah, it’s fine!” she said. “I think I know where you’re going with this!”

“If you can put a bubble around me, and send me there, then I could get help! I could bring anyone, I-I could get the Diamonds! As long as there’s a warp pad there, I could go talk to them, and hopefully we can figure something out!”

“I…suppose it’s worth a shot,” said Rose. “But are you sure a bubble can make it out of Despondos?”

“It’s worth a shot,” said Steven. Spinel walked over to him as he sat down, trying to make himself as small as possible. “If there’s even a chance it’ll work, we have to try.”

She nodded. “In that case, best of luck to you. And I’ll miss you, Steven.”

“Hmm? Oh, right,” Steven said somberly. If everything went back to normal, that meant that Rose would no longer exist. A thought then came to Steven: Rose remembered more than she should if she was just a creation of this illusion. She knew more than he did about her past with Spinel. “You’re…really here, aren’t you?” She looked up at him, and smiled. “So, if you’re really here, does that mean you’re not just a memory? Are you not…gone?”

Her grin turned almost embarrassed. “To be honest, I’m not entirely sure how I’m here,” she answered. “But I do know that even though I’m gone, I will never stop loving you, or anyone I left behind.” She placed a hand on his cheek, before touching her forehead to his. “You are my greatest accomplishment, Steven. Because you are your own person. Don’t ever forget that.”

“I won’t.” Steven wiped tears from his eyes as Spinel formed a bubble around him. “I love you, Mom.”

“And I love you, Steven. Now go, save the world.”

Spinel released the bubble, and it and its passenger disappeared. Neither of them had any way of knowing if he had reached his destination. Neither could know if he would succeed. All they could do now was wait for the static to consume their little island of the world.

“Welp…that’s that,” Spinel said. She sat down against a nearby tree, yawning and stretching. “Sheesh! I don’t know about you, but all this fighting and making-up sure’s got me tired!”

Rose giggled, sitting down next to her old friend. “You know what? I never thought of this before, but I think you remind me a lot of Steven. You’re a lot alike in so many ways.”

“Ya know, you’re right,” Spinel replied. “I like ‘im. Who knows? If he’ll still have me after this is all said and done, I think I’d like to keep bein’ his friend.”

“There’s no doubt in my mind he’ll have you,” said Rose.

And so there the two sat, simply watching the static approach. With no reason to fear it anymore, it was almost pretty, in a haunting sort of way. The way it rippled and shimmered, like pure white water.

“Hey, Pink?” said Spinel. “If it’s not too much trouble, do you think…could I see ya back as you used to be? For old time’s sake.”

Rose smiled. “Of course!” In a moment, her entire body was overcome with a white glow, save for her gemstone. She grew taller, and after she returned to pink, the face of Pink Diamond looked back at her.

With a smile, Spinel inched closer to her. The pair continued watching the static grow closer, resting their heads against one another. “I needed this,” said Spinel. “I really think I needed this.”

“I think I did as well,” said Pink.

By the time only their tiny patch of land was left, neither of them were bothered. “Do you think he made it?” asked Spinel.

“I hope so,” Pink replied. “But all we can do now is believe.”

The two Gems then vanished, leaving only white behind.

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Steven gasped as his eyes opened, sitting up as though awakening from a terrible dream. It took him a moment to collect his bearings, looking around at unfamiliar surroundings. Once he remembered why he was here, he realized that this was Spinel’s garden. It looked like nobody had tended to it in years, which he was sure was the case. He got to his feet, placing a hand over his stomach–his fingers pressed against the familiar shape of his gem. He was back in the real world.

“This is where Spinel stayed, all this time…” he said to himself, partially to confirm. He almost couldn’t believe that she had spent six thousand years just standing here, all alone. Even for a Gem, she must have been absurdly loyal.

“Steven?”

Turning around, he saw that he wasn’t alone. A few Gems were present, none wearing the Diamond sigil. He felt as though he had seen some of them before, but he couldn’t place his finger on where. However, when he saw the Gem that had spoken step closer, he realized where he knew them from. Hessonite walked up to him, accompanied by the crew of the *Crystallon* .

“Steven! Thank the stars, you’re alive! But what are you doing here? Oh, everyone’s been so worried, they’ll be relieved to see you safe!” She continued on after this, but Steven didn’t catch any of it, her words turning to static in his mind. He stumbled closer, Hessonite catching him before he could fall.

“I n-need to get to Homeworld,” he said. “I need the Diamonds.”

Chapter End Notes

I gotta tell ya, I've been really excited about this chapter for some time now, so it's great to finally share it! Not as excited as I am about the next one, though! Hope you're all pumped too!

The Sword

Chapter Summary

> Steven returns to Homeworld with hope of finding some way to save everyone, and what he finds could change his life forever.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter Twenty-Three: The Sword

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Steven had a lot on his mind as he stared at the stars out the window, as the *Crystallon* sped towards Homeworld. Could the Diamonds even help him? And if they could, would they, after he had refused Pink Diamond's throne? Maybe he would have to agree to stay with them to get their help; a possibility he mentally prepared for. But above all, he couldn't get the thought of his mom leaving Spinel behind in that garden, like she was nothing. No wonder she had teamed up with Emerald…

"Hey Steven! Whatcha thinkin' about?" Duchess, Pyrope's Ruby companion, peered around the doorframe into the room. Steven turned around to offer a brief look of acknowledgement, before looking back to the window. Seeing this, Duchess gestured for the trio of Garnets to enter.

"Steven? Are you alright?" Hessonite was the first in, followed by Demantoid and Pyrope. "You never did tell us what happened while you were in Despondos. Perhaps speaking your mind will help with what troubles you."

"Indeed," Demantoid added. "I can tell that you are quite troubled. Speaking your mind will allow us to better assist you."

Steven sighed, turning away from the window. "It's…hard to explain," he said. "It isn't one single thing, it's a bunch of little things. Some are big, like my friends being in danger, but then there's stuff like my powers not working." To demonstrate, he attempted to summon his shield. Aside from a small flicker from his gemstone, nothing happened.

"My… How exactly did that happen?" asked Pyrope.

"Spinel," Steven explained. "She brought something called a rejuvenator with her. Got me and the other Crystal Gems. They're back to normal now–at least, aside from that whole disappearing thing–but mine still aren't back. I don't know what to do."

"Well…I'm sure you'll have them back in no time," Hessonite assured him. "If the others were able to shake off its effects, there's no reason that you won't be able to as well!"

"Maybe." Steven didn't sound so sure. "Unless me being half-human has something to do with it."

"Hang on, did you say 'Spinel?'" Duchess asked. She looked up at Pyrope. "Ain't she the whole reason we were at the garden in the first place?"

Pyrope noticed Steven's quizzical expression. "Ah, yes, indeed she is," she explained. "After the Earth itself vanished, White Diamond personally ordered–er, *asked* us to look into the matter."

"I'll bet she did," Steven said.

"No, she really did!" said Hessonite, sounding almost surprised. "She even said please and everything! She was…quite upset that you were missing. They all were."

"Oh…" said Steven. "So, what brought you to the garden?"

"According to eyewitness reports, a Spinel matching the description of the one formerly belonging to Pink Diamond had been sighted on Homeworld several days before Emerald's attack.

It was surmised that the two were in league, which is why we, some of the only Gems with prior experience with Etheria, were approached to investigate."

"When we got here, we found nothing," said Pyrope. "It was as if she had vanished into thin air. The warp pad was still covered in vines, so she couldn't have taken that. And no ships were docked here for the last six thousand years, either."

"That we know about," said Hessonite. "Some may have swung by recently."

"So, Emerald must have come to her," said Steven. "How'd she find out about her? From the way Pearl made it sound, not many people knew about Spinel."

"Before Era-3, Emerald was quite high up on Homeworld's pecking order," said Hessonite. "She would've had access to a great number of files and records, some that likely would have made mention of Spinel and Pink. Perhaps that's how?"

"Yeah. Though I guess it doesn't matter at this point." Once again, Steven tried to summon his shield. As before, all that happened was that his gem briefly lit up. He let out a frustrated groan. "How do you put up with this?" he asked Demantoid. "Not having powers, I mean."

"Many Era-2 Gems such as myself make due by substituting technology." Demantoid raised her robotic arms to demonstrate. "Although it is a point of contention for many of us, I myself prefer it this way. Technology is far more understandable than Gem powers, and is easily repaired should it break down."

"And there ya go!" said Duchess. "We just need to get you a new shield! A mechanical one, that won't go away when–Oh! Can it shoot flames!?"

Pyrope picked her up. "Now, now, let's not talk about new shields until after the Earth is returned, hmm?" She looked at Steven.

"You wouldn't happen to have any clue as to how to go about doing that, would you?"

"No, that's partly why I wanted to see the Diamonds," replied Steven. "There's something about finding Adora's sword, but…I think we're a bit past that now."

Hessonite looked at Steven sympathetically. "I'm sure the three of them can come up with something. After all, they may not be as infallible as many of us Gems thought, but they're still trying to do all they can for Homeworld and their colonies."

Though part of him agreed, Steven stayed silent, only nodding. They would do what they could to help him, at least.

"We will be arriving shortly," said Demantoid. "I must go and prepare the vessel for docking." With that, she turned around and stepped out of the room. Pyrope followed behind her, Duchess looking at Steven as they left. Finally, Hessonite left Steven to his own devices, staring out at the stars.

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Although he had been back several times before since then, it was still jarring to Steven just how different Homeworld looked from just two years ago. Where once everything had been rigid and mechanistic, with an undertone of fear, now the surface seemed no different than Earth. Well, aside from being a cyclopean city eons beyond any human nation could create. Everyone went about their daily lives, no longer worrying about some sense of purpose being forced onto them. They were allowed to be whatever they wanted to be, perform the duties that they chose for themselves. The thought that he was partially responsible for this change caused a small spark of pride within him, only enough to break through his current melancholy for a small moment.

As the ship drew closer to the port, Steven could see the Diamonds waiting for him. All three looked anxious–Blue had her hands clasped below her chest, yellow had her arms crossed, but

White had a hand rested on either's shoulders. Some of the tension seemed to ease from them as the *Crystallon* drew nearer, as though just knowing Steven was near was enough to soothe them. Once the docking procedures were underway, Steven left the room and headed for the doors.

"Steven!" He barely had time to register what was going on, and wasn't even off the ship yet when Blue Diamond scooped him up and pressed him to her cheek–which was covered in tears, expectedly. "Thank the stars you're alright! I can't even tell you how worried we were! The thought that we might have lost you– Oh, I can't tell you how glad I am to see you!"

"T-Thanks," said Steven, offering her a pat on the cheek. "Though, 'alright' is a bit much…"

"Why? That traitorous lowlife didn't hurt you, did she?" asked Yellow, her voice brimming with fury. "That little… To go from one of my most loyal lieutenants to harming a Diamond–"

"No, I'm not hurt," Steven assured them. "But, everyone else, they're… All my friends are in danger. Earth and Etheria, something happened. I-it's hard to explain."

"Well, by all means, tell us!" White urged. "If there's any way we can help, we'll gladly pool all of our resources into doing so!"

Blue gently placed Steven onto the floor. "Okay, so…long story short, some of my…not-quite-friends tried to open a portal from Despondos back into here. But since Earth was there too, both planets kinda got merged into one, and everyone got mindwiped into thinking that was how it always was. Me and Adora got our memories back, but then Eartheria–that's what everyone called it– started to collapse."

"Ah. Two atoms cannot simultaneously exist in the same space," said White. Both the other Diamonds gave her a look. "Sorry, go on."

“Actually, that’s about it,” said Steven. “Most of the planet was gone by the time I got out. And the only reason I even got out at all is because of Spinel. She sent me back to the garden, where I ran into them.” He gestured towards the *Crystallon* .

“Then, Spinel really is involved.” Blue looked to Yellow. “We should have known Pink had left her behind.”

“Yeah, she seemed pretty upset about all that,” he said.

“And it’s hard to blame her,” Yellow said guiltily. “But Pink is only partially to blame. We should have seen the signs. Same with Emerald–I take full responsibility for her betrayal.”

“Now, Yellow, she made her own choices,” said White. “Besides, as you said, she was your most loyal follower, you couldn’t have predicted she would turn on us!”

“Of course I could have!” said Yellow. Noticing Steven’s confusion, she added “Emerald was very vocally against our stepping down from power. She believed that doing so would render Homeworld powerless, and open to rebellion. Ironically, her solution to this was to rebel. If I hadn’t brushed her off, I could have stopped all of this… I should have taken her threats more seriously. She wasn’t named the Slayer of Prime for nothing.”

This statement was enough to give Steven pause. “Hold on, what? ‘T-the Slayer of Prime?’ As in, she’s the one who killed Horde Prime?”

“Indeed,” said White. “Emerald is the one who led the charge during the Battle of Krytis, well over twenty years ago. She was given the *Sun Incinerator* as a medal of honor for her victory. I imagine this is why she is so attached to it–she sees it as a symbol of her worth.”

“Wow…” This was all a lot to process. But rather than focus on that, Steven kept his mind on his friends. “But nevermind! There’s gotta be something you can do to save everyone! Emerald mentioned that she used something called Project: Drawbridge to

send Earth to Despondos. Do you guys still have anything like that?"

"So that's how she did it…" Blue said quietly. "I'm sorry, Steven, but all records of Project: Drawbridge were destroyed after the Skeletor incident. And even if we still had them, we'd need a massive amount of power to generate a portal, like a First Ones artifact."

"You mean like the sword?" asked Steven.

This question seemed to catch the Diamonds off-guard. White and Blue both shared a concerned look, while Yellow stared at Steven. "How do you know about the sword?" she asked.

"Um…w-well, Adora's had it for a while now," he said, confused. "Y'know, Sword or Protection? She-Ra? Have I really not mentioned this to you guys yet?"

White looked off into the distance. "So," she said softly, "there's another sword…"

By now, echoes of ' *Find the sword* ' were playing in Steven's head on loop. "W-what do you mean 'another' sword!?" he said. "Is there some sort of second First Ones sword none of us know about!?"

The Diamonds all shared a brief look with one another. Silently, they all seemed to agree. Closing her eyes for a moment, Blue said "Steven, we need to show you something. Something that no Gem alive other than the three of us have ever seen, or likely ever will see. And if we're right, and I pray we are, it might just be the key to saving all of your friends."

"Why didn't you say do? Let's go!" said Steven. Blue held out her hand, and Steven stepped on, eager to get going.

Hessonite stepped off of the ship. "Er, sorry to interrupt, M–I mean, Yellow Diamond, but there's still the matter of the garden to discuss…"

“Hm? Oh, have President Zircon look it over,” said Yellow, waving her off. “We have something far more important to take care of.” The three Diamonds, four including Steven, set off back towards White’s temple.

“So, uh, where exactly are we going?” Steven asked.

“Somewhere ancient,” answered White. “Somewhere from even before the time of the Diamonds. A place from when Homeworld was still referred to as Eternia…”

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The three of them took Steven into White Diamond’s temple, passing by the murals and statues that lined the halls. Nobody spoke as they carried him past the rooms he was familiar with, until they ended up in White’s inner sanctum, and carried on still. They walked down numerous stairways until they ended up in a dark room underneath the temple, where the walls were lined with eye-shaped markings. Steven watched them warily as they watched him, unsure of whether these were security cameras, or former Gems.

At the far end of the room was a blank wall. Each of the Diamonds placed a hand against it, causing three like-colored panels to light up. These three diamond emblems merged into one, and grew to a size large enough to accommodate them all, as it faded into a doorway. All three of them stepped into what Steven could tell was a gigantic elevator. White pressed another panel, and the descent began.

The four of them remained silent as the elevator continued to descend, for what felt like twenty minutes. Eventually, in part because he couldn’t stand the silence, Steven asked the question that had been on his mind for a while. “What happened, exactly? I’ve known that Homeworld used to be Eternia for a while now, but I don’t know anything more than that. I mean…” He looked out at the seemingly endless expanse of emergence holes passing

them by. "...it's pretty obvious what happened, but I never got any details."

"I wish there was more to tell," said Blue somberly. "They made us, the First Ones. They made us, and we destroyed them, made their planet our own." She shut her eyes. "It's like you said–our entire existence was based around destruction. Every organic race we came near, we decimated."

"Don't simplify it," Yellow said, sounding annoyed. "They treated us like *dirt* . We were nothing more than machines to them–they made it more than clear they were willing to harvest us for the slightest disobedience!"

"So, much like how we treated our Gems?" Blue shot back, her voice icy. "If we were ever any better than our creators, it lasted until we became just like them!"

"Don't even pretend that's the same thing!" Yellow shouted. "There was no hierarchy with those monsters! To them, a Diamond was no better than a Pearl! Nothing more than tools made to–"

"Guys, guys, please!" Steven pleaded, sensing tensions rising. "I wasn't there, so I don't know how bad it was, but it sounds like you have some grievances with the First Ones…" Yellow raised an eyebrow as though to say 'You *think* ?' "But regardless, that's all in the past. We've all done things we aren't proud of, but the important thing is that you're all trying to be better, right?"

Blue and Yellow looked to one another, silently agreeing to disagree. The latter huffed, leaning against the wall. "I still say they had it coming," she muttered.

Blue Diamond looked down at Steven with a fond smile. "So much like Pink," she said, placing a finger on his cheek. "If she wasn't starting arguments, she was stopping them."

"I'm just glad I can help," Steven said, patting her finger. "White? Did you have anything to say?"

White, who had been unresponsive during this entire conversation, finally spoke. “They created us to colonize,” she said darkly. “So we colonized.” Steven then decided it was best to drop this topic for the time being.

“So…” he said. “You wouldn’t happen to know any ways of reversing a rejuvenator’s effects, would you?”

Once again, Blue looked down at him, this time with concern. “Why? Emerald didn’t bring one with her, did she? Are your friends alright?”

“They are now, but…well…” To show them, Steven once more tried to summon his shield, met with the same results as last time.

“Oh, Steven,” Blue said.

“Garnet, Amethyst, and Pearl all got reset too,” he explained. “But when it happened to them, they lost their memories. When they got them back, they all turned back to normal. But since I still have my memories, I don’t know how to get my powers back. Part of me was hoping you all knew a way…”

“In theory, rejuvenators were made to permanently reset a Gem,” Yellow explained. “The only way to truly erase a Gem’s memories is to tamper with the gemstone itself, so some Crystal Gems were able to fight through its effects. We don’t really understand how, and even if we did, your unique organic biology is unlike anything we’ve seen before. I’m sorry to say we’re in uncharted territory.”

“I was afraid of that,” Steven sighed. “But powers or no powers, I’m still going to do everything I can to save my friends.” He looked around at their surroundings. “Um, speaking of which, how soon are we gonna get to the bottom?”

“Not long now,” said White.

Sure enough, it was only another few minutes before the elevator slowed to a stop, and the doors slid open. The group stepped out

into an absolutely massive cavern, lit only by the cascades of lava falling into the chasm beneath them, where it pooled into a gargantuan lake. An equally giant stone bridge led across the chasm, over to an unidentifiable structure, where they headed towards.

White took notice of Steven's curiosity. "We're deep underground now, only miles from Homeworld's core," she said. "This castle here is all that remains of the old Eternia."

"Back during the initial war, it was the only structure of theirs we couldn't destroy," Yellow added. "Some sort of power prevented it. So instead, we buried it, progressively deeper and deeper, until it ended up here."

"This is where they kept it," said Blue.

"Um, kept what?" Steven asked.

Even though the cavern they were in was larger enough to make the Diamonds seem small, the structure was quite sizable too. As they drew closer, Steven started to notice some familiar features. It almost looked like a giant stone skull, worn down by the eons. He could barely make out the divot of an eye, and some grooves that would once have been teeth. Once they were inside, however, it got a lot more familiar.

"This…this is…" Steven was amazed. Blue set him down, and he took in the exact room he had seen so many times before. Rivers of lava flowed from the walls, creating a molten lake over which a bridge led to a raised platform. And on this platform, was a sword, connected by cables to an array of machinery. "This is the place from my dreams…"

Although surprised that Steven recognized this place, another concern was evident to the Diamonds. "What is all this!?" said Yellow, glaring at the tech spread throughout the chamber. "We're the only ones who know this place exists, how did Emerald get down here!?"

“That must be how,” said Blue, indicating the far side of the room. A circular hole had been bored through the wall, with the culprit, a slap-shod drilling machine made from an injector, lying beside it. “But are you sure this is Emerald’s doing?”

“It has to be.” White was examining the machines, which were siphoning power from the sword in the room’s center. “It would have taken a massive amount of power to open a path to Despondos, and this sword is the only thing capable of providing it.”

Steven looked up at them. “This is definitely the sword I’m supposed to find,” he said. “But…whose is it? And what’s it doing here?”

“I suppose you deserve to know,” said Blue. “This sword once belonged to the Eternians’ greatest warrior. He was the planet’s guardian, its protector. He wielded great power with this blade, but even he eventually fell to our assault. After he died, his people placed his sword here, where it’s lain ever since.”

“Not for lack of effort on our part,” said Yellow. “We tried everything we could to claim its power for ourselves, but nothing worked. Eventually, we gave up, and buried it down here.”

The sword seemed to call out to Steven. Only half-aware of what he was doing, he found himself crossing the bridge to get a better look. *Find the sword* . Handle and blade of polished gray steel, with a red runestone floating between them. “So, this is how I can get back to Despondos,” he said. “H-how do I turn it on?”

“Emerald figured it out, I’m sure it isn’t that difficult,” said White.

Steven hesitantly reached forward, his fingertips brushing against the handle. Despite the warmth of the magma-filled room, it was almost icy cold. He only had a moment to consider this, as the second his hand touched the sword, he felt his mind being thrown from his body as light consumed his surroundings.

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“Urgh…wha?” Steven looked around, rubbing his eyes. At first, he seemed to be in a pure white room, but he soon saw that wherever he was, it was filled with thick mist, obscuring the view from all sides. Confused, he looked around, until he heard a voice.

“So, you found it after all.” This voice; it was the same one he had heard. The one calling out to him to find the sword. “It’s good to finally meet you, Steven.”

Steven turned in the direction of the voice, and saw a silhouette walking towards him. As the figure grew closer, he could make out very familiar looking blond hair. “A-Adora?” he said. “What are you doing here?”

“Who?” the voice said. It wasn’t Adora, but a man…or more accurately, a boy, as he couldn’t have been any older than Steven. He was slightly taller and lankier than Steven, but his hair, tied in a similar ponytail, was the exact same color as Adora’s. “Er, sorry, I’m not sure who ‘Adora’ is. My name’s Adam.”

After a moment of looking at him–he really did look a lot like Adora–Steven answered. “Nice to meet you too,” he said. “So… this is your sword, huh?”

“It is,” Adam replied. “Or, was, I suppose. That’s why I’ve been calling out to you, actually: the sword chose you.”

“It ‘chose’ me?” Steven said. “How does a sword choose? Is this like an Excalibur situation?”

Adam grinned. “Well, maybe it’s inaccurate to say the sword itself chose you. If we’re being technical, you were chosen by He-Man himself.”

“H-He-Man?” said Steven, unable to hold back a snicker. “What exactly is a He-Man?”

It seemed Adam didn’t notice his reaction. “He-Man is the source of the sword’s power. Through it, you are able to channel him, and use Grayskull’s power as your own.”

"Grayskull…" Steven said. "Okay, so you don't know Adora. But are you familiar with someone called She-Ra?"

"She-Ra?" Adam cocked his head to the side. "I can't say I've ever heard of her. But I can vaguely remember hearing that the Sword of Power is not the only magical artifact of its kind. Does She-Ra allow one to transform into a giant, muscled warrior?"

"Oh yeah," said Steven, nodding. "With the Sword of Protection."

"Well, then I'd say you're more than familiar with what's going to happen next!" said Adam. "All you need to do is feel the Power of Grayskull within yourself, and–"

"Hang on a moment," Steven interrupted. "Sorry, but this is all a bit sudden, and I'm not even sure I can trust you. You're not the first person who's asked for my help with a magic weapon, and spoke to me in visions…"

Thankfully, Adam seemed to understand. "You must mean my uncle Keldor," he said solemnly. "I thought I sensed his presence a while back. I'm just glad you were able to stop him again."

"S-Skeletor's your *uncle* ?"

"Now then, you have nothing to worry about, I promise," Adam continued. "Keldor wanted you to bring you his staff, yes? I'm doing the opposite–I'm giving you a gift. The Sword of Power is a tool, one for you to use as you see fit. And because He-Man chose you, I have no doubt you will use it for good. In my last moments, I used this sword to save my friends, and I have no doubt you will use it to save yours. We may not have ever met before now, Steven, but I can tell from my time watching over you that you have a good heart. Now, do you vow to use this sword to do good?"

Although Adam's speech had assured Steven somewhat, he still wasn't entirely sure. Still, as he had no powers of his own at the moment, and no way to Etheria, this was his best hope. "I do," he said.

“Do you vow to stay true to your morals, and to never succumb to darkness?”

“I do,” Steven said, a bit more confidently.

“And finally, do you vow to uphold justice and fairness, and to use this blade to defeat your enemies?”

“I do.”

“THen it is done. I, Prince Adam of the house of Randor, previous vessel of He-Man, do hereby grant this power to you. Now go, and fight with the Power of Grayskull!”

“I will!” Steven shouted triumphantly, expecting to feel the power flowing through him. However, nothing happened, and he found himself in the same place. He looked around. “Er…how do I make it do the thing?”

Adam gave a knowing smile. “Oh, I think you already know,” he said. “Just feel the sword, and go from here.”

“Feel the sword…” Steven closed his eyes in concentration. Back on Homeworld, back in his body, he could feel the cold metal of the handle. His fingers wrapped around it and gripped tight. Indeed, he knew what he needed to do. “By the Power of Grayskull!”

Light erupted all around them. A warm glow filled Steven to the brim, and he felt his body and mind reuniting. He could tell that he would be leaving soon, so he said his goodbyes to Adam.

“Thank you, for everything. I promise I’ll do everything to be a worthy successor!”

Adam chuckled. “Oh, I have no doubt you will be! Now go–the world won’t save itself!”

The light and warmth reached a peak, and Steven could feel his body changing. He clenched his fists, one around the hilt of the

Sword of Power. “I have the power!”

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From the Diamonds’ perspective, the moment Steven had touched the sword, the entire room was covered by a blinding light, and all of the machines went haywire. Once the glare had subsided, Steven, and the sword, were gone. Overloaded cables led to the machines, all of which were fried.

“What–what happened!?” shouted Blue. “Where’s Steven!?”

“It…it must have worked,” Yellow replied. “He must have been transported to Despondos. I only hope that sword is enough to help him…”

White stepped forward, examining the spot where he had stood moments before. “Good luck, Steven,” she said, “and may the stars guide you.”

Chapter End Notes

> Happy new year, all! And what better way to kick 2022 off than with a chapter I've been excited about since I started writing this story--heck, maybe this series! As always, I can only hope that you all are as excited about this as I am. If you are, I'd love to hear from you!

The Power

Chapter Summary

As the time left for Earth and Etheria ticks away, a new hero arrives to save them both.

Chapter Twenty-Four: The Power

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The sounds of the battle behind her grew distant as Adora ran through the Whispering Woods, heading as fast as she could towards the Fright Zone. Right now, running was the only thing she could do. Nothing else mattered if she couldn't stop this, and there was only one way she knew how. The Sword of Protection was the key, and if she could just get to it, all of this would be fixed. It had to. It just had to.

In the back of her mind, it pained Adora to leave her friends behind, to face Emerald alone. She kept having to remind herself that none of this was real, that it didn't matter what happened here. Win or lose, everyone would be consumed by the static unless she fixed this. It was her sword that had caused all of this, and it was her that would fix it.

Adora cried out as, lost in thought, her foot had caught on a tree root, sending her careening into a ditch. She landed with a groan, dusting herself off and getting back up. "Can't…can't be much further now," she said. "Just gotta keep moving. Gotta keep moving so my friends don't get eaten by the world." She unsheathed her loaned sword to cut through some vines blocking her way. She stopped for a moment to examine her reflection in the blade, before sighing and putting it away.

"Adora?"

That voice. She knew that voice. She hadn't heard it in years, but…no, it was impossible. She looked around, finding its source

in a shadowed figure approaching her. Upon stepping into the light, her suspicions were confirmed. "You…" she said, unable to hide her amazement.

"Hello again, Adora," said Light Hope. The Great Computer long thought dead stepped closer, pushing branches aside as she did so, and her footsteps noticeably flattening the grass. "It has been some time since we last spoke."

"Well, yeah, 'cause you're supposed to be *dead* !" Adora said, staring incredulously at the figure before her. "How are you here? A-and how are you *here* here!?" She reached out to touch Light Hope, shocked to find that her hand didn't simply pass through her. She could feel the fabric of her robe, the resistance from her shoulder as she pressed against it. "What's going on…?"

"Unfortunately, I know little more than you do about this," replied Light Hope, taking a moment to examine her own hands. "Given the circumstances, my best estimate is that this false world, powered by the sword, created this body for me. As I am disconnected from Eternia's mainframe, I cannot say if there were reasons for it doing so."

"I…guess that makes sense," Adora said, after thinking about it for a while. "Steven's mom is here too, and from what I heard, that's about the same thing. But that doesn't matter! Come on, we have to go and stop Catra, before everyone's–"

"Wait." Light Hope grabbed onto Adora's arm before she could leave. "Although I do not know if the Sword had reason to bring me here, I know that I do have reason of my own to be here, Adora. Something that you must know."

"Uh, can it wait?" she asked. "We're kinda on a time limit here!"

Light Hope took this as an invitation. "The Sword chose you, but you do not yet know why. You have yet to fully understand yourself, your past…your purpose."

“What are you talking about?” Adora said, growing impatient. “If you haven’t noticed, the world’s in danger! This isn’t exactly the best time to be talking about my past!”

“You are special, Adora. Far more than you know. In over a thousand years on this planet, the one it finally chose was someone born on another. Haven’t you wondered why that is?”

“I…well, yeah, of course I have.” Less so after meeting her friends, but Adora had always wondered where she had come from. From what Shadow Weaver had told her, the Horde had found her as a baby, all alone in the middle of nowhere. Even when she had figured she was not from Eternia, she still had no idea where she actually was from. “Why does that matter right now?”

“I am not sure how long I can stay,” said Light Hope. “When the Sword is reclaimed, and this world is split apart once more, I will cease to be. I must tell you this while I still can.”

“Well, do you know where it is?” asked Adora. “You were pretty vague about it back then.”

“Three-seven-eight. Four-nine-two. Five-five-three. When the worlds are restored, come and find me.”

Adora stared at Light Hope for some time. “That’s it? That’s all you’re giving me? I-I don’t mean to sound rude or ungrateful or anything, but that doesn’t exactly help me with…anything, really. Could you be a bit more specific? I mean, it’s only my destiny, after all!”

For a moment, Adora swore she could see the brief flicker of a smirk across Light Hope’s lips. Almost as if she was enjoying her frustration. She just as quickly brushed it off as a trick of the light, something she imagined. Light Hope was about to say something else, but another voice interrupted her. “Adora! Adora, where are you!?” This one she recognized as Glimmer’s.

Upon hearing the voice, Light Hope turned to leave. Her strides were long and purposeful, as though she was fleeing from Glimmer. “Hey, wait!” Adora called out, following after her. “You can’t just leave like that! Come back!”

“Remember what I have told you,” Light Hope said, having all but vanished from view. “Three-seven-eight. Four-nine-two. Five-five-three. Remember these coordinates. I will be waiting for you.”

Adora tried to follow after her, but she was nowhere to be seen. “Light Hope!” she cried. “Come back! I still need you!”

“Guys, I think she’s over here!” Another voice, this one recognizable as Scorpia’s. The large princess came tearing through the trees, coming to a stop once she had reached Adora. “Hoo boy…you are…you’re quite a spry one!” she said, doubled over.

“There you are!” Glimmer hurried up to her as well, followed by Bow and Perfuma. “Adora, what were you thinking? You can’t just run off without us like that!”

Although she heard her, Adora was more focused on scanning the treeline. “Where’d she go? She was right here! None of you saw her, did you?”

“Um, saw who?” asked Perfuma.

“Light Hope. She was right here, and she was real! Not just a hologram, and she told me some numbers and…and…” The four of them were looking at her with concern. After giving one last look into the forest, she gave a sigh of defeat. “It’s nothing. Probably just a hallucination.”

“Hallucination or not, we should probably get moving,” said Bow. “If you and Glimmer are right, and getting your sword back will stop all this, we need to get to the Fright Zone before this staticky stuff absorbs the way there!”

"You mean you're coming with me?" Adora said, receiving smiles of confirmation from her friends. "Alright! Let's get a move on!"

As the five of them continued onwards, none of them noticed the figure watching from above. Light Hope looked down on them, perched up in the trees. At least, it was Light Hope at first. Once they were gone, her form shifted, growing darker, and more slender. Piercing red eyes stared at the party as they left, none the wiser to their misdirection. "Ah, Adora…too gullible for your own good!" said Double Trouble, wearing a malicious grin.

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Missiles exploded against the ground and castle walls, showing no sign of stopping. "How many of those things does she *have* !?" exclaimed Netossa, shielding herself and Frosta from the barrage.

"Too many!" replied Spinnerella, deflecting another cascade of the projectiles with a gust of wind. A few of them collided with the ship that had fired them, adding to its damage. Although Emerald's vessel had been continuously assaulted by the princesses for the past several minutes, it showed no signs of slowing down. In fact, the more damage it sustained, the more motivated its pilot seemed to become.

Emerald let out a scream of frustration. "You think this changes anything!? I'm going to tear Lars of the Stars to pieces, and his allies along with him–starting with you!" Everyone braced as another barrage was launched, but the missiles avoided them entirely, pounding against Brightmoon Castle. From the points of impact, a giant crack began to creep up the side of one of the towers, which threatened to fall right where everyone was standing.

Dust and debris fell to the ground as the tower began to topple over. Emerald momentarily halted her attack, watching intently how the princesses would react to this threat that there was little time to escape from. Much to her frustration, magic surrounded the tower, preventing it from falling. Micah stood firm atop an

adjacent tower, a spell holding up the crumbling tower. However, it clearly took all his concentration just to keep it in place.

"Hold on, love!" shouted Angella, flying over to aid her king. She created an energy barrier beneath the falling tower, pushing up against it. Slowly, the structure started to rise back up into place. However, another threat was becoming apparent: the static had continued growing closer. The winner of this battle wouldn't matter soon, something which Mermista took notice of.

"Um, are we just gonna sit here and let that stuff eat us?" she asked, pointing out the static. "I feel like we should get everyone out of here, like now!"

"I hear you, but Emerald's just going to follow us if we leave now," Spinnerella replied. "We need to take down her ship if we want to make it to safety."

"Then let's stop dancing and start fighting!" Mermista ran over to the lake, and with a wave of her hand, the water started swirling around the center. She ran across its surface, and once she reached the middle, it launched her like a slingshot towards the battleship.

It was clear Emerald wasn't expecting one of them to throw themselves at her, as she made no attempt to dodge or evade. Mermista landed trident-first on the side of the ship, the three prongs digging deep gashes in the hull. She forced her weapon deeper into the ship, hoping to pierce something crucial to keeping it in the air.

The vessel swerved back and forth to shake off the unwelcome hitchhiker, firing more missiles for good measure. One of these raced straight towards Queen Angella, who was currently preoccupied with keeping the castle from falling apart. Moments before it could strike her, she quickly put up a shield between her and it, but it wasn't enough. The explosion threw her out of the air, and she came to a stop within the castle.

“Angella!” cried Micah. The added strain hit him suddenly, and he was almost dragged down with the falling spire. He redoubled his efforts, but it continued to crumble. There was no way he could hold it by himself at this point.

From atop Emerald’s ship, Mermista surveyed the battlefield. Maybe he didn’t have to hold on… Reaching out, she willed a collection of watery strands to extend up towards the ship, grabbing on tight and pulling it towards the ground. The engines sputtered and strained as Emerald tried to fight against it.

The tips of the water tendrils hardened into icy spikes that dug into the metal. “Come on, keep pulling!” Frosta called to Mermista. “She’s almost at the ground–”

Their game of tug-o-war was interrupted by a surge of energy that spread across the entire field. Coming from seemingly everywhere at once, it felt like nothing they had felt before…and yet, something about it was familiar. As though even if their minds didn’t recognize the source, their bodies did. For a moment, everyone’s power was disrupted. Emerald’s ship spiraled out of control, and the tower began to fall again.

Mermista was the first to regain her bearings. “Spinnerella, hit it over here!” she called.

Spinnerella instantly sprang into action, buffeting the side of the tower with the strongest gale she could muster. The tower still fell, but tilted towards the ship as it did. Emerald either didn't notice in time, or was unable to move fast enough, as the ship veered right into the path of the crumbling tower. Stone collided with metal, crushing the vessel beneath its weight. A huge cloud of dust rushed from the point of impact, which everyone reacted to by covering their faces. Once it had cleared, there was no more m movement.

“Mermista!” cried Frosta, sprinting towards the wreckage. She had been standing on the ship when the tower fell, and nobody saw

her jump off. Netossa and Spinnerella joined her, running over to search the debris for their friend.

Meanwhile, Micah was on the ground, exhausted from the strain it took to keep the tower from falling. "I…must be…getting rusty," he panted. "All my time alone…" He stopped, realizing what he had just said. He did not remember any time he had been alone, and yet it came to him so naturally. His mind was swimming with half-realized memories, and he was slowly growing more certain that the clearer ones were the false ones.

That surge, he suddenly realized. Whatever that surge of energy was, it had unlocked something within him, something that this world had buried. For some reason, *Beast Island* was at the forefront of these memories.

Before Micah could think on this further, Angella approached from behind. "You performed wonderfully, my dear," she said, only looking slightly battered. "I just wish that this could have been a more joyous reunion."

"Hmm?" He turned to face her. "Reunion? What do you mean?"

A pained look crossed Angella's face. "I…can't explain it, but what Adora told us has been eating away at my mind. About none of this being real. And that wave a moment ago…it made me realize she was more right than I had thought."

"What are–" Before Micah could ask his question, Angella wrapped her arms around him. Although unsure of what was going on, he returned the gesture, feeling nostalgic for an embrace that his mind told him he received regularly. "I-I suppose I missed you too…"

The whole castle shook. Indeed, the entire field quaked as the static began to overtake the entire area. The already-unstable structure began to crumble as the void crept closer. Furthermore, something burst up from the rubble: a smaller, one-Gem craft that no doubt contained Emerald, shot up from the wreckage and sped

off into the horizon. The three princesses nearby were thrown off their feet, helpless as the static came closer.

Spinnerella was the first, thrown closest to the edge. She tried to get to her feet as the ground gave way beneath her. She created a gust behind her to push her closer to stable ground, but the entire courtyard was falling to pieces. A pair of glowing nets shot out, wrapping around her wrists and pulling her upwards.

"You weren't thinking of quitting already, were you?" Netossa held onto both nets, pulling Spinnerella closer. However, another quake almost made her lose her footing, causing the two of them to stumble closer to the edge.

Although Spinnerella kept trying to use her wind to blow them both to safety, it wasn't working. It was as though the air that went into the static couldn't come back out. "It's too late for me– Go! Save yourself!" she cried.

Netossa only pulled harder. "No way! Anywhere you go, I go with you! And if that means into that white abyss of nothing, then that's how it is!"

"Then I'm sorry, Sweetheart." Spinnerella thrust her arm forward, blowing Netossa back with a blast of wind. The nets disappeared, and she felt herself falling, down past the ground and into the void. She closed her eyes, knowing that at least Netossa was safe…

She then felt a tight grip on her arms. She opened her eyes, and there was Netossa, falling beside her. "What? You didn't think I'd let you get away, did you? We're in this together, for better or for worse!"

A smile crossed Spinnerella's lips, and spread to Netossa's. "I can't argue with that." The two embraced as they fell, and both vanished into the aether.

Up in the castle, Angella watched with subdued horror as her home disintegrated before her eyes. Resisting every urge to fall to

despair, she turned to her beloved. "As much as I wish we could be together again, I need to focus on the ones I *can* save. I have to move on." She planted a kiss on his forehead. "Farewell, my king."

"M-move on?" said Micah. With the messy jumble of memories cascading about his mind, it took a moment to realize what she meant. "Angella…" But it was too late, as his queen had already taken flight. "Angella, wait! I'm not–"

The castle was consumed by the static. Angella flew down as fast as her wings could carry her, down into the courtyard, doing her best to put the memories of Micah aside. Once she spotted her target–Frosta–she scooped the girl up in her arms and sped away from Brightmoon. Not a moment too soon, as the entire area disappeared, eaten up by the static.

"Mm…did we win?" asked Frosta, coming to. "Where's Mermista?"

"Don't worry, little one, everyone will be alright," Angella assured her. "Once Adora gets her sword, all will be right once again." She flew off towards the Fright Zone, which, worryingly, was also the direction Emerald had flown off in.

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"Did…did you all feel that?" Adora had stopped in her tracks, suddenly looking off over the horizon. The others stopped as well, but not just because she did; because they had felt it as well. For once, everyone knew exactly what Adora meant, as they had felt it as well.

"Yeah…what *was* that?" asked Scorpia. "I haven't felt something like that since…ever, I think."

"Okay, so this one time when I was working on my tracker pad, I got electrocuted," said Bow. "This felt sorta like a less painful version of that. And…deeper, if that makes any sense."

"I've felt something like that coming from the Moonstone," Glimmer said. "Whenever I recharge, it feels almost like that."

Adora, meanwhile, seemed as though she had a far deeper connection with the mysterious sensation. "When I turned into She-Ra for the first time, it felt almost exactly like that," she said. "Like this…this massive surge of energy running through me. You don't think the two are related, do you?"

"Well, you did say that all of this–" A gesture to their surroundings. "--was caused by the Sword of Protection," said Perfuma. "Maybe it senses that we're coming to rescue it!"

"Hold up, was it established earlier that your sword could think and stuff?" asked Scorpa. "Because if it was, I missed that conversation!"

"Whatever it was, we can't afford to just stand here." Adora continued on, urging her friends to do the same. "If the sword really is calling to me, then that's all the more reason to hurry up, right?"

And so, they followed her, reaching the end of the woods before long. Getting to the Fright Zone would likely still take some time, and some of them began to worry they may not make it in time. Walls of static lined the horizons, and there was no way of telling just how quickly they would close in. Bow made his way to the front of the group next to Adora. "So…did I hear you right back there, calling to Light Hope?"

She sighed. "Yeah, I…I saw her. She was here–and I mean *here* here, like actually solid."

"Hang on, you're telling me Light Hope was here?" said Glimmer, appearing beside them. "How exactly would that work? And why didn't she stay to see us?"

"I don't know. The whole thing was really weird," Adora said. "She kept talking about where I came from. Then she told me some random numbers and just…left." She was quiet for a moment,

pondering their interaction. “I mean, I know Light Hope could be cryptic, but this doesn’t really seem like the time for that.”

“Are you sure it was her?” asked Bow. “I mean, last I checked, Light Hope got erased by Horde Prime. And was also a hologram.”

Adora shrugged. “Dunno who else it would be. She said something about living on in the sword, and this world making things real.” Another pause. “It sounded better the way she said it…”

“Did you at least remember the numbers?” Glimmer asked.

“Yea, ‘course,” Adora said. “There was a seven, a few fives…look, can we wait until we deal with *this* crisis before we move onto the next?”

Given their silence, everyone agreed. Their path took them through what would have been serene hills, had it not been for the unnatural silence in the air. Adora was the only one who seemed not to notice, or care. She marched on, a single-minded focus on getting to Catra and ending this madness. Bow once again broke the silence.

“What exactly did you mean by ‘where you came from?’”

Adora averted her eyes, seemingly hesitant to answer. “I, um, assume she meant where I lived before I came to Etheria. I’m sure it’s not important, though…”

“Not important!?” Scorpia had suddenly appeared behind the trio, startling all of them with her outburst. “Of course it’s important! Don’t you wanna know about your origins!?”

“No, it’s not that I don’t!” Adora said. “It’s just…what if I don’t like what I find? I mean, we know the First Ones weren’t exactly the best people, so…what if wherever I was born, they were the same way? What if my parents were…”

Perfuma stepped forwards as well. “Excuse me, sorry to cut in, but I’d like to second Scorpia’s opinion! I think it’s very important to know where one came from, good or bad. Knowing your history is important, and even if you don’t exactly like the answer…” She placed a hand on Adora’s shoulder. “None of it will change who you are!”

“Yeah, exactly!” Scorpia scooped the other four of them up in a massive hug. Bow and Perfuma just rolled with it, Adora was mostly confused, and though Glimmer was indignant, she didn’t resist. “You know, if we make it outta this alive, we should hang out more ofte–”

None of them had heard the sounds of engines approaching in the distance until it was too late. The small fighter craft screamed past, peppering the ground with a spurt of gunfire. If it hadn’t been for Scorpia, many of them likely would have been hit. She took most of the barrage herself, falling over with a cry as the others scattered.

“Scorpia!” yelled Perfuma, crouching beside the wounded woman. Adora and Bow drew their weapons as the ship came around for another pass.

“I’m fine,’ Scorpia groaned, struggling to her feet. “My shell’s tougher than you’d think! Just knocked the wind outta me, is all.”

Emerald’s ship rocketed towards them, opening fire. Adora instinctively stood her ground, forgetting that she wasn’t She-Ra. Glimmer warped her and the others out of harm’s way, but not before Bow fired an arrow. The projectile short-circuited the ship’s weapons–Emerald banged on the dashboard in frustration, searching for her targets. The five hid within a cluster of trees, watching the ship circle back around. “What is she so angry about?” asked Bow.

“We don’t have time for this!” Adora shouted. “We can’t let her distract us! Come on, duck and weave!” She tried to make a run for it, only for Perfuma to pull her back with a vine.

"'Duck and weave?' What are you thinking!?" she cried. "You can't duck and weave past that thing!"

"She's right," said Scoripa, holding out her arms. "C'mere, I'll cover you!"

"No! Scorpia, we are not using you as a shield" Perfuma said.

Glimmer had been scanning the horizon. "I'll keep her distracted," she said. "The rest of you, make it to cover over there!" She pointed out a nearby crater that might provide shelter.

"Glimmer, wait–" Bow tried to stop her, but she vanished before he could. She reappeared further out into the field, right in Emerald's line of sight, waving for good measure. The fighter turned towards her, and she teleported again, leading it away from the others. "Hurry! Run!"

Everyone made a beeline for the crater. "Has that always been there?" asked Perfuma. "I've been this way quite a few times, and I don't remember a massive smoking crater in the middle of the field!"

"It's probably from Emerald or one of her ships!" Adora said. "Just get down there before–"

All four of them stopped in their tracks as something–no, someone–appeared from inside the crater. A hand reached out, its owner pulling himself up out of the hole. A person, easily eight feet tall, bulging with muscle, and covered in silver-gray armor. He wore a small crown-like helmet on his head, out from which his black hair cascaded in dreads down to his shoulders. Most of his face was covered in a thick black beard. As he steadied himself, he pulled up a glowing sword in his other hand. Adora and Bow readied their weapons at the figure, but something made them hesitate: on his stomach sat a glistening pink gemstone.

"S-Steven?" Bow said, his bow lowering in disbelief. "That can't be him, right? A-am I seeing things?"

‘Wait, *this* is that kid you’re always running around with?” said Scorpia. “Dang, puberty hit him like a truck…”

The towering man opened his eyes, glaring ahead at the group… and upon seeing them, his face lit up. “Guys!” he exclaimed in a booming voice, rushing over and lifting Adora up in a hug almost as bone-crushing as Scorpia’s. “I made it back! And I’m not too late, I can still save everyone!”

“Yup, it’s Steven alright,” Adora said in a pained tone.”

Steven dropped her. “Yeah, of course it’s me! Who else would I… Hang on, did you get shorter?” He looked down, staring with surprise at his new body. “Woah… Holy crap, I’m huge!” He raised his hands up to his face. “And hairy! I-it worked. I’m He-Man!”

Perfuma stared at Steven’s new form in utter confusion. “Oookay… I have *quite* a few questions, but how about we start with, what happened to you!?”

“Oh, uh, long story,” said Steven. “Basically, Mom and Spinel helped me back to Homeworld, the Diamonds gave me the Sword of Power, and Adam turned me into He-Man! Cool, right?”

Nobody was even remotely sure what to make of these new developments. Everyone just stood there, their current predicament momentarily forgotten. Forgotten, that is, until Glimmer suddenly appeared. “Guys, she’s coming back! She–what the? Is that Steven!?”

Before anyone could answer, Emerald’s ship opened fire again, rushing towards them. “Get back!” Steven shouted, standing in the way of the barrage, blocking most of the shots with his sword. As the fighter blazed past, Glimmer teleported again, landing right on top of it.

Everyone prepared for her to come back for another run. “So, what sort of powers do you have?” asked Scorpia. “Any neat stuff you can do?”

“Powers?” Steven said, looking down at his armor. “I don’t even know how to pee in this thing!”

Glimmer hammered the end of her staff against the ship’s windscreen as Emerald tried to shake her off. Eventually she was successful, sending the princess falling back towards the earth. She recovered by teleporting right to the ground, closer to the others. “Heads up!”

Emerald raced at the group, staying closer to the ground. She was practically foaming at the mouth as she beared down on them, intent on ramming into them. “No you don’t!” Steven ran forward to meet her, readying the Sword of Power. “Eat this!”

He swung the sword right as the ship was about to hit him, tearing straight through the armor. Emerald’s ship, taking the sword along with it, was thrown to the side, trailing smoke as it flew. The craft crash-landed several yards away, going up in a fiery explosion that sent hot air blowing their way.

“Aw, I had the sword for two minutes, and already I lost it!” Steven lamented. “Also…you don’t think it’s possible she bailed at the last second, do you?”

Perfuma examined the smoldering wreckage. “I’m…sure anything’s possible!” she said, not sounding entirely convinced.

It soon became apparent that anything was indeed possible, as the wreckage shifted, pushed aside by a very singed, very angry, and very much alive Emerald. She pulled herself out of the remains of her ship, hunched over like an animal as she glared at Steven. Fittingly, she let out a primal roar as she charged towards them.

“Woah! She is *mad* !” said Scorpia. She stood in front to stop her, catching a punch Emerald threw at her in her claw, followed by another. Emerald snarled, and broke free from her grip by leaping against her chest, throwing Scorpia to the ground.

Steven surprised her from behind with a punch to the back of her head. While it caught her unawares, she was able to block the follow-up, catching him in the jaw with one of her own. Emerald was thrown off by an exploding arrow colliding with her back, causing her to stumble forward. With another punch, Steven knocked her down.

In her rage, however, Emerald was nowhere near close to giving up. She got to her feet, only for vines to wrap around her legs. She growled at Perfuma, but was distracted by Glimmer appearing above her. Before Glimmer could strike Emerald with her staff, the Gem caught her by the collar, hurling her at Perfuma. "Guys!" shouted Bow, rushing over as the two princesses collided.

Emerald turned her attention back to Steven. She charged at him, ducking under a punch and knocking him into his back. Snarling, she climbed on top of him and wrapped her fingers around his neck, squeezing as tight as she could. "Is this…really going to… solve anything?" he strained, trying to free himself from her grip. "I know…about Krytis! You used to be…be a hero!"

But the Gem was relentless, refusing to even speak to him. He held out his hand, reaching out to something, anything. To his surprise, something suddenly flew out from the ship's wreckage: his sword. The Sword of Power flew through the air, landing in Steven's outstretched hand. Quickly he swung: Emerald's arm was severed. The Gem roared, backing off as Steven scrambled to his feet.

"Huh…handy," he said, examining the sword. "Er, no offense."

Emerald paid his word choice no mind, cradling her shoulder stump. With a bit of strain, the light emanating from her wound gave way to a repaired limb, which she flexed cautiously. Before she had the chance to charge Steven again, she herself was charged by Scorpia.

"Stay down!" said Scorpia, driving her stinger into Emerald's chest. Undeterred by either the piercing or by the venom, Emerald

simply batted Scorpia's tail aside, severing the stinger. "Ouch! … Aw man, not again!" Scorpia backed away as Emerald, having pried the stinger from herself, was now trying to stab her with it.

Steven swung his sword, both him and his weapon glowing with energy. His first attack missed, which gave Emerald the chance to drive Scorpia's stinger into his shoulder. The paralytic venom took effect instantly, sending him to his knees. "C'mon…no fair…"

"Sorry, that one's kinda on me!" said Scorpia. She and Emerald squared off again, but their battle was interrupted by an arrow fired by Bow. Before it could hit her, Emerald caught it, sending it at Scorpia. Electricity ran through her, taking her out of the fight; and for good measure, Emerald hurled her unconscious form at Bow, pinning him underneath her.

In one last-ditch attempt to stop her, Adora leapt on her from behind, repeatedly stabbing her sword into the Gem. After a moment of struggling, Emerald grabbed onto Adora, slamming her into the ground. Her sword fell from her hands, and Emerald brought the Adora's winded form close to her face, hissing out three words: "This. Ends. Now."

Emerald walked away from the battlefield, dragging Adora with her. "Wait…Adora!" said Steven, struggling through the effects of the venom. "Gotta…keep fighting. Can't…let go…yet!" He pulled the stinger from his back, trying to pull himself to his feet. The more effort he exerted, the more his sword began to glow a bright silver.

"I vowed, when my beloved *Sun Incinerator* was destroyed, that I would kill Lars of the Stars and everyone he associates with," Emerald snarled, pulling Adora along. "He and his crew are gone. The Crystal Gems are gone. The Princesses are gone. All that remains now is the six of you."

Adora did her best to break free from her grip, but she was unable to escape. Despite herself, she began to grow afraid when she saw where Emerald was taking her: the wall of static at the edge

of the world. “What’s the point of this?” she said. “Killing all of us won’t bring your ship back! Actually…couldn’t you just repair your ship?”

“ *Nothing* can replace the *Sun Incinerator* !” Emerald bellowed, lifting Adora over her head. “And if she had to die, so do all of you! I don’t care if I go with you, so long as every one of you is erased!”

Moments before Emerald could hurl Adora into the endless expanse, a glowing object streaked through the air, slicing through her form. The Sword of Power cut through her effortlessly, causing her to drop Adora as her eyes widened in shock. The glowing sword flew up out of the pit and returned to Steven’s hand. Adora leapt out of the way as Steven unleashed a wave of energy from his sword, sending both halves of Emerald tumbling into the void. The group gathered around, watching her disappear into nothing.

“Well…that just happened,” said Steven.

The six of them stared down into the static in silence, which Glimmer eventually broke. “Wow. She almost makes Catra look sane. …Welp, let’s get moving.” She left the pit behind, resuming their trek.

“Still, I kind of feel sorry for her,” said Perfuma. “She lost something really close to her.”

“So did Adora,” said Scorpia.

“Speaking of which…” Adora picked up her sword, joining Glimmer in heading off to the Fright Zone. “Now that she’s out of the way, we have a straight shot to Catra. We should get moving while we still can.”

“Man, I can’t wait to show everyone what I can do now!” Steven said excitedly. “Actually, I can’t wait to find out what *else* I can do!”

“Hey, now that Emerald’s been dealt with, would you mind telling us where you found that?” said Bow, pointing at the Sword of Power. “Didn’t you say something about Homeworld?”

“Oh yeah–it’s a really interesting story!” Steven said, heading to the front of the group as they walked. “So, after Emerald attacked Beach City, we decided to head to Dryl…”

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All around her, the static loomed in the distance, almost mocking her. It seemed to be deliberately saving her for last, consuming the entire world except for her sole bastion of safety, not that it would stay that way for long.

Catra gazed into the distance from atop the Fright Zone as her robotic army prepared for battle. Adora would be here soon, she was sure of it. That girl wasn’t one to give up easily, even when the odds were entirely stacked against her. But then again, so was she.

“Come on, Adora. I’m ready for you.”

The Honor

Chapter Summary

> With ruin soon approaching, the remaining heroes make their last stand.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter Twenty-Five: The Honor

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"...and the next thing I knew, I must have fallen from the sky or something, because I woke up in that giant crater. And that's when I ran into you guys!"

"Huh. That's…wow." Steven's recollection of events was a lot for everyone to take in, especially for Adora. "I never really considered the possibility that there'd be more than one sword. But I guess it makes sense, with how far the First Ones spread. And this Adam guy, you said he looked a lot like me?"

"Yeah, almost exactly like you," Steven replied. "I'd say you were a descendant if the Gems hadn't, y'know, killed them all."

"Well, you never know," Bow said. "Adora had to come from somewhere."

"That must've been what Light Hope meant!" said Adora, suddenly excited. "She was trying to send me back to where I came from. And now that Steven has a sword of his own–it can't be a coincidence! She was here for a reason, I know it. Something big is going on, and as soon as we fix this, I have to follow her directions! Who knows what could depend on it?"

“Getting a bit excited already, aren’t you?” said Glimmer. “Even if we can fix all of this, she didn’t exactly give you clear instructions, did she? Just a bunch of numbers you might not even remember…”

“Of course I can remember them!” Adora shot back. “Just not right now. And I’m sure we can piece something together. Bow’s great at cracking codes, right?” Bow looked uncertain.

“So, hang on, there’s still something I don’t get,” Scorpia said. “What exactly is ‘Grayskull?’ I mean, you use its honor, he uses its power, but what exactly *is* it?”

“I’m…not entirely sure, but I think it’s a family name,” answered Steven. “Like a house. That hologram guy that Horde Prime showed us, his name was Grayskull. I think he was like the king of Eternia or something.”

“Whatever it is, I’m just glad it’s on our side!” said Perfuma.

The gang continued walking for a little while, until their green surroundings gave way to red. The desolate wasteland that was the Fright Zone opened up before them, yet untouched by the static. And there, right in the center, was Hordak’s compound–his former compound, long since claimed by Catra. And she seemed to be preparing for war, as an enormous battalion of Horde bots and cybertroops stood guard, as though daring anyone foolish enough to come and try to breach the fortress. Everyone crouched behind a boulder, where Bow examined the area with his binoculars.

“You were right about Catra wanting this,” he said. “It’s like she’s got every robot the Horde has placed to stop us from getting to your sword. I don’t see any soldiers, though…”

“That’s a lotta bots,” Adora said. “If it was just us, I don’t think we’d be able to fight through them all. We still might not be able to.”

“I think I might just be able to help with that!” said Steven, holding up his newfound sword. “The Power of Grayskull could probably smash through that army!”

“I’ll help too!” said Scorpia. “A couple’a robots don’t scare me! I don’t have my stinger, though–not that it would’ve made much of a difference against robots, but still.”

“And me!” Perfuma announced. “We’re so close now, I will do whatever I can to save this world.”

“Thanks, you guys, but those robots are just a distraction,” Adora said. “I think Catra knows, or at least suspects that my sword is the key to all of this. If we really want to stop this, we can’t let them slow us down.” She turned to Bow and Glimmer. “And that’s where you two come in.”

“Are you thinking what I’m thinking?” asked GLimmer, enthusiastically lighting up her fist.

Adora nodded. “We’ll split into two teams: Team A, you three are our heaviest hitters, so you’ll distract the robots. And Team B, that’s us, infiltrate the Fright Zone and get to the sword, with Catra and her cronies none the wiser!”

“That’s not what I was thinking at all,” Glimmer said. “But if that’s how you want to do it, I trust you.”

“We got this!” said Bow. “Everyone’s depending on us–we can’t choke now!”

Steven stood up and cracked his neck. “Guess that’s my cue, then. Everyone ready?”

Scorpia and Perfuma got up as well. Glimmer grabbed onto Adora and Bow. “Ready!” she said.

“Then let’s do this!” Steven spun his sword around as he strolled closer to the Fright Zone. The other two princesses followed after him, while the Best Friend Squad teleported away.

It didn’t take long before Steven was noticed. His new form wouldn’t exactly have been stealthy even if he was trying to be, especially now that he was glowing with power. Horde bots, cybertroops, even a handful of megabots and cybertanks took notice of his approach, and moved to block his advance. He grinned.

“Weren’t expecting to see me, huh?” he said. “Well, here I am! I’ve got one sword, and I’m here for the other one! Just try and stop me!”

And try they did, immediately opening fire. Not expecting this sudden assault, Steven took a defensive position. Perfuma quickly erected a wall of vines to keep them safe, but it was quickly being burned through. “I can’t hold them for long!”

“Then let’s go on the offensive!” said Scorpia, holding out a claw to Steven. “Throw me!”

“‘Throw you?’” said Steven. “Are you sure–”

“Just do it!”

He did, hurling Scorpia over the barrier and into the fray. She slammed down into a cluster of the bots, crushing them beneath her claws. Her armor protected her from their blasts as she continued to smash them. Steven noticed a cybertank taking aim, which her armor likely wouldn’t protect against.

“Hang on!” he shouted, rushing towards it. The Sword of Power crackled with energy as he dragged it through the ground. He swung it upwards, launching an arc of pure energy towards the cybertank. The wave collided with the machine, ripping through its metal, and sending it up in an explosion as its own weapons combusted.

Not to be outdone, Perfuma cast up a collection of vines from beneath the earth, tearing through a myriad of incoming robots. These same vines lifted her into the air as more of the machines

approached, with several more covered in thorns whipping them apart.

And as all of this went down, Adora, Bow, and Glimmer watched from afar. “Okay, I don’t think any of them saw us,” said Adora. “Take us in.”

Glimmer teleported the three of them closer to the Fright Zone, under the radar of Catra’s mechanical army. All of them had advanced to stop the encroachment of Steven and the others. Within the Fright Zone’s walls, it was eerily still, the usual motion of the Horde soldiers noticeably absent. However, it wouldn’t stay silent for long.

While their guards were down, more robots emerged from the shadows, surrounding the trio. Adora reached for her sword, but before she could draw it, Bow fired an arrow at the closest bot; an electric pulse burst from the impact, shorting out most of them. A few remained, two of which Glimmer blasted with her powers. One drew closer with its blasters extended, and this one Adora managed to take out with a blow to the optic.

Bow notched another arrow, scanning his surroundings. “See any more of them?” he said.

Glimmer, her fists glowing, was doing the same. “Not yet, we should probably get moving while we can. Adora?”

Adora was the only one of the trio that was still, her gaze fixed on the tallest tower in the Fright Zone. Glimmer and Bow followed her eyes, and saw what she was staring at: Catra stood at the very top, gazing back at them. Even at this distance, one could feel the disdain she held from her glare alone. And for once, Adora shared this sentiment, staring daggers back up at her as she tightly gripped the hilt of her sword.

Catra retreated back inside, and Adora gave chase. “Wait, hold on!” called Bow, he and Glimmer ran after her. “Don’t go in alone!” But there was no stopping her as she tore in after her adversary.

Back outside the borders, Catra had apparently alerted her guards, as many of the robots began to break off from the battle, moving to intercept the intruders. “They’re going after Adora!” said Steven. “Stop them!”

With a wave of her arm, Perfuma spawned a wall of thick moss that covered most of the entrance. Those that it stopped tried to blast their way through, but many robots made it past the blockade. “I’ll go after them!” said Scorpia. With a mighty leap, she landed on the side of the wall, using her pincers to climb over and give chase.

Steven ran over to help, slicing through robots as he approached the floral barrier. Grabbing their attention yet again, the robots began to surround him again, only to be cut down with little effort on his part. The more machines he demolished, the more his expression went from purposeful to ecstatic, clearly enjoying himself as he left a trail of destruction in his wake. And although she destroyed a fair amount of them as well, Perfuma took notice of how manic he seemed.

“Steven? Are you feeling alright?” she asked.

Dropping the broken remains of a cybertroop he had crushed in his hand to the ground, Steven looked over at her. “I’m great!” he said, malice in his eyes despite his smile. “I feel better than I have in years! I feel like I could take on the *world* !” As he said this, he drove his fist clean through the chest of another bot, letting it crumple to the ground.

Perfuma had no time to inquire further, as another threat soon became apparent. Though they could likely fight off robots all day, they had no way of halting the static, which was growing closer by the minute. It almost seemed to creep around like an animal stalking its prey, surrounding the Fright Zone with careful precision. There were no gaps. By now, almost all of Eartheria had likely been consumed.

The sight of this snapped Steven out of his frenzied state. “What do we do!?” he yelled to Perfuma.

“The same thing as before!” she called back. “Hold them off for as long as we can, and hope Adora gets to her sword!”

The robots didn’t care about the static, but they could recognize that their opponents’ guards were lowered. The mechanical legions pressed the attack, surrounding the two of them just as the unearthly void surrounded them all. And as they did, still more poured into the Fright Zone whenever the opportunity arose.

“No! Stop them!” Steven shouted as the robots swarmed him, more and more of them chasing after Adora. He bashed them aside, cutting through their numbers as Perfuma held back as many as she could. “Stay *back* !”

With a yell, Steven drove the Sword of Power into the ground. With this, energy swirled around his form, culminating in a burst of pure might rushing outwards, blowing the machines back. This power also had a second effect: once the energy reached the approaching static, it was halted, the edges of the world glowing as it stopped in its tracks. This only lasted for a moment, as the second Steven broke his concentration, the static resumed its movement.

“Did…you see that?” Steven asked, amazed at what he just did.

“I definitely saw that!” said Perfuma. “Do it again!”

“Right!” Steven gripped the hilt of his sword tightly, focusing his energy towards the edges of the world. The void slowed, and eventually stopped completely. “Keep ‘em off me, this is harder than it looks!”

“Right!” Perfuma summoned a line of brambles around Steven, further whipping at any robot that came close with vines. Her barrier in front of the Fright Zone had mostly gone forgotten; hopefully Scorpia could hold them off on her own. “How much longer do you think you can hold it?”

“Long enough!” replied Steven. “I think I can buy Adora and the others enough time, but it’s gonna be tight!” As he used every fiber of his being to urge the world to stay together for as long as he could, Perfuma gave her all as well to hold the robots back. However, as more and more of them appeared, her barrier was becoming undone faster than she could repair it.

As the robots approached, Steven did his best to hold on, but they were slowly gaining ground. It would only be a matter of time before he would have to fight back, and he could no longer delay the static. But, just as it seemed they were out of time, a voice called out from above: “Watch your heads!” Like a frozen comet, a massive chunk of ice crashed down on the robots from the skies, crushing them beneath its weight.

The ice chunk burst open, skewering nearby robots with shards of frost. From out of it came Frosta, sending up waves of ice at the machines. Before either Steven or Perfuma could call out to her, she had erected a massive frozen wall around the former. And she wasn’t alone; a powerful laser rained down on the robots as Queen Angella descended. “Where are they?” she demanded.

“Inside,” answered Perfuma. “But we have to protect Steven! He can hold that stuff back!”

In reply, Angella blew apart a few cybertroops with a blast from her palm. “Then that is what we will do.” She created a barrier of her own around Steven, ensuring that no machine would get anywhere near him.

Frosta shot a shard of ice at a robot, spearing it through the chest. “How long do we need to hold them for?” she asked. “I mean, I could do this all day, but exact amounts are nice!”

“Just until Adora can get to her sword,” said Steven. “Which is hopefully soon!”

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With a glowing blast, Glimmer sent the Horde bot blocking their path crashing into the wall. Adora followed after her as she ran through the corridors, Bow shooting down any pursuers. "Just a little farther!" Adora assured. The three of them ran on, memory guiding them back to where this all began.

Soon enough, they had reached it. The doors to the chamber were blown open by an exploding arrow, and they headed inside. It was surprisingly quiet, only the hum of energy could be heard. No guards of any kind. The Black Garnet loomed ominously over them, connected to the portal that had started this all. And in its center, the Sword of Protection hovered, innocuous as a powerful First Ones artifact could seem.

"There it is," Glimmer said. She looked up at Adora, urging her to grab it. Adora took a few cautious steps forward, expecting this to not be as easy as it seemed. And indeed it wasn't; a voice accosted them from the shadows.

"I can't let you do that, Adora." Catra stepped out of her hiding place, emerging from the darkness. She seemed calm, almost relaxed, as the three got ready to fight. "There's only one way this can end."

"Catra!" Adora shouted. "Can't you see how crazy this all is!? The entire world–no, both worlds–are being destroyed! Is this really what you want!?"

"What I want?" Catra replied, her eyes narrowing to slits. "What I want is to *finally* win against you! I want to know that, even if it's just once, just *once* , I was better than you! And if the world has to die for that? Well…what has the world done for me anyway?"

"Even if *you* die too?" asked Bow.

Catra began to laugh. It started as small giggles, before going to full bodied, hysterical laughter, hard enough that tears were streaming down her face–tears that didn't look like tears of laughter to Adora. The three of them looked on, unnerved, as

Catra collected herself. “You don’t get it, do you? None of this, *none of this* , has ever ended with me on top! I finally become Hordak’s lieutenant? Lars and all of his stupid friends have to come in and ruin it all! I take Hordak’s place? Turns out, most of the Horde preferred him– *Hordak* ! They like *Hordak* more than they like me! What sense does that make!? And even now, when I try to set my sights on something bigger than Etheria, I end up destroying it all!” She laughed again. “Everything I know is *gone* , all because nothing goes my way! And the best part?” She glared at them, extending her claws. “I don’t care. Everyone I know is going to die, including myself–including you–and I feel numb. Isn’t that just *hilarious* ?”

“Look, Catra, I…” Adora extended her hand, trying to comfort her former friend. “Destroying the world isn’t going to make your pain stop. It’s just going to pass it on to someone else.”

“There won’t *be* anyone else,” Catra snarled. Her claws began to glow with heat. “Only when everything is silent can I finally be free of this! And I will kill anyone I have to to make that happen! Starting with *you* !”

Catra hurled herself towards Adora, who held up her sword defensively. Sparks flew as claws met sword, and Adora pushed Catra back. “Please! You have to stop this!” she pleaded. But her words fell on deaf ears as Catra lunged again, and again, and again. Eventually, she broke past Adora’s guard, tackling her to the ground. She raised her arm above her head, and drove it downwards.

Adora caught Catra’s wrist moments before her claws could make contact with her face. As the two struggled, she looked up. That expression on her face–Catra wasn’t here anymore. She was a beast, driven by rage, hate, and pain.

Fortunately, Adora didn’t have to consider this for very long, as an arrow suddenly hit Catra’s side, wrapping her in a net and throwing her off. She struggled for a moment, only for Glimmer to reach her, teleporting her away. The two reappeared near the

ceiling, Glimmer blasting Catra down to the floor, where she crashed. “Hurry, go!”

Trying to put this out of her mind, Adora sprang to her feet and raced over to the portal. At last, the key to stopping this was within reach; she gripped the hilt, pulling with all her might to dislodge it. “For the Honor of Grayskull…For the Honor of Grayskull! Why isn’t this working!?” Neither the oath nor her muscles could free the blade, even though her words caused some sort of distortion in its energy. “Hang on, I think it’s loosening!”

It was, but not in the way she had hoped. A blast of energy came from the sword, blowing Adora back and knocking the portal to pieces. With a deafening drone, a pit began to open up beneath the sword, spreading as the weapon rose up into the air. The room shook as it began to be consumed by the static.

“What the!? What happened!?” shouted Bow. The sword had passed through the ceiling like it wasn’t even there, causing more static to appear. “Adora, what did you do!?”

“I didn’t do anything!” Adora said. “I just tried to pull it free and it floated away!”

In the confusion, Catra managed to cut herself free from the net, making a break for the door. “Hey!” Bow fired an arrow, narrowly missing his target. He gave chase after her, only to trip and fall when another quake hit. Catra disappeared from view, leaving them behind.

The room was beginning to fall apart, due to both the static and the quakes. “Come on! After her!” Adora began to give chase, only for a giant column to topple over in her direction. Moments before it could crush her, Glimmer appeared, warping her out of harm’s way.

The two reappeared on the far side of the room. “You alright?” Glimmer asked.

"Never better," Adora groaned, rubbing her sore back. She looked around for her sword, only to realize she had lost it in the chaos. "Where's Bow?"

Glimmer spotted him a fair distance away. "There!" she called. He was trying to get up, but his leg was pinned beneath a piece of debris. "You go after Catra, we'll catch up!" Adora did so, and Glimmer teleported over to Bow; at least, that was her intention. Glimmer realized that although she had meant to go right to him, she had only gone over a fraction of the room. *Crap* –it had been a while since she had last recharged, hadn't it? "Bow, hold on, I'm coming!" Glimmer headed towards Bow the old fashioned way, running to meet him.

"Glimmer! Stay back, it's too–" Bow shouted, gesturing for Glimmer to stay away. The static was inching closer, too quickly for either of them to do anything. By the time Bow was aware of it, it had already interrupted his warning, swallowing him up.

"NO!" Glimmer warped again, using every last bit of her power she could to reach him. But her magic was all but tapped, as he had already disappeared by the time she got to where he had been. For a moment, all she could do was sit there, staring down into the void. *It's not real* , she reminded herself, *He's not really gone.* She knew Adora's sword could undo all of this…but seeing someone you know vanish right before you isn't something you easily forget. In spite of it all, she willed herself to her feet, and ran after Catra.

– – –

The quakes had been felt all over the Fright Zone. Outside, as the four continued fighting off the hordes of machines, it felt as though the ground suddenly began to shake violently, with almost everyone having to rebalance themselves. The robots stumbled as well, but quickly resumed their assault. "What was that!?" shouted Perfuma, looking back with concern at where their friends had gone.

“I don’t know!” said Steven, still holding the static back. “But as long as we keep holding on, we–” Before he could finish, a loud groan came from the wall of ice around him. The quake had caused it to become unstable, and it had begun to fall apart. A tower of ice cracked apart, toppling over directly towards him. Risking being crushed beneath it, Steven had no choice but to lift the sword, cutting the ice in two.

Without Steven holding it back, the static immediately resumed its approach, swallowing up many of the robots as it raced towards them. Frosta created more walls of ice to stave it off, but they were swallowed up immediately. Knowing that there was no way to stop it, all of them ran into the Fright Zone. But the static was approaching too fast.

“Guys! Wait for me!” Frosta cried, trying to run to safety. She had been furthest away when the quakes hit, and her small stature was not doing her any favors. Perfuma was the first to act, rushing back to the young princess.

Once more, Steven plunged his sword into the earth in an effort to beat back the nothingness, but it seemed to have no effect this time. Angella rushed after the two, but only arrived in time to see them be consumed by the static. She pulled back, lest she follow them, and flew away from the approaching void.

“Queen Angella!” Steven called up to her. “There’s still time, go to Adora!” He seemed to know that there was nothing more he could have done. She could tell he was afraid, but he hung on as long as he could regardless. Taking a deep breath, the static overtook the ground where he stood, and he vanished into nothing.

There was still time. Steeling herself, Angella took to the skies, scanning the ground for those that remained.

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“HYAH!” With a mighty cry, Scorpia threw a Horde bot aside, where it crashed into several cybertroops. She barely broke her

stride as she continued on, trailing an entire battalion of robots behind her. "Hey, scrap-for-brains! Got an intruder right here! Come and get me!"

Scorpia, in an effort to lead them away from Adora and the others, drew as many robots to her as she could. It was not hard to do, considering the trail of destruction she left behind her. Even after the quake, and the Fright Zone had begun to disintegrate, she kept on with her mission. Her claws tore through metal as she ran on through the streets, only for something–or rather, someone–to catch her eye.

It was only a glance at first, but the two of them stopped and stared at one another, their respective goals momentarily forgotten. Scorpia looked up at Catra, stood up on the rooftops, and Catra stared down at her. In this moment, memories suddenly hit the two of them hard. Scorpia gasped as she recalled a potent shock run through her body, followed by blackness. "No…" Catra mouthed up above her, her eyes wide.

Among all the pain, the burning question of Why? ran through Scorpia's mind. "Catra…" She reached out a claw, as though desiring to come closer. She didn't get the opportunity, as it was then that the robots caught up to her. Cybertroops immediately began dogpiling her, which seemed to break the spell, as Catra resumed running away. "Catra, no! Wait!" yelled Scorpia, but to no avail. Soon enough, both she and her cries were swallowed up by the static, just like so many before her.

Catra continually assured herself that she had a plan. That she was running towards something, instead of away. But in truth, she was running because it was all she could think to do. Adora had been so close, only failing because the sword was unstable. If she got to it again, she could ruin all of this. But is *this* really what she wanted?

As if on cue, she heard footsteps behind her. With a growl, she looked behind her to see Adora hot on her heels. She continued

onward and upward, sprinting across the rooftops. No matter how far she got, Adora kept after her, eventually catching up.

Catra was knocked off her feet as Adora tackled her, the both of them ending up on a nearby roof. "Catra! Enough!" said Adora, holding her down. "Whether you want me to or not, I'm fixing this! You can help me or stay out of my way, but I will *not* let you put everyone in danger again!"

Taking that moment to make her move, Catra kicked Adora off of her, delivering a slice with her claws that was only narrowly dodged. "You don't *let* me do anything! You don't control me anymore!" Adora fell back as Catra swung at her repeatedly; without a sword, Catra had the upper hand in this fight. Adora looked around for something to give her an edge…and then she saw it.

When the Sword of Protection had disappeared, she had assumed that Catra was somehow responsible. But there it was, hovering high above the Fright Zone's tallest tower. All she had to do now was get there.

Quickly, she swept Catra's legs out from under her and sprang to her feet, leaping to the scaffolding on a nearby building. Catra followed her, and was much faster when it came to climbing. Adora ducked out of the way of her claw strikes until she had made it up to the roof, where she felt Catra grab her leg.

"Is it even worth it?" Catra asked, pulling Adora down. She saved herself by grabbing onto a pipe, which only barely supported her weight. "Do you think they even really care about you? Or is it just She-Ra that they want?"

The pipe was close to breaking. "You're really pulling that card now?" Adora shot back. "If I've learned anything in this time, it's that Glimmer and Bow care more about me than you *ever* did!" This had the desired effect: Catra lunged, her added weight causing the pipe to break free, carrying the two of them over to a nearby balcony.

Adora got to her feet, trying to ignore the claw wounds she had received. She staggered forwards, only to hear the tell-tale hiss of Catra's claws heating up. She whirled around just in time for the white-hot metal to graze her leg. She stumbled back, letting out a cry as Catra stood up.

" *I'm* the one who never cared about *you* !?" snarled Catra, bearing down on Adora. "You're the one who always kept me down! Who left me behind when it suited you! Was I ever really your friend? Or were you just using me, just like Shadow Weaver!?" She repeatedly swung at Adora; sometimes her swipes were dodged, sometimes she could feel her claws slicing through fabric, and deeper.

"Stop!" Adora snapped. "That's not you! Shadow Weaver's still in your head!" She grabbed onto Catra's wrists. "She's still making you think that way. Tell me, is this really what you want?"

Catra seemed to solemnly consider this for a moment. "I'm sorry, Adora," she said, "but this isn't about what I want anymore." She pulled her arm free from Adora's grip, delivering a punch to her gut. She loomed over her as he doubled over. "It's about what I need."

Moments before she could strike her again, Adora suddenly burst forward with a punch of her own, sending Catra reeling. Adora took this moment to race forwards, stopping mere inches before falling off the building's edge. She turned in time to see Catra lunging at her, and ducked to the side, causing her to fall down below. After making sure she had caught herself, her claws digging into the walls, Adora made her way upwards.

Below her, most of the Fright Zone was already gone, vanished by the static. Off in the distance, there was nothing–where they were now was all that remained of Eartheria, the rest having been devoured. A lone island stood in a sea of nothing, and it was slowly sinking. At last, she had reached the top of the tower. There, the sword hovered above her, surrounded by a storm of static. She held out her arm, reaching for it, but nothing

happened. "...For the Honor of Grayskull!" she cried. Once again, nothing happened. The sword hovered in the air, unmoving.

"Well, that was just sad." Catra pulled herself up to the rooftop as well, smirking. "Was that your plan? How exactly did you expect to get up there?" She strolled over to Adora, emanating a sense of victory. "It's over, Adora. You lost."

"Not yet I haven't!" Adora threw a punch, only for Catra to dodge, following up with a slice from her claws. Adora cried out and threw another punch, but Catra caught her arm, knocking her down with a headbutt.

"After all this time…I finally beat you." Catra got on top of Adora, pressing her knee into her chest. Dazed and weakened, all Adora could do was grip her leg. "Do you wanna know how it feels?" She reached back, delivering a cut to Adora's cheek. "It feels better than anything I've ever felt! I wonder why…"

"Catra…please…" Adora looked up at her, barely conscious. "Don't do this…"

"For what it's worth…I'll miss you." Catra raised her claws over her head, preparing to deal the final blow. Adora refused to give in even now, even if all she could do was gaze up at her. For a moment, a look of hesitation flashed in Catra's eyes. And then, she struck.

In a literal flash, a beam of light collided with Catra, throwing her off of Adora and the rooftop, sending her down to the static below, where she was consumed as well. Adora looked at its source, and saw Glimmer, exhausted. "Thought you could…finish this without me, huh?" she panted.

Smiling, Adora reached out a hand to her. "Hi, Glimmer," she said weakly, as she took her hand. "Glad you could make it."

She tried to get up, but Glimmer wouldn't let her. "No, you stay here. Leave getting that sword to me!" Looking up at the Sword of Protection, Glimmer focused every last bit of power that was still

in her, and teleported up to it. But despite it all, she came up just short, falling back down to the roof. Standing up, she tried again, once more not quite making it. She tried again, and again, but didn't have enough power to get to it.

"Glimmer," said Adora, "don't strain yourself. You don't have enough magic to make it." She sat up, placing a hand on the princess's shoulder.

"I have to!" she said. "Without that sword, the whole world is gone! If I don't get it, who can!?"

"Me." The two of them looked over to see a pair of wings reflecting the light as Angella descended, touching down on the rooftop next to them. "I will retrieve the sword."

"Mom!" cried Glimmer, jumping to her feet. "Hang on, it isn't that easy! Steven told us that whoever takes the sword–"

"...Will be trapped. I know," said Angella. She leaned down, placing a hand on both of their shoulders. "Listen to me: the two of you are some of the bravest, kindest, most noble people I know. No matter what happens next, I have no doubt in my mind that you will be able to handle it."

"Angella, no," Adora said. "It's my sword, so it's my burden. Carry me up to it, let me–"

"No!" said Glimmer. "No, I'll do it! Mom, you said it yourself, we still need Adora!"

"And Adora needs you." Angella pulled a teary-eyed Glimmer into a hug. "You are going to do extraordinary things, Queen Glimmer. But you need your friends to support you, just as they need you." She planted a kiss on her forehead. "Goodbye, my sweet Glimmer."

"No…Mom, no!" Glimmer tried to stop her, but Angella had already taken to the skies, headed towards the sword. "Please, don't do this!"

Angella grabbed onto the sword's hilt, giving one last glance down at the two of them. Although there was sadness in her eyes, her gaze was primarily one of love. "Take care of each other…"

With one single movement, she wrenched the Sword of Protection free of its place. A blinding cascade of light filled the air, and when it subsided, Angella was gone. But the storm had disappeared as well, and the static emanating from it almost seemed to be waiting for what would happen next. The sword descended from above, coming to a rest in Glimmer's hands. The two shared a wordless glance before she passed it onto Adora, who held it aloft.

"For the Honor of Grayskull!"

A beam of golden light illuminated what little remained of the world, spreading far and wide. The static hummed, resonating with the energy that had created it. And with a rushing sensation like passing through a tunnel, all was still.

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Adora stirred. "Hmm?" She opened her eyes, taking a moment to get a feel for her surroundings: she was back in the castle, in her bed. The past events all felt like a dream–which they sort of were, in a way. She raised a hand to her cheek and felt nothing, her wounds having vanished. Once she tried to get to her feet, she winced, her hand gripping her side. Not all of her wounds, apparently, she noted.

On the other side of the room, Bow was getting to his feet. Glimmer sat on the floor by the door, staring at the wall. "What happened?" he asked, looking around. "Did…did we do it?"

Leaning against the bedside was the Sword of Protection. Adora prodded it experimentally, with no effect. "We did," she said solemnly.

Bow looked between the two. "So, what's going on?" he said, as Adora walked over to the window. "Shouldn't we be happier?"

Glimmer got to her feet, turning around. Traces of tears still lined her face. “She’s gone, Bow. She sacrificed herself for all of us.” Bow said nothing. As he took this in, he reached out, and the two of them embraced. However, they had little time to ruminate, as Adora called their attention away.

“Uh…hey, guys?” she said. “I think you’ll wanna see this…”

Her anxious tone giving them pause, Bow and Glimmer headed over. What they saw wasn’t bad, per se, but it was definitely shocking. Even Glimmer momentarily forgot her sorrow at the sight that presented itself out the window.

Stars. The sky was full of stars.

Chapter End Notes

> It took a while, but we finally got there! This was an exciting journey to be on, and I hope you enjoyed it as much as I did! The last chapter should be up in a few days.

Here We Are in the Future Redux

Chapter Summary

> With both planets now out of Despondos, everyone plans on their next move.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter Twenty-Six: Here We Are in the Future Redux

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"So…I guess it worked in the end, huh? And all it took was nearly destroying the world!"

Entrapta and Catra stood on a terrace outside of the latter's sanctum, gazing up at the sky. After all of that, Entrapta's machine had worked; Etheria had been transported out of Despondos. While Entrapta excitedly went over all of the data this new sky was providing, Catra seemed far less enthusiastic than either of them thought she would have been. An opportunity to conquer the universe, and all she could do was sit sullenly on her balcony.

"The funny thing is, none of this would be possible without Adora!" Noticing Catra's mood, Entrapta decided to change the subject. "Er…I can't wait to explore the vastness of space! Just think of all those planets, and stars, and comets, and all sorts of other celestial bodies out there! All that data…ooh, I'm getting jittery just thinking about it! Aren't you excited?"

Catra sighed. "I don't know what I am," she said.

"I wonder if Scorpia has anywhere she'd like to visit," Entrapta wondered. "Hey, Scorpia! Where're you hiding? Come and–"

"Entrapta," Catra said, looking up at her. "She isn't here. Not anymore."

"Hmm? What do you… Oh." Entrapta remembered what had happened before the portal opened. " *Oh* …"

"No point dwelling on it now," Catra continued. "Come on, we need to prepare for…what?" A ship had lifted off from the ground, interrupting her. It continued on up into the upper atmosphere, followed by another, and another. "What's going on? I didn't authorize this!"

"Hmm. I wonder where they're going," said Entrapta.

"Come on!" Catra headed back inside, urging Entrapta to follow after her. Meanwhile, down on the ground level, both Gems and Catra's remaining Horde soldiers were loading supplies onto Emerald's ships, as well as boarding them themselves. Emerald herself oversaw the process, while also speaking with Bluebird Azurite.

"Whatever," Emerald said. "She's only one Topaz–well, two. Either way, how hard could it be to replace her? We'll send out a signal once we…hold on." Catra angrily walked up to her, Entrapta meekly following behind. "Look who's finally awake!"

"Zip it!" hissed Catra. "What is this? After everything you've sunk into this, you're running away? Shameless as that is, what exactly makes you think you have command over *my* troops!?"

Emerald shook her head. "As a matter of fact, I'm not 'running away.' I'm simply relocating. The Fright Zone is no longer a secure base of operations, now that this planet has been removed from Despondos."

"And you're doing this without my permission? I don't care what you used to be under Homeworld, but this is my army, my empire! The only reason you have any sort of say in this is because you were useful to me! Lars of the Stars doesn't interest me anymore, so you can take your Gems and–"

"Oh, *open your eyes* , will you!?" yelled Emerald. "Think! The only reason I was bold enough to launch an attack on Earth was because of Project: Drawbridge! And the only reason your precious Horde made it as far as it did was because this planet was tucked away in Despondos! Now that we're all out in the main universe, how long do you think it will take Steven to sic his Diamond allies on your forces? A week? Two? Face it: the only way either of us are going to survive this is if we make ourselves scarce, and regroup!" She turned to a shuttle which was boarding both her and Catra's forces. "'Your' soldiers have opted to join me. I hope you will as well."

"Uh, Catra?" said Entrapta. "I know you don't exactly like relying on others, but she does have a point. Now that Homeworld is part of the equation, it definitely seems likely they'll get involved before long. And given what we know about them, well…"

Catra glared at her, before looking back at the Fright Zone. It wasn't just that she had spent years gradually working her way up the ranks, but this place was also where she had been born and raised. By Shadow Weaver, but still. She resented leaving it behind, and she resented Emerald for forcing her hand…but she resented losing even more. " *Fine* ," she snarled, standing beside Emerald. "I just hope you have a ship or two that can stand up to Homeworld's forces."

"Oh, you want a ship?" Emerald looked at her with a knowing, manic smile splitting her face. "I can get you a ship…"

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"Hrrmm…just five more minutes…" Steven grumbled, reaching for his blankets to block the sun from his eyes. However, when his hand touched sand, he realized he wasn't in his bed. He rubbed his eyes as he sat up, realizing he was on the beach in front of the temple. "Huh? Did…did we… Guys!"

Steven excitedly leapt to his feet once he realized that the Gems were there as well. They were just as dazed as he was, and

seemed quite surprised to see him running over. He pulled all three of them into a massive hug, holding onto them like he was afraid they were going to disappear again.

"I'm so glad you're all okay!" he said. "With the whole world crumbling apart, I was so worried I'd never see you all again! And I…I…" Noticing their looks of confusion, he placed them back down. "Um, is something wrong?" It was only now that he realized that he was taller than even Garnet. Only after looking down at himself did he realize he was still He-Man. "Oh, right, you're wondering about the…yeah, it's kinda hard to explain."

Amethyst cocked her head to the side. "Is this that puberty thing Pearl was talking about? Man, it hit you like a truck!"

"What? No, no, I just got a magic sword from the Diamonds!" Steven said, holding it up to show them. "It's basically like Adora's."

Pearl examined the artifact. "Whatever it is, it's definitely ancient." She turned her attention to the boy. "Are you feeling alright? No lightheadedness, shortness of breath, violent urges…?"

"Guys, it's still me!" he assured them. "Without this, I wouldn't have been able to help Adora save us all! …Speaking of which, where is everyone? Are they alright? Come on, we have to make sure that–"

"They're fine," Garnet said. She pointed a panicking Steven towards his house, where movement was coming from within. "Why don't we go say hi?" He nodded, leading them inside.

"...but the way over here was gone by the time we…hey, look who's back!" Bismuth stopped telling her tale of events as the others entered, standing up to greet them. However, her excitement turned to a look of confusion as well. "What the? What happened to *you* ?"

She, Peridot, Lapis, and Connie all gaped in puzzlement at Steven's new form. Though they could tell it was still him, it was

quite obvious that he had undergone some rather radical changes. He waved sheepishly at them. "Hey guys!" he said. "What's goin' on?"

"Wow, puberty hits like a truck," said Lapis.

"That's what *I* said!" Amethyst replied.

"Uh, I think *you* should tell *us* what's going on!" said Peridot. "Did you fuse with Greg or something? And is that a First Ones sword?"

"Like I said, it's a long story," he replied. "And no, Dad didn't… Dad! Is he here!?" Steven frantically looked around. "Oh, he's probably been so worried!"

"He has," Garnet said. "He should be here right about…"

"Steven!" With that, Greg suddenly burst through the front door, looking around the room just as frantically as his son. "What happened!? Last thing I remember was running to Dryl, and then I woke up in my van! Is he…" He trailed off once he saw He-Man standing in the middle of the room. "...Steven!?"

"Hi Dad," Steven said with a small wave. "So, yeah, some stuff happened while you were all…occupied. Long story short, I found a way to get to Homeworld, and the Diamonds gave me the Sword of Power!" He held it up. "Or, I guess it gave itself to me. But now I can turn into He-Man!"

"Wow. That's…a lot to take in…" Greg said, sitting down on the couch. "Still, I'm just glad you're in one piece."

"I am, too." Connie had been silently taking in Steven's new form all this time, only now speaking up. She got to her feet and made her way over to him, looking up at him. "...This is weird, right? I'm not the only one who thinks this is weird?"

"No, it's very weird!" Steven said. "I'm still having a bit of trouble adjusting to it myself!" A small laugh. "And I'm only just now realizing I don't know how to turn it off…" He examined his sword,

shaking it slightly. “Is there a button I can press, or…?” In a flash of light, he had shrunken back down to his regular size, thankfully sans beard. “Ah, there we go!”

“So it is like Adora’s, you can turn it on and off,” Connie said. “That’s good–I think I like this you better.”

“Yeah, I…I do, too,” Steven said, blushing slightly. Connie did the same, averting her gaze. “Still, it’s pretty cool that I can turn into a giant now!” he said. “I’ll just need to figure out how it works. And learn to use a sword…”

“That part I can help you with!” said Connie. “Hang on…if you could fuse with Adora…and Stevonnie could fuse too…can He-Man also fuse with people?”

“Okay, I think we have enough to worry about now!” Pearl said, blocking that chain of thought. “I think we should focus on what He-Man can do before thinking about what He-vonnie can do.”

“He-vonnie, that’s good,” said Lapis. “You should use that.”

Bismuth looked around. “Alrighty then, is everyone good? No more surprises, or last-minute entries?” Everyone seemed finished. “Okay then… You can come out now!”

For a being of her size, Topaz had been hiding surprisingly well. Once she emerged, Steven was surprised he hadn’t noticed her before. The yellow Gem nervously approached the others, who only stared.

“Everyone, this is Topaz,” Bismuth said happily, putting an arm around the fusion’s shoulders. “She used to work for Emerald–keyword being ‘used to.’ She’s had a little falling-out with her old employers, and wants to join the Crystal Gems!”

“...Hi,” she said quietly, giving a small wave. “I think I’d like to help out. I-if that’s alright, of course.”

“Of course,” said Garnet. She walked over, holding out her hand, which Topaz shook after a moment’s hesitation. “Welcome to the team, Topaz. We’re glad to have you.”

Steven turned to Connie. “So, seems like you had your own little adventure while we were gone,” he said.

“We sure did!” she replied. “For that matter, after Earth and Etheria got merged, me and Bismuth and Lapis…oh, you don’t want to hear about that.”

“No, I do!” said Steven. He looked over at Topaz. “But…there’s something I need to do first. Tell me all about it in a minute, okay?”

“You got it!” Steven headed out the front door, getting licked by Lion as he passed by. His path took him beyond the temple, in the direction of Beach City. From the look of things, everything was back to normal. He would have time to check on everyone later, though. For now, he turned right and climbed up the hill towards the lighthouse.

Sure enough, the one he was looking for was sitting just at the edge of the cliff, looking off into the horizon. “I thought you’d be here,” Steven said, sitting down next to Spinel. It was where she had first arrived on Earth, after all. “How’re you holding up?”

“...Better,” she said with a smile. “Still not great, but better than I was before. Thank you, for sticking with me, even after what I did.”

“No prob, Bob,” Steven said. “Sticking with people is what I do. I mean, just down there, Lapis, Peridot, Bismuth, Topaz…all of them tried to kill me at some point. And now look at them!”

“You sure have a knack for befriending your enemies!” Spinel said with a chuckle. “...Pink was the same way. She…she always saw the best in people. And even though I’m still upset she left me behind, I…I’m glad that this is the place she decided to come to.”

“Me too.” Steven laid down in the grass, Spinel doing the same. “So, have you decided what you’re going to do now?”

“N-not really,” she answered. “I mean…where am I supposed to go?”

“Who says you have to go anywhere?” said Steven. “If you wanted to, you could stay right here.”

She looked over at him. “You really mean it?”

“Of course!” he said. “You are my new best friend, after all!”

For a moment, Spinel teared up, but held herself together. “Thanks, Steven. For everything.” The two of them laid beside each other, looking up at the clouds. “Now I know why Pink said to believe in Steven…”

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“Should…should we say something?” said Bow.

It wasn’t really a funeral. Not only because of the informality of it all, but because Angella wasn’t dead. But for all intents and purposes, they all knew the difference was negligible. Once dawn had broken, the three of them had delivered the news to the others. A palpable sense of melancholy now hung over the kingdom of Brightmoon as Glimmer knelt down before a small pile of stones, laying a moon lily beside them–her mother’s favorite flower.

“If you have something to say,” she replied, standing up and looking down at the makeshift grave. Neither Adora nor Bow did; although they missed Angella as much as Glimmer did, they hadn’t known her their entire lives like she had. “...Where do we go from here?”

The two looked at each other. “Go?” said Adora. “A-are you asking us?”

“What are we supposed to do?” asked Glimmer, her fists clenching. “Mom was the entire reason the Princess Alliance even exists! Without her, how are we supposed to even–”

“I know this is gonna be hard,” Adora said, stepping forward. “Angella was the center of all of this, she held us together. But before she…” She cleared her throat. “Angella told us to take care of each other.” She held out an arm, gesturing for Bow to come closer. “And that’s exactly what the Best Friend Squad is going to do.” She and Bow both embraced Glimmer, pulling her into a group hug.

Glimmer, however, didn’t return the gesture. “Is it just supposed to be that easy?” she said, pulling away. “All we have to do is hold hands, and everything will be alright!? My mom is *gone* ! None of this is going to bring her back! And now, all of a sudden, I’m supposed to be the Queen, which I have no idea how to do, and I’ll never see her again, and…” Noticing the pair’s hurt expressions, she trailed off. “Guys, I’m…I’m sorry. I’m just not sure how I can do this without her.”

“It’s okay, Glimmer,” said Bow. “This is going to be hard for all of us. But like Adora said, you’ll still have the Best Friend Squad. We’re here for you, no matter what.”

Despite it all, Glimmer managed a small smile. “Thanks, you two,” she said, wiping away a tear. “Er…would you excuse me for a moment? There’s something I need to do.”

“Sure, sure, of course,” Adora said. “But if this is what I think it is, you don’t have to hide from us. We can all cry together.”

“No, it’s not that,” Glimmer said. “It’s…queen stuff. I’ll meet back up with you in a bit.” With that, she turned and headed back into the castle, with Adora and Bow sharing concerned looks.

She walked through the gates, where the guards said nothing, though their quick glances at her said everything. She walked through the command room, where Castaspella had come all the

way from Mystacor to hold down the fort until her coronation. Her aunt spoke with the general, as well as Netossa and Spinnerella, about plans for Brightmoon's immediate future. Glimmer avoided their gazes, and continued on through the corridor, where Perfuma and Frosta were filling Mermista in on all that she had missed.

"...I'm telling you, he was like eight feet tall! And he had this big ol' beard, like some sort of mighty barbarian! And he was ripped, let me tell you…"

Glimmer didn't hear the rest of the conversation, as her journey took her down into the castle's lower levels where she rarely ventured. Where anyone rarely ventured, for that matter. Aside from the staff, who occasionally cleaned down here, there was little need for anybody to travel these darkened halls. However, they had lately become the temporary home of one of Brightmoon's uneasy allies, whose assistance she sought.

Hordak stood before a planning table, a map of the Fright Zone laid out. Huntara and Tung Lashor stood beside him, as well as a handful of his loyalists. "Provided the Princesses will aid us, our best bet would be…hmm?" He looked up to see that Glimmer had joined them. "Princess Glimmer. Has our temporary alliance expired already?"

"No," she said, glaring coldly at nothing in particular. "As much as I hate you…you aren't the one who killed my mom."

"Ah, yes," he said, nodding. "For what it's worth…you have my condolences."

"Don't pretend to care," she muttered. "Right now, you want your Horde back, and I want to make things right. As much as I wish we could go our separate ways, we still need each other. But as the new Queen of Brightmoon, *I* get to decide on the terms, got that?"

"And what are those terms?" Hordak asked.

“The Princess Alliance will aid you in taking back what is yours,” Glimmer said. “The Fright Zone will be yours again, and we can even negotiate giving you more territory if you cease your hostilities. And in return…” She looked up at him, hate–but not for him–in her eyes. “...you will help me kill Catra.”

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The ship jumped out of hyperspace, joining the rest of Emerald’s fleet at the space station. The enormous installation was far enough away from any Gem-controlled planet to be safe from their prying eyes. “Well? What do you think?” asked Emerald. Catra and Entrapta stood up and walked over to the window for a better view.

There was only one ship docked at the station, but it made all the others look like playthings. In fact, the station seemed to be specially designed to house a ship of its size. The ship was Emerald’s trademark green color, and was easily several miles across in width, shaped like a diamond when viewed from above. The dreadnought bristled with armaments, and was more than large enough to house most of the fleet. Although she tried to hide it, Catra was impressed Emerald had managed to acquire something so powerful.

Emerald grinned, sensing Catra’s admiration. “I told you I would get you a ship, didn’t I?” She gazed down at the vessel as well. “Lord Catra, I give you the jewel of my armada, the *Supermassive* . It’s a Titan-class destroyer, one of the last in existence, left over from Era-1. Getting my hands on it was no easy feat, but thankfully, I’m not the only one who disapproves of the Diamonds allying with Earth. This, my friends, will be our ace in the hole towards winning this war. Well? Did I come through?”

“It’s…incredible!” said Entrapta. “You could fit the entire Fright Zone inside of it! What exactly is it made of that it stays together under its own weight? What kind of power source does it have!?”

“She’s right–you really have outdone yourself,” Catra said. “So, this should be enough to tear through Homeworld’s armies?”

“Er…” Emerald wrung her hands. “Not exactly. Homeworld is still quite powerful, so we will need to take a much less direct approach. We’ll need to focus on disrupting their supply chain by destroying lesser colonies and outposts before we can attack them directly. However, with this on our side, as long as we play it smart, nothing can stand in our way!”

“That’s what I like to hear,” Catra said with a smirk. “You know… Entrapta, I’ve been thinking. As impressive as ‘Lord Catra’ is, I think we need something a bit bigger to really get the point across. And since I’m not limited to just one planet anymore, why not go with something bigger? How about…’Emperor Catra?’”

“I…er…” said Entrapta, glancing nervously at Emily.

“I, for one, think it suits you just right!” said Emerald. “Now…shall we begin our conquest, My Emperor?”

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The door of the cryo-tube hissed open, and Shadow Weaver stumbled out among the mist. She was disoriented, her head pounding; she steadied herself as she coughed violently, half expecting to heave something up. As her blurry vision gradually cleared, she took in the familiar sight of her business partner’s underground abode.

“Feeling a bit unwell?” A condescending metallic voice called to her from a nearby workbench. Partially obscured by shadow, Modulok was pouring an unknown liquid the same orange color as his skin into a series of tiny syringes. “I’m not surprised. Cryostasis is hard on everyone the first time, even myself. Though it does do away with many of the pesky side-effects of quantum restructuring…”

Shadow Weaver stood back up, rubbing her throat. “A bit of warning next time you plan on tearing the fabric of reality apart

would be nice," she shot back."

The former Force Captain turned to face her. Given his maw full of fangs, she could never tell if he was smiling or not. "Yes, yes. Admittedly, that part was not in my original plan." She could almost detect a hint of bashfulness coming from his voice box. "Had I known that Emerald would have brought a second planet into the equation, I would have prepared these tubes sooner. But, I find it unwise to dwell on one's failings." He slithered past her, placing the needles into a pouch on his hip. "The sooner we move forward, the sooner we can achieve our goals."

Three tubes sat beside Shadow Weaver: hers, one for Modulok, and one for his little assistant. "Indeed, our goals," she said, subtly preparing her magic. "Such as the Heart of Etheria?"

Modulok stopped in his tracks, turning back to stare at her with his piercing red eyes. "The Heart of Etheria? Where exactly did you hear of such a thing?" There was unease in his voice, she could tell.

"You aren't the only one who has secrets, Doctor," said Shadow Weaver, creating a small pool of dancing shadows just beneath his feet. It was a small thing, but the threatening gesture was clear. "And as someone who keeps secrets, I find it all the easier–and more enticing–to find out what others are hiding from me. I could have delved deeper, but I wanted to hear it directly from you. After all, we are partners now, aren't we? So tell me…what exactly is it you plan on doing?"

Knowing he'd been outmaneuvered, Modulok let out a small chuckle. "Come with me," he said, heading to the surface. The dark sorceress dispelled her shadows for now, but stayed suspicious, lest he not keep up his end of the bargain. She followed him up the steps to the surface, where it was only a small bit brighter than his bunker. Strangely though, it was a lot brighter than an Etherian night should have been, especially since they weren't near any large kingdoms.

In her time studying the magical arts in Mystacor, Shadow Weaver had seen many wondrous and terrible things. She had seen many more such things after she began dabbling in more forbidden practices. But even she was taken unawares at what waited for her. “Impossible…” she whispered, staring up at the starry skies. A motley gang of outcasts did the same, each of them possessing some sort of mutation. Even Modulok’s two favorite creations, bestial as they were, seemed intrigued.

Beside her, Modulok laughed again, this one more triumphant, and perhaps a bit smug. “I told you those girls of yours would set us free, did I not? Ye of little faith… Perhaps now you will trust me a bit more, yes?”

“Why should she?” The familiar voice of Modulok’s shapeshifter came from behind the pair, as they strolled up to them. “It’s not like you’re the trustworthy sort anyway.”

“The prodigal thespian returns!” said Modulok. “Tell me, has the grain of truth been planted in dear Adora’s head?”

“It certainly has,” Double Trouble responded. “She knows the coordinates, though whether she’ll remember them is another story. But she bought it hook, line, and sinker–she actually thought I was Light Hope! Of course, my performance was excellent, as always.”

“Yes, the coordinates,” Shadow Weaver interjected, her tone a warning. “Enlighten me, to where do those coordinates lead?”

“I suppose you deserve to know–as you said, we are partners,” Modulok said. “You see, all of this has been in service of one thing: Eternian supremacy. We were one the premier minds throughout all of creation, but now, we are all but extinct. With the Heart of Etheria at our disposal, we will have everything we need to reestablish ourselves as masters of the universe. And Adora holds the key to that future.”

“For your sake, you had better need her alive,” Shadow Weaver said, the crystal on her forehead glowing.

“Yes, yes,” Modulok said, waving his hand dismissively. “You will have your Adora. But why think so small? What if I told you that once I am finished with her, you could have all the Adoras you could possibly want?”

“Elaborate.”

“There will be time for that later. Right now, we have an entire universe out there, waiting for us to take our thrones.” Modulok fitted one of the syringes into a small crossbow-like device. “It would be rude to keep them waiting, no?”

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The smell of the salty sea air roused Scorpia from her dreams. That, and getting seawater splashed in her face. She woke with a start, coughing and spraying the water out of her nose. “Hoo boy, that’ll…that’ll get ya right up!” She got to her feet, brushing off the sand. Looking around, she found herself on a beach. “What did I do last night? Hey, Catra? Entrapta? Are either if you–”

Scorpia’s heart sank as she suddenly remembered what had happened. Catra had finally gone too far, and she had tried to stop her. But to no avail. A shock, and then she fell unconscious. The Eartheria debacle seemed like a dream…but at this point, she was almost wishing it had been real. To one side of her was an endless expanse of ocean, and to the other, a dense, dark jungle. All sorts of chittering, screeching, growling, and noises she couldn’t even name reverberated through the trees. It seemed Beast Island lived up to its name.

“Aw man…”

Chapter End Notes

And with that, this chapter of Steven and Adora's story has come to a close! I'm really enjoying telling this story, and I'm

glad so many of you are excited to read it! I'll probably be shifting focus to some of my other projects before moving on to Part 6, but it'll get here before you know it! Until then, happy Lunar New Year, and I'll see you next time!

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